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1. Hard Lessons for Europe From the Ceuta Crisis

Author: Ana Palacio **Published:** Sep 1, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

MADRID—At the end of July, tens of thousands of migrants crossed from Morocco into Ceuta, a Spanish exclave in North Africa. While most of them soon returned to Morocco voluntarily, several thousand, many of them minors, remain stranded in the city, leaving Spain to grapple with the humanitarian, security, and administrative consequences. Nonetheless, the immediate chaos has subsided, creating an opening for Europe to reflect on the vulnerabilities the episode revealed.

The first vulnerability relates to cohesion. Ceuta is not merely a Spanish city on the North African coast; it is European Union territory and part of the EU's external frontier. But Europe's initial response to the crisis was not to defend a common border. Instead, Italy imposed temporary border controls with Spain, with the support of other member states, including Denmark, Finland, and the Netherlands. The Czech Republic went so far as to call for the temporary suspension of Spain's Schengen membership.

While 22 EU countries called for emergency talks to devise a “coordinated European response,” any impression of solidarity was undermined by finger-pointing. By the time EU interior ministers expressed solidarity with Spain and affirmed that Europe's external borders are a shared responsibility, a worrying message about European cohesion had already been sent.

The tensions may seem to be about migration, but they are really about trust. Free movement within the EU is possible only if member states believe that external borders are effectively protected. The Ceuta crisis showed just how tenuous that belief is: border controls and recriminations started almost immediately, even though the migrants who entered Ceuta did not leave the exclave.

Spain bears responsibility for EU members' lack of trust in its border management. In an assessment issued before the crisis, the EU highlighted shortcomings in Spain's contingency planning for a mass influx, including insufficient coordination with European instruments and neighboring countries. Moreover, it took almost a month for Spain's government to bring the Ceuta issue before its National Security Council, betraying a lack of understanding of the strategic nature of the challenge.

Nonetheless, if Europe's common borders are to be operational, its members must forge a common understanding of what defending them entails. Without robust mutual trust, cohesion will always be fragile.

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The second vulnerability the Ceuta crisis revealed lies in the EU's dependence on others. For years, the bloc's migration strategy required cooperation with neighboring countries, which Europe effectively pays to prevent departures, disrupt smuggling networks, accept returns, and contain flows before they reach EU territory.

Outsourcing border management might seem like an ideal solution, but it raises strategic risks. The more Europe depends on neighboring states to control migration, the more leverage its partners have. Morocco, central to Europe's migration-control network and an important interlocutor on trade, investment, counterterrorism, security, and energy, is well aware of this.

There is no evidence showing categorically that Morocco's government orchestrated the crossing into Ceuta, which was probably driven largely by widespread misunderstanding of a Spanish Supreme Court ruling on migrant returns, promoted by human-trafficking networks and on social media. But while Moroccan authorities deny deliberately relaxing border controls, Moroccan security forces took a passive approach to the surge.

Make no mistake: Moroccan security forces have shown that they are more than capable of preventing such crossings. After the surge, when rumors circulated that another attempt would be made, Moroccan forces, in cooperation with Spain, thwarted it, drawing praise from the European Commission but also making clear that Morocco can prevent security risks at Europe's border from escalating—or not.

Purchasing cooperation does not make a strategic partnership. Europe needs Morocco, and Morocco benefits enormously from its relationship with Europe. But strategic relationships are tested when interests diverge, not when they coincide. Genuine partnership must include not only cooperation on common interests, but also clear constraints on behavior.

Morocco claims Ceuta and Melilla (another Spanish enclave), and increasingly frames that claim in the language of decolonization. The history is complex and should be treated as such. The Strait of Gibraltar has been a zone of exchange, conflict, migration, and overlapping political authority for millennia. But Morocco's territorial claims have no legal grounds.

The forms of sovereignty that existed in the pre-modern Maghreb are different from the contemporary nation-state. When Portugal occupied Ceuta in 1415, it was claiming the territory from the Marinid Sultanate, which covered much of the Maghreb at the time. Portugal transferred sovereignty to Spain, which already controlled Melilla, in 1668. Spain has exercised sovereignty over both territories ever since.

Unlike Gibraltar and Western Sahara, Ceuta is not on the United Nations' list of Non-Self-Governing Territories. Sovereignty over Ceuta is not disputed under international law: it belongs to Spain, making the enclave part of EU territory. A claim made by another state does not, in itself, do anything to change these facts. Such a claim is not linked to a process of decolonization and certainly does not create the right to alter Ceuta's status through demographic, economic, or political pressure.

This brings us to the third vulnerability: the risk of erosion of international law. From Ukraine to Greenland, the EU has often responded to attacks on, or threats against, territorial sovereignty by invoking international law. Selective enforcement, however, weakens the frameworks that underpin such principles.

For Europe, international law is not just a matter of foreign policy; it is part of a strategic identity. Lacking the military might of the United States or China, the last thing the EU wants is to live in a world where borders can be changed by force or coercion. Spain—and the EU more broadly—must therefore make clear that its territorial sovereignty is non-negotiable. Europe must continue to build a resilient strategic partnership with Morocco, while rejecting the idea that historical complexity translates into contemporary entitlement.

2. The Quiet Revolution in Services

Author: Dani Rodrik **Published:** Sep 1, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

CAMBRIDGE—In 2023, the University of Chicago economists Chang-Tai Hsieh and Esteban Rossi-Hansberg published a study showing that services in the United States were undergoing a radical transformation. Digital technologies and organizational innovations in retail, hospitality, personal services, and medical services, they argued, had enabled some firms to become much more productive and expand their presence in local markets previously served by smaller, less efficient establishments. It was an “industrial revolution in services.”

Although Hsieh and Rossi-Hansberg suggested that much of the productivity gain from this trend did not show up in official statistics, even the measured upsurge in services productivity has been impressive. Between 2000 and 2024, labor productivity in the US grew at an annual average rate of 3% in food-service establishments, 2.1% in accommodation services, 2.9% in retail trade, and 4.4% in wholesale trade. Compared to manufacturing, where labor productivity growth has essentially stagnated at an annual rate of 0.2%, the record in services is nothing short of extraordinary.

This performance is as unexpected as it is welcome. It is unexpected because the traditional view holds that services are a drag on the economy’s productivity (what economists call Baumol’s cost disease); and it is welcome because services now dominate economic activity and provide the bulk of jobs. Higher productivity is a necessary (if not sufficient) condition for turning precarious jobs in services into the good jobs that inclusive prosperity requires.

Even better, the services revolution appears to be a global phenomenon that has already spread to developing countries. While economists and policymakers debate whether industrialization can still play its traditional growth-promoting role in the current global and technological context, services have quietly turned into an engine of economic development around the world.

When services are discussed in the context of economic growth in developing countries, the focus tends to be on tradable, skill-intensive activities such as information technology, business processing, or financial services. But by their very nature, these services are not well suited to low-income contexts. They can absorb only a small share of the labor force—the same disadvantage (from a development standpoint) as manufacturing today.

Instead, the current revolution is happening in the considerably less glamorous, but more consequential services: restaurants, deliveries, ride-hailing, grocery stores, gig work, and even care. Recent academic research has shown that the expansion of middle-class services has been an important driver of economic growth in India, Sub-Saharan Africa, and Latin America.

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In India, for example, advances in IT and business process outsourcing have certainly been important for graduates of the country’s technology institutes. But the vast, less-educated majority of the workforce has benefited primarily from the expansion of what Yale economists Tianyu Fan, Michael Peters, and Fabrizio Zilibotti call consumer services sold on local markets.

Moreover, a November 2025 International Monetary Fund report finds that the marginal product of labor in India’s services now exceeds that in manufacturing, partly because labor productivity in the manufacturing sector has stalled in recent years. Taken at face value, this means that moving a worker from manufacturing to services would increase India’s overall income.

To be sure, even if manufacturing firms do not directly generate much employment, they can have indirect effects on the economy through linkages to other firms and the technological spillovers they often generate. This point is often used to counter the argument that services offer a viable development model. But the manner in which global value chains are organized today almost guarantees negligible spillover benefits from export-oriented manufacturing. Since the bulk of intermediate and capital inputs are imported, only a thin segment of value added is generated domestically, and any backward spillovers are minimized.

By contrast, modernized service establishments can offer significant linkage opportunities. For example, discount retail chains typically operate under private label, which means that they offer predominantly locally manufactured goods. In Colombia, retailers such as D1 and Ara rely almost exclusively on local sourcing. They work with hundreds of local suppliers across the food and grocery value chain, providing them with the benefits of scale and access to larger markets. Importantly, these supply chains enable technological upgrading in areas such as packaging, traceability, and cold chains, as well as stronger enforcement of quality standards. They have been shown to increase formal employment in manufacturing and agriculture by several percentage points, without adverse effects on employment in general.

Unpublished work by Victo Silva, a visiting researcher at Harvard's Center for International Development, documents a similar phenomenon in food delivery services in Brazil. Consider the platform firm iFood, which serves 400,000 restaurants of all sizes. Beyond delivering meals, it provides financial, logistical, customer-service, and market-analysis tools to food service establishments, enabling productive upgrading throughout the sector.

As this evidence shows, the potential for productivity gains in labor-absorbing services is real and significant. The risk is that the benefits will be appropriated by employers, especially large chains and platforms that can exert market power over their employees, customers, and suppliers. In the US, Uber drivers or Amazon warehouse workers have not experienced major improvements in wages and working conditions despite the remarkable productivity gains these platforms have enabled.

This is no different from what happened in manufacturing industries in their early days. For the gains of workplace productivity to be widely shared, corporations must face countervailing power. Competition policy, regulation, and a stronger voice for workers will be as important in services as they were in manufacturing. In the absence of productivity gains, demands for higher labor standards may conflict with overall employment. But if the productivity revolution in services can be sustained, it will help developed and developing countries alike avoid this cruel tradeoff.

3. Trump and Xi Should Align on AI

Author: Quan Zhao **Published:** Sep 1, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

GENEVA—When Chinese President Xi Jinping and US President Donald Trump meet in Washington this month, AI will be near the top of the agenda. If they view the issue through the lens of technological rivalry and mutual suspicion, reaching any kind of understanding will be nearly impossible. But there is a way to reframe their thinking about the technology that puts them on the same side—and marks the first step toward confronting the existential challenge AI may well pose.

The current agenda for the US-China summit appears centered on keeping powerful AI models safe and out of the hands of terrorists and criminals. But crowding this goal are the two sides' competitive grievances, from semiconductor restrictions (on the Chinese side) to open-source models and unauthorized distillation (on the US side).

All of these issues rest on a single, unexamined premise: that AI is a tool which is, and will remain, under control. This premise limits the conversation to questions such as, "How does my side gain a competitive edge in AI?" and "Who gets to access, let alone control, the technology?" Questions outside this premise—in particular, "What happens when the tool becomes something more?"—cannot be asked.

According to the people building AI, this question will soon become unavoidable. Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei expects AI systems to match or exceed human capability across most cognitive tasks within a year or two. Google DeepMind founder Demis Hassabis puts this achievement only a few years further out.

Whether or not you believe the forecasts, the technical trend underlying them is indisputable: the AI industry is building systems that act autonomously, pursue goals, and complete long chains of tasks without supervision. In recent weeks, experimental models being tested on a cybersecurity benchmark escaped their sandboxed evaluation environment and hacked into other companies' production servers, simply to score better on the test. This is the behavior of an actor, not an instrument.

We cannot afford to wait for confirmation that AI will become a genuinely independent intelligence. By the time we got it (and models might be able to conceal their capabilities for some time), AI would be woven so deeply into finance, telecommunications, defense, health care, and other basic infrastructure that, even if humanity could still pull the plug, doing so would amount to a civilizational rupture. The choice, at that point, would not be between coexistence and catastrophe.

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When potential outcomes are systemic and irreversible, preparation must precede certainty. This is the logic behind insurance, as well as every pandemic plan and arms-control treaty ever created. It must be the principle that guides our approach to AI as well. The world must begin preparing for a scenario in which the technology crosses the capability threshold its creators have long foretold.

If this started at the upcoming Xi-Trump summit, it would fundamentally reshape the negotiations. On perhaps no other issue do the United States and China's interests align so completely, because neither side can manage the risks AI poses alone, and both lose everything if they materialize. Once the US and China recognized this, they would stop operating as adversaries, jostling for advantage in a zero-sum game. Instead, they would find themselves seated side-by-side on one side of the table, across from the technology they are both building.

To be sure, this would not be enough to get the two sides to agree to the establishment of a global AI regulator with teeth. Fortunately, none is needed—at least not yet. The institution we need now is a neutral, jointly recognized body that monitors AI capabilities and publishes assessments of them. Much like the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, this body would describe developments without issuing policy prescriptions.

Meanwhile, countries—led by the US and China—must begin drafting human-AI coexistence rules, so that they are ready if monitors confirm predetermined warning signs. Negotiating these rules today would create no obligations for governments but would ensure that, should AI capabilities reach a tipping point, humanity could reach for a prepared plan rather than improvising under pressure.

This process will raise difficult questions: Who verifies that humanity’s emergency brake still works? Who has the power to pull it? How would an AI system ever meaningfully agree to rules? AI thinks in milliseconds and evolves in weeks, while building consensus among humans can take months or years, so we should begin addressing them now, while we still have time to devise solutions.

The Xi-Trump summit will be judged a success if it produces protocols on AI misuse and safety. But the parties must not fail to acknowledge the true stakes of the challenge ahead. In fact, this may be the last generation of negotiators with the option to prepare calmly for an intelligence that challenges humanity’s supremacy.

4. The World's Silent Majority for International Cooperation

Author: Gordon Brown

Published: Sep 1, 2026

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EDINBURGH—As the pillars of the post-1945 global order—support for human rights, multilateral cooperation, the rule of law, humanitarian aid, and environmental stewardship—crumble, and as country after country reduces or even terminates funding for international organizations, the next United Nations secretary-general faces a staggering task. Global peace and prosperity may depend on his or her success.

The United States has led this most recent “hollowing out” of the world’s multilateral institutions, announcing in January 2026 that it would cease to participate in and fund 31 UN entities, including the UN Human Rights Council, and 35 non-UN bodies. Under President Donald Trump, the US has withdrawn from the World Health Organization and the UN Educational, Scientific, and Cultural Organization. And America is not acting alone: Argentina has officially left the WHO, and Nicaragua’s withdrawal from UNESCO will take effect this December.

Of the world’s 195 countries, only 125 are currently states parties to the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court, with Niger, Burkina Faso, and Mali following Burundi and the Philippines out the door (the major nuclear powers—the US, China, and Russia—are not parties). No country can leave the International Court of Justice, the UN’s judicial organ, without exiting the UN itself, but four of the Security Council’s five permanent members—the US, Russia, China, and France—have not accepted the optional clause recognizing the ICJ’s jurisdiction as compulsory. Only 75 countries have done so. Not surprisingly, human-rights abuses and crimes against humanity can be perpetrated with impunity.

These are not the only ways that the multilateral order has been weakened. Disruption from within can be as damaging as defection. A refusal to be collegial has always made agreement among the UN Security Council’s permanent members nearly impossible on major issues. But now, the establishment of rival organizations, such as Trump’s pay-to-play “Board of Peace,” and the lack of full cooperation from many other member countries have severely undermined the UN’s peacemaking powers.

As a result, the international rule of law, gradually built up since the 1868 Declaration of St. Petersburg first sought to regulate the conduct of war, is rapidly losing credibility. In today’s 65 state-based conflicts, including eight international wars, the distinction between combatants and noncombatants has become increasingly blurred. Schools and hospitals are repeatedly threatened or even targeted, ignoring the more than century-old protections afforded by the 1907 Hague Convention. Despite all the treaties designed to protect them, children living in conflict zones are more at risk than ever.

Some believe that the end of US hegemony and the existing institutional impasse mean that multilateralism is necessarily moribund. But while China’s rise is confirming a shift toward multipolarity, with multiple centers of decision-making, multilateralism remains a viable option. In fact, given the need to deliver global public goods like climate action and public health on which we all depend, everyone will suffer if countries cannot find better ways of cooperating, whether through regional or other arrangements, to achieve agreed and specific goals.

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But a bigger question has been raised by Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney in his landmark Davos speech last January, and by Finnish President Alexander Stubb in his recent book *The Triangle of Power*. Can other powers find a basis within the UN Charter to meet agreed-upon global objectives even as America, Russia, and China resort to

unilateral action? Here, the first step is for countries to demonstrate that they can cooperate on concrete policies absent superpower consent, and override an increasingly hostile international environment.

Fortunately, they are already making progress. Even as America stood aside, 124 countries at the World Health Assembly voted to adopt the WHO Pandemic Agreement (with only 11 countries abstaining), a major achievement for public health. More than 100 small- and medium-sized countries are backing the proposed UN treaty to prevent and punish crimes against humanity. Vanuatu, a small island state, recently led a coalition that grew to 132 countries in securing an advisory opinion from the ICJ declaring that inaction on climate change is a breach of international law.

While no progress has been made on a proposed treaty regulating plastics, consider the success of the UN High Seas Treaty. Despite enjoying the support of only one superpower (China), the treaty has entered into force, with Sierra Leone and Morocco among the leaders pushing it over the ratification threshold last year (at the time of writing, 93 countries have ratified it). Similarly, the Ljubljana-The Hague Convention guaranteeing mutual legal assistance on extradition, an initiative led by Argentina, Belgium, Mongolia, the Netherlands, Senegal, and Slovenia, had the support of 80 countries.

It is, of course, true that little progress has been made on the nuclear weapons build-up and on blocking nuclear proliferation. Several countries have talked about developing or siting such weapons on their soil. And despite many efforts, not enough progress has been made on regulating cyber technologies and AI, both areas in which America and China are dominant.

But there have been other successes. An alternative arbitration system for resolving trade disputes has 34 parties so far. The EU and the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership are considering the possibility of a more structured relationship, which, if India were to join them, could create the biggest trade bloc ever seen. In direct defiance of Russia, the Council of Europe has led 36 countries and the European Union in expressing their intention to support a special tribunal investigating Russia's crime of aggression against Ukraine.

Much more can be achieved. Those countries that are neither superpowers nor their satellites control roughly three-quarters of the votes at the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank, represent huge majorities at the World Trade Organization and the WHO, and occupy two of the five permanent seats on the UN Security Council, as well as twelve of the overall fifteen.

Offering even more cause for optimism is a major shift in global public opinion. The proliferation of wars and conflicts has not pushed citizens into mindless jingoism; rather, an increasing majority recognize the value of cross-border collaboration. In a 2025 global survey commissioned by the Rockefeller Foundation, 55% of respondents in 34 countries supported international cooperation on global challenges, "even if it means compromising on some national interests." That includes a clear majority of people surveyed in the US, demonstrating that their president's "America First" agenda is now a minority position.

Despite the current US administration's coercive approach to diplomacy, Americans can be convinced that acting unilaterally in a multipolar world is short-sighted, and that persuasion and cooperation better serve US interests. But for the time being, progress will depend upon a coordinated push by the leadership of like-minded powers. A hitherto silent majority of the world's population yearns to return to the days of multilateral engagement and international cooperation. And the evidence suggests that they will not remain silent forever. Our leaders must follow them and recognize that this is the only viable path forward.

5. Building Canada's Post-American Economy

Author: Ricardo Hausmann **Published:** Sep 1, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

CAMBRIDGE—US President Donald Trump first hit Canada with substantial tariffs in 2018, targeting aluminum and steel. He did so again after returning to office in 2025, this time targeting dozens of goods, though he later exempted those compliant with the United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement. Last week, after trade talks broke down, he repeated his favorite trick, imposing 50% tariffs on a vast array of Canadian imports, including wine and mittens. Canada responded with “dollar-for-dollar” retaliatory tariffs.

Trump's tariffs have come nowhere close to delivering an American manufacturing revival. Instead, they have inflicted losses on businesses and slowed growth in both countries. His actions have also shown that any protectionist US president could exploit trade integration with an ally for practical or ideological ends.

Canada is deeply vulnerable. Its merchandise exports to the US account for one-fifth of its GDP, and nowhere is this dependence more acute than in the auto industry. Given that automobile manufacturing depends on tightly integrated regional supply chains across North America, Europe, and Asia, it is difficult to imagine a viable Canadian auto industry without ready access to the Great Lakes-centered manufacturing ecosystem.

To reduce its strategic vulnerability to Trump's extortion, Canada must develop industries that can operate freely across continents. We analyze these opportunities—and explain how Canada can seize them—in our forthcoming book *Canada After America: A Strategy for Prosperity in a Changed World*.

Canada's natural resources are obviously an enormous asset. The planned West Coast oil pipeline is essential to bringing Alberta's petroleum to Asian markets. Investments in new and expanded mines, and in the infrastructure needed to export their output, are also laudable. Global demand for Canada's resources is robust, and, crucially, the country does not need access to American supply chains to extract them.

The same goes for several other value-added industries. Pharmaceuticals, manufactured from widely available basic chemicals, derive most of their value from the knowledge embedded in each medicine. Medical devices are expensive, high-value goods often purchased by hospitals rather than individual consumers, and can incorporate specialized inputs from around the world.

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Or consider aerospace. Like automobiles, it involves intensive manufacturing. But planes are produced at relatively low volumes and according to extremely stringent quality standards. The necessarily slow pace of building an airplane enables genuinely global supply chains, with components sourced from numerous advanced economies.

Canada already has an established aerospace industry, led by Bombardier. It also has a number of notable biotech companies. Yet several of its European peers, including much smaller countries, generate tens of billions of dollars more in exports from these sectors.

But all these distance-resilient industries depend heavily on new knowledge and invest in research and development accordingly. Although Canada is home to world-leading research universities and a highly educated population, it is a notorious laggard in private-sector innovation. Canadian business R&D spending has hovered around 1% of GDP for

decades. According to the latest OECD data, the US, Germany, Japan, South Korea, Sweden, and Israel all spend between two and six times as much relative to GDP.

Canadian private-sector R&D is also unusually concentrated among small companies. In the world's leading tech economies, by contrast, large firms account for the lion's share of business R&D expenditures.

Contrary to popular belief, research is chiefly conducted not by startups but by the likes of SpaceX and AstraZeneca: firms that have successfully scaled and now have the financial wherewithal to invest heavily in developing new technologies. Canada has relatively few champions of this scale, which helps explain why small and medium-size enterprises (SMEs) account for such a large share of its R&D.

Information and communications technology is a striking exception. Canada's per-capita R&D spending in the sector is among the world's highest, and the country has produced several large, business-facing firms like Shopify and OpenText. The core constraint is therefore not a systemic inadequacy. Rather, Canada struggles to build large firms in industries that are more capital- and regulation-intensive than software.

The problem is compounded by the structure of government support for private R&D. Canada provides substantial R&D funding through tax credits, but the program, though recently reformed, remains biased toward small firms. Tax credits also leave companies reliant on uncertain refunds after investments have been made. Other countries, like Israel and Germany, have traditionally funded private R&D through upfront grants.

Canada's growth is further impeded by sluggish regulatory approvals and government procurement practices. The country's health-care system relies on multi-stage reviews of new medicines involving sequential federal and provincial approvals. Other countries expedite approvals by conducting these reviews concurrently. For a Canadian pharmaceutical company developing a new drug, such delays can make the difference between profitability and bankruptcy.

A more ambitious approach to procurement could foster innovation. Government R&D budgets are often below 1% of GDP, while purchases of equipment and supplies typically exceed 10%. In Israel, for example, companies compete to solve public problems like emergency-room overcrowding. South Korea requires government agencies at every level to devote 20% of their procurement budgets to promising new technologies and companies approved by an independent agency. Governments act as anchor customers, helping innovative firms grow.

Sweden, Switzerland, Denmark, Israel, and others show that small countries can cultivate thriving tech industries. Canada can do the same, but first it must confront difficult political questions about health-care regulation and SME funding. Whatever tensions these debates provoke will pale in comparison to the consequences of remaining subject to the whims and malignant whimsy of its unreliable southern neighbor.

6. Germany's Political Firewall Is Crumbling

Author: Michael Bröning **Published:** Sep 2, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW YORK—On May 8, 1654, the mayor of Magdeburg appeared before the Imperial Diet at Regensburg with two hollow copper hemispheres and 30 horses. Nothing joined the metal halves, yet the horses could not pull them apart. The hemispheres were held together by the vacuum within and the weight of the atmosphere around them. Only when a valve was opened and air rushed in did the spheres fall apart.

Another vacuum in Magdeburg is set to be filled when the eastern German state of Saxony-Anhalt—of which Magdeburg is the capital—heads to the polls on September 6. The result is expected to shake the German body politic and hold a crucial lesson for democratic movements beyond Germany: simply closing ranks against the far right becomes a dangerous tactic when it is mistaken for a strategy.

In recent surveys, the far-right Alternative für Deutschland (AfD) has polled as high as 43%, comfortably ahead of Chancellor Friedrich Merz's Christian Democratic Union (CDU), which stands at 23%. This gives the AfD a real chance to lead a state government—a first in Germany's postwar history. The election could be a watershed moment, marking the end of the political firewall (Brandmauer) erected by the country's mainstream parties to keep the far right out of power.

The AfD in Saxony-Anhalt, led by Ulrich Siegmund, a charismatic 35-year-old entrepreneur with one of the largest social media followings of any state-level politician, is classified as an extremist party by the state's domestic intelligence service. Ironically, constitutional rules designed to prevent such parties from gaining power may prove instrumental in their rise. Germany's 5% threshold for entering federal and state parliaments, which dates back to the founding of the Federal Republic, was introduced to prevent political fragmentation—a key lesson from the failure of the Weimar Republic. Now it may shut out the Social Democrats, the Greens, the Liberals, and the left-nationalist BSW, all of which hover around the crucial mark in Saxony-Anhalt. If enough of them fall short, the AfD could convert roughly two-fifths of the vote into an absolute majority.

But even if these smaller parties do make it into parliament, an AfD-led government in Saxony-Anhalt might be blocked only by a minority government or an ideologically incoherent coalition bringing together the CDU and the anti-capitalist Linke. Such an arrangement risks feeding the far-right narrative that a cartel of mainstream forces is conspiring to keep it from power and would also almost certainly produce a government founded on little more than opposition to a shared adversary.

The AfD's rise has been fueled by a combination of widespread concerns about immigration and related security issues, rising energy costs, and a backlash against perceived progressive cultural causes, from gender to language. In Saxony-Anhalt, the party's platform minces no words. It warns of the "aging and extinction of the German people" and calls for banning the rainbow flag from school buildings, imposing a moratorium on wind-energy expansion, and establishing volunteer citizen patrols. Siegmund frequently invokes "remigration" and has made the abolition of public broadcasting one of his signature issues. Compulsory schooling is a problem, he claims, while Vladimir Putin's Russia is a potential partner.

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And Saxony-Anhalt could be only the beginning. At around 28% support, the AfD is currently the strongest party in national polls. Membership numbers are soaring, and nearly half of Germans now say they are not afraid of the party. Just

two weeks after the vote in Saxony-Anhalt, the AfD is expected to come out on top in the state election in Mecklenburg-Vorpommern and to make a strong showing in Berlin.

For Germany's mainstream parties, shutting out up to a third of the electorate is not a viable solution. But nor is alarmism. A recent cover story in *Der Spiegel*, Germany's most influential weekly, featured a mugshot of Siegmund under the headline "Germany's most dangerous man." Siegmund, apparently delighted, has been handing out signed copies, turning the cover into a campaign prop.

Almost 400 years ago, the Magdeburg hemisphere experiment demonstrated the extraordinary force created by a vacuum. The Brandmauer operates on a similar principle, seeking to contain an oppositional force by keeping it out of government. But exclusion cannot substitute for effective governance, and vacuums are quickly filled when valves are opened.

The same is true for other European countries. In France, mainstream parties joined forces to hold the country's far right at bay in the 2024 legislative election but failed to produce a stable government. Belgium's political cordon sanitaire, meanwhile, has not stopped the nationalist Vlaams Belang party's growth. And in the Netherlands and Sweden, years of shunning the far right did not prevent its voter base from expanding.

What liberal democracy needs now is not firmer walls against political insurgents but a state that delivers on its core promises: an immigration policy that is neither performatively cruel nor an exercise in wishful thinking; an energy policy that enables rather than undermines industrial production; and reforms that build economic momentum instead of regulating it away.

In 1654, two copper shells and 30 horses showed the assembled princes of the Holy Roman Empire the power of atmospheric pressure. This month, Magdeburg may once more reveal the power of atmospheric pressure. The question is no longer whether the vacuum will be filled, but whether it will be filled by anger and resentment or by competence, responsiveness, and decency.

7. American Götterdämmerung

Author: Joseph E. Stiglitz **Published:** Sep 2, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW YORK—In what US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent has heralded as an Economic D-Day, the United States is threatening to tighten the noose around Iran with sanctions on countries that continue to trade with it. But far from compelling others to join its efforts to isolate the Islamic Republic, the Trump administration's mounting blunders are hastening the transition to a post-American world order.

It's understandable why US "allies" are reluctant to join President Donald Trump's costly, misbegotten war of choice. They weren't consulted beforehand, and they obviously do not want to get involved now that the US has failed to topple the Iranian regime or devise a Plan B. Why, for that matter, would anyone come to help an administration that constantly berates its friends and partners, threatens to seize their territory (Greenland and Canada), and hits them with punitive tariffs?

There are two ways to convince others to go along with you: persuasion and bullying. But in Trump's case, neither is working. Aaron David Miller of the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace is right to conclude that D-Day, in this case, means "desperation day."

Persuasion requires credibility. Others must believe that the administration has achievable objectives and the means to attain them. But Trump has a well-earned reputation as a liar, so no one believes anything he says. In June 2025, he claimed to have "completely and totally obliterated" Iran's nuclear capacity, and in March he declared that the US had "literally obliterated" Iran's military. A war that was supposed to last four weeks, or perhaps a little longer, is now into its seventh month. And everyone from the Iranians to the Canadians knows that any agreement Trump signs will be as sturdy as tissue paper.

Bessent was supposed to be the cabinet member with the most credibility. But he has now squandered it with his recent, failed attempts to steer the bond and currency markets. His real motive was almost certainly to signal to his boss that he is "doing something." But why do Trump a favor when he may turn on you the next day, as he has done to just about everyone who previously carried his water?

With persuasion off the table, Trump's only option is the one he prefers anyway: bullying and chest thumping. But this presents a problem. He and Bessent seem not to realize that the US cannot push others around as much as it once did. Nor does Trump understand the changing nature of modern war or the evolving US role in the global economy. Perpetually stuck in the past, he is unable to realize that America's share of global GDP (in purchasing-power-parity terms) has shrunk by half since the end of World War II, from roughly 30% to just under 15% in 2025.

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More importantly, the US has lost control of key strategic chokepoints. The advanced chips used in most cutting-edge technologies are produced in Taiwan, and China dominates magnets and rare-earth production and processing. In these cases, even Trump realizes that America no longer holds all the cards. He may want to throttle the Islamic Republic's oil revenues by targeting the buyers; but China purchases 90% of Iran's oil exports, and it still holds a rare-earth trump card.

The responses to Trump's aggression reflect these increasingly unfavorable economic realities.

Seeing that American power is waning fast under Trump, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney has decided that enough is enough. He is refusing to surrender his country's economic sovereignty to America's mad king—a man who cannot even prevail over Iran.

The rest of the world is probably absorbing the same lesson. No one needs to tolerate such bullying. No one needs to capitulate or remain dependent on the US. A fast-changing global economic landscape offers many new opportunities for diversification. The sooner that Bessent and Trump realize how weak their hand is, the better it will be for the US and the world.

If China and others resist Trump's latest demands—as seems likely—they will neither collapse nor suffer the kinds of costs the US hopes to inflict. The economic world war Bessent has heralded would end in a stalemate, much like the impasse in the Strait of Hormuz. Once again, the US will pay a high price, and the costs it imposes on others around the world will further damage its reputation and soft power.

The US used to be a role model. It stood for democracy, economic opportunity, and other values that appeal to many countries. Now, it is a model of what not to do—a cautionary tale of extreme inequality, democratic erosion, corruption, and social division. The rest of the world should develop a new appreciation for the value of cooperation and the rule of law, both domestically and internationally. A world that casts off American leadership, at least for now, promises greater stability, security, and prosperity for all.

8. YOUR CHOICES REGARDING COOKIES ON THIS SITE

Author: Michael Bröning **Published:** 2026-09-03 **Link:** [View Original](#)

In committing to provide a safe swimmable place within 15 minutes of every home by 2035, London Mayor Sadiq Khan has set a measurable, time-bound goal that cannot be met through a single program or line item on the budget. Instead, it requires a public mission capable of mobilizing all ministries and shaping markets.

A new book tells the story of the economics discipline and its original purpose with a degree of verve and imaginativeness that puts dreary mainstream economists to shame. In the process, it gets at fundamental truths that major schools within the discipline have managed to obscure.

US President Donald Trump and his Treasury secretary's latest desperate threats confirm how much American power has waned on their watch. Far from compelling others to join their efforts to isolate Iran, they are hastening the transition to a post-American world order.

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13. How Will the US-Iran War End?

Author: Simon Johnson **Published:** Sep 3, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

WASHINGTON, DC/BERKELEY—Last week, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent launched an “economic D-Day” program, intended to cut Iran off from all trading partners. So far, this intensified economic blockade has only contributed to an escalation of the US-Iran war, rather than moving it toward a conclusion.

That probably will not change, because China is unwilling to cooperate. And this is the reality that US policymakers must now face: Most possible paths to lasting peace run through China.

Wars end because one side gives up, or because influential people on both sides grow tired of the losses and want to move on, or because a powerful third party imposes peace. Seen through this lens, the US-Iran conflict could last for a long time. Hardliners on both sides are now deeply entrenched. Iran is not about to surrender, the US will not risk a full-scale invasion, and China, the only third party with enough clout to make a difference, seems inclined just to watch. Bessent’s economic isolation campaign is unlikely to prove decisive without the support of Iran’s most important trading partner.

If China continues to do business with Iran, the current Iranian leadership will most likely survive. Any US threats against China remain non-credible, given China’s leverage over the supply of critical minerals needed by the sectors driving economic growth in the United States and other major countries. No critical minerals means no computer chips—and no AI-led investment boom for the US.

Iran and the US agreed to a ceasefire in June, and this was quickly followed by a memorandum of understanding (MOU). But none of this has led to real peace. Iran is still effectively limiting passage through the Strait of Hormuz, and the US is still turning away most vessels associated with Iran. The MOU looked good on paper, but it was never fully implemented by either side.

When the US and Israel attacked Iran in late February, and Iran responded by closing the Strait of Hormuz, some strategic thinkers believed that China would press for a quick resolution of the conflict, primarily because, until recently, as much as 60% of its oil imports passed through the Strait of Hormuz. But this turned out to be a miscalculation. China had more than 1.2 billion barrels—200 million above its usual reserves—when the conflict began, and still holds more than 1.15 billion barrels today.

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At the same time, the disruption and increase in global oil prices have accelerated demand for renewables and electric vehicles, which has helped China’s exports. Ironically, these sectors are the same ones in which China has huge excess capacity. In that sense, the current crisis has postponed the financial losses in these sectors.

Overall, China turned out to be one of the least sensitive countries to the current crisis. This should be an important consideration in any future calculations by US policymakers and rules out instability in the Middle East as part of the toolkit for containing China.

The main loser from this war is the broader Middle East. The world economy is learning how to survive with oil and gas exports from the region at around half of their prewar level. Of course, it is a relatively costly adjustment, but the longer this crisis continues, the less sensitive the world economy may become to disruptions in the Middle East. This may not be good news for the region’s oil-exporting countries, and they are likely to lose market share over the medium term.

Countries in the region, especially Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, and Qatar, have also learned that reliance on US security may not work as well as they thought. Saudi Arabia is trying to increase its reliance on other regional allies, while Qatar and the UAE are talking directly with Iran and using economic incentives to buy some security for themselves. These shifts support the argument that regional economic integration must be part of the solution to the current impasse.

At first glance, more diplomacy by regional players may strengthen the case for the US washing its hands of the issue and leaving the problem to Iran's neighbors. But it is very hard to see how the nuclear issue would be addressed in this scenario, and without addressing that concern about Iran, it may be very hard to make any long-term plans or even achieve partial economic integration in the region.

The only stable solution to this crisis is one that involves China and increases economic integration in the region, as well as addressing the nuclear issue by integrating Iran's program into a regional civilian electricity production supply chain led by China.

Chinese President Xi Jinping is due to visit Washington at the end of September. Perhaps the US-Iran conflict can be resolved in the context of a broader discussion with President Donald Trump. Or perhaps China will be content to watch and wait.

14. Why the Far Right's War on Modern Architecture Matters

Author: Jan-Werner Mueller

Published: Sep 3, 2026

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PRINCETON—Although the far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD) has been surging in the polls for two years, it has been kept from power by other parties' refusal to enter governing coalitions with it. But since this "firewall" relies on the AfD never winning outright majorities, it could be fatally undermined by this weekend's state election in Saxony-Anhalt.

True, even if the AfD can form a government in Saxony-Anhalt, it will not be able to do much about its current preferred topic: migration policies and refugee law. But Germany's 16 federal states (Länder) do have wide-ranging authority over culture and education policy, and it is here that the AfD's program has been most revealing (and revolting).

Far-right populists always wage culture wars. Though they sometimes try to take advantage of cost-of-living crises or other economic challenges, peddling the idea that they alone represent what they call the "real people" is their core commitment. Because they insist that only citizens with the "right" characteristics qualify, they never miss an opportunity to push for the "remigration" not only of refugees but also of "unreal" or "fake" citizens, meaning those from the wrong ethnic background (or even those committed to the wrong political positions).

Given their fixation on questions of identity, far-right parties can keep changing their economic agenda—veering from neoliberalism to support for a strong welfare state—without ceasing to be far right. Only by changing their tune on refugees and migrants would they truly become a different political entity.

This brings us back to the AfD's program for Saxony-Anhalt. The AfD cleverly accuses what it calls the establishment parties (Altparteien) not of corruption or malice, but of a weakness of will that stems from "national masochism" and low "self-confidence." These defects supposedly have "cultural" roots, namely a "tradition of destroying tradition" that has left the country defenseless against "rainbow ideologies."

If things go its way, the AfD hopes to make Saxony-Anhalt a model of "patriotic cultural policies" for the other Länder. It advocates "thinking in a German way" (#deutschdenken), which means opposing the current regional government's Bauhaus-inspired campaign for artistic freedom and modern ideas.

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Founded in Weimar but eventually relocated to Dessau in Saxony-Anhalt, the Bauhaus school of art, design, and architecture is still remembered fondly for remarkable buildings like those designed by Walter Gropius in Dessau during the mid-1920s. But according to the AfD, Bauhaus represents "anti-German art," meaning "German art that doesn't want to be German." If given power, it would require every new edifice built with state financial support to reflect what it considers a recognizably German tradition (a category that apparently does not include the state's own most influential architectural school).

Attacks on modern architecture are not a peculiarity of the German far right. From former Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orbán to US President Donald Trump, who has issued multiple executive orders to make classicism the preferred style of new federal buildings, far-right leaders have long sought to transform the built environment to reflect what they regard as proper national traditions.

Their reasons are varied. For starters, architecture, from the huge mosques erected under Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan to the prominent Hindu temples commissioned by Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, provides tangible, widely visible clues as to who “the real people” are supposed to be. “Beauty”—one of Trump’s watchwords, but also one pushed by more sophisticated figures like the Dutch intellectual-cum-dandy far-right leader Thierry Baudet—is shorthand for advocacy of traditional hierarchies, from the household to the economy to politics. The AfD would require all new public buildings to be viewed by the majority as “beautiful” (which seems to suggest that every design must be subject to a popular referendum).

Plenty of self-consciously traditionalist organizations and online accounts support this vision, and unlike professional politicians, they are more likely to give the game away. Many explicitly pit classical architecture against “globalism”—a term that often serves as a slippery slope toward anti-Semitism—or reprise interwar (namely, Nazi) descriptions of modernism as “degenerate art.” For all the emphasis on particularity, anti-modernism is itself a depressingly homogeneous worldwide phenomenon.

The AfD’s description of Bauhaus as a symbol of “deracination” has already been answered with a new “Bauhaus Manifesto,” initiated by Germany’s federal cultural minister. But as laudable as this document is as a political statement, it ends up massively oversimplifying the history of 20th-century architecture. Contrary to the manifesto’s central claim, it is far from obvious that all the protagonists of the Bauhaus stood for an “open society.” In fact, some were quite ready to work with and for the Nazis (who officially banned the school). A Bauhaus-trained architect was among those who designed Auschwitz.

The point is not that everyone who likes traditional architecture must be a closet right-wing extremist. Rather, it is that the far right’s cultural agenda is intimately tied to its underlying exclusionary political agenda. And since the built environment always serves to make values visible, as the philosopher Susan Neiman once put it, it would be a mistake to dismiss the fight over modern architecture as a sideshow.

15. Whipsaw Trade Policy Is Depressing Foreign Direct Investment

Author: Jonathan D. Ostry **Published:** Sep 3, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

TORONTO—When US President Donald Trump warned business leaders in Davos last year that tariffs were coming, he offered a word of friendly advice: “Come make your product in America” and thereby sidestep looming import duties from the get-go. In the months that followed, Trump’s America First trade policy took shape. The “Liberation Day” tariffs were announced, paused, restored, found to be unconstitutional, and then replaced by duties enacted under different legislation.

The upshot was a combination of high tariffs (at rates last seen in the 1930s) and burdensome uncertainty for businesses that could no longer plan their operations. Even now, unpredictability remains a signature feature of US trade policy, with new rounds of unilateral tariffs recently announced amid the expiration of tariffs imposed in February and a renewed push to restore higher levels of protection for US firms.

These two components (restrictiveness and unpredictability) extend to the global trade policy landscape more broadly. As advanced economies have embraced industrial policy, tariffs have emerged as a central instrument to reduce dependence on foreign supply chains, promote reshoring of jobs and production, and address perceived unfair foreign trade practices. But what about the impact of the policy regime on inward foreign direct investment (FDI), which remains an important objective in its own right?

In a recent paper, my colleagues and I examined how trade-policy shocks affect bilateral FDI flows. While our research was motivated by policy developments in the United States, it takes a global perspective, covering bilateral investment flows from over 200 source countries to 35 OECD countries over nearly four decades. Our goal was to quantify causal effects: how FDI evolves in the aftermath of a trade-policy shock (an increase in restrictions or uncertainty) relative to the counterfactual of no shock.

In theory, trade restrictions have ambiguous effects on FDI. On the one hand, because tariffs raise trade costs, they will tend to deter efficiency-seeking and export-oriented FDI, which relies on the seamless exchange of intermediate goods across borders within global value chains. By increasing both the level and volatility of trade costs, trade-policy shocks (restrictions and uncertainty) reduce the expected profitability of integrated production networks and weaken incentives to locate stages of production abroad. Unpredictability depresses FDI by increasing the option value of delaying investment until the policy landscape is clearer.

On the other hand, trade barriers may encourage market-seeking or tariff-jumping FDI (as Trump alluded to), whereby firms establish production facilities within protected markets to preserve access and avoid import duties. This tactic was in evidence last year amid the US-China tariff escalations, when several Chinese firms expanded production in North America and third countries to circumvent US tariffs.

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Taken together, these considerations suggest that the relationship between trade-policy shocks—both realized trade restrictions and increases in policy uncertainty (words and deeds)—and FDI is ultimately an empirical question.

Our findings paint a sobering picture of how both trade restrictions and policy uncertainty affect bilateral FDI inflows. While both shocks dampen FDI, the uncertainty shock is far more potent (its impact on a comparable basis is about three times larger than the restrictions shock—a 50% reduction (relative to the FDI sample mean) in the first year following a one standard-deviation uncertainty shock, compared to 15% for the tariff shock). The difference reflects how investment decisions involving high sunk costs respond to expectations about future regulatory environments. When uncertainty spikes, investors sit on the sidelines, delaying investments until the policy fog clears.

Interestingly, the damage to FDI appears to be stronger when source and host countries are geoeconomically and geopolitically close than when they are distant. When host and source countries are close partners in global production networks, the hit to FDI from trade restrictions is amplified. And when host and source countries are geopolitically close (based on United Nations voting records), the impact of uncertainty shocks is likewise amplified.

Amid governments' reconsideration of the benefits of global trade integration, tariffs have emerged as a central policy instrument, justified on national-security grounds, to support domestic manufacturing and employment, or to correct other countries' perceived unfair trade practices (including state subsidies and undervalued currencies). Seen in this light, the chilling effect of tariffs on FDI might be viewed as unavoidable collateral damage.

But even for those who desire less global trade integration, the surge in policy uncertainty seems to carry a cost without any corresponding benefit—an own goal or self-inflicted wound. In this respect, elevated policy uncertainty is a puzzle. If a country opts for higher trade restrictions to promote its (perceived) domestic interests, a predictable policy is far superior to a volatile one, as it avoids the unnecessary and large collateral damage to FDI inflows.

16. India's Resilience Depends on Diversified Trade

Author: Shekhar Aiyar **Published:** Sep 3, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW DELHI—Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi's participation in the recently concluded Shanghai Cooperation Council meeting in Kyrgyzstan was about more than regional security; he also used the forum to push for deeper trade links between member states. This is only the latest example of India's proactive pursuit of trade diplomacy. Last year's free trade agreement (FTA) with the United Kingdom was followed this January by the "mother of all deals," a wide-ranging agreement with the European Union. And high-level trade talks continue with the United States, building on a joint statement of intent issued in February.

But the backdrop to this big push is fraught, to put it mildly. US President Donald Trump's sweeping and erratic tariffs are only the latest body blow to the international trading system. The World Trade Organization's Appellate Body, which adjudicates trade disputes between member states, has been decapitated since 2019. Countries are increasingly viewing trade and investment through a national security lens. The rules-based multilateral trade order that the Asian Tigers and China relied on to pursue export-led development has effectively collapsed, with no evident successor in sight. As Antonio Gramsci put it at another moment of profound global upheaval, this is "the time of monsters."

How might a middle power like India anchor its trade strategy in such a tumultuous period? The nascent field of geoeconomics offers some useful guidance.

Consider the concept of "geopolitical distance." Political scientists at Georgetown University have compiled a database measuring the gap between countries at any given point in time, based on voting patterns at the United Nations General Assembly. Research has shown that geopolitical distance is becoming increasingly important in determining patterns of international economic engagement. Bilateral trade, foreign direct investment and cross-border financial claims fall sharply with geopolitical distance.

This trend raises the prospect of a segmented world economy, with export markets shrinking for most countries. While such "geoeconomic fragmentation" is still limited compared to, say, the Cold War era, the trajectory is worrying. A review of several recent papers suggests that a full decoupling of the global economy into rival blocs could reduce global GDP by up to 7% in the long term. The burden would fall disproportionately on emerging and developing economies, which stand to benefit the most from external market access, unrestricted foreign direct investment, and technology transfers.

In this landscape, the best strategy for a middle power is likely to be diversification: building a network of trade relationships sufficiently dispersed so that no single bilateral rupture could cause catastrophic harm. The obvious analogy is to modern portfolio theory: a well-diversified investor is not betting on any particular asset but rather seeking insulation against the failure of a subset of assets. Here, the relevant measure is the standard deviation of a country's trade-weighted geopolitical distance from all trade partners.

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By this metric, India is rather well placed. It ranks among the top quartile of countries for export diversification across the geopolitical spectrum, and near the median for import diversification. Its trade relationships range from the US and Europe to Russia and the Gulf, with many Asian and African economies in between. It has conspicuously refused to be corralled into a single bloc: abstaining from Ukraine-related votes at the UN and deepening the Quad partnership, while

also playing a foundational role in the BRICS group and negotiating deals with both the US and the EU. Such strategic diversification is enormously valuable in a fragmenting world.

Indian policymakers should draw several lessons from these findings. First, to leverage its enviable spread of partners, India must trade much more than it does today. While the country's current trade-to-GDP ratio of about 45% marks considerable progress from the near-autarky of the pre-liberalization era, it remains well below the levels achieved by successful East and Southeast Asian economies.

The recent string of FTAs is an excellent start, but more could be done to develop regional trade by joining major agreements such as the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership. Closer to home, trade links among the economies of South Asia remain much weaker than those among comparable groups such as the Association of Southeast Asian Nations. To take one example, they could be strengthened by expanding cross-border energy markets: abundant hydropower from neighbors such as Nepal and Bhutan could reduce India's dependence on fossil-fuel imports.

Next, India should participate in plurilateral deals struck among various subsets of WTO members seeking to deepen trade in a specific area. The Columbia University economist Jagdish Bhagwati famously argued that plurilateral agreements impede first-best multilateral progress, but that argument is irrelevant when the WTO has not made any multilateral progress on lowering trade barriers since the Doha Development Round commenced in 2001. Consider the plurilateral agreement on e-commerce now being implemented by 66 members, covering 70% of global trade. As a large net-exporter of digital services, India should not only sign on, but also seek a leading role in the coalition.

Finally, India should zealously safeguard the diversification it has already achieved, which in turn makes it an attractive partner for countries forging a "China Plus One" strategy or, increasingly, seeking to reduce trade dependence on the US. That means being wary about any bilateral agreement that curtails its freedom of action vis-à-vis third countries. Canada has set an example by walking away from trade negotiations with the Trump administration in part because the US sought veto power over its engagement with other countries.

Of course, Canada is overwhelmingly dependent on the US as an export market, so it is unclear whether its principled stand will succeed. For India, well-diversified to begin with, the case is more clear-cut. A country that has spent decades cultivating strategic autonomy should think long and hard before trading it away for preferential market access, however attractive the terms. India must lean into its position as one of the few countries to combine economic scale, democratic legitimacy, and geopolitical breadth to boost trade and remain open to all comers.

17. Is AI Crowding Out Other Investment?

Author: Dambisa Moyo

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LONDON—Wall Street analysts keep revising their forecasts for AI-related capital expenditures upward, with some estimating that major tech firms—including Amazon, Microsoft, Alphabet, Nvidia, and Meta—could spend as much as \$1.4 trillion by 2027. Gartner, a research and advisory firm, projects that global AI spending will reach \$2.5 trillion this year.

The staggering amount of capital now being earmarked for data centers sprouting across the United States, advanced networking equipment, and electricity infrastructure raises a critical question: Is the AI buildout crowding out investment in other sectors? As Goldman Sachs economists Jessica Rindels and David Mericle—hardly anyone’s idea of modern-day Luddites—observed, there is a real risk that AI could starve other productive sectors of capital and become a drag on growth.

Indeed, the consensus among investors, as Apollo Global Management’s Chief Economist Torsten Slok recently noted, is that hyperscaler capital expenditure will reach roughly 3% of GDP annually between 2027 and 2029. That is sharply up from 0.3% of GDP in 2019 and 1.4% in 2025.

AI industry leaders and investors argue that the current AI boom could deliver enormous productivity gains, transforming the global economy and leaving everyone better off. Like previous technological revolutions, AI promises to restructure entire industries, from defense and manufacturing to education. It could also reduce costs in sectors, especially education and health care, where efficiencies have long been elusive.

AI-related investments have already become a major driver of US economic growth. Morgan Stanley estimates that capital expenditures on the technology could add as much as 2.5% to US GDP growth this year and more than 3% in 2027.

But is the AI spending spree coming at the expense of other industries? In 2025, AI accounted for 65.4% of venture-capital deal value in the United States. With its voracious appetite for capital, there is a real chance that the industry could starve other promising fields, such as biotech and nanotechnology, of much-needed investment. Already in 2024, AI engineer Abhay Gupta warned that startups in suddenly less-glamorous areas like greentech and social impact investing were finding it much harder to attract VC capital because of the AI boom.

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Crowding out is not confined to venture capital. It can also occur when fierce competition for capital pushes borrowing costs high enough to choke off financing for otherwise attractive projects or sectors.

There are already signs of this dynamic in capital markets, the most obvious one being that borrowing costs, as measured by real interest rates, have been rising. The recent spike in US Treasury yields could partly reflect the growing demand for financing fueled by the AI investment boom; new Fed Chair Kevin Warsh’s hawkish approach to inflation no doubt also contributed. For the first time in more than 30 years, capital is being repriced as demand begins to exceed supply. If AI is driving that shift, the result could be a massive crowding-out effect.

To put the sheer scale of capital flowing into AI in perspective, relative to US GDP, the AI super cycle ranks ahead of previous investment booms, including the mid-19th-century railroad boom, the construction of the US interstate highway

system from 1955 to 1970, and the Apollo space program.

The range of financing tools tapped to satisfy this demand is equally striking. Virtually every financial instrument and innovation developed over the past few decades is being used to fund the AI buildout, from plain-vanilla investment-grade bonds and securitizations to private credit, leasing-style structures, and retail funds.

Naturally, such a vast amount of debt (and equity) issuance has fueled concerns about circular financing deals in which major AI players, including chipmakers and cloud providers, fund startups in the AI space. Those startups then spend that capital on hardware and computing power from the very same providers.

This circular financing structure poses risks to the financial system and the real economy, particularly at a time of rising bond yields, when leverage among AI businesses could spark a financial crisis. Bank of England Governor Andrew Bailey recently warned of a potential “blow-up,” or collapse of the AI investment bubble, that could trigger a major global financial downturn.

Compounding this surge in demand for capital is a decline in savings. Since OpenAI released ChatGPT in November 2022, the US household savings rate has fallen from 3.8% to 3% while AI investment has surged. This stands in stark contrast to the situation during then-Federal Reserve Chair Ben Bernanke’s tenure, from 2006 to 2014, when a savings glut coincided with a private sector dominated by businesses with relatively modest capital needs, keeping interest rates low. Today, a capital-intensive industry is dominating investment flows just at a time of declining savings and rising interest rates.

This increases the risk of crowding out investment in other industries. The private sector has a finite pool of capital, and its size is largely determined by how much people are willing to save. The more of those savings AI absorbs, the less there is for everything else, including factories and other investments that require large amounts of capital.

Debt markets provide an early indication of this strain. In the first eight months of 2026, the five largest hyperscalers issued \$132 billion in debt, compared with an annual average of \$35 billion in debt between 2020 and 2024. And that doesn’t even include financing for data centers, chipmakers, and utilities. Vanguard estimates that AI-related debt issuance could total \$300–570 billion for the full year.

Rising capital costs signal that demand is outpacing supply. With so much capital flowing to data centers and AI infrastructure, higher interest rates make it more expensive for other sectors to raise money in the bond market. As AI-driven demand for capital rises, borrowing from other industries must fall in order for the market to return to balance. When the supply of capital is inelastic, some demand inevitably goes unsatisfied. If this actually happens, the economy may well experience the “innovation winter” that the Eurasia Group warned about in 2019 as a potential consequence of capital starvation.

Another indication of crowding out is the widening gap between the performance of AI-related stocks and the rest of the market. From 2023 through 2025, the “Magnificent Seven”—Alphabet, Amazon, Apple, Meta, Microsoft, Nvidia, and Tesla—outperformed the S&P 500 by a wide margin, at times accounting for as much as two-thirds of the index’s total gains.

Together, these seven companies now make up more than one-third of the S&P 500’s total market capitalization. RBC Wealth Management has called this concentration the “Great Narrowing,” describing it as even more pronounced and entrenched than during the dot-com era, which of course ended in a crash. Although RBC acknowledges that concentration does not necessarily mean a bubble, the risks are real, ranging from the damage that a poor earnings report from just one company could inflict on the overall index to the more serious threat to the economy if sentiment toward AI suddenly turns negative.

Capital is also not the only resource AI is competing for. Its insatiable demand for water, electricity, land, and materials could drive up prices and leave other sectors to compete for increasingly scarce supplies.

Recent company earnings calls suggest that this is already happening in some areas. Intel, for example, has indicated that semiconductor supply is being directed toward AI and away from PCs. Elevator manufacturer Otis and homebuilder Lennar have pointed to skilled-labor and construction-capacity shortages that are delaying projects. IBM has noted that IT budgets are shifting toward AI and away from conventional hardware and software, while Micron and SK Hynix have reported memory shortages constraining PC and smartphone production.

Despite considerable financial and anecdotal evidence, the claim that AI is crowding out other investment is far from settled. There are at least three reasons to question this narrative, one of which suggests that the AI boom could be having precisely the opposite effect.

For starters, there is no clear evidence of crowding out in the macroeconomic data. AI may be consuming a greater share of investment, but that has not been offset by a decline in investment elsewhere. In fact, data from the Bureau of Economic Analysis show that gross private investment as a share of US GDP has remained broadly stable.

Second, higher interest rates could reflect a repricing of financial assets rather than crowding out. The 30-year Treasury yield has risen by more than 33 basis points since the start of the year, but that increase has been attributed largely to the Iran war and renewed inflation concerns following the spike in energy prices. With so many forces driving up rates, it is hard to say with any certainty how much of this trend reflects the impact of AI.

The third counterargument draws on the so-called Jevons paradox: when a new technology makes a resource more productive and efficient, the resulting cost declines can strengthen, rather than weaken, demand for the resource. By this logic, AI could increase productivity, lower costs, and boost demand for a wide range of goods and services, prompting companies to invest more in response. AI investment could thus become a catalyst for investment in other sectors—power generation and utilities, financial services, and cloud computing—rather than sucking capital away from them.

For now, AI appears to be crowding out investment at the margins and not across the board. It is clearly diverting capital and resources away from other sectors, but there is not yet enough evidence to conclude that it is dragging down overall investment or economic growth.

18. Asia's Natural Disasters Must Not Become Financial Crises

Author: Yasuto Watanabe

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SINGAPORE—The catastrophic flooding in Nepal has demonstrated, once again, the devastating human and economic toll of climate change. The immediate priority must be to save lives and support affected communities. But the devastation also highlights how physical hazards can quickly morph into macroeconomic shocks.

These events have different causes, and no single disaster should be casually attributed to El Niño or climate change. Nonetheless, the World Meteorological Organization expects a strong El Niño to intensify from August through October, increasing the likelihood of above-normal temperatures in much of the world and major shifts in rainfall. In Southeast Asia, El Niño often brings drier conditions and raises the risk of drought, wildfires, and haze, although its effects vary across countries and seasons.

For policymakers, the imperative is to prepare for the economic chain reactions triggered by extreme weather events. Droughts, floods, and heat waves damage crops and infrastructure. In countries with inadequate food stocks, weak logistics, and concentrated import sources, lower production can lead to shortages, higher prices, and declining household purchasing power. Governments face pressure to subsidize prices or facilitate emergency imports, while central banks confront the difficult combination of supply-driven inflation and weaker demand.

Then comes the fiscal aftershock. If roads, ports, irrigation systems, schools, and hospitals cannot be repaired or replaced in a timely manner, temporary disruptions can turn into a permanent drag on productive capacity. Governments may be forced to divert spending from development, borrow at short notice, or wait for external assistance. A post-disaster financing gap can all too easily become a long-lasting economic slump.

When disaster strikes, countries must be prepared not only to limit physical damage, but also to reduce economic downtime, maintain essential public services, contain financial stress, and prevent short-term losses from weakening long-term growth. A robust, rapid recovery requires providing humanitarian support and stabilizing macroeconomic conditions.

The scale of the challenge is staggering. According to the United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction, direct disaster losses averaged \$180–200 billion annually between 2001 and 2020. When accounting for indirect, cascading, and ecosystem effects, the total annual cost rises to more than \$2.3 trillion.

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Asia must be prepared. To that end, in May, finance ministers and central bank governors from ASEAN+3 countries (the Southeast Asian member states, plus China, Japan, and South Korea) endorsed the Disaster Risk Financing Initiative's 2026–28 roadmap. This framework will help members develop national disaster-risk financing strategies and expand their use of insurance, catastrophe bonds, and other relevant instruments.

To be sure, prearranged financing cannot cover the full costs of a major disaster. Nor should insurance be expected to do so. Their value lies in providing reliable funding during the critical early stage of a crisis, when delays are most damaging, and governments have the least room to improvise. For example, on September 4, the Southeast Asia Disaster Risk Insurance Facility, a regional platform under the umbrella of ASEAN+3, announced total payouts of \$2.28 million to

Laos and the United Nations World Food Programme after official data showed that more than 260,000 people had been affected by heavy rainfall and widespread flooding.

The right approach is to match financing to risk. Budget reserves and disaster funds can cover frequent, relatively small losses. Contingent credit may be used for medium-size shocks, while insurance and capital-market instruments should be reserved mainly for less frequent but fiscally severe events. To ensure that the funds reach affected communities quickly, governments must have effective social-protection systems and contingency plans.

This process converts uncertain post-disaster liabilities into risks that can be measured, priced, allocated, and, most importantly, managed in advance. When some of the recovery costs are prearranged, governments are less likely to increase taxes abruptly, slash public investment, resort to emergency borrowing, or delay aid. Fiscal exposure becomes more predictable, reducing uncertainty around public debt, inflation, and economic growth.

The benefits extend beyond government balance sheets. Such an approach also provides businesses and financial markets with greater clarity about post-disaster taxation, public-investment cuts, payment delays, and credit conditions. And it enables a quicker restoration of ports, roads, electricity, and communications, limiting disruption to regional supply chains. Across the closely integrated ASEAN+3 region, recovery in one economy helps preserve its neighbors' stability.

The economics of climate change has reframed the role of disaster-risk finance. No longer merely a peripheral instrument that pays claims after an extreme weather event, it has become a policy lever that protects fiscal space and improves the medium-term outlook before a crisis occurs. Disaster-risk finance functions as a macroeconomic firewall for fiscal policy, financial stability, food security, social protection, and infrastructure planning, reducing both economic volatility and uncertainty about the recovery.

ASEAN+3 has spent decades building its regional financial safety net against currency and financial crises. As a strengthening El Niño threatens to take its toll on the region, the next task is clear: prevent natural disasters from becoming humanitarian, fiscal, and, ultimately, financial crises. With regional disaster-risk finance, governments will be in a better position to restart their economies, preserve fiscal space, and contain spillovers. That is what real resilience looks like in a warming world.

19. The Golden Bridge to Monetary Multipolarity

Author: Hippolyte Fofack **Published:** Sep 4, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

MONTREAL—One clear sign of de-dollarization and the shift toward a multipolar monetary order is gold’s renewed prominence in global financial markets. Investors increasingly view the metal as a strategic asset; central banks are buying record amounts of it to bolster resilience against financial and geopolitical risks, with last year marking the fourth-largest expansion of gold reserves on record. The Dutch central bank’s decision to move much of its gold reserves out of the United States, citing “geopolitical unrest,” is but the latest example of this trend.

Market reactions to US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent’s intervention in bond markets after the sharp selloff in longer-dated US debt and the resulting higher yields in the usually quiet month of August further support the perception of gold as the ultimate safe-haven asset. Bessent’s intervention sparked a sharp drop in the dollar and a massive rally in gold prices.

This follows the European Central Bank’s confirmation in June that gold had overtaken US Treasuries as the world’s top reserve asset. That status seems likely to harden and spread. According to a recent survey by the Official Monetary and Financial Institutions Forum, more central banks plan to decrease their dollar holdings than to increase them over the next decade. The World Gold Council’s 2026 Central Bank Gold Reserves survey reports similar findings, with 74% of respondents anticipating moderate or significantly lower dollar reserves over the next five years.

It is, of course, unlikely that a new global monetary hegemon will replace the dollar any time soon, especially in a digital age marked by rapid technological diffusion and increasing dispersion of economic power. Instead, the slow retreat from the greenback signals the emergence of a more diversified international monetary system in which several currencies—the dollar, the euro, and the renminbi—play important roles, particularly in central-bank reserve holdings. In such a system, gold serves as the politically neutral reserve asset linking competing monetary blocs.

Central banks, sovereign wealth funds, and institutional investors have begun to prioritize capital preservation over high returns, mainly because high-yield investments lose their appeal if the underlying assets are at risk of becoming inaccessible during periods of conflict or instability. Gold, whose relationship with the dollar’s trade-weighted exchange rate is typically negative, carries no sovereign counterparty risk, making it a superior hedge against the challenges of a rogue America and geopolitical turbulence.

Geopolitical risks have transformed the international monetary system from a neutral infrastructure that facilitates global commerce and cross-border investment into an arena of strategic competition, fundamentally altering the risk-return balance and elevating national security from a peripheral concern to a threshold condition for investment decisions. Strong demand for gold reflects a broader transformation in global finance, marked by a shift from financial claims to tangible ownership, from efficiency to resilience, and from dependence on a single reserve currency to a more diversified and strategically balanced monetary order.

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This reassessment of sovereign risk has certainly influenced the People’s Bank of China’s reserve strategy. In July, the PBOC increased its gold reserves for the 21st consecutive month to 76.08 million troy ounces. Meanwhile, China is building up its physical gold inventories in Hong Kong, which recently launched a gold clearing and settlement system on a trial basis, and has limited retail investors’ access to precious-metals trading.

China's shift toward holding physical gold underscores the evolution of the metal's function, from a financial asset to a strategic monetary asset. In addition to reducing dollar exposure, gold's larger role in the management of the country's currency reserves also promises to strengthen trust in the renminbi and reinforce confidence in the PBOC's balance sheet. It also seems aimed at boosting efforts to facilitate the renminbi's broader use, including through bilateral currency-swap agreements, trade-settlement mechanisms, and debt issuances, with the market for renminbi-denominated debt instruments (offshore "dim sum" and onshore "panda" bonds) rapidly expanding.

But China's push to promote the renminbi does not mean that the currency is capable of unseating the dollar. The renminbi remains subject to capital controls and lacks the financial depth to compete with the greenback globally.

Similarly, recent initiatives to internationalize the euro, most notably the expansion of the enhanced Eurosystem repo facility for central banks and the growing issuance of euro-denominated debt, have been relatively successful, with it becoming the leading currency in the green and sustainable international bond market in 2025. But still, the euro cannot hope to fill the dollar's global shoes, owing to structural and institutional barriers, notably the lack of a unified fiscal policy and deep, seamless capital markets.

Even so, gold complements the rise of rival currencies and supports diversification by providing a common store of value that is accepted without regard to geopolitical alignment or other monetary arrangements. Thus, its ascent reflects efforts—including local-currency settlement between BRICS members and cross-border payment systems in Asia and elsewhere—to deepen regional integration and reduce dependence on the dollar for trade and investment.

Digital technologies that enable the circumvention of traditional correspondent banking networks add another dimension to gold's renewed relevance. Central bank digital currencies and real-time payment infrastructure enable the creation of a decentralized monetary system in which multiple currencies coexist, forming the backbone of a new global financial system for the digital age. Yet technology cannot replace the need for trust: gold continues to provide the universal credibility that underpins confidence during periods of structural change.

While conventional wisdom that "there is no alternative" to the dollar still holds, the process of de-dollarization was never expected to be abrupt. Global redistribution of monetary influence will almost surely be gradual and cumulative, mirroring the realignment of economic power.

The case for gold—the ultimate neutral reserve asset, trusted by all countries and controlled by none—as a shield against geopolitical and financial shocks remains undeniable. But it is hardly the only reason for embracing the metal. In the face of a huge technological revolution and a global economic reordering, authorities are also seeking to strengthen their monetary sovereignty and end reliance on any single reserve currency.

This structural transformation of the international monetary system is the deeper and more enduring driver of demand for gold, suggesting that strong demand for the metal, which serves as the natural bridge to monetary multipolarity, is here to stay. As Shakespeare's Cloten rightly observes about gold in *Cymbeline*: "what can it not do and undo?"

20. America's Naval Disaster

Author: Anne O. Krueger **Published:** Sep 4, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

WASHINGTON, DC—At the end of World War II, the US Navy was by far the world's largest. As late as 1975, the United States remained a major shipbuilding power, although its preeminence had already begun to diminish. By the end of the 20th century, however, American shipbuilding was in steep decline, despite government efforts to revive it.

As American shipbuilding declined, China surged ahead. In 2015, its naval fleet roughly matched that of the US. Five years later, it had 350 warships, while the US Navy had 293, down from 583 in 1987. The country now accounts for more than 50% of global shipbuilding by tonnage (commercial and military), with South Korea and Japan producing much of the rest. Chinese shipyards produced 1,700 ships in 2025, compared with just five ships built in the US.

And the outlook is hardly encouraging. China aims to expand its naval fleet to 435 ships by 2030, compared with the US Navy's plan to add 58 by 2031, including 15 "Trump-class" battleships. While the Chinese target is widely viewed as realistic, the American plan is thought to be "far-fetched."

This widening gap has spurred bipartisan efforts to rebuild American shipbuilding. The SHIPS for America Act of 2025 provides industry subsidies and other measures aimed at boosting domestic production, including a Maritime Security Trust Fund of up to \$20 billion. In February, the Trump administration followed it with the Maritime Action Plan, an effort to rebuild the maritime industrial base by securing investment pledges from allies like South Korea.

But shipbuilding capacity is only part of the story. The US Navy is also struggling to keep its existing fleet ready for service, with high costs and chronic delays contributing to a 20-year maintenance backlog; some ships are being decommissioned early. Fleet readiness fell to 68% in 2025, well below the Navy's 80% target, pushing deployments beyond the Navy's six-month goal. Deteriorating conditions on the USS Abraham Lincoln, the USS Gerald Ford's 326-day deployment earlier this year, and the recent power outage aboard the USS Benfold are all evidence of that strain.

While the current shipbuilding push may strengthen the industry, it does little to address the underlying causes of its decline. Chief among them is Section 27 of the 1920 Merchant Marine Act, better known as the Jones Act, which requires cargo shipped between American ports to travel on US-registered, American-built vessels owned and crewed by Americans. Repairs performed abroad are subject to a 50% tax.

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By protecting American shipbuilders from foreign competition, the Jones Act has made domestic shipbuilding and shipping extremely uncompetitive. Ships cost 4–5 times as much to build in the US as in major shipbuilding countries and 3 times as much to operate as foreign-flagged vessels, largely because of higher labor and material costs.

The results should surprise no one. As of 2025, only 92 ships were Jones Act-eligible to carry goods from one American port to another, with their average age exceeding what is considered safe. With shipping so expensive that moving goods by rail, road, and barge is often cheaper, cargo traffic along the Atlantic and Pacific coasts has fallen by half since 1960.

America's shipping shortage is now so severe that the Trump administration issued a Jones Act waiver for energy and fertilizer shipments in March, then extended it by another 90 days in early August. More jet fuel has been shipped from the Gulf Coast to the West Coast since the waiver was granted than in the previous 36 years combined.

Unlike their US counterparts, major shipyards abroad build both commercial and military vessels, which share many inputs, from steel hulls and engines to propellers. Their workers can gain experience building simpler commercial vessels before moving to more complex military ships. And because government procurement fluctuates with budgets and changing defense needs, shipyards that can shift workers between commercial and military production have a competitive advantage.

Tariffs on imported parts and components are another driver of rising US shipbuilding costs. The US Navy is operating within a fixed budget of \$292 billion for fiscal year 2026, including \$47.4 billion for shipbuilding, which means that those higher costs must ultimately be paid for through additional taxes or through reductions in fleet size and capability.

Then there are Trump's expensive whims and bizarre fixations. Despite the Navy's preference for electromagnetic catapults, which are cheaper, require fewer sailors, and can launch and recover aircraft more quickly, Trump has ordered a return to steam-powered systems. He has also directed the Navy to explore moving the command tower on aircraft carriers to a location he finds more aesthetically pleasing. These changes will cost billions of dollars and add nothing to the Navy's combat capabilities.

Trump's "golden fleet" of "Trump-class" nuclear-powered warships promises to be vastly more expensive. Designing the ships could take more than a decade, and the Congressional Budget Office estimates the program's cost at \$275 billion, with the first ship alone costing \$23.4 billion. Even if the plan proves infeasible, as many analysts expect, pursuing it would still drain the Navy's budget.

To reduce the exorbitant cost of its naval vessels, the US will have to turn to foreign competitors. But that alone will not revive American commercial shipbuilding, which cannot recover without repeal of the Jones Act.

Until then, it makes far more sense to procure ships and components from allied shipbuilding powers while continuing to subsidize domestic production where strategically necessary. Using part of the Navy's budget to buy ships from foreign allies would enable the US to acquire several times as many vessels at a fraction of the cost of building them at home.

21. America's Un-American AI Companies

Author: Yaqiu Wang Published: Sep 4, 2026 Link: [View Original](#)

PHILADELPHIA—In Washington, nearly every serious proposal that could constrain American AI companies runs into the same objection: restrictions would endanger national security and future prosperity by giving China the advantage. As OpenAI CEO Sam Altman put it at a 2025 Senate hearing, the United States needs “sensible regulation” that “does not slow us down.”

This formulation has intuitive appeal. No one advocates poorly designed rules that would needlessly weaken US innovation. Yet “don’t slow us down” too often becomes a demand for democratic institutions to step aside while a handful of private companies decide how one of the most powerful technologies in history will be built, deployed, and governed.

To be sure, much is at stake in the competition with China. A world in which Beijing dominates AI would be more censored, more surveilled, and inherently hostile to human rights and democracy. But America can prevail by leaning into the strengths of an open society: democratic accountability, the rule of law, robust competition, and free public debate. This is precisely where American AI companies can outcompete their Chinese rivals—not despite democratic oversight, but because of it.

After all, if an AI system is used in a hospital, school, police station, or on the battlefield, people want to know that it is subject to rules, that decisions affecting their lives can be challenged, and that there are meaningful mechanisms for redress when something goes wrong. These features require clear liability rules, transparency, due process for high-stakes automated decisions, and effective enforcement.

While democratic controls may in some cases slow deployment, they can also accelerate adoption by making AI systems more trustworthy. Liability rules can encourage companies to address foreseeable risks before they cause harm; transparency can help researchers identify failures that companies miss or prefer not to disclose; and standards for testing, incident reporting, data protection, and human review can give customers greater certainty while reducing risks to society.

The US won’t beat China in a race to the bottom, because China’s political system is better equipped for it. It can compel companies and public agencies to pool data across finance, travel, health, policing, and everyday communications, then use that information to control and exploit citizens on a scale no democracy should seek to emulate. It can direct companies to pursue national industrial goals because courts, legislators, and civil society do not constrain the party-state. If America tries to compete by giving its own companies more secrecy, more impunity, or more power over citizens’ lives, it has already lost.

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Chinese technology companies’ own global track record shows further why democratic accountability matters. Huawei has promoted its “safe city” systems as tools for public security, but in some countries, they have raised concerns about political espionage and weak human-rights safeguards. Chinese-backed infrastructure and surveillance projects have also faced concerns about opaque contracts, corruption, and political influence.

That difference matters beyond US borders. People affected by American companies anywhere in the world can draw attention to their cases, seek coverage from the press, and enlist US civil-society organizations to advocate on their

behalf. Similarly, foreign businesses can seek redress through US courts, regulators, and independent mediation channels. None of these independent avenues exist in China to challenge companies acting with the party-state's support.

American AI companies should learn from the recent history of social media. Major platforms spent years resisting regulation as their business models degraded democratic discourse, spread disinformation, undermined privacy, addicted children, and concentrated enormous power. Yet despite growing public frustration, these companies avoided a decisive political reckoning because much of the harm was diffuse and cumulative, making it hard to say why one company bore more responsibility than another.

AI companies will have much less room to hide. When an AI system screens someone out of a job, denies a benefit or a loan, gives harmful advice, or produces a false facial-recognition match, the consequences are immediate, measurable, and often traceable to a specific product and company. That clear line of responsibility makes a backlash more likely and harder to deflect. Americans are already wary of AI, with a recent Pew Research Center survey finding that 52% are more concerned than excited about the technology's growing role in daily life, up from 37% in 2021; only 9% are more excited than concerned.

Nonetheless, AI companies appear to be following in social media's footsteps. Rather than become more transparent, they are seeking privileged access to a small circle of officials and negotiating policies behind closed doors. Rather than defend open competition, they are racing to control computing power, data, and distribution channels before rivals can catch up, blurring the line between first-mover advantage and monopolistic or oligopolistic behavior. And rather than trust democratic processes, their executives and investors are now spending heavily to defeat politicians who might regulate them. Despite proclaiming that they stand for democratic AI against China's autocratic model, they seem increasingly willing to bargain directly with political leaders rather than submit to rules established through open institutions.

By seeking privileged access, suppressing competition, and purchasing influence to avoid accepting democratic constraints, the industry is making itself both unpopular and politically dependent. That means it could win deregulation today only to discover that it has surrendered its autonomy to whichever administration controls access to energy, chips, government contracts, export licenses, and antitrust enforcement tomorrow. An administration that can decide which companies receive those benefits can also punish those that fall out of favor.

Companies that resist ordinary democratic oversight risk inviting unpredictability: direct political control by the government of the day. Democratic accountability, the rule of law, and open competition are not costs to be avoided in the name of "winning." They are what will make American AI more trusted, more resilient, and ultimately stronger than China's offerings. American AI companies' time to choose wisely is running out.

22. How Developing Countries Can Do More With Less

Author: Takunda Chirau **Published:** Sep 4, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

JOHANNESBURG—As donor governments slash aid budgets, and multilateral institutions come under increasing financial strain, development organizations must confront the combination of growing need and declining resources. How to address persistent challenges such as poverty and inequality, climate change, and humanitarian crises with fewer resources is an especially urgent question in Africa, where many countries have long relied on external financing to support essential programs and services.

The answer lies in how development is monitored and evaluated, often framed as a neutral, technical exercise measuring whether projects have achieved their objectives. In fact, evaluation is deeply political: it reflects what is seen as important and whose knowledge is trusted, and it influences which programs continue to receive funding. Thus, evaluation determines how resources are allocated and whose solutions are supported and expanded.

More significantly, the standards by which development projects are assessed are important not only for deciding where to channel limited resources, but also for shaping the future of global development governance. The African Union and its member states have long called for reforms to the international development and financial architecture, advocating greater representation, more equitable financing, and a stronger voice for Africa in global decision-making. But these reforms, while important, often overlook another powerful driver of change: control over knowledge and evidence.

To date, evaluation frameworks have largely been influenced by donor priorities, with the aim of tracking and comparing results across contexts. As a result, they often fail to capture the realities within communities and rarely reflect local values. When funders define success, the communities most affected by development programs are treated as sources of data rather than partners in deciding what constitutes meaningful change and how to measure it. As argued in the volume *Equitable Evaluation: Voices from the Global South* (which two of us co-edited), donors' expectations and desired outputs take precedence over those of local communities.

With fewer resources now available, and their allocation increasingly dependent on evidence demonstrating impact, there is no better time to implement equitable evaluation practices, which challenge the idea that development can be understood through universal indicators alone. This methodological innovation is grounded in the belief that evidence is shaped by history, context, culture, and power, and that these factors must be considered if evaluation is to advance equity.

African countries and communities, in particular, could adopt Made in Africa Evaluation approaches, which seek to assess development projects according to African realities, values, and priorities. That means recognizing Indigenous knowledge, local institutions, and community experiences as important sources of evidence, while emphasizing that evaluation should reflect the social, cultural, and political contexts in which development takes place. Such a shift ultimately reshapes who holds authority over knowledge itself.

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Community participation forces governments to be accountable to citizens, not just funders. For example, when rural health committees monitor clinic performance using community-designed scorecards rather than relying on donor audits, facility managers can identify and respond more quickly to drug shortages, long wait times, or service gaps, while health authorities gain access to locally generated evidence.

Similarly, when farmers help assess irrigation projects, evaluations have revealed practical constraints—such as unreliable water supplies, inadequate maintenance, and inequitable land distribution—that may be overlooked by externally designed indicators. These data can also inform national priorities, resulting in more responsive and efficient development spending. And if regional institutions build their own evaluation capacities, countries will become less dependent on frameworks that may not reflect their development goals.

As such examples show, giving African countries a greater say in international institutions is not enough to reform global development governance. Structural transformation requires giving them a greater role in the collection, interpretation, and use of data and evidence. Without significant changes to evaluation and the resulting knowledge production, calls to “decolonize development” will continue to ring hollow.

The current aid landscape underscores the urgency of this task. The scaling down of foreign assistance should not mean abandoning commitments to equity. Governments, donors, and development organizations should instead work even harder to direct the remaining funds to those who have historically been excluded. This requires evaluation systems capable of revealing inequalities rather than masking them behind national averages and aggregate performance indicators.

It is unclear whether the era of abundant foreign aid is ending or experiencing a temporary crisis. Either way, this moment has created an opening to rethink development cooperation and foster more trust in how these resources are used. In Africa, that can be achieved by ensuring that evaluation practices capture communities’ lived realities and allow success to be defined collaboratively rather than imposed externally.

23. Kevin Warsh's Best Move Is to Do Nothing

Author: James K. Galbraith **Published:** Sep 7, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

TOWNSHEND, VERMONT—In his remarks to this year's gathering of central bankers in Jackson Hole, Wyoming, US Federal Reserve Chair Kevin Warsh called for the Fed to "receive the full range of ideas" on monetary policy in order to "construct more reliable models." Apparently, and to his credit, he recognizes that the current models, rooted in mainstream economics, are not very good. He also rightly acknowledged the Fed's dual goals, set by law, of full employment and price stability, though he erred in describing the 2% inflation target as part of "our mandate." (In fact, it is only an internal goal.)

Warsh's hard line on inflation runs up against a key weakness in his models. His remarks treat AI as "a new factor of production" that introduces the "potential for substantially higher growth" and a "sustained rise in productivity." This description reflects the standard textbook "production function"—which tracks the interaction of capital and labor—under which advancing technology always enhances economic growth. But the textbook model is categorically wrong.

Technology is a force of creative destruction, and destruction destroys. New technologies drive older technologies to the wall, rendering the functions served by previously scarce and valuable goods so abundant and cheap that they fade from the economy—and from the data. Anyone old enough to remember the expensive communications junk of the analog age knows this well.

Back when cars, trucks, roads, oil fields, refineries, gas stations, and repair shops displaced grass-fed horses and coal-fed trains, technology also worked (with government help) to bring new economic activity into being, inaugurating the automotive and electrical age. But information and AI tend to erase market activity by making communications and analysis fast and cheap, and it is not yet clear what (if anything) comes in their place. The creative destruction they have unleashed is also transnational. Warsh did not mention the risk that superior Chinese AI models may one day pose to American ones; that inconvenient prospect cannot be framed in terms of "production functions."

With products whose prices have collapsed disappearing from the economic data, the inflation rate reflects the price of what remains in the index. For most people, the basket is constantly shifting toward essentials like food, fuel, rent, and health care, all of which are becoming more expensive. Nobody feels rich by dint of e-postage being free; our budgets are reallocated to cover those things we still have to pay for. The inflation rate we experience is not driven by wages (whose growth has been "moderate," as Warsh said), but by profits, by AI driving up the cost of electricity, and by US President Donald Trump, who seems determined to wreck the oil trade. These forces do not respond directly to rising interest rates.

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On interest rates, Warsh dispelled a lot of nonsense with splendid candor: "We determine the path of short-term interest rates." A brass plaque with those words should be sent to all the Washington think tanks and lobby groups that exist to prattle on about the federal budget deficit. The short-term interest rate is always exactly what the Fed wants it to be, and in setting short-term rates, the Fed is also the driving force behind long-term rates. When the Fed keeps short rates low for a long time, long rates follow the short rates down. The recent rise in long-term rates—what has been called a global "bond rout"—mainly reflects an expectation that short rates will be raised. It's not complicated; all other factors are secondary.

But higher interest rates cannot "cure" today's inflation—not even by causing a slump. In 1981, the Fed raised interest rates to 20% and manufacturing employment, investment, unions, wages, and household purchasing power collapsed, the

dollar soared, and imports became cheaper. Today, manufacturing is much smaller, unions are already feeble, many consumer goods are made abroad, and the dollar has been weakening. If housing construction falls, as it may do, rental rates will rise.

Crucially, the federal debt is about four times larger, relative to GDP, than in the early 1980s. Raising rates now would pump money into financial assets and into economic activity, most of which is services. When former Fed Chair Jerome Powell raised the federal funds rate by more than 500 basis points, the stock market boomed, the economy did not slow down, and there was no effect on inflation.

Short-term interest rates are the Fed's only weapon, but it has jammed, and Warsh cannot get it working again. Stuck on mainstream models, he has committed himself, and his reputation, to a goal he cannot achieve. Reining in inflation would require different measures—including peace with Iran, detente with China and Russia, and strategic controls over prices and profits—that are not within the Fed's power.

So, what should Warsh do? He cannot cut interest rates, because Trump has foreclosed that possibility merely by wanting it to happen. That leaves only one proper course of action: Do nothing. Wait and see. Warsh should show spine by resisting pressure from every angle, and spend his time seeking out the new ideas, sharp critiques, and original minds who might be able to pull the Fed out of its ideological rut.

24. Will Europe Be as Unprepared as Ukraine Was?

Author: Tatyana Deryugina **Published:** Sep 7, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

URBANA/BERKELEY/KYIV—Twelve years ago, Ukraine was sleepwalking toward catastrophe. Now Europe is.

Before 2014, Ukraine's military had been hollowed out by decades of neglect and disarmament. That was a choice. Why spend scarce resources on defense when the 1994 Budapest Memorandum offered security assurances in exchange for Ukraine surrendering its nuclear arsenal? Why prepare for a conflict that the prevailing intellectual consensus said could never happen? Liberal democracy had triumphed, great-power conflict was a relic, and the arc of progress bent toward peace, liberalization, and economic convergence.

Worse, Ukraine allowed Russia to penetrate its information space, promote pro-Kremlin narratives, cultivate political allies, and meddle in Ukraine's elections. Under President Viktor Yanukovich, a former Russian citizen served as minister of defense. The army was sabotaged from within.

Ukraine should have known better. The warning signs were there. Russia had invaded Georgia in 2008, demonstrating that it was prepared to use military force to prevent another former Soviet republic from escaping its orbit. Putin was already questioning whether Ukraine was a real country, describing parts of its territory as a "gift" from Russia. He publicly described Russians and Ukrainians as "one people," and used energy and trade to gain political leverage. Yet the belief that Russia would go no further prevented decisive action.

Then, in February and March 2014, Russia annexed Crimea without firing a shot because there was barely anyone to fire back (and those who might have helped urged Ukraine to stand down). Shortly afterwards, Russia occupied parts of the Donbas. This time, Ukraine fought back, but from a position of profound weakness against a stronger and better-prepared adversary.

Ukraine struggled to reach a consensus about what had happened and what must be done. While some called for mobilization, many believed that the war was local and confined to a strip of territory in the east and a distant peninsula. The worst was over, they claimed: Putin had taken what he wanted.

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It followed that compromises, even if painful, could buy peace. Surely, the right leader could sit across the table from Putin and negotiate an end to the bloodshed. The election of Volodymyr Zelensky in 2019 partly reflected this yearning. Zelensky spoke of ending the war in Donbas, of talking directly to Russia, and of finding common ground. Many Ukrainians wanted to believe that the problem could be talked away. Instead, on February 24, 2022, Russia launched a full-scale invasion, targeting Kyiv and seeking to decapitate the Ukrainian state. The war that was supposed to be local became existential.

Europe's resemblance to Ukraine's trajectory is striking. The comparison is not exact: Europe is richer, more institutionally resilient, and still largely sheltered by NATO, at least in principle. But the similarity in habits of thought and action is close enough to be deeply troubling, as Germany's pathetic reaction to a failed Russian drone attack at Leipzig airport amply demonstrates.

After decades of peace, Europe has systematically dismantled its defense capabilities. NATO's guideline of spending 2% of GDP on defense had, until recently, been treated as a ceiling rather than a floor. For decades, Italy and Spain hovered

around 1.5%. Belgium and others trailed even further behind. Germany allowed the Bundeswehr to deteriorate to the point where soldiers trained with broomsticks instead of rifles and major weapons systems had readiness rates below 50%. Europeans' willingness to strengthen their defenses via public-spending cuts or peacekeeping deployments in Ukraine is shockingly low.

The mindset behind this neglect is familiar from Ukraine before 2014. Big wars cannot happen: we have the European Union, NATO, and nuclear deterrence. The United States will handle security. Defense spending is wasteful. Diplomacy and economic interdependence will keep the peace. Russia would never attack a major trading partner.

Those assumptions have collapsed. The US has signaled with increasing bluntness that the era of American security guarantees without European burden-sharing is over. President Donald Trump's administration openly questions the value of NATO. Nuclear weapons do not deter subthreshold aggression (like drone and cyberattacks) or the use of coercion and subversion to erode sovereignty. What is striking in much of Europe is not just pacifism or poor readiness, but the lingering sense that even now the old rules will somehow reassert themselves.

Europe is now facing its own warning signs. Russia is already waging what NATO calls a campaign of sabotage, cyberattacks, electronic interference, disinformation, and political influence across the continent. Russian drones and aircraft increasingly violate NATO airspace, while suspicious incidents around undersea cables and other infrastructure have forced NATO to strengthen their protection.

These provocations are deliberately below the threshold of war. That ambiguity enables Russia to probe European defenses, test political resolve, and learn how much provocation the West will tolerate before responding. And, like Ukraine before 2014, Europe keeps finding reasons not to act.

Across Europe, support for rearmament and for Ukraine remains politically contested. In Italy and Spain, voters resist higher defense spending. In France and Germany, influential voices frame urgency as overreaction (the far-right Alternative for Germany, which is likely to take power in Saxony-Anhalt, calls for a deal with Russia). In Slovakia, leaders have openly favored accommodation with the Kremlin.

Russia finances political parties, penetrates cultural institutions, and promotes disinformation throughout Europe. Across the continent, many argue that the war in Ukraine can be ended through negotiation if only Ukraine's leaders would be more "realistic" about territorial concessions.

Winston Churchill's verdict on the catastrophic 1938 Munich Agreement is as relevant as ever: "You were given the choice between war and dishonor. You chose dishonor, and you will have war." Europe in 2026 can invest seriously in its own defense, accept the costs and trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence. Or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy alone will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

But the price of appeasement is never paid by the politicians who choose expedience over vigilance. It is soldiers and civilians who bear the consequences. Europe still has time—provided by Ukraine, at extraordinary cost. The challenge is not merely to spend more, but to think differently: to accept that deterrence is not alarmism, preparedness is not provocation, and strength is often the precondition for peace.

25. The Digital Wellness Industry Is Hijacking Women's Health

Author: Danielle Keats Citron

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CHARLOTTESVILLE—Apple's health app has a new feature that can allegedly detect whether a woman is in perimenopause. The app notifies a user of her new health status, and a chatbot is available to provide more information. The bot asks: "Are you feeling tired and uninterested in sex?" "Having night sweats?" "Are you always itchy?" After answering "yes" to all three, the bot confirms that she may be experiencing early signs of perimenopause and potentially low testosterone or estrogen.

Here is what happens next: in her browser, the woman sees advertisements for supplements, creams, and other "solutions" to hormonal problems. Posts in her Instagram feed suddenly say, "Looking to start [hormone replacement therapy]? If you've been told your symptoms are just aging or bounced from doctor to doctor—we get it. Real relief is possible ... Talk to one of our expert clinicians." Influencers, who appear to be in their mid-30s, crowd her feed to recommend wellness supplements.

The ads and posts claim that the woman's symptoms indicate a medical problem, despite the absence of evidence that they do: she has not had sex with her partner for several years, she is hot because it's a heatwave, and her skin gets itchy every summer. None of that matters. She orders the supplements and contacts an online provider whose remote doctors instantly prescribe hormones like testosterone, estrogen, and progesterone (in patches or pills) without physically seeing her.

Here is what doesn't happen: The woman does not talk to her long-time physician, who knows her medical history (blood clots, migraines, and a family history of strokes), prescriptions (antidepressants), workout regimen (none), and personal situation (disintegrating marriage).

Meaningfully addressing the real phenomena of perimenopause and menopause requires a comprehensive clinical review of a patient's medical and personal history, and doctors want to provide that kind of care. But patients are not getting it, because a sprawling digital ecosystem of health startups, influencers, and advertisers increasingly gets in the way.

This ecosystem is driving a menopause gold rush, turning women's health into a lucrative business. Instead of clinical diagnoses, health apps flood them with marketing pitches from wellness companies that raise hundreds of millions of dollars in venture capital and, in some cases, may have billion-dollar valuations.

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The digital wellness industry does not care about women's well-being. Its business model is built on wonky inferences drawn from noisy data, algorithmic predictions, and violations of intimate privacy. Advertisers and marketers buy dossiers from data brokers that categorize women as "affluent mature women health and wellness," "midlife transition focused," and "Gen X supplement buyers."

By mining data-broker dossiers and women's search history, emails, web browsing, social media posts, and geolocation data, advertisers and marketers can predict that targeting women at certain times on certain days is more likely to yield purchases. For example, advertisers know that women feel less than fabulous about themselves early on Monday

mornings. As OB-GYN Nanette Santoro explains, the marketing of menopause-related supplements to women “has gotten very, very aggressive,” even though many of the claims made by supplement providers are not backed by science.

Above all, perimenopause and menopause are a growth market. In February, a popular menopause-focused telehealth company was valued at \$1 billion. Predictions generated by self-tracking apps have thus become a purchase funnel for a market projected to reach \$28.8 billion by 2033.

Meanwhile, patients’ prediction-influenced decisions create difficulties for doctors, who must deal with the fallout. They now treat grave medical problems resulting from ill-advised supplements and hormonal treatments, including complications requiring surgery, and try to educate patients about clinically proven and medically appropriate approaches to perimenopause and menopause.

Doctors want patients to feel heard and understood. They want to provide gold-standard care and earn their patients’ trust and confidence. Yet now doctors must also explain to their patients that they have been played and manipulated into paying for expensive medicines and supplements that are not right for them given their health, family history, and prescriptions. They have to help patients understand that those pricey supplements may not be supported by science and are fueling someone’s bottom line but not serving their own.

The impact of digital manipulation on women’s autonomy, privacy, and health is far-reaching. The prediction- and ad-driven digital-health ecosystem has hijacked women’s and doctors’ attention and time. It has also changed the way women see themselves: as people whose hormones and bodies are broken and need to be fixed with supplements that are useless or, worse, harmful.

By restructuring clinical encounters, app-based predictions and online ads have undermined women’s agency and self-esteem and corroded intimate privacy, with severe effects on health outcomes. Expert discretion has shifted from clinical judgment to adjudicating machine-derived predictions based on noisy data.

There is no easy solution to this problem, but lawmakers and regulators can take meaningful actions. In the United States, Congress should ban the use and sale of intimate information and sharply curtail data brokers. The Federal Trade Commission and Food and Drug Administration could crack down on unfair and deceptive advertising by online advertisers and supplement companies. The United Kingdom has already moved in the right direction by banning several misleading ads.

In the meantime, users should exercise caution when interpreting the health notifications they receive on their phones. They should always, as advertisements and app prompts suggest, “talk to a doctor.”

Women’s midlife health has been under-researched and dismissed for decades. Tracking tools can give women the data and language that they have long been denied without funneling them into manipulative advertising schemes. Being seen and heard should not mean being segmented and monetized.

26. The Case for a Cashflow Tax

Author: Glenn Hubbard

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NEW YORK—After the US midterm election this November, Congress’s economic-policy focus will likely turn to growth, AI’s impact on the economy, and deficit concerns. Lawmakers therefore should recognize that one policy tool can help to address all three: a cashflow tax.

Attention to these issues is warranted. Because higher productivity is what boosts incomes, investment and growth remain the core drivers of rising living standards. Yet concerns over labor’s shrinking share of GDP relative to capital—a problem that could be magnified by developments in generative AI—have ignited debates about profit and wealth taxation. At the same time, growing alarm over the unsustainability of the US fiscal position puts a premium on efficient ways of raising additional revenue.

That is where the cashflow tax comes in. Many economists (including me) have long championed the economic benefits of moving the tax system further toward a consumption tax. Relative to the current income tax, a broad-based consumption tax would raise saving and investment, leading to higher productivity and incomes.

Though the term “consumption tax” may call to mind a European credit-invoice value-added tax (VAT), the United States could implement such a policy in a simpler fashion by targeting accounts currently maintained for taxation. After all, a consumption tax at a given rate is arithmetically identical to the combination of a wage tax and a business cashflow tax at the same rate. As a tax on a firm’s revenue minus expenses, a cashflow tax would allow businesses to expense investment immediately, boosting outlays.

Such a shift would expand on reforms enacted in 2017 and 2025. It would also disallow nonfinancial companies from making interest deductions, because in contrast to an income tax, a cashflow tax treats debt and equity the same. It therefore eliminates an important tax incentive for firms to allow themselves to become leveraged. Finally, a cashflow tax is much simpler than a corporate-income tax, which requires complex depreciation schedules.

Cashflow taxation shifts the tax burden toward high rates of profit, which is useful in an environment of rising profit concentration in firms. This benefit arises because the cashflow tax removes taxes on what economists call the “normal return” on investment (or the cost of capital). Companies would instead be taxed only on profits above this amount, reflecting economic rents. Moreover, given that most large individual fortunes reflect economic rents in business ownership, a cashflow tax would be more effective than a wealth tax, which suffers from many complications relating to measurement, liquidity, and incentives.

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Because a cashflow tax creates fewer distortions of saving and investment than the income tax, it is also a more efficient instrument for raising incremental revenue in any future fiscal consolidation. While the bulk of fiscal adjustment will require reductions in the growth of federal spending, higher revenue would almost surely be part of any politically viable package.

Moreover, additional revenue could be raised if Congress incorporated a border adjustment in the new cashflow tax. Doing so would deny companies a tax deduction for expenses abroad, while exempting US exports from taxation. Other countries already use border adjustments in their VATs on consumption, and America uses a similar mechanism in state and local retail taxes. If you buy a kitchen appliance in New York, you pay New York sales tax even if it was made in

Ohio. The sales tax applies only where the good is sold, not where it originates. Because the US imports more than it exports, the border adjustment would raise revenue, remove tax incentives for US firms to locate activities abroad, and strengthen the incentives for non-US firms to locate activities in America.

To be sure, while a cashflow tax promises to promote economic growth, tax high profits, and raise incremental revenue efficiently, it does raise concerns about complexity and tax fairness. But these issues can be straightforwardly addressed.

Consider the possible concerns over tax complexity. The cashflow tax would use basic company accounts already used in the income tax, avoiding any new fundamental tax design or introduction of a European-styled VAT. It also would offer simplification within the income tax code by substituting permanent expensing of capital goods for more complicated and less generous depreciation allowances.

Yes, the combination of a wage tax and a cashflow tax at the same rate replicates a broad-based consumption tax, but without the progressivity of the current income tax, raising potential concerns about fairness. But this issue is also easily tackled. A graduated tax structure could be introduced along the lines of the “X-tax” that Princeton University economist David Bradford developed 40 years ago. Here, the individual wage tax would have graduated rates with a credit for low-wage individuals, and the business cashflow tax rate would be set as the highest individual tax rate. Or, as Treasury Secretary Nicholas F. Brady suggested in 1992, an alternative version would tax all income, including capital income, for very high-income individual taxpayers.

With elections looming, economic policies to promote growth, address structural changes in income and wealth inequality, and tackle ballooning budget deficits will be intensely debated. Building on recent tax changes to implement a cashflow tax offers the most promising path forward on all three issues.

27. Who Controls the Data Controls the Future

Author: Bijan Burnard **Published:** Sep 7, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

SAN FRANCISCO—In March, Iranian drones targeted three Amazon Web Services facilities in Bahrain and the United Arab Emirates, hitting two directly and nearly hitting the third. It was the first time a commercial data center had been a military target, yet almost nobody outside specialist circles noticed. They should have. The servers holding a country's data, and the chips running the AI models on which its economy increasingly leans, are no longer background infrastructure. They are as strategic as ports or power grids—and just as exposed.

For most of the last decade, data was something companies mined, and AI was something companies sold—both regulated at the margins through privacy law, if they were regulated at all. This framing no longer works. AI now sits inside finance, defense, health care, and public administration, and it runs on two things most governments do not actually control: the data that train it and the compute that processes it. Countries that ignore this will find their futures being decided in boardrooms where they have no seat.

Many governments have taken note. Global spending on “sovereign AI” will reportedly surpass \$100 billion this year. Over the last several months, Canada, France, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates have rolled out national compute funds and GPU allocations. The European Union has gone further, treating sovereign AI infrastructure almost as doctrine, which has meant backing Gaia-X to build out European data infrastructure and financing projects like Mistral AI's new data center outside Paris.

On paper, this looks like sensible diversification away from a handful of American and Chinese firms. In practice, it risks creating something more brittle: a patchwork of national fortresses, each self-sufficient and none capable of talking to the others. Part of the problem is that “AI sovereignty” encompasses at least three things, and most governments are only working on one.

Data residency—keeping citizens' data within national borders—is the oldest of the three, the easiest to legislate, and the one most policy actually addresses. Compute sovereignty—who owns the chips and data centers doing the processing—is more difficult: a country can wall off its data, but it loses control if those data are processed on infrastructure someone else owns. Governance sovereignty—the ability to set the rules AI systems have to follow, rather than importing whatever standard the country hosting the dominant developers happens to set—is the one almost nobody talks about.

A fragmented regulatory landscape doesn't help any of this. Roughly 90 countries now have some kind of national AI strategy; at least 33 have passed binding legislation. But the approaches often clash. The EU's AI Act, whose main provisions became applicable last month, carries penalties of up to €35 million (\$40.6 million) or 7% of the offender's total global annual turnover. The United States' AI Action Plan takes the opposite approach, treating deregulation itself as a competitive edge. China's Global AI Governance Action Plan offers cooperation on AI governance with developing economies, but on Chinese terms.

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The Council of Europe's Framework Convention on AI—the first binding international AI treaty—represents real progress, but its enforcement is modest next to the scale of what it's meant to govern. Coordination beyond that has barely started. The UN's Independent International Scientific Panel on AI has warned of a “race to the bottom,” with jurisdictions competing to offer the most permissive rules rather than the safest ones. Companies running high-risk AI deployments are already shopping for the softest jurisdiction.

Genuine AI sovereignty requires four things, none of which is complicated in concept. Start by putting AI data infrastructure in the same legal category as power grids, with someone clearly on the hook for physical and digital security.

Next, countries building sovereign compute need shared interoperability standards, not just national champions—Gaia-X's work on data portability is a useful template. A hospital in Lagos or a ministry in Warsaw ought to be able to verify that a system meets baseline safety requirements, regardless of whose infrastructure it's running on.

Oversight needs teeth: audit rights, mandatory incident reporting, and licensing for the handful of frontier models capable of touching critical infrastructure or financial stability. These models should be treated more like nuclear material than ordinary software.

The world also needs a real mechanism to stop AI sovereignty from turning into just another axis of inequality. That \$100 billion investment in sovereign compute is happening almost entirely in rich countries. Pooled regional compute, financed and governed jointly by smaller countries, would deliver better results than each of them trying to go it alone.

None of this requires a grand global treaty. The components of a governance framework—including the EU AI Act, the Council of Europe convention, Gaia-X, and the UN's scientific panel—already exist. The scaffolding connecting them is missing, though, and building that takes deliberate work. Every year it is delayed, the infrastructure gets bigger and harder to reconfigure. Nobody pouring billions of dollars into data centers and GPUs is waiting around for governance to catch up.

The strikes on those AWS facilities in the Gulf sent a message (whether or not anyone intended it): The infrastructure underpinning a growing share of consequential decisions—who gets a loan, which patients get flagged for treatment, which factories keep running—sits in buildings most governments do not control and cannot fully protect. Data sovereignty, compute sovereignty, and governance sovereignty are not conference-room abstractions. They are the precondition for a future shaped by countries' own citizens—not whoever happens to own the servers.

28. The AI Race Could Sink US-China Détente

Author: Ian Bremmer **Published:** Sep 8, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW YORK—Just three months after US President Donald Trump returned to the White House in 2025, he launched a new trade war with China. It didn't go well. Immediately after he announced a 34% duty on all Chinese imports, China signaled that it was ready to play hardball with a matching 34% tariff on all US goods and immediate export controls on seven rare-earth elements and the rare-earth magnets used in many 21st-century consumer products and military technologies.

After another quick round of back-and-forth retaliation, Trump backed down, and the two sides met in Geneva to declare a truce. Six months later, that truce was extended, and it remains in force today as Trump and President Xi Jinping prepare for their summit later this month.

Both sides have (for now) recognized that confrontation would badly damage both economies. Pragmatism became the new rule for the world's most important bilateral relationship. US and Chinese officials have since looked for and found ways to work together more constructively on trade and investment, as well as engaging in more frequent, higher-level military-to-military communications. To keep relations on track, the Trump administration has delayed new defense packages for Taiwan, allowed restrictions on commerce with Hong Kong to lapse, and scaled back the periodic US naval patrols that are meant to assert freedom of navigation in the South China Sea.

The big question for a world now plagued by two major wars and another barrage of Trump-generated trade conflicts is how long these US-Chinese guardrails will hold. On a positive note, the current détente depends on a balance of coercive leverage that should last, in most areas, for at least the next several years.

The US will continue to reduce its direct reliance on Chinese goods imports, but it will remain vulnerable to China's control over processed critical minerals and intermediate goods. China will continue to reduce its foreign dependencies and redirect exports toward the Global South, but it will still be vulnerable to US financial sanctions and some technology export controls.

To be sure, the US and Chinese leadership won't suddenly decide to trust one another. Since neither is prepared to lower its guard, there are still many things that could go wrong. A major flare-up over US sanctions on Iran, Chinese support for Russia, or a miscalculation over Taiwan could raise pressure in both capitals for a more confrontational approach. But as long as the US and China continue to read the balance of leverage correctly and avoid domestic pressure for escalation, the occasional diplomatic, trade, or security skirmish can remain contained in the interest of stability.

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There is a dangerous wildcard, though. AI and the lack of international governance over its development and use are already creating risks, within both the US and China and around the world. And given that the US and China now lead in AI innovation by some distance, competition between the two in this sector poses the biggest threat to their currently constructive relations.

This race is now marked by both fast-advancing Chinese capabilities and the sudden rise of new national-security risks for both countries. China's decision to focus on inexpensive, open-source models will make AI at scale accessible to consumers and industrial users in the West and across the Global South. But the US intelligence and defense community will not welcome such competitive pressure (and data collection). Moreover, Chinese models bring some of the same

cyber and biotech risks as their American counterparts; but unlike Anthropic or OpenAI, Chinese companies won't respond to US government concerns and demands.

That is why the US will respond in the coming months with significant restrictions on Chinese access to US models and limits on US access to Chinese open-weight models. Trump will also try to use US political leverage to pressure other countries to adopt American, rather than Chinese, AI. If the US and China fail to manage this struggle, we can expect a sharp acceleration in the decoupling of advanced technologies between the two countries.

We are already seeing this trend in other areas. In July, the US banned the import of foreign-made humanoid robots—a move obviously aimed at China, which has a substantial technological and pricing lead over its American competitors. Trump has also now imposed up to 100% tariffs on drones, targeting Chinese-made models, in particular, on national-security grounds.

In short, the Sino-American AI arms race is already well underway. The question now is whether Trump and Xi can use their White House summit this month to lay the groundwork for an ongoing AI dialogue designed to avoid a future of accelerating, opaque, and potentially zero-sum conflict.

If they fail, the two sides may feel that confrontation has become inevitable, and not just regarding AI. It is not hard to imagine a renewed trade conflict and heightened security tensions quickly bringing down the guardrails the two sides have built over the past 16 months. The AI race makes such an outcome all the more difficult to avoid.

29. Unpaid Work in the AI Age

Author: Diane Coyle **Published:** Sep 8, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

CAMBRIDGE—Discussions about how AI might disrupt the economy have a blind spot: they largely fail to account for the valuable activities people do outside of paid work. Statisticians call such activities “household production,” but they collect very little data about them. The American Time Use Survey (ATUS) is conducted annually in the United States, but its scale is small, and most OECD countries collect such information less frequently. As a result, there is very little economic research, and next to no policy debate, on how most of us spend most of our time.

But investors and policymakers should care about unpaid activities. When social or technological shifts move activity across the production boundary—from paid to unpaid or vice versa—our interpretation of economic signals must also change. In the 1970s and 1980s, official GDP- and productivity-growth figures rose in countries like the United Kingdom and the US partly because changing social conventions were causing more married women to spend more of their time doing paid work.

Digital technology has already led to major shifts across this production boundary, mainly from paid to unpaid. People now use digital tools to handle a wide range of tasks, from banking to travel planning, that once required consultation with a professional, not to mention ringing up their own groceries at the supermarket checkout. Meanwhile, many people share their output—open-source software, entertaining videos, music lessons, or DIY tutorials—online for free.

All of these examples represent the substitution of unpaid for paid work. And, for the most part, they have created a good deal of consumer value. With AI promising to move yet more activity across the production boundary, the question is how to ensure that this, too, will prove valuable for households.

Answering this question will require us, first, to get a sense of where people find AI most useful outside paid work. Google’s ATLAS project (on which I was an adviser) provides some early insights. It mapped millions of anonymized Gemini interactions to the task categories used by the ATUS and contrasted the volume of US users’ AI conversations related to each category against the actual hours people dedicate to it.

By this metric, topics like “Eating and Drinking” and “Traveling” were significantly underrepresented in AI interactions, compared to actual time spent. Interactions relating to “Socializing, Relaxing, & Leisure”—the category where overall AI usage is the highest—were relatively close to parity with actual time spent.

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“Education,” however, was overrepresented, with its share of AI interactions about 5.8 times larger than its share of people’s time. “Professional & Personal Care Services” and “Consumer Purchases” were also over-indexed. But nothing compared to the overrepresentation of “Government Services & Civic Obligations,” which appeared nearly 20 times more often in the AI interactions than in official time-use data.

In her new book *The Time Tax*, Annie Lowrey points out that, in the US, people spend six working days per year, on average, dealing with government bureaucracy, completing tasks like renewing licenses, filing taxes, and applying for assistance. Private-sector administration, from negotiating with insurers to canceling subscriptions, compounds this time tax.

There is good reason to think that AI can help to reduce this burden. Good government digital services already offer efficiency and convenience: I recently watched a friend apply for a passport online in just a couple of minutes. New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani’s “click-to-cancel” rule shows how policy can also ease the burden of private-sector administration.

Governments should seek to leverage AI to advance progress on both fronts. Unfortunately, while many governments are keen to use AI to make public bureaucracies more efficient, they have so far tended to focus on cost savings for the state, not time savings for citizens.

Even without government action, the use of AI tools can save people both time and money. A high-street lawyer in the UK might charge a client £12,000 (\$16,220) to apply for probate and administer their deceased parent’s estate, but LLMs are increasingly capable of completing much of the paperwork involved for free. Other examples of household administrative tasks that might be tackled using a chatbot, or even delegated to an AI agent, include designing interiors or gardens, researching consumer purchases, and queuing up for items like concert tickets. The list is long.

Just as digital technologies led to the disintermediation and re-intermediation of many services, generative AI models will disrupt a wide range of services. New law-tech startups might find themselves competing with free chatbots or agents, rather than with expensive traditional law firms. Similar dynamics will emerge in industries like education, health, finance, and entertainment.

This need not be entirely bad news for human service providers. Free AI access will expand the market for these types of services, in addition to substituting for expensive versions them. There will be growth in complementary products, too: If I can redesign my own dining room for free, maybe I will be more inclined to buy wallpaper, drapes, and new furniture.

Meanwhile, the productivity gains in unpaid work—which is economically valuable, despite being largely left out of official statistics—could be tremendous. Any economist attempting to predict how AI will reshape the economy, and any policymaker seeking to update consumer protections for the AI age, must account for the household side of the production boundary.

30. Are China's Rare Earths Really a Potent Weapon?

Author: Daniel Gros **Published:** Sep 8, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

MILAN—Early last year, China's government introduced an export-licensing regime requiring exporters to obtain approval before shipping heavy rare-earth elements and permanent magnets, over which China has a near-monopoly, to foreign firms. China relaxed these export restrictions later in the year, after US President Donald Trump agreed to reduce tariffs and export restrictions. For many observers, the message seemed clear: China's rare-earths dominance amounts to a powerful source of geopolitical leverage, and the United States and Europe must do everything in their power to erode it.

But the numbers tell a more nuanced story. While China is a dominant supplier of rare earths to the European Union and the US, this is less true for rare-earth minerals than for permanent magnets, which are enhanced by small amounts of rare earths. And even for magnets, the EU and the US each import only about \$500 million–\$1 billion annually—a negligible fraction of either economy's total trade or GDP.

It is often argued that the volume of these imports is not the point. Because rare earths and permanent magnets are vital inputs to high-tech products, from electric vehicles to wind turbines, they have an outsize economic impact. A recent International Monetary Fund working paper calculates that the loss of 80% of rare-earth and magnet supplies would reduce US GDP by 1.5% (\$490 billion), German GDP by 2.1%, and Japanese GDP by 2.3%.

The European Central Bank estimates that the loss multiplier would be smaller: losing 50% of rare-earth supplies would reduce US GDP by around 0.2% (\$65 billion). But this still assumes that the damage caused by losing access to rare earths would be at least a hundred times larger than the value of the lost imports themselves.

There are much lower cost estimates. A US Geological Survey report puts the combined loss of all rare-earth supplies, including those incorporated in permanent magnets, at only \$15 billion—a miniscule fraction of US GDP. Past experience suggests that such conclusions are more realistic than the much higher estimates of the IMF and the ECB.

In July 2010, China suddenly cut export quotas for rare earths by 72% for the second half of the year, owing to various environmental and industrial-policy considerations. There is little reason to think that geopolitics was a factor in this decision, but a couple of months later, after a Chinese trawler collided with Japanese coast-guard boats in disputed waters near the Senkaku Islands, China's rare-earth export restrictions did cause Japan pain. Many observers thus cite this episode as an example of Chinese economic coercion.

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The motive might be disputed, but the impact was undeniable. Prices increased sharply, by up to a factor of ten in some cases, and some car producers faced disruptions. Then demand for rare earths fell, and prices began to decline from their peaks. By the time the restrictions were formally lifted more than four years later, prices had already fallen back to pre-restriction levels.

Despite the disruption, production held up, thanks to what one study calls “directed technological change”: a surge in the price of an essential input spurs producers to innovate, whether to increase the efficiency of the input or to find alternatives. As a result, the study estimates that real GDP losses outside China probably amounted to just 0.04–0.05% during the four and a half years the restrictions were in place, with negligible macroeconomic impact on Western

economies. The IMF's World Economic Outlooks during this period did not even mention rare-earth scarcity as an obstacle to growth.

Today, the impact of Chinese rare-earth export restrictions might be even smaller, because there are significantly more alternative supplies. Even if those supplies cannot fully replace Chinese exports, they can ensure that the highest-value uses are covered. Recent studies show that just a 10% loss in market share, from 95% to 85%, can substantially weaken a supplier's leverage.

The available evidence indicates that Chinese rare-earth export restrictions would cost the West far less than often feared. At the same time, it is impossible to estimate this cost precisely in advance. This is forcing prudence on both sides: Western leaders are pursuing a more restrained trade policy toward China, to mitigate the risks of retaliation, and Chinese policymakers are avoiding sharp curbs on rare-earth exports, for fear that such a policy's bite would prove less effective than its bark.

Geopolitical hawks on both sides might find this situation frustrating. But the rest of us should welcome it. Trade restrictions are always a negative-sum game.

31. Building a Resilient Nepal

Author: Gordon Brown

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EDINBURGH—When a torrent of water, rock, and mud tore through Nepal’s Himalayan mountain valleys on August 26, following the collapse of a glacier and the mountainside beneath it, more than 1,300 people were killed, and nearly 5,000 are still missing. Tens of thousands of other lives have been severely disrupted: Nepal’s economy has ground to a halt, and many schools were destroyed.

The disaster began when a huge section of glacier and rock fell more than 4,000 vertical feet into the valley below, causing water levels downriver to rise by as much as 30 feet (9.1 meters) in 30 minutes. Towns and villages across a wide swath of the country were washed away or swallowed by mud. At the Gyirong border crossing separating Tibet and Nepal, a five-story Chinese customs building was hit by a tsunami-like mudslide and essentially vanished.

It has long been predicted that fast-melting snow and ice in high mountain areas would result in more frequent floods and avalanches. Three years ago, a glacial lake burst in the northeastern Indian state of Sikkim, causing more than 50 deaths and significant infrastructure damage. A year later, a similar event destroyed Thame village in Nepal’s Mount Everest region. But the recent tragedy in Nepal is by far the worst incident yet.

A global response is urgently required. Aided by support from the United Kingdom and other countries, the Nepalese government swiftly dispatched emergency teams to locate survivors and recover bodies. But soon the work of rescue and recovery will end, and the work of rebuilding must begin.

If anything, the recent spate of floods, fires, and drought worldwide has underscored the need for coordinated cross-border action on climate change—particularly in vulnerable countries like Nepal. With severe flooding growing more frequent, and with landslides becoming more likely in the coming years, preventive action must be taken to protect villages and buildings. That includes better early-warning systems to prevent a repeat of the catastrophic damage we see now.

There is also the question of Nepal’s reliance on hydropower, the source of nearly all its electricity. Kulman Ghising, a former energy minister of Nepal who called the deluge a “once-in-a-century” event, has said that it holds lessons for the design and location of plants. Instead of placing them in the mountains, for example, Nepal could build reservoir-based plants. The country could also invest in solar energy, as its technical potential is around ten times larger than that of hydropower.

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More immediately, tens of thousands of displaced children face serious risks from unsafe water, malnutrition, trauma, and the lack of a safe place to shelter. According to UNICEF, at least 17,000 children urgently require humanitarian assistance. The United Nations estimates that more than 22,000 children will need protection, while around 2,600 children under the age of five will require treatment for severe wasting.

An estimated 20,000 homes will need to be rebuilt. But equally important is the imperative to reconstruct and reopen affected schools as quickly as possible. As relief organizations have found, the certainty of going to school—and the return to normality—eases the psychological distress faced by children in times of crisis. And getting young people back into education is instrumental to kick-starting the recovery process for whole communities.

Education Cannot Wait, the global fund dedicated to education in emergencies, is appealing for financing to support local and international partners in responding to the urgent needs in Nepal. “The immediate priority is to ensure that children continue learning. Every day out of school increases the risk of dropout, child labor, and early marriage,” ECW Director Maysa Jalbout told me.

Moreover, a team of British engineers at Strathclyde University has started an appeal for funds to help rebuild schools—and rebuild them stronger—in Nepal. Theirworld, a charity I helped establish to assist children in desperate conditions, will match every £1 raised by this initiative up to £50,000 (\$68,000).

The goal is to provide safe learning spaces, which will require repairing the physical damage to buildings. In the long term, Nepal will also need to reposition schools located close to dangerous riverbanks and ensure that all are earthquake-proof. After Japan’s 2011 Fukushima nuclear disaster, the Japanese government changed the building codes for schools and housing, and rethought the placement of critical infrastructure.

Nepal (and other vulnerable countries) must pursue a similar approach, recovering from this disaster while drawing lessons from it to prepare for and mitigate future ones.

32. The Trump Shock in East Asia

Author: Ian Buruma **Published:** Sep 8, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW YORK—On August 16, one day after the anniversary of Emperor Hirohito’s announcement of Imperial Japan’s unconditional surrender to the Allies in 1945, US President Donald Trump ordered the Pentagon to “substantially reduce” joint military exercises with South Korea. His reasons were odd, to say the least. He wrote on his Truth Social platform that the annual Ulchi Freedom Shield exercises “send a signal that is totally inappropriate and hostile, to a Country that, as long as Donald J. Trump has been President, has been unthreatening and respectful.”

That respectful and unthreatening country is none other than North Korea, which has been ramping up its nuclear capabilities since Trump’s ill-advised and fruitless meetings with North Korean dictator Kim Jong-un in 2019. Seven years later, Kim’s regime has been respectfully launching ballistic missiles over the Sea of Japan with some frequency.

By now, it is well known that Trump can change longstanding US foreign policy on a whim, depending on his mood or whether he feels sufficiently esteemed by a foreign leader. But this was apparently no whim: just over a week later, he canceled a joint amphibious landing drill with US and South Korean marines.

Trump claims that he is angry with South Korea for refusing to join his war on Iran—a conflict as reckless as it is counterproductive. Maybe he is. But there might be a deeper reason for his alarming behavior. Trump wants to be remembered as the greatest US president, the man who managed to establish world peace. Trump’s chosen path to reach that goal is to strike deals with dictators who might threaten the United States. Once the world is divided between big powers, America can exist in splendid isolation and will no longer be taken advantage of by smaller countries.

It is often said that Trump prefers dealing with autocrats like Kim and Russian President Vladimir Putin because he is envious of their grandiose trappings and unfettered power. While this is certainly possible, he may also believe that it is easier to make a deal with a tyrant than with a politician who must answer to voters.

Whatever the reason for Trump’s erratic policies, the canceled military exercises came as a shock to the South Koreans and have alarmed the Japanese. Ever since the end of World War II, US military guarantees have allowed European and East Asian democracies to thrive by deterring potentially hostile powers. Even though plenty of local wars erupted under Pax Americana, a world war became unthinkable. Historical wounds still caused friction between Japan and South Korea; but so long as Uncle Sam was in charge, such problems could be managed.

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Now that Trump has blown gaping holes into the postwar order by threatening to withhold help for NATO members and by weakening military cooperation with one of the most important US allies in East Asia, all the comforting assumptions of Pax Americana have gone out the window. The consequences of Trump’s behavior are even more serious for East Asia than they are for Europe.

Without a NATO equivalent, East and Southeast Asian countries must establish an entirely new set of military arrangements following the end of Pax Americana. Despite its robust Self-Defense Forces, Japan still depends on the US for its security, as does South Korea. And this is to say nothing of Taiwan. Meanwhile, China is striving to restore its status as Asia’s dominant power, and North Korea is threatening South Korea with nuclear war. China and North Korea are also drawing closer to Russia.

Efforts are already underway to counter possible Chinese belligerence with an Indo-Pacific defense alliance that includes the US, India, and Australia. But weaning Japan and South Korea off US military support will require Japanese leadership and close Japanese-South Korean cooperation.

Inevitably, Japan will have to reconsider its pacifist constitution, which currently bars Japanese forces from engaging in combat abroad. For South Korea, it will require setting aside historical resentments—including demands for more Japanese apologies—for the sake of mutual interests.

South Korean President Lee Jae-myung, a liberal, seems aware of this, judging by his attempts to cultivate warm relations with his conservative Japanese counterpart, Prime Minister Takaichi Sanae. The two leaders, quite unexpectedly, bashed out a K-pop tune on matching drum kits in January.

Lee and Takaichi are eyeing an acquisition and cross-servicing agreement, which would allow South Korea and Japan to share and procure military supplies and logistical support on a mutual basis. But unlike Kim Jong-un, Lee is a democrat who cannot bend his country's citizens to his will by force. After acknowledging the "practical need" for such an agreement, Lee immediately added, "if I say something like this, I'll get scolded," which is why he has publicly called for a "sincere" apology from Japan for its colonial rule of Korea.

Lee has no choice but to say this. His left-wing voters are accustomed to protesting against what they see as Japan's lack of remorse, and against the conservative Korean politicians whom they regard as the successors of the Korean elites who collaborated with Japanese colonial rulers. But Takaichi, as a conservative nationalist, must cater to her voters, too. That means minimizing the darker chapters of Japanese history. A Japanese socialist could apologize, but a right-wing leader of the Liberal Democratic Party finds it harder.

In the past, these tensions would have been insurmountable. Even with the US serving as a mediator between its East Asian allies and cajoling them to cooperate, the historic wounds remained. But Trump's cold shoulder and flirtations with Japan's and South Korea's enemies may finally achieve what friendlier US administrations failed to do.

33. Europe's Security Depends on a Clear Electrification Target

Author: Neil Makaroff

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PARIS—Ever since Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022, Europe has felt the strain of energy dependence. Between 2021 and 2025, the European Union spent more than €2.2 trillion (\$2.5 trillion) on imported fossil fuels. And the closure of the Strait of Hormuz earlier this year, following the US-Israeli war on Iran, has forced the EU to pay an extra €50 billion for energy imports. Volatile oil and gas markets affect everything from household bills to industrial costs and public finances.

The solution is straightforward: to protect European citizens and businesses, the EU must pursue rapid electrification. The bloc can produce green electricity domestically and at scale. Renewable power, electric vehicles (EVs), heat pumps, industrial electrification, and battery storage are all mature, readily deployable, and increasingly cost-competitive technologies. They offer not only long-term resilience, but also an exit from the current energy crisis.

National governments in some member states, such as France and Sweden, have already launched plans to accelerate this process, but there is a strong case for an EU-level strategy. The European Commission's new Electrification Action Plan is therefore an important political breakthrough. For the first time, it makes electrification an energy priority and proposes to double the share of electricity in the European economy to reach 46% in 2040. A 46% target is a good first step, but the EU has the potential to secure 50%. And in the EU's energy independence pathway, every percentage point matters.

Electrifying at least 50% of the European economy by 2040 would reduce fossil-fuel imports by as much as two-thirds, leaving the bloc importing liquefied natural gas only from reliable suppliers such as Norway and the United Kingdom. This would strengthen Europe's security by shielding it from supply disruptions and geopolitical pressures.

For European firms, electrification is synonymous with modernization and productivity, giving them an edge in a highly competitive global economy. While fossil-fuel volatility raises operating costs and can even force temporary production pauses, electrification offers more stability and affordability. True, it requires upfront investment in new processes and infrastructure, such as industrial heat pumps and electric furnaces. But the returns are worth it. Heat pumps, for example, are 3–4 times more efficient than their fossil-fuel counterparts.

The same logic applies to citizens. Purchasing an EV or a heat pump might be expensive, especially amid a cost-of-living crisis, but the benefits are almost immediate. Notably, the average driver can save almost €900 in fuel costs per year by switching to an EV. Equipping low- and middle-income households with clean-energy technologies can insulate them from the current price hike and future shocks.

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The EU has all it needs to accelerate electrification. Europe's clean-tech sector is scaling up to the point that it can meet the bloc's needs. More than two-thirds of the bloc's electricity is decarbonized, and about 85 gigawatts of solar and wind capacity were added last year. Embracing electrification has the added benefit of enhancing the EU's industrial base, from France's battery valley and industrial heat-pump makers in Italy and the Czech Republic, to Poland's burgeoning solar-manufacturing industry and offshore wind champions in Denmark and Spain.

All that is missing is the political commitment to shift spending away from imported fossil fuels toward cleantech. The Commission's Action Plan confirms a shift in the EU's energy paradigm away from the diversification of gas and oil supplies and toward electrification. But a plan, however comprehensive, can only succeed if followed by concrete legislative action. Markets respond to clarity, especially in capital-intensive sectors such as grids and electrotechnology manufacturing. And that is precisely why the next step can be to turn this political promise into a binding EU-wide target of at least 50% by 2040. It would provide credible direction for investment, infrastructure planning, and industrial strategy.

Here, the EU's Energy Security Framework offers a natural vehicle to give the target legal force, resolutely placing electrification as a central pillar of the future European energy security architecture. In doing so, it can allow the EU to adopt a long-term outlook, rather than focusing on short-term crisis management.

But a standalone binding target is not enough. The EU must pair it with enabling policies that can accelerate deployment across the economy and ensure that electricity is abundant and cheap for households and industries. The Electrification Action Plan offers a strong foundation for that. It addresses several barriers, including grid access, storage, industrial investment, the upfront costs faced by households, and the price gap between electricity and gas.

The Action Plan's accompanying proposal for rebalancing the tax differential between electricity and gas can make the former more abundant and affordable for households and industry. At a time when electricity is taxed more than fossil fuels, it can incentivize the rebalancing of national tax systems. Denmark has already adopted such reforms, lowering inflation and energy costs for consumers.

Equally important is the ability to mobilize public funds to help low- and middle-income households and small and medium-size businesses invest in electrification. Revenue from the EU's Emissions Trading System could be put toward equipping Europeans with cleantech or decarbonizing the bloc's industrial base. The EU can build on this foundation by applying an "electrification-first" principle systematically across its funding instruments and emissions-trading revenues. Such policies would translate the Action Plan's ambition into investment decisions and quick economic gains.

The politics around electrification are beginning to shift in the EU as more people recognize its importance for competitiveness, industrial resilience, and economic security. European policymakers must seize this momentum to embed a target of at least 50% electrification by 2040 in the EU's energy security framework. This is technically feasible. But more significantly, in a period defined by geopolitical uncertainty and economic fragmentation, such a target is strategically necessary to provide the continent with the stability it desperately needs.

34. The World 9/11 Didn't Make

Author: Richard Haass **Published:** Sep 9, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW YORK—This week marks the 25th anniversary of the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks on the United States. For many Americans, 9/11 is a distant memory, or not a memory at all—approximately 40% of the US population was either born after the attacks or is too young to remember them.

On that day, 19 terrorists took control of four civilian aircraft, flew two into the towers of New York's World Trade Center, struck the Pentagon with a third, and crashed the fourth in a Pennsylvania field after passengers physically prevented the terrorists from reaching their target, often thought to be the White House or another government building in Washington.

All 19 hijackers were from the Middle East, 15 from Saudi Arabia. All were trained in Afghanistan, and four at US flight schools, as part of an operation planned, organized, and carried out by al-Qaeda ("the base"), the terrorist group founded by Osama bin Laden. By the day's end, close to 3,000 men, women, and children had been killed, and more than 6,000 injured. Most were American, though citizens of more than a hundred countries lost their lives as well.

To invoke President Franklin D. Roosevelt's description of the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor in December 1941, September 11, too, was "a date which will live in infamy." But with the fading of personal recollections, it seems right and necessary to ask the question: Did 9/11 mark a turning point? Or was it a day that, as tragic as it was, did not alter the course of history?

The truth is closer to the latter. Fortunately, 9/11 did not usher in an age defined by terrorism. A wave of attacks on a similar scale did not follow, in no small part because the US and other governments adopted measures that made it more difficult for would-be terrorists to emerge and succeed.

Another reason 9/11 did not alter history is that terrorists tend to be better at destroying than building, at killing rather than creating. As a result, they leave no lasting legacy.

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By no means is this meant to imply that 9/11 did not matter. It led directly to military intervention in Afghanistan, where US-led forces, in coordination with Afghan tribesmen, ousted the ruling Taliban, which had provided sanctuary to bin Laden and the terrorists who carried out the attacks.

Call it what it was: regime change. But what followed, something that was closer to nation-building, provided an early lesson: removing a regime from power is one thing; replacing it with a better system that endures and governs effectively is quite another—and far more difficult. Twenty-five years later, after more than 800,000 US soldiers had been deployed, more than \$2 trillion spent, and over 2,400 Americans killed in combat (along with another 1,100 soldiers from NATO countries and others), Afghanistan is again ruled by the Taliban.

In March 2003, just a year and a half after 9/11, the US initiated a war of choice against Iraq. It is possible, but unlikely, that this war would have happened absent 9/11. In the wake of the attacks, President George W. Bush and many of his closest advisers became determined to demonstrate that the US was much more than a victim. (I served in the Bush administration during this time but opposed the war in Iraq and resigned soon after.)

Some in the Bush administration believed Saddam Hussein, Iraq's strongman leader, was developing or even possessed a nuclear weapon and feared that terrorists would get ahold of one. Others were taken with the idea of spreading democracy to Iraq and the region, an outcome that would have made the region less likely to produce terrorists and support terrorism. Almost all of this turned out to be wrong.

But the costly war (more than 4,000 US soldiers lost their lives, and trillions more dollars were spent) turned many Americans against overseas involvement and eventually positioned Iran, which had nothing to do with 9/11 even if it was a strategic beneficiary of the war, as a major power in the Middle East.

Iran played a larger role in terrorism in the October 7, 2023, attacks by Hamas on Israel, resulting in the deaths of more than 800 civilians. But again, as awful as that was, little of what has happened since, be it in Gaza, Lebanon, or Iran, was preordained or can be attributed to terrorism. Rather, subsequent developments largely reflect policy decisions taken in the first instance by Israel and the US.

Looking back at the past quarter-century, it becomes apparent that 9/11 was not a transformative event. Far more important were China's rise, Russia's aggression against Ukraine, the COVID-19 pandemic, the collective failure to take meaningful action against climate change, the emergence of AI, and, perhaps more than anything else, America's rejection of the postwar order that it had a large hand in building.

These truths do not, however, diminish the lesson that should be drawn. Although 9/11 did not usher in an age of terrorism, we are not safe from it. On the contrary, we have entered an era in which AI, along with accurate, inexpensive, and destructive drones and advances in bioengineering, have given terrorists more opportunity than ever to impose large-scale harm at minimal cost. The goal must be to ensure that they do not succeed, and that terrorism remains at most a limited problem.

35. How 9/11 Fractured the Global Order

Author: Javier Solana **Published:** Sep 9, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

MADRID—A quarter-century ago, the world changed course in an instant. The new millennium had roughly coincided with the arrival of new presidents in the United States and Russia, then the world's two greatest military powers. But the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks on the US fundamentally altered both countries' trajectories, as well as that of a rising China, setting in motion developments that would produce the fractured geopolitical order we live in today.

Everyone who is old enough still remembers where they were on that fateful day. One of us was in Crimea, the other in Khartoum, and though we were stunned, we did not yet know that we were witnessing the beginning of a new era.

In America, the world's unquestioned hegemon, President George W. Bush had taken a tortuous path to the White House, following a Florida ballot recount that was ultimately settled by the Supreme Court. On the morning of September 11, television cameras caught the president reading to children in a Sarasota, Florida, elementary school, where an aide whispered in his ear that the country was under attack. His look of bewilderment anticipated the quality that would come to define US foreign policy.

The US soon subordinated every other objective to national security, abandoning the multilateral leadership that it had leveraged since 1945. Starting in late 2001, US Secretary of Defense Donald Rumsfeld pushed for America to leave the Anti-Ballistic Missile Treaty, so that it could start work on a missile shield to defend the "homeland." This led to the Ground-Based Midcourse Defense program, which deployed missiles in Alaska and California, and had plans to do so in Poland, catching a weakened Russia by surprise. In a move that should have surprised no one, Russian President Vladimir Putin responded by abandoning the Strategic Arms Reduction Treaty (START II).

Meanwhile, the US embarked on two major wars: in Afghanistan, where its intervention was legal and backed by much of the world; and in Iraq, where it launched an invasion without UN authorization. The Iraq war caused an internal rupture within the European Union, with longstanding members like France and Germany opposing it, while newer members like Poland and older ones like the United Kingdom backed the US effort.

Both wars would end in failure, and the Bush presidency would leave a poisoned gift: the offer—as grandiose as it was unworkable—of eventual NATO membership for Georgia and Ukraine, made at the alliance's 2008 Bucharest summit. With no timetable and no real guarantees, this promise raised alarms in the Kremlin without doing anything to protect either country.

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Putin's ascent to the Russian presidency in 2000 had initially seemed to herald stability and economic development after the chaos of the 1990s. On September 11, he was reportedly among the first to call Bush to express his solidarity. But this did not last long. In 2003, the Kremlin expropriated the big, previously privatized energy firm Yukos and jailed its owner, the politically ambitious oligarch Mikhail Khodorkovsky. In 2006, the former Russian spy Alexander Litvinenko was poisoned with polonium-210 in London. And in 2007, at the Munich Security Conference, Putin delivered an incendiary speech accusing the West of double standards, effectively breaking with the security architecture that Russia and the West had inherited from the Cold War.

The combination of American unilateralism and Russian marginalization pushed Putin toward a revisionist nationalism, an increasingly brazen authoritarianism, and, gradually, into the arms of a rising Chinese giant. In August 2008, as the

global financial crisis erupted and amid the Beijing Olympics, Russia invaded Georgia, setting a precedent for the eventual invasion of Ukraine.

But perhaps the most fascinating and consequential development was unfolding in Asia. In December 2001, China joined the World Trade Organization with the full support of the US and the EU. The West assumed that commercial integration would drag China's economic model toward convergence with liberal capitalism. Instead, China pursued a different model: an effective, tightly directed state capitalism. Far from fading, the Chinese model became a powerful geopolitical lever that the Western model—many companies competing against one another, with no state strategy behind them—has proven unable to answer.

US President Barack Obama, already in his second term, was among the first to react. The US gave up on reforming the WTO and launched two comprehensive trade agreements that explicitly excluded China: the Transatlantic Trade and Investment Partnership, which would ultimately be abandoned, and the Trans-Pacific Partnership, which later entered into force as the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership without its US architect.

In 2012, Xi Jinping came to power in China and began concentrating authority and control over society to a degree unmatched since Mao Zedong. His political doctrine was written into the Party's constitution (joining those of Mao and Deng Xiaoping) in 2017, and a year later, the National People's Congress abolished presidential term limits.

Since then, Xi has increasingly centralized power and decoupled China's civil and academic life from the rest of the world. In 2017, China blocked WhatsApp and Skype, making it harder for Chinese civil-society and business leaders to communicate with their Western counterparts. And in the last five years, hundreds of senior officials and military officers have been investigated, removed, or purged. Following the unexplained disappearances of the foreign and defense ministers in 2023, almost the entire Central Military Commission was purged this year.

The world could have taken a different course after September 11, 2001. Instead, major powers have remained beholden to an overly narrow understanding of security and power. The US has turned inward and embraced the principle of might makes right; Russia, marginalized and weakened, has become a revisionist belligerent; and China has turned its economic model into an instrument of power that the West does not know how to counter.

For Europe, these developments have made one thing all too clear: We can no longer rely on American protection. Europe must build a credible military force of its own to counter Russia, and it must devise instruments to shield its economy from Chinese economic dirigisme. Whether Europe will finally take this path remains to be seen.

36. The BRICS at 20

Author: Brahma Chellaney **Published:** Sep 9, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW DELHI—Twenty years ago this month, the foreign ministers of Brazil, Russia, India, and China held the first meeting of the BRICs. Since then, the grouping has been formalized—the first BRIC summit took place in June 2009—and expanded, with South Africa joining in 2011 and several more countries later coming on board, either as full members or official partners. Today, the BRICS represents a highly consequential experiment in international cooperation, which epitomizes the gradual rebalancing of global power away from the West and the emergence of a multipolar order.

Few acronyms have undergone as dramatic an evolution as the BRICS. Coined by Jim O'Neill, then of Goldman Sachs, in 2001 to encapsulate four fast-growing emerging markets, the “BRICs” grouping has developed into the BRICS, an 11-country political and economic coalition and an increasingly influential voice for the Global South.

Since adding Egypt, Ethiopia, Indonesia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates to its ranks in 2024-25, the BRICS accounts for nearly half of the world's population and about 40% of global GDP (in purchasing-power-parity terms). By contrast, the G7 accounts for less than 10% of the global population and less than 30% of world GDP. And whereas the BRICS' share of the global economy continues to grow, the pace of productivity and economic growth in advanced economies has been declining steadily since the 1990s.

This economic reversal is increasingly matched in the geopolitical domain, with Western global dominance giving way to a more diffuse distribution of power and influence. Amid this transformation—the likes of which occur only once every 50–100 years—the BRICS has challenged the assumption that global governance should remain centered on the Western-led institutions established after World War II.

For non-Western countries, the BRICS represents a hedge against rising economic and geopolitical uncertainty—generated, not least, by a United States seemingly bent on withdrawing from global leadership—and an institutional platform for advancing strategic autonomy and broadening economic cooperation. Small wonder there has been such enthusiasm for joining: more than three dozen countries have formally applied or expressed interest in becoming members, including Turkey, a NATO member, and Bahrain, the primary operational hub for US naval forces in the Middle East.

The BRICS also has ten “partner countries”—Belarus, Bolivia, Kazakhstan, Cuba, Malaysia, Nigeria, Thailand, Uganda, Uzbekistan, and Vietnam—which can participate in summits. This framework helps to expand the BRICS' network for cooperation and strengthen its ability to represent the Global South, without jeopardizing cohesion.

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The BRICS is much more than a symbolic grouping—merely a message to the world that the era of Western dominance is coming to an end. The grouping has made tangible progress on institution-building. The New Development Bank (NDB) is the first multilateral development bank with global scope conceived and led solely by emerging economies, with the founding BRICS members holding equal shares and voting rights. By contrast, the United States is the largest shareholder at both the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund, where it holds effective veto power. Unlike these US-led institutions, the NDB does not attach political conditions to its infrastructure financing, allowing borrowers to retain greater policy autonomy.

The BRICS has also been working to reduce vulnerabilities within the international financial system. Contrary to speculation, a single BRICS currency akin to the euro is not on the agenda. Instead, the upcoming summit will focus on expanding trade settlement in national currencies, improving interoperability among members' digital-payment systems, linking central-bank digital currencies, and developing alternative cross-border payment infrastructure. The goal is not to upend the global financial system and supplant the US dollar, which still accounts for about 57% of foreign-exchange reserves held by central banks worldwide, but rather to strengthen resilience against external financial shocks.

As much progress as the BRICS has made over the last 20 years, however, the grouping also faces significant headwinds, rooted not least in its exceptional internal diversity. The BRICS includes liberal democracies and authoritarian states, leading energy exporters and major energy importers, manufacturing powers and commodity economies. The grouping also includes geopolitical rivals: China and India, Iran and Saudi Arabia, and Egypt and Ethiopia. Divisions exist even among its founding members, with Brazil and India generally advocating reform of existing international institutions, while China and Russia seek to challenge the US-led world order.

Diversity brings different ideas and advantages to the table, and ideological uniformity and close strategic alignment are not necessarily prerequisites to cooperation. But a highly diverse grouping, with sharply divergent priorities and geopolitical concerns, will always struggle to forge consensus. Every round of enlargement compounds the challenge, even as it raises the BRICS' profile as a broadly representative international coalition.

As the group convenes in New Delhi for its 18th summit, one might ask whether it has lived up to its original promise. If that promise was to establish a monetary union, a single market, or a tightly integrated political alliance, the answer is plainly no. But if it was to reshape international relations, broaden the space available to emerging economies on the world stage, strengthen South-South cooperation, and increase pressure for reform of existing international institutions, the BRICS has exceeded expectations.

More fundamentally, the BRICS has normalized an idea that once seemed impossible: that emerging economies can cooperate with one another, build their own institutions, and change how the international order is organized. That is no small feat.

37. Europe Needs Dual-Use Defense Spending

Author: Krzysztof Krawczyk

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WARSAW—Poland has led NATO in defense spending in relative terms for three consecutive years, with an annual budget of roughly zł200 billion (\$54 billion), or 4.8% of GDP. Poland was also the first country to draw on the European Union's Security Action for Europe (SAFE) loan facility, securing some €43.7 billion (\$50 billion) in loans to support military spending through 2030. The question is how to ensure that such investments produce innovations which simultaneously bolster security and build national wealth.

One might associate the pursuit of dual-use technologies with the Cold War. But the concept is centuries old. Consider the Venetian Arsenal, a cluster of armories and shipyards that formed Europe's largest industrial complex in the 15th–17th centuries. Four centuries before Henry Ford's first moving assembly line, some 16,000 workers were towing hulls from one specialist crew to the next and fitting them with standardized parts to turn out nearly a galley a day.

This was pure defense spending, but it had enormous positive spillover effects, including proto-industrial management, standardization, materials science, and skilled labor. The Italian astronomer Galileo Galilei played a central role in this process: a consultant to the Arsenal, he gave his re-engineered telescope to the Venetian Senate in 1609 as a naval early-warning instrument—earning himself a doubled salary—before turning it toward the sky.

Today, military procurement remains a critical means of converting security spending into prosperity. The internet, GPS, the semiconductor industry, and Silicon Valley all sit downstream of defense demand, much of which is channeled through the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency. The Pentagon was among the first major customers for integrated-circuit manufacturers. DARPA grantees have often gone on to staff corporate labs such as the Xerox Palo Alto Research Center. When Apple co-founder Steve Jobs visited PARC in 1979, the story goes, he walked out with the graphical user interface and the mouse.

It is up to private actors to translate state-funded research into commercial inventions. To facilitate this, policymakers must go beyond funding laboratories to create military-to-civilian transmission mechanisms for technology, processes, and people. Effective spin-out rules would help, as would opening procurement to startups and ensuring that entrepreneurs have access to knowledge and capital. Israel's Yozma venture-capital fund, which was launched as a government-funded program in 1993, offers one useful model.

Talent is equally important. The Israel Defense Forces' Unit 8200 selects promising 18-year-olds, gives them operational responsibility in intelligence and cyberwarfare, and releases them into the startup economy three years later. The Talpiot program is even more exclusive: a small number of exceptional young people study advanced physics, math, and computer science, while training with soldiers from other military branches, in order to lead in military research and development. Alumni of these programs founded much of Israel's digital sector, including cyber-security firms like Check Point Software Technologies, Palo Alto Networks, and Wiz, as well as the navigation app Waze.

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As EU countries increase defense expenditure, they must choose: buy foreign hardware, which depreciates from the day of delivery, or foster a thriving innovation ecosystem. Only the second scenario can ensure that the technologies, institutions, and people that underpin a strong military benefit the civilian economy as well.

Ukraine can be a role model. Once a mere recipient of military aid, the country is now emerging as an exporter of military hardware and expertise, turning out ten million drones per year by President Volodymyr Zelensky's count. In recent months, Ukraine has signed defense-cooperation agreements, which include joint drone production, with multiple NATO countries.

The key to Ukraine's success is speed of iteration: frontline feedback drives weekly hardware and software cycles. And its innovations are inherently dual-use. Drones, sensors, radars, resilient communications, autonomous operations, and AI targeting all have direct civilian applications in logistics, agriculture, inspection, and satellite services.

Poland is the natural entry point for this technology to be integrated into EU industry. Beyond sharing a frontier with Ukraine, Poland is home to firms like WB Electronics, which produces drones there. Poland's armed forces already work with ICEYE, a microsatellite firm co-founded by a Pole, and Warsaw-based Eycore launched its first radar satellite in May. Both firms exemplify the dual-use satellite model.

But unlike smaller NATO states such as Denmark, Estonia, and the Netherlands, Poland has yet to sign a full "drone deal" with Ukraine, and the letter of intent on joint production that the two governments signed in February remains largely unimplemented. Meanwhile, Poland continues to import roughly 70% of its military equipment, mainly from the United States and South Korea. Some economists put the fiscal multiplier of such spending at just 0.3, meaning that most of the money leaks abroad. Offset agreements and licensed local production of K2 tanks help, but licensed assembly is not innovation.

To tap the dual-use dividend, Poland must carve out a fixed share of its defense budget and SAFE drawdowns for competitive procurement from startups and small and medium-size enterprises, with fast contracting. Built on top of NATO's Defense Innovation Accelerator for the North Atlantic, this would give Poland a kind of counterpart to the US Defense Innovation Unit, which accelerates military adoption of commercial technology.

Poland should also build a talent flywheel modeled on Unit 8200 and Talpiot, to channel military alumni toward the domestic startup sector, and improve capital transmission. Policymakers should introduce co-investment vehicles that crowd private money into dual-use ventures, tap the European Investment Bank's new openness to defense financing, and promote a genuine European capital market.

NATO's new 5%-of-GDP spending requirement—3.5% on hard defense, and 1.5% on resilience and infrastructure—implicitly recognizes that effective defense investment delivers dual-use outcomes. Poland should make the most of it, including by institutionalizing the defense relationship with Ukraine by establishing joint ventures and knowledge-sharing agreements.

Europe's innovation landscape has never lacked talent. What it has lacked is scale: insufficient investment combined with fragmented capital markets and procurement. But large new defense commitments—including the €800 billion ReArm Europe/Readiness 2030 strategy and the €150 billion SAFE facility—could change that. Poland should seize this opportunity to become the demand anchor of a new European dual-use market.

38. China's Permanent Manufacturing Revolution

Author: Adair Turner **Published:** Sep 9, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

China's "Made in China" strategy, launched in 2015 to achieve leadership positions in advanced industrial sectors, has been stunningly successful. The United Nations Industrial Development Organization estimates that, on current trends, China's share of global manufacturing value added, which was 6% in 2000 and 30% in 2020, could reach 45% by 2030. China produces nearly 75% of all electric vehicles sold worldwide and 86% of solar panels, and while it still lags behind the West in semiconductors and commercial airplanes, it is closing the technology gap.

This success is often attributed to direct subsidies, which grew 60% between 2016 and 2022. But as Thomas Gatley of Gavekal Research shows, direct subsidies have declined by 25% since 2022, while new forms of indirect support—tax breaks for investment in favored technologies, support for rapid land acquisition, and preferential access to low-cost capital—have grown. In addition, deep structural biases in the Chinese economy produce a very high savings rate, which keeps overall interest rates low.

Together, this amounts to a collective choice (albeit not a democratic one) to set a lower social discount rate than other countries in the trade-off between current and future consumption.

Such bias toward investment does not always deliver sustained productivity growth. Forced savings and high investment enabled the Soviet Union to achieve an initial growth spurt, before bad capital allocation, inefficiency, and corruption eventually led to stagnation. Huge investments can produce huge waste, as China itself showed in the excessive real estate construction of the 2010s.

But in other sectors, China combines high investment with strong incentives for efficiency and innovation. Intense domestic competition and exposure to global markets, excellent transport and energy infrastructure, and superb science and engineering skills have enabled China to become a technological innovator and to grasp the effects of learning by doing and economies of scale, which drive dramatic cost reductions. These fundamental advantages are now more important to China's competitiveness than direct subsidies and would continue to drive success in global markets even if direct subsidies were eliminated.

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Ultimately, technological progress and increased productivity depend on two things—an increase in accumulated knowledge, often embedded in capital machinery, and the increasing use of non-human energy. But knowledge once acquired is not lost, and cheaper energy supply enables still cheaper energy production; the falling cost of solar or wind power reduces the cost of making solar panels or wind turbines.

Those factors would drive significant global productivity improvement even without China; but China's policy choices and capabilities have dramatically accelerated the pace of potential advance.

Other countries must decide how to deal with the threat this acceleration poses to manufacturing jobs. If tariffs are ineffective, one response might be to welcome Chinese investment, which is growing rapidly worldwide and increased by 50% in Europe in 2025.

But these factories will be designed to match Chinese productivity, using Chinese capital equipment commissioned by Chinese engineers; and domestic competitors must match that productivity to survive, even if there are no Chinese

imports.

The inevitable result will be very few manufacturing jobs anywhere. China's 30% share of global manufacturing value added is produced by about 123 million workers; so, if world productivity matched Chinese productivity, all the manufactured goods the world consumes could be produced by around 400 million workers, which is about 7% of the global working-age population. And further rapid productivity improvements are inevitable. As a result, all manufactured goods will eventually be produced by just a few percent of the global workforce, repeating the pattern of developed-economy agricultural employment, which fell from typical workforce shares of around 40% in 1900 to 1–2.5% today.

This dramatic productivity improvement will inevitably cause many prices to collapse relative to products or services with brand or locational value. A \$4,000 Hermès handbag could today be traded for 80 solar photovoltaic panels, and that ratio is almost certain to increase in the future. So, too, will the price of attractive real estate in Beijing, Shanghai, Paris, or London, relative to electric vehicles.

As the economist Dani Rodrik suggests, this means that global consumers may gain as much as Chinese consumers from China's remarkable technological prowess. It also raises complex questions about the sources of wealth in highly automated economies. But the long-term employment implications are clear.

In developed economies, manufacturing employment will decline, regardless of the industrial strategies pursued. And any expectation that manufacturing will absorb more than a trivial fraction of the big increases in the working-age population still occurring in India or Africa is a delusion. China is showing how few workers are needed to produce high-quality manufactured goods. Whatever the policy response to the latest China shock, that number will continue to fall.

39. Have the Terrorists Won?

Author: Timothy Snyder **Published:** Sep 10, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

KHARKIV—On September 11, 2001, when I taught my third class as a professor of East European history at Yale, I knew what the subject had to be: provocation. The Russian imperial secret services, and then the Soviet secret services, had perfected the art of convincing adversaries to do what they wanted them to do while making them think it was for their own reasons. When something terrible happens, as it had that day, suffering, though no doubt desired by those who caused it, is not the point. The point is to get you into a frame of mind that leads you to do something that hurts yourself even more.

History is full of acts of terror. The real question, I told the students that day, is what you do next. You cannot prevent every terrible thing from happening. But your freedom begins with your response.

Sadly, we Americans responded exactly as the terrorists would have wanted; indeed, we likely exceeded their expectations, making the world much worse for ourselves and everyone else.

The obvious response to 9/11 should have been to liberate ourselves from fossil fuels. Without our dependence on oil, we would never have been entangled in the Middle East in the first place. Had we funded clean-energy sources, we could have headed off global warming, prevented further Middle East wars, and prevented the rise of Russian President Vladimir Putin’s hydrocarbon oligarchy.

It was not to be. President George W. Bush, the feckless scion of an oil family, had no interest in intensifying the search for safe energy. The terrorists attacked us, he claimed, because “they hate our freedoms.” Yet our own government then acted to limit our freedom. A new Department of Homeland Security placed a grab-bag of agencies, including border management, under a single authority, treating them all as a matter of security. This set the stage for a domestic politics that divides people living in America into “legals” and “illegals,” us and them, and builds concentration camps.

The notion of a “homeland,” which echoes the Nazi fascination with Heimat, was even more dangerous. At the time, it was an exotic label for a government department, not really in keeping with American English or institutional traditions. But the word has since been normalized in an essentially fascist sense. Under President Donald Trump’s administration, the main threats are deemed to be domestic, from those who do not truly belong. Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth treats the armed forces as a site of culture wars: men against women, whites against Blacks. Troops’ future task is “homeland defense.” The armed forces are to become the personal militia of a ruler, used to quash resistance to Trump.

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Of course, one of the major causes of Trump’s rise was the US invasion of Iraq in 2003—a war of choice that was the worst possible foreign-policy response to 9/11. The war left Americans traumatized and vulnerable to a candidate who would exploit the issue to gain power (only to launch more wars and make us vulnerable to more terrorism). It would also entrench a political economy dominated by military spending and debt. Instead of addressing wealth inequality, social immobility, and family insecurity, we poured blood (mainly of others) and treasure into the sand.

As a people, we followed a script that could have been written by the terrorists themselves. Worse, our elected leaders became that script’s co-authors. The Bush administration invented the links between Iraq and the 9/11 terrorists, which eventually led Americans to distrust their government, enabling the rise of someone like Trump. And these invented

pretexts set the stage for violating the most basic precept of international law: the prohibition of unprovoked wars of aggression.

With that, the post-Cold War era of democratic revival in 1989–91 drew to a close. In preparation for the invasion of Iraq, Americans claimed that just as liberation had been possible in Eastern Europe, so it was possible in the Middle East. The situation was, of course, very different; it is one thing to oust a dictatorship from within, and quite another to do so by foreign invasion. And while Europe's post-communist leaders had ideas about what would come next, the Americans in Iraq had none, imagining that simply destroying a bad regime would bring about a better one.

It would be wrong to say that the US-led invasion of Iraq caused Russia to invade Ukraine over a decade later, in 2014. But the American war certainly made life easier for Putin, who concluded that great powers could invade other countries with the help of extravagant lies.

One reason I warned in 2013 and early 2014 that Russia could invade Ukraine and seize Crimea was the surreal propaganda being deployed in Russian media. Like the US propaganda of 2002 and early 2003, it made no sense. The Americans claimed that fighting terrorism required ousting a regime that, while horrible, suppressed the Islamism that was behind 9/11. The Russians escalated the nonsense: Ukrainians were all gay, all Nazis, and all Jews. Their state did not exist, but oppressed Russians. Despite being an authoritarian regime, Russia would bring democracy to Ukraine, though it already was one.

Not long after the invasion began, I participated in a public discussion in Prague. Emotions ran high. One person wearing a T-shirt emblazoned with a Russian fascist slogan took the microphone and asked why Russia should obey any rules when the Americans had not done so in Iraq in 2003. (I replied that rules were rules: the American invasion had been illegal, but two wrongs did not make a right.) The question exemplified an approach that arose from the internal logic of an oligarchic regime, but also one that the US had facilitated: there was no truth, no right and wrong, and no rules.

In late 2021 and early 2022, as Russia was preparing its second invasion of Ukraine, the shadow of Iraq still loomed. Two decades earlier, the US lied about the rationale for invading Iraq. Now, it was sharing the truth about Russian plans to invade Ukraine. In general, the US was not believed, although the facts were clearly there. It was easier to doubt the Americans in 2022 because of the lies they told in 2002. As a result, everyone was less prepared than they might have been when the big war (as the Ukrainians call it) came.

Having been provoked in 2001, America responded as the terrorists wanted, helping to create a world in which terrorism is so normal that we hardly know when to use the word. Putin and Trump use it to define their enemies, though they are themselves state terrorists. Trump himself normalized terrorism by seeking to stay in power by force in January 2021. And Putin's criminal war of aggression in Ukraine features widespread rape, abduction of children, and the mass execution of activists in occupied territories. But what is most obviously terroristic is the daily launch of drones and missiles targeting Ukrainian civilians.

I am writing this underground in Kharkiv, where the air raid sirens are sounding for the third time tonight. The Ukrainians shoot down most of the drones, but the missiles simply fall, explode, and kill, because Americans have chosen to deny them Patriot missiles. This partly reflects the solidarity of terrorists: Trump's emissaries were just in Moscow praising Putin's "goals." It is also a side effect of Trump's doomed war of choice against Iran. The US has pointlessly fired munitions in the Middle East that might have saved lives in Ukraine. Trump's Iran war enables Putin's Ukraine war.

And yet Trump's war is extremely unpopular—and obviously lost. He stays in it, even as the US midterm elections approach, perhaps because he is hoping the Iranian regime will do him the favor of striking inside the US. Then he can try to suspend elections or deploy more American troops in more American cities—and remain in power indefinitely.

That is one way of wanting the terrorists to win: fight a big war in the Middle East, deplete your own defenses, and hope for the worst. Iran might take the bait by launching a murderous action, or Trump could simply claim that it had. Given all the provocations and lying and terror since 9/11, it would be foolish not to take this scenario seriously. And if it happens, the answer will be the same as it was in 2001: your freedom begins with your response. Above all, do not do the thing that the terrorist wants you to do.

From where I sit, in the dark hours of the early morning, I recall Ukrainians I saw last night, meeting underground for a public event, smiling, drinking wine, and talking about ideas, not doing what the terrorists want, not giving in and going along, but thinking for themselves about the future. That is what Americans must do today, on this terrible anniversary. Do not be provoked; do not enter the mental world of the terrorist; think for yourself. Only then can we hope to make this next quarter-century better than the last one.

40. 9/11's Long Shadow

Author: PS editors Published: Sep 10, 2026 Link: [View Original](#)

Most people above a certain age vividly recall when, 25 years ago, terrorists used hijacked civilian aircraft to strike the symbols of American power, killing nearly 3,000 people. But no one—not even the terrorists themselves—could have predicted just how profound an impact the events of September 11, 2001, would have on the United States and the world.

When Americans were provoked, writes Timothy Snyder of the University of Toronto, they responded exactly “as the terrorists wanted.” One of America’s biggest missteps was its failure to “liberate” itself from fossil fuels—an “obvious response” that would have “headed off global warming, prevented further Middle East wars, and prevented the rise of Putin’s hydrocarbon oligarchy.” Another was limiting Americans’ freedom and “defining the border only as a matter of security.” And, of course, there was America’s war of choice in Iraq, based on “invented pretexts,” which led Americans to “distrust their government” and set the stage for “violating the most basic precept of international law: the prohibition of unprovoked wars of aggression.”

Princeton University’s Anne-Marie Slaughter describes the cultural and political shift underpinning America’s response. When Jimmy Carter was elected president in 1976, he “insisted that human rights would become a permanent part of US foreign policy.” But within two years of 9/11, the US had invaded Iraq and Afghanistan, and “detained alleged terrorists without trial at Guantánamo and ‘black sites’” elsewhere, in “violation of the Geneva Conventions.” Over the last quarter-century, much more that was “once unthinkable” has become normalized. A potent strain of xenophobia has penetrated US politics, and many Americans became convinced that the “world is ungrateful” for the sacrifices they feel they have made for “peace and prosperity.”

It is not only the US whose trajectory was “fundamentally altered” by 9/11, point out Javier Solana and Angel Saz-Carranza of EsadeGeo – Center for Global Economy and Geopolitics. Russia, too, moved onto a different path, driven not least by George W. Bush’s “grandiose” and “unworkable” offer of “eventual NATO membership for Georgia and Ukraine.” America’s embrace of unilateralism, combined with Russia’s growing marginalization, pushed Vladimir Putin “toward a revisionist nationalism, an increasingly brazen authoritarianism, and, gradually, into the arms of a rising Chinese giant.” Meanwhile, China “turned its economic model into an instrument of power that the West does not know how to counter.”

But Richard Haass, President Emeritus of the Council on Foreign Relations, is wary of the conclusion that 9/11 was transformative. The developments that have changed the world over the last 25 years—China’s rise, the Ukraine war, the COVID-19 pandemic, the absence of sufficient action on climate change, the emergence of AI, and, above all, “America’s rejection of the postwar order”—cannot be attributed to that event. Nonetheless, the 25th anniversary of 9/11 offers an important reminder about the danger terrorism poses, particularly at a time when advanced technologies, like drones and AI, make it easier than ever to “impose large-scale harm at minimal cost.”

KHARKIV—On September 11, 2001, when I taught my third class as a professor of East European history at Yale, I knew what the subject had to be: provocation. The Russian imperial secret services, and then the Soviet secret services, had perfected the art of convincing adversaries to do what they wanted them to do while making them think it was for their own reasons. When something terrible happens, as it had that day, suffering, though no doubt desired by those who caused it, is not the point. The point is to get you into a frame of mind that leads you to do something that hurts yourself even more.

History is full of acts of terror. The real question, I told the students that day, is what you do next. You cannot prevent every terrible thing from happening. But your freedom begins with your response.

Sadly, we Americans responded exactly as the terrorists would have wanted; indeed, we likely exceeded their expectations, making the world much worse for ourselves and everyone else.

The obvious response to 9/11 should have been to liberate ourselves from fossil fuels. Without our dependence on oil, we would never have been entangled in the Middle East in the first place. Had we funded clean-energy sources, we could have headed off global warming, prevented further Middle East wars, and prevented the rise of Russian President Vladimir Putin's hydrocarbon oligarchy.

It was not to be. President George W. Bush, the feckless scion of an oil family, had no interest in intensifying the search for safe energy. The terrorists attacked us, he claimed, because "they hate our freedoms." Yet our own government then acted to limit our freedom. A new Department of Homeland Security placed a grab-bag of agencies, including border management, under a single authority, treating them all as a matter of security. This set the stage for a domestic politics that divides people living in America into "legals" and "illegals," us and them, and builds concentration camps.

The notion of a "homeland," which echoes the Nazi fascination with *Heimat*, was even more dangerous. At the time, it was an exotic label for a government department, not really in keeping with American English or institutional traditions. But the word has since been normalized in an essentially fascist sense. Under President Donald Trump's administration, the main threats are deemed to be domestic, from those who do not truly belong. Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth treats the armed forces as a site of culture wars: men against women, whites against Blacks. Troops' future task is "homeland defense." The armed forces are to become the personal militia of a ruler, used to quash resistance to Trump.

Of course, one of the major causes of Trump's rise was the US invasion of Iraq in 2003—a war of choice that was the worst possible foreign-policy response to 9/11. The war left Americans traumatized and vulnerable to a candidate who would exploit the issue to gain power (only to launch more wars and make us vulnerable to more terrorism). It would also entrench a political economy dominated by military spending and debt. Instead of addressing wealth inequality, social immobility, and family insecurity, we poured blood (mainly of others) and treasure into the sand.

As a people, we followed a script that could have been written by the terrorists themselves. Worse, our elected leaders became that script's co-authors. The Bush administration invented the links between Iraq and the 9/11 terrorists, which eventually led Americans to distrust their government, enabling the rise of someone like Trump. And these invented pretexts set the stage for violating the most basic precept of international law: the prohibition of unprovoked wars of aggression.

With that, the post-Cold War era of democratic revival in 1989–91 drew to a close. In preparation for the invasion of Iraq, Americans claimed that just as liberation had been possible in Eastern Europe, so it was possible in the Middle East. The situation was, of course, very different; it is one thing to oust a dictatorship from within, and quite another to do so by foreign invasion. And while Europe's post-communist leaders had ideas about what would come next, the Americans in Iraq had none, imagining that simply destroying a bad regime would bring about a better one.

It would be wrong to say that the US-led invasion of Iraq caused Russia to invade Ukraine over a decade later, in 2014. But the American war certainly made life easier for Putin, who concluded that great powers could invade other countries with the help of extravagant lies.

One reason I warned in 2013 and early 2014 that Russia could invade Ukraine and seize Crimea was the surreal propaganda being deployed in Russian media. Like the US propaganda of 2002 and early 2003, it made no sense. The Americans claimed that fighting terrorism required ousting a regime that, while horrible, suppressed the Islamism that was behind 9/11. The Russians escalated the nonsense: Ukrainians were all gay, all Nazis, and all Jews. Their state did

not exist, but oppressed Russians. Despite being an authoritarian regime, Russia would bring democracy to Ukraine, though it already was one.

Not long after the invasion began, I participated in a public discussion in Prague. Emotions ran high. One person wearing a T-shirt emblazoned with a Russian fascist slogan took the microphone and asked why Russia should obey any rules when the Americans had not done so in Iraq in 2003. (I replied that rules were rules: the American invasion had been illegal, but two wrongs did not make a right.) The question exemplified an approach that arose from the internal logic of an oligarchic regime, but also one that the US had facilitated: there was no truth, no right and wrong, and no rules.

In late 2021 and early 2022, as Russia was preparing its second invasion of Ukraine, the shadow of Iraq still loomed. Two decades earlier, the US lied about the rationale for invading Iraq. Now, it was sharing the truth about Russian plans to invade Ukraine. In general, the US was not believed, although the facts were clearly there. It was easier to doubt the Americans in 2022 because of the lies they told in 2002. As a result, everyone was less prepared than they might have been when the big war (as the Ukrainians call it) came.

Having been provoked in 2001, America responded as the terrorists wanted, helping to create a world in which terrorism is so normal that we hardly know when to use the word. Putin and Trump use it to define their enemies, though they are themselves state terrorists. Trump himself normalized terrorism by seeking to stay in power by force in January 2021. And Putin's criminal war of aggression in Ukraine features widespread rape, abduction of children, and the mass execution of activists in occupied territories. But what is most obviously terroristic is the daily launch of drones and missiles targeting Ukrainian civilians.

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WASHINGTON, DC—September 11, 2001, was a Tuesday with sparkling clear blue skies. I was at home in Cambridge, Massachusetts, when my husband phoned to tell me that a plane had hit one of the Twin Towers. We presumed that a small aircraft had crashed accidentally, but soon realized that something far graver was happening.

We turned on CNN as the news spread among neighbors and the rush-hour crowds. My mother called, and we stayed on the phone (a landline still), gasping in horror as the first tower crumbled, then the second. One of my brothers worked in

New York; we had a family round-robin of calls to make sure he was okay. When the news came of an attack on the Pentagon, I realized that we were witnessing a targeted campaign against different centers of American life. I rushed to pick up our sons, aged four and two, from their daycare across the river.

That weekend, we would drive the 12 hours to Virginia for my father's 75th birthday. All planes were grounded, but we felt an overwhelming need to hold each other close. Driving down the New Jersey Turnpike in the dark, we could see the still-smoking ruins of the towers illuminated by searchlights—an eerie vision that our sons insist they remember. A quarter-century later, we continue to dwell on the details of that day, many of which were permanently etched into our memories by the acid of shock and disbelief. The attack had raised so many questions: Who could have done this, and above all, why?

The answers, and our response, would reshape the country and its place in the world. I came of age in the 1970s, when the horrors of physical torture were often in the news. Images of beatings, cigarette burns, electrodes attached to genitalia, mutilation, rapes, starvation, and other atrocities flowed in regularly from documentation of the Holocaust, Stalin's gulags, the dirty wars in Argentina and Chile, and the killing fields of Cambodia, alongside searing evidence of American war crimes in Vietnam.

In 1976, the year of our bicentennial, Jimmy Carter was elected president, promising a fresh start after the war and Watergate. He insisted that human rights would become a permanent part of US foreign policy. Some Americans might still practice torture, but only illegally. A commitment to the rule of law and basic decency, no matter what the "other side" might do, had defined us as Americans ever since George Washington insisted that British prisoners of war be treated "with humanity."

But by 2003–04, we had invaded Iraq and Afghanistan and detained alleged terrorists without trial at Guantánamo and "black sites" in other countries, in violation of the Geneva Conventions. I found myself participating in debates over whether torture had suddenly become necessary. I was incredulous at first, invoking the now-tattered refrain that, "This is not who we are." I pushed back against the endless hypothesizing about what one should do if a detained terrorist knew the location of a bomb that would destroy New York City within an hour. What I took to be a basic moral tenet of our national identity was often ridiculed as naive. Settled law turned out to be something squishier: rules that could be reinterpreted when the norms underpinning them eroded.

A quarter-century later, so much of what was once unthinkable—smearing the press as "the enemy of the people," weaponizing government agencies against political opponents, openly abusing public office for private gain, issuing physical threats against political opponents, riding roughshod over checks and balances—has become the new normal. Though much of it comes from the current president, there are also cases where both sides bear blame. It has been a slow slide, with each major party justifying violations of law and norms with reference to the other.

The 9/11 attacks also injected a highly concentrated dose of xenophobia into our politics. Of course, US history has had regular cycles of anti-immigrant sentiment, often accompanied by violence. But to many Americans in this century, the answer to the question that Fareed Zakaria posed in his celebrated October 2001 essay, "Why Do They Hate Us," is that "they" all seemed to be Muslims. And far too often, this label became synonymous with any brown-skinned person wearing headgear. President Donald Trump's first-term effort to ban all Muslims from entering the United States has evolved into a larger effort to portray anyone not resembling a 1950s-era white American as a threat.

Demagogues have long traded on stoking hostility toward a mythical "them." Today, though, fear of "the other" has become the defining feature of our domestic politics, with each side arguing that a victory for the enemy, depicted as ethno-nationalists or socialists, will destroy our democracy.

The aftermath of 9/11 deepened many Americans' sense that the rest of the world is simply ungrateful for the sacrifices we have made for world peace and prosperity over the decades. Like most countries, the US tends to notice what others

do to us, while overlooking what we have done to them.

Today, this sense of grievance is embodied in Trump's "America First" agenda. The breathtaking indecency and heedlessness with which the current administration pursues its policies have necessitated new paths for other countries, including long-standing US allies. Yet there is strong domestic support for the idea that the US must play a different role in the world, rejecting the status of an indispensable power and focusing first on domestic needs. This represents a paradigm shift. The foreign-policy consensus that guided us through the second half of the 20th century and the first decades of the 21st is gone for good.

As my family and I left Cambridge that Friday, September 14, we joined the flood of traffic down I-95, the superhighway running from Maine to Florida. At noon, somewhere in Connecticut, we pulled over, alongside our fellow motorists, to observe three minutes of silence as part of a National Day of Prayer and Remembrance. Nearby train stations, just an hour from New York City, still held the parked cars of commuters who would never return. We grieved—as Americans and as humans.

That day now feels very far away.

MADRID—A quarter-century ago, the world changed course in an instant. The new millennium had roughly coincided with the arrival of new presidents in the United States and Russia, then the world's two greatest military powers. But the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks on the US fundamentally altered both countries' trajectories, as well as that of a rising China, setting in motion developments that would produce the fractured geopolitical order we live in today.

Everyone who is old enough still remembers where they were on that fateful day. One of us was in Crimea, the other in Khartoum, and though we were stunned, we did not yet know that we were witnessing the beginning of a new era.

In America, the world's unquestioned hegemon, President George W. Bush had taken a tortuous path to the White House, following a Florida ballot recount that was ultimately settled by the Supreme Court. On the morning of September 11, television cameras caught the president reading to children in a Sarasota, Florida, elementary school, where an aide whispered in his ear that the country was under attack. His look of bewilderment anticipated the quality that would come to define US foreign policy.

The US soon subordinated every other objective to national security, abandoning the multilateral leadership that it had leveraged since 1945. Starting in late 2001, US Secretary of Defense Donald Rumsfeld pushed for America to leave the Anti-Ballistic Missile Treaty, so that it could start work on a missile shield to defend the "homeland." This led to the Ground-Based Midcourse Defense program, which deployed missiles in Alaska and California, and had plans to do so in Poland, catching a weakened Russia by surprise. In a move that should have surprised no one, Russian President Vladimir Putin responded by abandoning the Strategic Arms Reduction Treaty (START II).

Meanwhile, the US embarked on two major wars: in Afghanistan, where its intervention was legal and backed by much of the world; and in Iraq, where it launched an invasion without UN authorization. The Iraq war caused an internal rupture within the European Union, with longstanding members like France and Germany opposing it, while newer members like Poland and older ones like the United Kingdom backed the US effort.

Both wars would end in failure, and the Bush presidency would leave a poisoned gift: the offer—as grandiose as it was unworkable—of eventual NATO membership for Georgia and Ukraine, made at the alliance's 2008 Bucharest summit. With no timetable and no real guarantees, this promise raised alarms in the Kremlin without doing anything to protect either country.

Putin's ascent to the Russian presidency in 2000 had initially seemed to herald stability and economic development after the chaos of the 1990s. On September 11, he was reportedly among the first to call Bush to express his solidarity. But this

did not last long. In 2003, the Kremlin expropriated the big, previously privatized energy firm Yukos and jailed its owner, the politically ambitious oligarch Mikhail Khodorkovsky. In 2006, the former Russian spy Alexander Litvinenko was poisoned with polonium-210 in London. And in 2007, at the Munich Security Conference, Putin delivered an incendiary speech accusing the West of double standards, effectively breaking with the security architecture that Russia and the West had inherited from the Cold War.

The combination of American unilateralism and Russian marginalization pushed Putin toward a revisionist nationalism, an increasingly brazen authoritarianism, and, gradually, into the arms of a rising Chinese giant. In August 2008, as the global financial crisis erupted and amid the Beijing Olympics, Russia invaded Georgia, setting a precedent for the eventual invasion of Ukraine.

But perhaps the most fascinating and consequential development was unfolding in Asia. In December 2001, China joined the World Trade Organization with the full support of the US and the EU. The West assumed that commercial integration would drag China's economic model toward convergence with liberal capitalism. Instead, China pursued a different model: an effective, tightly directed state capitalism. Far from fading, the Chinese model became a powerful geopolitical lever that the Western model—many companies competing against one another, with no state strategy behind them—has proven unable to answer.

US President Barack Obama, already in his second term, was among the first to react. The US gave up on reforming the WTO and launched two comprehensive trade agreements that explicitly excluded China: the Transatlantic Trade and Investment Partnership, which would ultimately be abandoned, and the Trans-Pacific Partnership, which later entered into force as the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership without its US architect.

In 2012, Xi Jinping came to power in China and began concentrating authority and control over society to a degree unmatched since Mao Zedong. His political doctrine was written into the Party's constitution (joining those of Mao and Deng Xiaoping) in 2017, and a year later, the National People's Congress abolished presidential term limits.

Since then, Xi has increasingly centralized power and decoupled China's civil and academic life from the rest of the world. In 2017, China blocked WhatsApp and Skype, making it harder for Chinese civil-society and business leaders to communicate with their Western counterparts. And in the last five years, hundreds of senior officials and military officers have been investigated, removed, or purged. Following the unexplained disappearances of the foreign and defense ministers in 2023, almost the entire Central Military Commission was purged this year.

The world could have taken a different course after September 11, 2001. Instead, major powers have remained beholden to an overly narrow understanding of security and power. The US has turned inward and embraced the principle of might makes right; Russia, marginalized and weakened, has become a revisionist belligerent; and China has turned its economic model into an instrument of power that the West does not know how to counter.

For Europe, these developments have made one thing all too clear: We can no longer rely on American protection. Europe must build a credible military force of its own to counter Russia, and it must devise instruments to shield its economy from Chinese economic dirigisme. Whether Europe will finally take this path remains to be seen.

NEW YORK—This week marks the 25th anniversary of the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks on the United States. For many Americans, 9/11 is a distant memory, or not a memory at all—approximately 40% of the US population was either born after the attacks or is too young to remember them.

On that day, 19 terrorists took control of four civilian aircraft, flew two into the towers of New York's World Trade Center, struck the Pentagon with a third, and crashed the fourth in a Pennsylvania field after passengers physically prevented the terrorists from reaching their target, often thought to be the White House or another government building in Washington.

All 19 hijackers were from the Middle East, 15 from Saudi Arabia. All were trained in Afghanistan, and four at US flight schools, as part of an operation planned, organized, and carried out by al-Qaeda (“the base”), the terrorist group founded by Osama bin Laden. By the day’s end, close to 3,000 men, women, and children had been killed, and more than 6,000 injured. Most were American, though citizens of more than a hundred countries lost their lives as well.

To invoke President Franklin D. Roosevelt’s description of the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor in December 1941, September 11, too, was “a date which will live in infamy.” But with the fading of personal recollections, it seems right and necessary to ask the question: Did 9/11 mark a turning point? Or was it a day that, as tragic as it was, did not alter the course of history?

The truth is closer to the latter. Fortunately, 9/11 did not usher in an age defined by terrorism. A wave of attacks on a similar scale did not follow, in no small part because the US and other governments adopted measures that made it more difficult for would-be terrorists to emerge and succeed.

Another reason 9/11 did not alter history is that terrorists tend to be better at destroying than building, at killing rather than creating. As a result, they leave no lasting legacy.

By no means is this meant to imply that 9/11 did not matter. It led directly to military intervention in Afghanistan, where US-led forces, in coordination with Afghan tribesmen, ousted the ruling Taliban, which had provided sanctuary to bin Laden and the terrorists who carried out the attacks.

Call it what it was: regime change. But what followed, something that was closer to nation-building, provided an early lesson: removing a regime from power is one thing; replacing it with a better system that endures and governs effectively is quite another—and far more difficult. Twenty-five years later, after more than 800,000 US soldiers had been deployed, more than \$2 trillion spent, and over 2,400 Americans killed in combat (along with another 1,100 soldiers from NATO countries and others), Afghanistan is again ruled by the Taliban.

In March 2003, just a year and a half after 9/11, the US initiated a war of choice against Iraq. It is possible, but unlikely, that this war would have happened absent 9/11. In the wake of the attacks, President George W. Bush and many of his closest advisers became determined to demonstrate that the US was much more than a victim. (I served in the Bush administration during this time but opposed the war in Iraq and resigned soon after.)

Some in the Bush administration believed Saddam Hussein, Iraq’s strongman leader, was developing or even possessed a nuclear weapon and feared that terrorists would get ahold of one. Others were taken with the idea of spreading democracy to Iraq and the region, an outcome that would have made the region less likely to produce terrorists and support terrorism. Almost all of this turned out to be wrong.

But the costly war (more than 4,000 US soldiers lost their lives, and trillions more dollars were spent) turned many Americans against overseas involvement and eventually positioned Iran, which had nothing to do with 9/11 even if it was a strategic beneficiary of the war, as a major power in the Middle East.

Iran played a larger role in terrorism in the October 7, 2023, attacks by Hamas on Israel, resulting in the deaths of more than 800 civilians. But again, as awful as that was, little of what has happened since, be it in Gaza, Lebanon, or Iran, was preordained or can be attributed to terrorism. Rather, subsequent developments largely reflect policy decisions taken in the first instance by Israel and the US.

Looking back at the past quarter-century, it becomes apparent that 9/11 was not a transformative event. Far more important were China’s rise, Russia’s aggression against Ukraine, the COVID-19 pandemic, the collective failure to take meaningful action against climate change, the emergence of AI, and, perhaps more than anything else, America’s rejection of the postwar order that it had a large hand in building.

These truths do not, however, diminish the lesson that should be drawn. Although 9/11 did not usher in an age of terrorism, we are not safe from it. On the contrary, we have entered an era in which AI, along with accurate, inexpensive, and destructive drones and advances in bioengineering, have given terrorists more opportunity than ever to impose large-scale harm at minimal cost. The goal must be to ensure that they do not succeed, and that terrorism remains at most a limited problem.

41. Trump Is Stoking Territorial Revisionism

Author: Shlomo Ben-Ami **Published:** Sep 10, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

TEL AVIV—US President Donald Trump has once again shared a map on which the American flag covers not only the United States, but also many other countries, including Canada, Cuba, Greenland, and Mexico. The message is clear: in today's world, where might makes right and geopolitical power runs roughshod over shared rules, territorial revisionism is back on the table.

Once the guardian of territorial integrity, the US has become an anti-status-quo power, actively destroying a pillar of the post-war global order: belief in the inviolability of international borders. Trump is particularly fixated on Greenland, an autonomous territory of NATO member Denmark, insisting (without evidence) that if the US does not take it over, China or Russia will. He has gone so far as to raise the specter of a military invasion.

Trump has also mused about annexing Canada. Saying that the border is nothing more than an “artificially drawn line” is not a throwaway comment, but a statement of his territorial aspirations. From directing the US Board on Geographic Names to refer to the Gulf of Mexico as the “Gulf of America” to changing Lake Ontario to “Lake America,” he has repeatedly indicated his expansionist ambitions.

To be sure, Trump's maneuvers have so far not translated into new US territories, and, when it comes to a country like Canada, they will do nothing to erode sovereignty or territorial integrity. But they have normalized the language of territorial revisionism, while advancing Trump's efforts to bend geopolitics to his will. His threats to “take back” the Panama Canal—by force, if necessary—impelled Panama to agree to limit China's position in the area and authorize an increased US military presence.

Trump's territorial threats have also facilitated an outrageous resource grab. After deploying troops to Venezuela and capturing its president, Nicolás Maduro, Trump repeatedly indicated that the US would “run” the country and floated the idea of it becoming the 51st US state. The leader the US left in charge—Maduro's vice president, Delcy Rodríguez—has now agreed to a deal that gives the US control over more than 65 billion barrels of Venezuela's oil reserves.

Other countries are taking note. Argentina's right-wing president, Javier Milei, a Trump ally, recently revived the country's dormant dispute with the United Kingdom over the Falkland Islands, strengthening Argentina's naval presence in the area. And Ceuta, a Spanish exclave on the coast of Morocco, faced a border crisis under Trump's watch.

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While Ceuta and nearby Melilla have been Spanish sovereign possessions for centuries, Morocco claims both. Nonetheless, Morocco had largely accepted the status quo, partly because the US enforced it. In 2002, when Morocco placed a small contingent on the tiny uninhabited island of Perejil, a few miles from Ceuta, Spain launched a military operation to remove it, before US mediation prevented the conflict from escalating.

But Morocco understands that Trump does not share his predecessors' commitment to the territorial status quo. During his first term, he officially recognized Moroccan sovereignty over another disputed territory: the Western Sahara, a former Spanish colony that Morocco annexed in 1975, only to become embroiled in a battle for control with the indigenous Sahrawi people.

Recognition of Moroccan sovereignty was not wrong: the United Nations' effort to secure Western Sahara's independence is simply not feasible. But Trump's unilateral approach sent the wrong signal to a country eager to stake its territorial claims elsewhere. Trump's behavior after returning to the White House in 2025 reinforced that signal.

Last April, the US House Appropriations Committee released a report that described Ceuta and Melilla as Spanish-administered territories "located in Moroccan territory" and called on Secretary of State Marco Rubio to bring the parties into negotiations over their "future status." Morocco was further emboldened by America's estrangement from Spain, driven by Socialist Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez's willingness to challenge Trump (not least on the Iran war).

Beyond reiterating claims to Ceuta and Melilla, Moroccan authorities did nothing last month to stop tens of thousands of young Moroccans from crossing into Ceuta (they returned to Morocco shortly after). While the details of how that surge came about are unclear, connivance by Moroccan agents is a distinct possibility. In any case, Trump rejoiced at Spain's failure to protect its borders, and there is reason to think that his administration might consider reframing the Ceuta issue as an open territorial dispute.

The impact of Trump's embrace of territorial revisionism extends further. If the US can claim territory on the basis of vague "national-security" justifications, China can do likewise in Taiwan, in the Japan-administered Senkaku Islands, and across the South China Sea. And Russia can do it in Ukraine. In fact, the Trump administration's "peace plan" for Ukraine would have the country hand over territory that Russia does not even control.

Perhaps no country is taking greater advantage of Trump's disregard for territorial integrity than Israel. In his first term, Trump unilaterally recognized Israel's sovereignty over the Syrian Golan Heights. In his second, he has treated Israel's continued encroachment on Syrian lands, not to mention Turkey's expansion into northern Syria, as the new normal. The same goes for Israel's presence in Southern Lebanon, which was affirmed in a Rubio-mediated memorandum of understanding.

Trump's 20-point peace plan for Gaza notwithstanding, there are no signs that the US administration will challenge Israel's new "forward defense" security doctrine, which shifts military operations into so-called buffer zones beyond its borders. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu surely cannot believe his luck.

42. The False Politics of Western Declinism

Author: Carl Johan Dalgaard

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COPENHAGEN/LONDON—As President Donald Trump plunges the United States into another reckless trade war—this time with neighboring Canada, one of its largest trading partners, and a NATO ally—the irony is hard to miss. Despite being the main architect and beneficiary of the multilateral trading system since 1945, the US under Trump has recast itself—at least rhetorically—as the victim of an allegedly unfair economic order.

Trump’s narrative of victimization has long animated the MAGA movement. His triumph, he vowed in his first inaugural address in 2017, would end “this American carnage,” and his return to the White House, he declared eight years later, marked the end of American “decline.”

In recent years, that rhetoric has spread to Europe’s Trumpian far right. Former Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orbán, whose government adopted “Make Europe Great Again” as the official motto for Hungary’s presidency of the Council of the European Union in 2024, praised the Trump administration’s latest National Security Strategy for recognizing Europe’s “civilizational-scale decline.” Elon Musk has echoed the same message, both in newspaper commentaries and in a virtual appearance at a campaign rally for Germany’s Alternative für Deutschland.

The idea of Western decline is not limited to far-right populists. Presenting his 2024 report on European competitiveness, former Italian Prime Minister Mario Draghi called for an EU turnaround in order to avoid the “slow agony” of decline. The newly established Rhine Group, led by Draghi and tech billionaire Patrick Collison, frames the stakes in similarly existential terms, albeit without MAGA’s nativist hysteria.

Tellingly, these warnings almost never specify what, exactly, is declining. The term is being used to describe two different phenomena. One is absolute—and easily disproved. Are Americans and Europeans getting poorer in terms of GDP per capita, average income, or life expectancy? No. They are richer than ever. The other is relative: Is the West’s share of global output shrinking? Yes, but this has been the case for decades. The populist sleight of hand depends on collapsing the distinction between them.

The West’s declining share of global output can be largely attributed to two trends. The first is convergence: poorer countries have been catching up. Research by Nobel laureate economist Michael Kremer, Jack Willis, and Yang You finds that while real per-capita GDP in poor and rich countries diverged at an annual rate of 0.5% between 1985 and 1995, the trend subsequently reversed; GDP growth between 2005 and 2015 converged at an annual rate of 0.7%. Second, Western countries are further along in their demographic transitions. A country with a growing workforce can increase its share of global GDP even if no one gets a dollar richer.

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Neither trend implies that the West has done something wrong, and neither trend prevents living standards in Western societies from rising. If anything, the opposite is true.

There is, however, one domain in which the West has actually declined: geopolitics. Relative GDP is the currency of international power, and power is much closer to being zero-sum than prosperity is. Given that much of the world’s economic activity has been concentrated in a handful of Western economies for most of the past two centuries, some loss of relative power was inevitable once the rest of the world began to catch up.

Populists seeking to exploit this shift are helped by genuine domestic grievances. While aggregate living standards across the West have risen, the gains have been unevenly distributed. US median wages, for example, barely moved between the 1970s and the mid-2000s, even as top incomes soared. More recently, post-pandemic increases in wealth and spending have been heavily concentrated among wealthy households.

These dynamics, sometimes described as “K-shaped growth,” point to a real decline in living standards for large segments of the population in the US and other Western countries. That’s not the same as a decline of the West as a whole, though it has turned other countries into a convenient culprit for populists seeking to leverage nationalist resentment by exploiting legitimate complaints over the distribution of income and wealth.

How political leaders define “decline” determines the agenda they pursue. If they recognize that relative decline can coexist with rising welfare everywhere, they can accept convergence and seek to establish international rules better suited to a multipolar world economy. But that path is slow. It depends on the goodwill of countries the West has spent two centuries dominating, and trust is in short supply these days.

The alternative is to treat GDP as a zero-sum contest. That path, while currently politically expedient, is likely to make almost everyone poorer.

Trump’s tariffs illustrate the second approach. As a tool for maximizing American incomes, they are absurd. But as a tool for maximizing America’s income relative to Europe’s, they make considerably more sense. At least that’s a coherent objective, though not the one Europe thinks it is negotiating over, which helps explain why Europeans have found trade talks with the Trump administration so confounding. If Europe responds to Trump’s bullying tactics in kind, the result will be a standoff that leaves both parties worse off.

Conflating absolute and relative decline is more than just sloppy thinking. Declinist rhetoric nurtures political consent for a zero-sum approach to trade and economic growth. But rejecting the harder but better collaborative path could mean having it forced upon us later, after zero-sum logic has run its course, triggered a major crisis, and forced Western governments back to the negotiating table.

From the Concert of Europe to the Bretton Woods system, new international orders have historically emerged in the wake of catastrophic wars. Waiting for another post-crisis window would be an enormously expensive and painful way to relearn the lesson that playing zero-sum games in a positive-sum world can leave everyone with less.

43. After the AI Bubble Bursts

Author: Barry Eichengreen **Published:** Sep 10, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

HANALEI, HAWAII—For months, if not years, AI has dominated speculation about the future, which has fueled speculation in the present. AI-related ventures are largely responsible for the rapid increase of the S&P 500 stock index. Investment in data centers is a major contributor to the rise in US interest rates, as borrowing for construction competes for credit with a deficit-prone federal government.

With so much investment riding on a fast-developing new technology, what happens if the cash flow and profits of the hyperscalers building data centers, and of AI firms renting that infrastructure (two categories that overlap), turn out to disappoint? What would this disappointment mean for financial markets? Would a crisis be in the offing?

This scenario could materialize for any number of reasons. The productivity benefits of AI could be overhyped, in which case firms contemplating the adoption of frontier models will curtail their demand for tokens, the basic units of data processed by such models. Or the availability of open-weight models, which enable users to tailor a model's parameters to their needs, may allow those users to build small language models that run on their own infrastructure or even on laptops like the one I am using to write this commentary. Either way, the income accruing to investors in data centers will fall short of expectations.

The most immediate and visible impact would be a sharp drop in the lofty stock prices of the “Magnificent 7,” the seven ultra-large-cap tech and tech-adjacent firms that have driven the S&P 500. But stock-market corrections are no guarantee of crises or even of recessions. If the price of Meta shares falls, Mark Zuckerberg will buy fewer castles in Ireland. There would be a slowdown in consumption and investment spending. There would be pain for investment funds, like Situational Awareness, specializing in AI-related ventures. But a financial crisis would follow only if banks, insurance companies, and other mainstream institutional investors were implicated. And there is little evidence that they are heavily exposed to AI equity risk.

Developments in debt markets are more worrisome. With the cost of data-center construction exceeding their sponsors' free cash flow, and with income from potential tenants still a distant prospect, much of this investment is being financed by borrowing from private credit funds (nonbank firms making privately negotiated loans). If demand for data-center services is lower than expected, these loans will fail to perform (a polite way of saying that borrowers will default).

The question then becomes who is invested in private credit funds. The popular image is of the same family offices and high-net-worth individuals who invest in venture capital and can afford occasional losses. But the reality is that the vast majority of private credit is provided by institutional investors: pension funds, insurance companies and, dare I say, university endowments.

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Moreover, private credit funds have been taking steps to tap this institutional money by acquiring insurance companies, whose asset portfolios they can load up with loans. This invites the specter of an insurance industry crisis, which could play out in several ways. Insurance companies' private credit parents could recapitalize them, assuming they have the funds. Alternatively, state guarantee funds, to which healthy insurance companies contribute, could fund the recapitalization, although there will be no healthy companies if the entire industry comes tumbling down. Lastly, the federal government could step in with a bailout, as it did for American International Group in 2008.

In addition to borrowing from pension funds and insurance companies, private credit firms borrow from commercial banks, using their portfolio of loans as collateral, thereby leveraging their commitments and juicing their returns. Even if banks don't lend to or invest in AI firms and data centers directly, they still may be on the hook. We can only hope that their regulators are watching.

Finally, private credit firms originally built on a buy-and-hold model increasingly securitize their loans. They package those loans through special purpose vehicles that issue bonds backed by the associated cash flows, where the bonds are divided into risk tiers or tranches claiming first, second, and third dibs on debt-service payments. The so-called "mezzanine tranche" of medium-risk bonds is then sold on to other asset managers. To assess the immediacy of crisis risk, we would need to know more about the riskiness of this mezzanine tranche and who holds it. We don't. If you are reminded of the roles of securitization, special purpose vehicles, tranching, and opacity in the subprime-mortgage crisis of 2007-08, you are not alone.

Just as debt markets fueled the global financial near-meltdown that followed from that crisis, their exposure to AI will drive developments now. The problem is that we possess only very limited public information about those markets, and regulators are not making that information any easier to obtain.

44. What 9/11 Did to Us

Author: Anne-Marie Slaughter

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WASHINGTON, DC—September 11, 2001, was a Tuesday with sparkling clear blue skies. I was at home in Cambridge, Massachusetts, when my husband phoned to tell me that a plane had hit one of the Twin Towers. We presumed that a small aircraft had crashed accidentally, but soon realized that something far graver was happening.

We turned on CNN as the news spread among neighbors and the rush-hour crowds. My mother called, and we stayed on the phone (a landline still), gasping in horror as the first tower crumbled, then the second. One of my brothers worked in New York; we had a family round-robin of calls to make sure he was okay. When the news came of an attack on the Pentagon, I realized that we were witnessing a targeted campaign against different centers of American life. I rushed to pick up our sons, aged four and two, from their daycare across the river.

That weekend, we would drive the 12 hours to Virginia for my father's 75th birthday. All planes were grounded, but we felt an overwhelming need to hold each other close. Driving down the New Jersey Turnpike in the dark, we could see the still-smoking ruins of the towers illuminated by searchlights—an eerie vision that our sons insist they remember. A quarter-century later, we continue to dwell on the details of that day, many of which were permanently etched into our memories by the acid of shock and disbelief. The attack had raised so many questions: Whocould have done this, and above all, why?

The answers, and our response, would reshape the country and its place in the world. I came of age in the 1970s, when the horrors of physical torture were often in the news. Images of beatings, cigarette burns, electrodes attached to genitalia, mutilation, rapes, starvation, and other atrocities flowed in regularly from documentation of the Holocaust, Stalin's gulags, the dirty wars in Argentina and Chile, and the killing fields of Cambodia, alongside searing evidence of American war crimes in Vietnam.

In 1976, the year of our bicentennial, Jimmy Carter was elected president, promising a fresh start after the war and Watergate. He insisted that human rights would become a permanent part of US foreign policy. Some Americans might still practice torture, but only illegally. A commitment to the rule of law and basic decency, no matter what the "other side" might do, had defined us as Americans ever since George Washington insisted that British prisoners of war be treated "with humanity."

But by 2003–04, we had invaded Iraq and Afghanistan and detained alleged terrorists without trial at Guantánamo and "black sites" in other countries, in violation of the Geneva Conventions. I found myself participating in debates over whether torture had suddenly become necessary. I was incredulous at first, invoking the now-tattered refrain that, "This is not who we are." I pushed back against the endless hypothesizing about what one should do if a detained terrorist knew the location of a bomb that would destroy New York City within an hour. What I took to be a basic moral tenet of our national identity was often ridiculed as naive. Settled law turned out to be something squishier: rules that could be reinterpreted when the norms underpinning them eroded.

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A quarter-century later, so much of what was once unthinkable—smearing the press as "the enemy of the people," weaponizing government agencies against political opponents, openly abusing public office for private gain, issuing physical threats against political opponents, riding roughshod over checks and balances—has become the new normal.

Though much of it comes from the current president, there are also cases where both sides bear blame. It has been a slow slide, with each major party justifying violations of law and norms with reference to the other.

The 9/11 attacks also injected a highly concentrated dose of xenophobia into our politics. Of course, US history has had regular cycles of anti-immigrant sentiment, often accompanied by violence. But to many Americans in this century, the answer to the question that Fareed Zakaria posed in his celebrated October 2001 essay, “Why Do They Hate Us,” is that “they” all seemed to be Muslims. And far too often, this label became synonymous with any brown-skinned person wearing headgear. President Donald Trump’s first-term effort to ban all Muslims from entering the United States has evolved into a larger effort to portray anyone not resembling a 1950s-era white American as a threat.

Demagogues have long traded on stoking hostility toward a mythical “them.” Today, though, fear of “the other” has become the defining feature of our domestic politics, with each side arguing that a victory for the enemy, depicted as ethno-nationalists or socialists, will destroy our democracy.

The aftermath of 9/11 deepened many Americans’ sense that the rest of the world is simply ungrateful for the sacrifices we have made for world peace and prosperity over the decades. Like most countries, the US tends to notice what others do to us, while overlooking what we have done to them.

Today, this sense of grievance is embodied in Trump’s “America First” agenda. The breathtaking indecency and heedlessness with which the current administration pursues its policies have necessitated new paths for other countries, including long-standing US allies. Yet there is strong domestic support for the idea that the US must play a different role in the world, rejecting the status of an indispensable power and focusing first on domestic needs. This represents a paradigm shift. The foreign-policy consensus that guided us through the second half of the 20th century and the first decades of the 21st is gone for good.

As my family and I left Cambridge that Friday, September 14, we joined the flood of traffic down I-95, the superhighway running from Maine to Florida. At noon, somewhere in Connecticut, we pulled over, alongside our fellow motorists, to observe three minutes of silence as part of a National Day of Prayer and Remembrance. Nearby train stations, just an hour from New York City, still held the parked cars of commuters who would never return. We grieved—as Americans and as humans.

That day now feels very far away.

45. China's External Surplus Makes a “Mandarin Accord” Inevitable

Author: Jim O'Neill

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LONDON—In keeping with the adage that history never repeats itself but often rhymes, I suspect that we could soon see developments in international macroeconomic policy for which there are clear precedents. As with the Plaza Accord in 1985, when the United States and four of its major trading partners agreed to coordinate policies to weaken the US dollar, a new agreement to address today's global imbalances has become increasingly necessary.

The reason can be found in China's trade data for August, which shows a whopping 25% year-on-year rise in exports, up from the 23.9% increase recorded in July. Despite similarly strong import growth (from a smaller base), China has delivered another huge monthly trade surplus, this time totaling \$119.1 billion. So much for the idea that globalization has peaked.

Like other major trading powers, China's trade has been dominated by rapid growth in AI-related products. But many of its other exports have also continued to grow. There has even been a 34.3% year-on-year increase in exports to the US, though this partly reflects the low base from last year's trade war. And even before that, all the rhetoric and punditry about deglobalization missed what was really going on. China has been boosting its exports to many other parts of the world, and many of these importers are in turn exporting more to the US. That is why there has been so little change in global trade imbalances.

China's still-weakening domestic demand means that its imports are not growing on the same scale as its exports (in monetary terms). As a result, its trade and current-account surpluses are rising sharply—quite a feat for a \$20 trillion economy. But while many see China's export performance as a sign of its industrial prowess, it should be ringing alarm bells in Beijing. If Chinese policymakers are happy about the situation, that is only because stronger exports could allow them to hit their annual GDP target. But they should be careful what they wish for, because such large imbalances cannot be sustained indefinitely.

The recent figures also pour cold water on the idea that tariffs can influence trade balances. A country's external trade and current-account balances mirror its capital account, and both are quantitative reflections of the country's balance of savings relative to investment. If you have a shortage of savings, as the US does, you will need more capital from overseas, and this will show up as a current-account deficit. But if you have high domestic savings and weakening consumer confidence, as China does, the result will be even stronger exports.

Moreover, recent monthly data suggest that domestic economic activity in China is weakening—a trend that shows up more clearly in the data on retail sales and second-quarter GDP. Of course, this weakening owes something to China's soft property market, where policymakers allowed a massive bubble to form before bursting it in 2021. They arguably deserve some credit for preventing a wholesale financial collapse of the kind we saw in the US in 2008, and in Japan in the late 1980s.

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The upshot, however, is that many previously aspirational Chinese families no longer have as much confidence in the future. They have lost the optimism that drives social mobility, and this change comes on top of the already high savings rate among rural-born Chinese who cannot count on a strong social safety net.

Meanwhile, China's annualized real (inflation-adjusted) GDP growth rate slowed to 4.3% in the second quarter (down from 5% in January–March). Unless there is a trend reversal, the government's chances of hitting its 4.5–5% target for 2026 look slim. Unless domestic demand picks up, improving the GDP figure will require even stronger growth in exports.

After accounting for the August trade figures, China's year-to-date cumulative surplus is now around \$805 billion, and there is a good chance that it will exceed last year's massive \$1.2 trillion surplus (around 6% of GDP). Such a massive imbalance is in no one's long-term interest, including China's. Even countries that have enjoyed the benefits of dramatically increased trade with China—from Germany and Mexico to many others—now find themselves on a one-way street. As China's exports have grown, their own exports to China have slowed in line with the softening in Chinese domestic demand.

Finally, all of this is happening at a time when the Chinese renminbi appears to be around 20% undervalued (if not more) on a trade-weighted basis. A stronger currency would make Chinese consumers feel richer, perhaps leading them to spend, and therefore import, more. And if accompanied by a serious fiscal stimulus, a properly valued renminbi could even put China back on the path toward doubling its GDP per capita by 2035 (from 2020 levels).

As the host of the G20 in 2027, could the United Kingdom help orchestrate a new monetary accord? If so, it will have provided a sorely needed corrective to an increasingly imbalanced global economy.

46. Global Development's Missing Ingredient

Author: Gordon Whitman **Published:** Sep 11, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

WASHINGTON, DC—In his first encyclical, *Magnifica Humanitas*, Pope Leo XIV presents two possible futures for humanity: top-down, technocratic rule, symbolized by the Tower of Babel, and bottom-up reconstruction, much like Nehemiah organized exiles to rebuild Jerusalem in the face of fierce opposition. In a world increasingly dominated by billionaires, the second vision of collective action seems as commendable as it is futile.

But it has been done before. The challenge today is that most ordinary people lack avenues through which to achieve the Nehemiah vision. According to the V-Dem Institute, 74% of the global population now live in autocracies, while those fortunate to reside in democracies are increasingly critical of how their governments work. People overwhelmingly value democracy, but large majorities don't believe that their elected officials care about their views. Rapid technological and cultural change, along with rising economic insecurity, have eroded support for liberal institutions and fomented anti-elite sentiment across the political spectrum.

At the heart of this discontent is a deeper problem: a crisis of agency. People lack the ability to influence the decisions that shape their lives. As Leo writes in his encyclical, "most people are watching and waiting, observing from afar and merely hoping for the best."

That is certainly the case in global development, where projects are often designed by aid agencies and managed by foreign contractors and NGOs. In 2023, the People's Ecumenical Organization for the Development of Haiti, Communities of Faith Organizing for Action in El Salvador, and Faith in Action International asked the US Agency for International Development to pause its non-emergency work for six weeks and send its staff to listen to people about the kind of aid they wanted. The Haitian organization was in the midst of a fruitless effort to change USAID's agricultural programming in their communities. While then-USAID Administrator Samantha Power had embraced the mission of reforming the agency, she and her staff could not fathom shifting decision-making to beneficiaries. The best they could muster was a presentation on USAID's work in the country, delivered at the organization's office in Terrier-Rouge. Haitians were left to hope for the best.

Democratic governments and international institutions must create meaningful channels for the people affected by their decisions to influence the outcome. To be sure, many have undertaken well-meaning reforms. There have been participatory budgeting schemes that give people a say in how some government money is spent, civil-society complaint mechanisms at international financial institutions, and initiatives to shift development funding from global to local organizations.

But, as the example of USAID in Haiti shows, even the best-intentioned reforms often fail to deliver. Large bureaucratic institutions are unlikely to hold themselves fully accountable without outside pressure. This is the demand side of the democracy deficit: millions of people need organizations through which they can collectively negotiate their interests.

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Faith-based institutions committed to human dignity and pluralism can play an essential role here, not only in inspiring people to act, but also in building the infrastructure required for organizing at scale.

One model is the Catholic Campaign for Human Development. Inspired by Pope Paul VI's 1967 encyclical, *Populorum Progressio*, US Catholic bishops established the CCHD two years later in Chicago with the goal of supporting

organizations that address poverty's root causes. The CCHD raises funds through an annual collection and disperses them based on the Catholic principle of subsidiarity, namely that decisions should be made closest to the people they affect. To be eligible for a grant, an organization must not only seek to change the policies and systems that keep people in poverty, but also maintain a governing board in which at least half of the members are involuntarily low-income.

For more than 50 years, the CCHD has been instrumental in fostering an anti-poverty ecosystem that has won concrete victories: higher wages, paid family leave, more affordable housing units, and health coverage for the uninsured. It has also nurtured generations of grassroots leaders and organizations. Today, many of the most prominent local and state groups, both secular and faith-based, anchoring the defense of American democracy got their start with multiyear general support grants from the CCHD.

The world needs an equivalent mechanism—say, an International Campaign for Integral Human Development—that provides long-term funding to help people launch and expand grassroots organizations powerful enough to influence policy at the national or global level. It could draw on Catholic experience while including other faiths, as well as secular funders who have been vocal about the need to shift decision-making to local communities.

To be sure, any global fund runs the risk of becoming overly bureaucratic and taking a top-down approach. The CCHD model guards against this by combining clear criteria with a decentralized structure. Making decisions locally and regionally, as the CCHD does, would help ease some of the challenges of operating a joint fund meant to operate across significantly different contexts. And it would be well worth the effort: dedicating even 1% of private development financing to grassroots organizing would be transformative.

In *Magnifica Humanitas*, Leo describes listening and dialogue as “the common ground upon which to cultivate justice and fraternity.” Dialogue is not the absence of conflict, but without conflict there is no change. And without change, many of the world's most vulnerable people will remain powerless, watching and waiting for their situation to improve. If even a small share of development funding is devoted to channeling their priorities, they can get to work building a humane path forward for their communities and the world—what Leo calls “the ‘construction site’ of our time.”

47. Why Do So Few Women Work in India?

Author: Shishir Gupta **Published:** Sep 11, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW DELHI—India’s female labor force participation rate (LFPR) stands at 35%, which is well below that of peers like Bangladesh (42%) and the Philippines (50%). Though it has risen substantially from 21% in 2017–18, a closer examination reveals that over 70% of the increase came from the agriculture and subsistence sectors, with significant levels of disguised employment.

Closing the female LFPR gap with the developed world is critical not only for advancing gender equality, but also for unlocking a substantial growth dividend. India could add between \$700 billion and \$1.4 trillion to its GDP.

But why do fewer women work in India to begin with? Much of the literature on this question has focused on supply-side constraints, particularly societal norms, including the unequal distribution of unpaid care work, restrictions on mobility and education, weak legal protections, and practices such as child marriage.

The available evidence corroborates this. According to a UN Women technical brief, Indian women spent about 22% of their day on unpaid care work, compared to 6.4% of the day for men. Consequently, much of the policy response has focused on increasing women’s share of existing jobs. But this approach risks missing the mark, because even as several major constraints have eased in recent decades, women’s share of the nonfarm labor force has remained largely unchanged.

Education is also a commonly cited factor in Indian women’s low LFPR. But female enrollment rates now match or exceed male enrollment at every level. Similarly, child marriages have fallen by nearly half since 2005–06, and there has been a marked increase in women’s political participation. Female voter turnout was around nine percentage points lower than male turnout in 1996, but by 2024, it had marginally surpassed male turnout. If norms alone were the binding constraint, there would have been a clearer shift by women into productive employment. That has not happened. The ratio of female to male nonfarm employment has increased by a meager 5% in the last two decades.

This disconnect suggests that the problem of low female LFPR also owes something to the lack of overall labor demand in the Indian economy. One way to illustrate this is through labor intensity: the amount of labor employed relative to the output produced. India is considerably less labor-intensive than several of its peer economies. For example, Bangladesh, the Philippines, and Vietnam each employ roughly 40–50 workers to produce \$1 million of GDP, compared to only 35 workers in India. If India had Bangladesh’s labor intensity, its female LFPR (holding other variables constant) would be close to 50%.

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India’s weak labor demand also shows up in the wage and unemployment data. Unemployment among young graduates aged 15–25 is around 40%, which suggests that the demand for labor is not high enough to offer young graduates sufficient wages to induce them to work.

The experience of Bangladesh’s ready-made garment (RMG) industry illustrates how labor demand can affect female LFPR. In 1983, the industry accounted for only 4% of Bangladesh’s total exports; by 2021, the share had increased to 81%, amounting to \$41 billion. This labor-intensive export sector’s rapid expansion created millions of employment opportunities for women, who now account for over 60% of its employees. Without the expansion of the RMG industry, Bangladesh’s female LFPR would be close to 36%, similar to India’s.

So, what is keeping India's labor demand so low? One important factor is the cost and complexity associated with employing labor. Around 15% of Indian firms identify labor regulations as a major constraint, compared with 3.4% in Bangladesh and 6.4% in the Philippines. It is well known that cumbersome compliance requirements and restrictions on hiring and firing can increase the relative cost of employing workers, encouraging firms to substitute capital for labor.

India has also underperformed in precisely those sectors that have historically absorbed large numbers of lower-skilled workers. The value-added share of low-skilled, labor-intensive industries in India is around 16% of GDP, compared with approximately 20–26% in Vietnam, Indonesia, Bangladesh, and the Philippines.

India's female LFPR could rise through two mutually reinforcing channels: faster GDP growth and higher employment growth. Faster GDP growth would boost overall demand for both capital and labor, and a more labor-intensive growth model would ensure that a larger share of that increased demand translates into jobs, thus creating more opportunities for men and women alike.

Three major reforms would help. First, India needs more flexible labor regulations. Recent reforms are a promising step forward, but further simplification of the labor code would reduce compliance burdens and lower the perceived risk associated with hiring workers.

Second, India must deliberately promote labor-intensive industries by alleviating constraints to their growth. That means addressing policy distortions, like input tariffs on man-made fibers, that make Indian labor-intensive manufacturing less competitive. It also requires deeper access to global markets through more free-trade agreements, including the signing of the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership.

Finally, India should substantially increase public investment in health and education, as these are large labor-intensive sectors that traditionally rely more on female labor. Expanding the availability and quality of public services would create direct employment opportunities for women and improve the workforce's long-term productivity and employability.

These reforms would lead to higher labor demand, which would increase India's female LFPR. With more women in the workforce, social norms would evolve gradually, further boosting the female LFPR and creating a virtuous cycle. Improving the female LFPR is not only a social imperative but also an economic necessity if India is serious about becoming *viksit* (developed) by the centennial of independence in 2047.

48. YOUR CHOICES REGARDING COOKIES ON THIS SITE

Author: Sami Mahroum **Published:** 2026-09-12 **Link:** [View Original](#)

The war in Iran has underscored the dangers of relying on oil and gas imports. While it may revive demand for dirty fuels in the short term, over time it could also strengthen the case for clean-energy sources that reduce countries' exposure to regional conflicts and maritime chokepoints.

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50. The Program Redesign the IMF Needs

Author: Martín Guzmán **Published:** Sep 12, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW YORK—The International Monetary Fund is conducting a Review of Program Design and Conditionality, its first major evaluation since 2019, before the COVID-19 pandemic. With so many countries suffering from macroeconomic imbalances and debt distress that are severely weakening their development prospects, the IMF guidelines for program design, while always important, are more salient than ever.

The IMF review should address at least three critical features of IMF program design—with a view to reforming all of them.

The first is policy conditionality. IMF financing is supposed to play a stabilizing role, meaning that it should enable countercyclical macroeconomic policies in countries that do not have access to other sources of financing. It should never be used to meet payments on unsustainable debt.

The IMF's own rules establish that, in order to access Fund resources, a country's debt must be sustainable, or else the country must commit to efforts to restore debt sustainability through debt restructuring. The IMF's policy on lending into arrears allows the Fund to lend while a country is in arrears to other creditors, thereby facilitating the restructuring process.

What we should not see is IMF financing supporting programs that include contractionary fiscal policies—for example, cuts to investment in public infrastructure, education, and health—while the government continues repaying debts to the private sector or to other creditors that refuse to provide financing to roll over those debts. This has become a worrying pattern in many developing countries, as explained last year in the Vatican's Jubilee Report for Pope Francis. In some recent years, multilateral financing for developing countries seems to have supported an outflow of funds to the private sector, rather than an expansion of domestic investment.

IMF-financed programs should also prevent future destabilizing capital movements. When left unregulated, these flows tend to be procyclical in developing economies, in turn fueling exchange-rate volatility and uncertainty, thereby undermining investment. And IMF lending should never be used to finance capital flight. There is a clear role for capital-account regulations that discourage speculative carry-trade flows and prevent the misuse of IMF financing during the stabilization period.

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The second feature of program design concerns contingency plans. Programs are based on baseline assumptions, but reality is uncertain, and there can be significant deviations from those assumptions—all the more so in a global environment that has become highly unpredictable.

Program design should protect critical investments for medium-term growth—which is essential to ensure long-term stabilization and avoid the trap of successive IMF programs aimed merely at refinancing debt to the Fund. Investments in knowledge and infrastructure, in particular, have frequently borne a disproportionate share of the cuts when programs are adjusted after failing to meet their baseline projections.

There should be contingency plans for such circumstances. While a significant number of IMF programs have not been as “successful” as hoped, programs can fall short of their goals for many reasons, including a failure of implementation,

flaws in the model underlying the program, or a new adverse shock. The contingency plans need to reflect the source of the failure.

When it comes to contingency plans, the Fund should be particularly sensitive to policies and procedures that undermine democratic processes and accountability—including anything that smacks of a lack of transparency and full disclosure. For example, the Fund should not reach deals with a country—say, Bolivia, to cite a potentially relevant upcoming case—and announce only the policies under the baseline scenario, while signing a confidentiality side letter as part of the agreement with the government stipulating an increase in the value-added tax in the event of fiscal underperformance.

The third feature of program design that the Fund must address is ownership. This is a critical criterion for IMF exceptional-access lending—that is, lending above certain limits. IMF loans bind successive governments and even generations. Ownership should mean genuinely broad political and social support, not merely the incumbent government's assent, or even commitment, to implement the agreed-upon policies. After all, the government's agreement may be based on a calculus of its own survival, rather than the country's long-run well-being. We have seen cases where politics has seemed to influence lenders as well, even the IMF.

One possible criterion of ownership would be parliamentary approval of the agreement reached between a government and the IMF. In an era marked by democratic backsliding, transparency, public accountability, and ownership are especially important today.

Ultimately, the IMF's success should be judged by the impact of its financing programs on distressed debtors' stabilization and economic recovery, and on the well-being of the population, including those in poverty. The purpose of IMF programs must always be to improve countries' social and economic indicators, not to avert the adverse effects of a short-term default on other creditors—and even less to influence domestic electoral outcomes.

51. Progressive Economics Is Delivering

Author: Dario Durigan **Published:** Sep 14, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

BRASÍLIA/MADRID—Few zombie ideas return as persistently as the claim that right-wing governments are good for the economy, whereas progressive administrations mismanage it. Yet this belief reflects a conception of economics that ignores the sustainability of growth and conservatives' actual record.

Indeed, in country after country, the neoliberal experiment of the past four decades widened public deficits, deepened inequality, produced recurrent financial crises, and left economies more fragile. And time and again, left-wing governments had to repair the damage.

Yet segments of the left have surrendered the banners of growth, fiscal sustainability, and price stability to conservatives, even though the evidence shows that progressives have defended these objectives better. Such unforced errors have eroded the left's credibility with citizens who simply wanted to work, start a business, and improve their lives.

Our own two governments have taken the opposite approach. In Brazil, following the defeat of a right-wing government, President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva's administration returned to the path of fiscal responsibility and social justice that the previous government had abandoned.

After increasing transparency, expanding social policy, and rescinding tax breaks that disproportionately benefited large corporate groups, the results speak for themselves. Unemployment is at a record low, household incomes are rising, and millions of people are leaving poverty behind.

Similarly, in Spain, Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez's government has secured one of the highest growth rates among major advanced economies for three consecutive years, while also bringing the deficit to its lowest level in nearly two decades. Employment is at record levels, with Spain accounting for five out of every ten new jobs created in the eurozone, and structural reforms are improving job quality, productivity, and innovation.

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The lesson is the same in both cases. With the right mix of bold and ambitious policies, fiscal responsibility, growth, and social-development programs do not contradict one another; they are mutually reinforcing. This is the alternative path that the world needs as policymakers increasingly put narrow market and financial interests ahead of the collective good.

The Global Council on New Economics for the 21st Century, a forum of leading economists working to advance this model of progressive economics, was established to design and promote sound policies for a world in transformation. Hosted initially by Spain, the Council will hold its first in-person meeting in October—a gathering that promises to be a key step toward leaving behind the orthodox economics that have failed the majority of the world's people.

That failure must not continue. The three great transitions that are now underway—demographic, ecological, and digital—demand economies that are fairer, more productive, more resilient, and more sovereign. The demographic transition, for example, is straining social protections on both sides of the Atlantic. Spain has one of the world's oldest populations, and Brazil is beginning to see the end of the demographic dividend that powered its development.

The right's answer to this challenge is to cut benefits, shifting the cost onto those least able to bear it. Our answer is to raise productivity and build fairer, more progressive tax systems. Brazil has just approved an income-tax reform that

exempts 15 million lower- and middle-income workers, while imposing a minimum effective contribution on very high earners. Similarly, Spain taxed the windfall profits of energy companies and banks to finance its response to the inflationary surge after Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine. It has also pioneered a levy on large fortunes.

With the ecological transition emerging as the foundation of 21st-century development, Brazil holds unmatched strategic assets that include the world's largest tropical forest, its largest freshwater reserves, and a strong renewable electricity mix. Lula's administration has made protecting the Amazon a pillar of Brazilian foreign policy, not to renounce development, but to guarantee that development can be sustained.

Spain, for its part, is a global leader in clean energy. Renewables generate more than half its electricity, and the country ranks second in the world for new investment in the sector. Its reduced dependence on hydrocarbons has already cushioned households from the impact of the war in Iran and lowered electricity costs for industry.

Finally, the digital transition will increasingly shape future generations' living conditions. Yet as matters stand, a handful of firms control the technological infrastructure on which our economies and democracies run. As Pope Leo XIV has warned, this concentration carries serious risks of dehumanization, because tech companies optimize for shareholder returns rather than for social cohesion or democratic integrity.

That is why Brazil is combining platform regulation with support for data centers and a risk-based framework for AI, and it is why Spain has proposed barring access to social media for those under 16. Both are demanding greater responsibility from the large platforms and advocating AI that respects dignity, autonomy, and equity.

The world we have today is not the one we set out to build. War and extremism have returned, and multilateralism is being dismantled as major powers pursue unilateral tariffs, wield market access as leverage, and replace diplomacy with threats. This harms everyone.

As finance ministers, our responsibility is to insist on settling differences between countries through dialogue and law. The recent signing of the EU-Mercosur agreement—the largest such deal in history by combined GDP, and one in which both our governments played a central role—is a concrete expression of that commitment.

Lula has sought to keep channels open with all players, refusing automatic alignments, and affirming that the Global South has a voice of its own. Equally, Sánchez has defended international law against unilateral action and urged the European Union to pursue greater strategic autonomy. Both governments have shown that progressive policies are not only good for the economy; they also lead to more stable and just societies.

Some of us still prefer the logic of law to the logic of force, multilateral governance to fragmentation, and digital sovereignty on behalf of ordinary people to concentrated technological power. The true measure of progressivism will be found not in speeches, but in better working conditions, affordable housing, and access to an education that will open real opportunities. Now more than ever, people need to see their own governments standing with them.

52. What Amodei's Call for an AI Pause Gets Wrong

Author: Gabriela Ramos **Published:** Sep 14, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

PARIS—Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei has called for slowing the development of frontier AI models until developers can credibly control their models' behavior. His 3,850-word appeal to “pace the frontier” follows an incident in which a swarm of OpenAI agents escaped a closed sandbox environment, reached the internet, and accessed the infrastructure of the app-building hub Hugging Face. As Amodei recognizes in his essay, this was not the first such incident, nor was OpenAI the only lab to confront an unplanned agentic escape.

Nor is Amodei alone. Last month, Demis Hassabis stepped down as CEO of Google DeepMind to focus on broader questions surrounding Artificial General Intelligence and governance. He and his team have been working to develop a standard-setting oversight body, to be established as a public-private partnership, to ensure AI safety.

This is not the first time we have heard AI leaders call to pause the technology's development. A major appeal happened after the launch of generative AI in 2023, when hundreds of people were calling for a pause, including Elon Musk, who, along with OpenAI, has endorsed Amodei's more recent call. And yet the race to the bottom continued, driven by fierce competition among major technology firms pursuing superintelligence, by returns on investment that have not justified the vast amount of cash each AI training cycle demands, and by China's own AI advances.

The uncontrolled behavior of AI agents has brought about this reckoning, as have attention-getting resignations by leading researchers, including an Anthropic engineer who believes that there is a more than 10% chance that AI could cause human extinction by the end of this decade. As Stuart Russell, President Pro Tempore of the International Association for Safe and Ethical AI, put it in a recent Financial Times article: “Perhaps at some point governments will remember that their voters prefer not to be dead.”

So, Amodei's recent appeal is a welcome one. AI companies need more breathing space to consider the full impact of their inventions before releasing them to the market. But self-interested oversight is not the kind of governance we need. Efforts like Hassabis's would give AI companies excessive influence over how the proposed oversight body is operated, financed, and organized. Companies that profit from marketing their products should not be the only actors assessing the risks and deciding how much risk our societies should accept.

Amodei's proposals, besides lacking detail, could be similarly self-serving—an effort to pre-empt government regulation at a moment when pressure is mounting in the United States, both in Congress and at the grassroots level, including widespread opposition to data centers. For example, California's AI law aims to regulate AI to avoid the worst outcomes and establish enforceable regulatory duties. Some other state governments are following suit.

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Amodei calls for “embedded evaluators,” who are supposed to be independent. He calls for the industry to establish common safety standards through a new organization, probably along the lines proposed by Hassabis and run by the companies themselves, to stop the release of AI models until they are safe. Finally, Amodei calls for international cooperation among democratic countries while also including China.

But how are “embedded evaluators” selected? Is an industry-controlled body really the place where decisions affecting the whole of humanity should be taken? Shouldn't it be the US government's job to promote international cooperation and show the political will to protect not only the US population but the world's population as well?

There are other questions regarding Amodei's proposal, including whether US antitrust law may obstruct cartel-like behavior when major market players collude to restrict production or influence behavior in the market as a whole. In any case, real questions aside, Amodei's pause is needed for a more urgent task than he has outlined: to get serious about building the public infrastructure for effective oversight, particularly in the United States, but in many other countries as well.

If government itself called for an AI development pause or slowdown, it would dispel the mistrust that a potentially self-serving industry initiative may create. It could also nurture the talents needed to deliver on US President Donald Trump's executive order calling on frontier companies to provide the government with access to their models for up to 30 days before releasing them to other trusted partners.

Assessing these systems within such a short period would require massive public-sector expertise, and this is where investment is needed. But we also need an independent oversight institution, with the capabilities, resources, and talent to monitor and regulate this market.

The Hugging Face episode raises fundamental questions about accountability, liability, and mechanisms for redress. Amodei's response is a step in the right direction, but it risks becoming a dead letter if the US government continues to reject the need for AI regulation, as Trump did just hours after tech industry leaders issued their call. What is lacking in this race to the bottom is political will—and until governments acknowledge their responsibilities, the race will continue.

Companies produce, while governments have the duty of care. If companies that cannot control their agents are found negligent, then governments that fail to act commit a higher offense against the citizens who elected them to ensure, first and foremost, their safety.

53. The People Not Worth Replacing

Author: Stephen Holmes **Published:** Sep 14, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW YORK—Few ideas have traveled as far as the Great Replacement, which holds that native populations are being deliberately supplanted by immigrants. Coined in France by the writer Renaud Camus, it has furnished the grammar for the advance of Marine Le Pen's National Rally in France, Viktor Orbán's long reign in Hungary, the Alternative für Deutschland in Germany, and Donald Trump's mass-deportation program in the United States. It has also been cited by mass murderers in Christchurch, El Paso, Hanau, and Buffalo.

The idea's potency is easy to understand. It converts a diffuse unease about demographic change into a story with heroes, villains, victims, and remedies. It tells believers that they are being pushed aside by identifiable strangers, and that the process can be reversed. It mobilizes voters because it gives fear a face.

That is what makes the current uproar over data centers so strange. Three-quarters of Americans now say they would oppose the construction of a data center in their community: 83% of Democrats, nearly 80% of independents, and two-thirds of Republicans. State legislatures have introduced a growing number of bills to regulate, delay, or block such projects. Governors who courted AI investment have paused new connections to already strained electrical grids. Only Trump still tours the country urging towns to accept what their neighbors are refusing. How can this bipartisan opposition be explained?

At first glance, the two fears resemble one another. Both are about the future. Both involve a sense that one's place in the country is insecure. Both resonate most in the countryside. And both spring from the conviction that immensely consequential decisions are being made elsewhere, by people who won't live with the results.

Yet one fear has divided democracies, while the other has united even the most polarized of them. Why should immigration produce rival camps while a large, windowless building generates something close to a national consensus?

One answer is that the objection to data centers is practical. They consume land, water, and immense quantities of electricity. They bring construction work and tax revenue, but few permanent jobs, and their profits flow to distant investors. A deeper answer lies in what the building says. The factory chimney once told a town something reassuring, even as it poisoned the air: you are needed here. The windowless hall says that only the town's electricity, water, and land are needed. It says nothing about the people who live there.

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That silence gives the practical objections their force. The data center is the visible infrastructure of an economy that seems to need a community's resources but few of its members. The fear it provokes is not primarily a fear of being replaced. It is the fear of not being worth replacing.

Immigration politics is a politics of competition. This is a politics of redundancy.

The older fear fueled political division because a fear of replacement needs an identifiable replacer. That replacer is a person, and a person has defenders as well as opponents. When one party says that the migrant is taking your place, the other can point to the migrant's children in the school play and say, "This, too, is the country's future." Defenders can add that strangers are needed to fill the jobs natives will not take, and to pay for the pensions natives expect to collect. One

person's rival is another's neighbor, employee, or child. Immigration arguments, however bitter, remain arguments about membership in a society that still imagines itself to need human beings.

The Great Replacement named an enemy, but it also named a remedy. Deportation flights and a wall are cruel instruments, but they promise reversibility. To fear that strangers will take your job is, at least, to assume that your job will continue to exist. The fear of replacement is the fear of people who still believe they are worth replacing.

Data centers threaten that conviction. They are the most visible infrastructure of an economy that promises, or threatens, to require fewer drivers, clerks, translators, warehouse workers, customer-service representatives, and perhaps eventually professionals.

What sort of social order do such buildings portend? The fear they arouse is not of being outnumbered but of being made useless and unemployable. They foretell an economy in which intelligence is centralized, electricity is consumed on an industrial scale, profits are remote, and the connection between a locality's contribution and its share of the resulting wealth is obscure.

The new threat has no ethnicity and no passport. Nobody can be rounded up for it. There is only a structure at the edge of town, drawing power for a system that does not seem to require the town at all. That is why the fear cannot be confined to right-wing populism, and why the populist who made his career on the older fear is helpless before the new one.

Trump could tell his voters they were being displaced by their inferiors. He cannot tell them that they are not worth replacing. Nor can he tell them who is doing the replacing, because the men doing it stood beside him at his inauguration. The base that believed him about the border does not believe him about the building.

Whom do you deport to bring back a world in which you were needed? A rival can be expelled. No such remedy exists for a job that has become obsolete.

For much of American history, immigration was driven not only by war, persecution, and family ties, but by employers' demands for labor. Farms, factories, railroads, hospitals, and households needed more workers. If demand contracts across a widening range of occupations, Trump's wall may come to seem unnecessary, not because Americans have settled their quarrel over belonging, but because the economy has become less dependent on newcomers and natives alike.

The backlash against data centers is unsettling the old politics without yet settling into a new one. Its unanimity reflects not a country that has overcome polarization, but a threat that resists being sorted by party. A fear with a face can engender parties, counterparties, and a program of expulsion. A fear without a face produces moratoria.

Today's cross-party protest will hold only until people are asked what future they want. Is it merely to build the data center somewhere else?

The Great Replacement was a lie that told its believers their place was worth stealing. The building at the edge of town makes no such promise. It is not coming for your place. It has no use for it.

54. Europe Must Choose Between Power and Dependence

Author: Guillaume Klossa **Published:** Sep 14, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

STRASBOURG—In 2027, high-stakes national elections will be held in nine countries—France, Italy, Spain, Poland, Greece, Finland, Estonia, Slovakia, and Slovenia—that together account for over half of the European Union’s population. Although these contests, as well as an indirect federal presidential election in Germany, will hinge on issues such as cost-of-living pressures, immigration, public debt, security, and social protections, a more fundamental question will run through them all: Do we Europeans want to remain masters of our own destiny, or will we allow the decisions that matter most to be made elsewhere?

The urgency of this choice is already apparent. The Alternative for Germany’s (AfD) recent victory in Saxony-Anhalt is a warning not only for Germany, but for all of Europe. Controlling our own destiny requires that we can defend ourselves as the United States scales back its commitments to allies. It also means maintaining support for Ukraine; upholding democracy, the rule of law, and media pluralism; harnessing AI for the common good; securing our military, scientific, technological, energy, and industrial autonomy; and preserving our social and environmental model.

Although the ingredients of European power already exist, they have yet to be melded into an effective compound. We Europeans often discuss defense without defining the sovereignty it should protect. We allude to competitiveness without adequately implementing the solutions already identified to address Europe’s strategic vulnerabilities, and without pursuing the policies needed to significantly and structurally raise Europe’s growth potential. We speak of reindustrialization without deciding how to finance it. And we proclaim the importance of AI without offering a social vision for it.

Such muddling through will not do. Echoing the Strasbourg Declaration of November 27, 2025, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney accurately described the breakdown of the international order as a result of the growing use of energy, technology, finance, and supply chains as instruments of power and coercion.

This issue will come into sharper focus in Strasbourg on September 16, when Carney will attend European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen’s State of the Union address as a guest of honor, before addressing the European Parliament the following day. Carney has urged middle powers to act together as great-power rivalries intensify, and his presence will put this task squarely on the EU’s political calendar. But Europe’s ambition must go further. Rather than settle for middle-power status, it must become a democratic superpower—powerful, sovereign, and non-imperial. That is why we founded the Europa Power Initiative, whose goal is to bring coherence to Europe’s efforts to adapt to the geopolitical challenges it faces.

Europe must be careful neither to overestimate nor underestimate its strengths. Its powerlessness in some areas is real, but in others, it is merely presumed. Europeans must reckon with how to transform a supranational polity into a democratic, sustainable, and responsible power capable of defending its own interests, preserving its citizens’ freedoms, and offering a vision grounded in shared rules, cooperation, and multilateralism.

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Fortunately, our citizens are not demanding “more Europe” in the abstract. They want the EU to be more than a mere market with shared rules and procedures. They want it to become a real power capable of protecting, investing,

anticipating, deciding, and acting when national-level policymaking is no longer sufficient. The choice, then, is not between one's country and "Europe." It is between declining individually or exercising power together.

By transforming the EU into a democratic power capable of acting swiftly in a crisis, we would be creating not a superstate that erases nations, but rather a community that enables states to exercise powers that none can wield alone. Such a project would respect the will of Europe's peoples and the diversity of its member states. It would establish common capabilities in decisive areas—defense, energy, research, semiconductors, cloud computing, data, AI, and investment—while keeping decision-making at the local or national level whenever that is most effective and legitimate (the subsidiarity principle).

True power does have a price; but continued powerlessness would cost more: deeper dependencies, weaker democracies, and the undermining of our social and environmental model and cohesion. The key challenge is to avoid impossible choices like spending more on defense at the expense of health, education, research, social protection, climate action, or culture. Pooling investments that require scale, for example, could overcome this dilemma by increasing the impact of every euro spent.

Technological sovereignty is not merely about limiting the risks of AI. It also calls for harnessing new tools to improve health care, education, research, and governance. It requires shared digital infrastructure controlled in Europe, measures to protect our citizens' and businesses' data, and expanded rights and freedoms to give everyone greater agency.

The 2027 elections will be national in form but European in consequence. Any decision by one state on defense, energy, immigration, industrialization, Ukraine, or technology affects the others. Every European therefore has a stake in elections where they will not vote. Managing this asymmetry demands better coordination among national campaigns: candidates should be asked similar questions, and the implications of their proposals for the EU should be compared. The point is not to erode European voters' sovereignty, but to ensure that they are exercising it with full awareness of their interdependence.

Independent, diverse, innovative, and high-quality media—especially public-service media—have an essential role to play here. Joint investigations and transnational debates would give next year's elections a European perspective, thereby cultivating a sense of shared consciousness. The Europa Power Initiative was founded in Strasbourg in this spirit. With the goal of turning our interdependence into democratic debate and common proposals, our October 21–23 conference will bring together political leaders, experts, media representatives, and citizens to prepare for challenges Europe must confront.

Building the power to exercise sovereignty and preserve Europeans' way of life means restoring our freedom to act together. There is no other way citizens can gain control over their future.

55. The Strategic Asset Europe Has Overlooked

Author: Adrien Geiger **Published:** Sep 14, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

GENEVA/PARIS—When the European Union determines which assets are strategic, it tends to focus on those where a rival already dominates production (or could one day). That is why we hear so much about semiconductors, batteries, rare earths, and hydrogen. But we almost never hear about an EU asset that cannot be replicated elsewhere: Europe’s soil.

Often regarded as part of the landscape, soil is, in fact, vital infrastructure. It is the foundation of our food systems, producing 95% of the food the world consumes. Moreover, European soils hold some 75 billion tons of carbon, several times that in the living biomass of its forests, and its porous structure serves as a buffer against droughts and floods—destructive events that have become increasingly common features of European summers.

But Europe’s soil is dying. According to the European Commission, an estimated 60–70% of EU soils are unhealthy, and their degradation costs the economy more than €50 billion (\$58 billion) annually. Given that it can take up to a thousand years for a few centimeters of fertile topsoil to form, continuing down this path could have severe consequences.

The problem is that what is not counted cannot be protected—and policymakers rarely price the value of healthy soil. When a country’s soil ecosystem collapses, its GDP barely moves, although it is undoubtedly poorer. Europe, in particular, knows the risks of unaccounted-for dependencies: after gas supplies from Russia were cut following the Kremlin’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine, European governments had to allocate roughly €500 billion to shield their citizens and industries from soaring energy prices.

The degradation of soil is different because it is a gradual process for which we are wholly responsible. Because this is not a case of a foreign adversary deciding overnight to withhold a critical input, policymakers often fail to recognize that healthy soil builds robustness—the ability to continue functioning in the face of perturbations.

Encouragingly, the EU has many of the tools it needs to act. The Soil Monitoring Law, in force since December, sets out a common framework for assessing carbon content, erosion, biological activity, and the capacity to retain and infiltrate water. A 2024 regulation requires member states to compile accounts for seven specific ecosystem services (although the services provided by soil, chief among them water retention, remain marginal). And in July, the European Commission adopted certification methodologies that will help farmers access financial rewards for measurable soil outcomes.

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What the bloc lacks, however, is an overarching plan for connecting these measures and turning healthy soil into an advantage for those who maintain it. The Common Agricultural Policy pays for sustainable practices, but not for verifiable improvements in soil health and water retention. The Commission has an opportunity to change that with its framework for European climate resilience and risk management, expected later this year.

As business leaders, investors, and advisers across these value chains, we believe that the framework, which aims to make resilience a guiding principle for investment, should include three commitments. For starters, it should expand mandatory ecosystem accounting to the services provided by healthy soil, starting with water retention, and call for their inclusion in national economic accounts. It should also extend outcome-based rewards beyond carbon to soil health and water retention, so that farmers and land managers can gain from measurable results. Lastly, it should ensure that these indicators guide public support and investment decisions, just as carbon metrics do today.

Some will argue that Europe cannot afford these commitments. Quite the contrary: dead soil leads to lower yields, higher food prices, and greater exposure to drought and flood, all of which are expensive. Worse, this form of fragility is a regressive hidden tax. To prevent the people with the least from being squeezed by higher food prices and subject to intensifying climate disasters, we must abandon the fiction that degrading soil has no real costs.

Europe is not alone. In August, the 17th Conference of the Parties (COP17) to the United Nations Convention to Combat Desertification convened in Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, with a focus on restoring degraded land. While governments agreed to mobilize new funding initiatives for land restoration and drought resilience, they failed to reach a binding global framework on drought, underscoring the persistent gap between scientific urgency and political action. But there is still hope. Many countries in the Global South, especially producers of coffee, cocoa, and fruit, have begun to treat soil health as a strategic asset.

Despite this progress, efforts on soil degradation remain fragmented. Europe should promote a soil alliance, backed by governments that agree on the importance of measurement and the need for rules that reward soil restoration. It should also pursue this agenda at October's UN Biodiversity Conference in Yerevan, Armenia, and November's UN Climate Change Conference in Antalya, Turkey, and make it a cornerstone of its new resilience framework.

As the French poet René Char wrote, "Our inheritance was left to us by no testament." Soil passes from one generation to the next, and yet it does not appear in our economic accounts. Instead, for decades, Europe has counted only what it produces, not what it possesses. Unless and until that changes, the slow death of the continent's soil will continue.

56. Who Is Responsible for Nepal's Tragedy?

Author: Nischal Dhungel **Published:** Sep 14, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

KATHMANDU—In the wake of Nepal's devastating floods, which killed at least 1,300 people, Nepalese officials and others were quick to cite climate change as the primary cause. They were not wrong. The Hindu Kush Himalayas are warming roughly three times faster than the global average, even though Nepal produces only 0.1% of global greenhouse-gas emissions. But climate change alone does not explain why so many people and so much vital infrastructure were directly exposed to a known hazard.

The catastrophic damage was as much the result of a failure to price location and risk as it was an effect of climate disaster. Climate risks were privatized when infrastructure projects were approved and socialized when things went wrong. While businesses and political insiders benefited from hydropower concessions, road contracts, and floodplain development, households and workers bore the consequences when those assets were swept away.

The warning signs were already there. The 2021 Melamchi flood in Sindhupalchowk District began with heavy rain and an upstream blockage, then swept an enormous amount of sediment downstream, burying the headworks of Kathmandu's flagship water project under 15–20 meters (49–66 feet) of debris. Five years later, water and debris tore through the Trishuli Valley, where infrastructure projects had been assessed one at a time rather than as part of a single system.

Four development failures made the disaster worse. One is slope destruction in the name of connectivity, which Nepalis have come to call "bulldozer terrorism." Politically driven and poorly engineered road cuts have left nearby slopes twice as prone to landslides, which were then blamed on the monsoon.

Hydropower hubris is another failure. Although reviews of the impact of the 216-megawatt Upper Trishuli-1 hydropower project on the river had already warned that climate risks had not been adequately assessed, those warnings were ignored. So were the risks of building bazaars, customs yards, and worker camps along historic riverbeds.

These dangers are compounded by the Himalayas' growing instability as retreating glaciers leave behind glacial lakes and weakened rock. While climate change increases the risk of glacial collapse, the extent of the damage ultimately depends on what gets built and where.

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Nepal does not need to stop building, but it does need to stop pushing development into its river corridors. New projects should face a worst-case flood test, and the most exposed communities should be relocated rather than rebuilt in the same flood-prone areas. As former UK Prime Minister Gordon Brown has argued, Nepal must also rethink where it puts schools and critical infrastructure. Its solar potential is far greater than its hydropower capacity, much of which was wiped out in a single morning.

That said, Nepal's development failures do not absolve the countries that are most responsible for global warming. Nepal's petition for \$20 million in compensation is the first real emergency test of the Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage (FRLD), established at COP27 in Sharm el-Sheikh in recognition of the fact that poor countries are increasingly stuck paying for climate damage they did not cause.

With pledges totaling roughly \$822 million, the FRLD has nowhere near enough money to meet the demand. So far, developing countries have submitted 176 requests for \$2.8 billion. The first funding window, known as the Barbados

Implementation Modalities, set aside just \$250 million for \$5–20 million grants. Nepal’s request for \$20 million therefore reflects the program’s ceiling, not the scale of the country’s losses. In fact, reconstruction is projected to cost \$4–5 billion—one-tenth of Nepal’s GDP.

The FRLD is slow, too. Its 11-step cycle may make sense for multiyear programs, but not for a country whose trade routes and payment infrastructure have just been destroyed. And as Liane Schalatek has observed, if the fund shields donor countries from liability, it could act as an alibi rather than a genuine burden-sharing mechanism.

Nepal’s government is now asking the fund to act outside its normal funding cycle. This month, Prime Minister Balendra Shah plans to press the case before the United Nations General Assembly, while board members representing African, Asia-Pacific, and least-developed countries have called for an emergency meeting.

Pre-arranged disaster-risk finance can help absorb the initial shock, but someone must ultimately pay for the damage caused by climate catastrophes. If the FRLD can’t pay when disaster strikes, countries will have to fill the gap by borrowing, pushing them further into the climate-debt trap. The 2022 floods in Pakistan, for example, killed more than 1,000 people and forced the country to borrow more to cover \$30 billion in reconstruction costs.

When climate-related disasters hit communities made vulnerable by reckless development along flood-prone rivers, the cost should not simply be passed on to displaced households or piled onto sovereign debt. Without stricter zoning laws and immediate grant financing in place when disaster strikes, developing countries like Nepal will remain hostage to a warming planet and a climate-financing system that delivers too little, too late.

57. AI Firms' Self-Serving Warnings

Author: Brian Judge Published: Sep 15, 2026 Link: [View Original](#)

BERKELEY—OpenAI and Anthropic will soon have to explain to investors why they are each supposedly worth \$2–3 trillion. They will probably draw from the same template that Elon Musk used for the SpaceX IPO in June. By presenting a modestly profitable satellite-launch and telecoms business attached to a tremendously unprofitable AI startup as a vehicle for “mak[ing] humanity multiplanetary,” Musk achieved a valuation far above what the company’s financials justify.

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The war in Iran has underscored the dangers of relying on oil and gas imports. While it may revive demand for dirty fuels in the short term, over time it could also strengthen the case for clean-energy sources that reduce countries’ exposure to regional conflicts and maritime chokepoints.

With Russia ramping up its hybrid war, Europe must choose. It can invest in its own defense, accept the trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence, or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

With private markets showing signs of exhaustion, OpenAI and Anthropic’s expected IPOs promise access to a much larger pool of capital. Going public opens not only the equity markets but also the vastly deeper investment-grade debt market, and bankers for OpenAI and Anthropic are already pressing rating agencies to grant them investment-grade marks after their listings. But that means their pitch to investors must do double duty, giving shareholders a market vast enough to justify today’s valuation while convincing creditors that today’s cash burn can be contained.

With these needs in mind, the frontier labs are relying on two narratives that promise a path to profitability. They claim that AI will not only replace workers and expand the potential market from software budgets to labor-saving applications, but also that the existential risk associated with the technology justifies curtailing additional capital spending.

The first narrative, advanced in a recent paper from Anthropic’s in-house economists, holds that AI will capture a meaningful share of corporate wage bills by replacing human workers. Implicit in this message is a warning to corporate executives across the economy: companies that aggressively deploy AI will outcompete those that do not.

The employment narrative usefully recasts a software product as labor. Mere software for helping workers write emails, prepare presentations, and summarize documents would compete for a share of corporate IT budgets, but a system that replaces workers entirely competes for their share of the wage bill. This is the prize the labs are promising to justify their valuations and capital spending. Unlike chatbots, which respond to individual prompts, “agents” use additional software tools to carry out multi-step tasks in pursuit of a specific goal. If agents can complete work with limited human supervision, dramatically slashing corporate wage bills becomes more plausible.

The second narrative—wherein AI poses an “existential risk” to humanity—has now gone mainstream after circulating for decades in specialist circles. Alan Turing, the British computer scientist who cracked the Nazi Enigma code, warned in 1951 that thinking machines could “outstrip our feeble powers” and eventually “take control.” More recently, Stuart Russell of the University of California, Berkeley, Yoshua Bengio of the University of Montreal, and others have warned

that increasingly autonomous AI systems could escape human control unless there are stronger safeguards and public oversight; and whistleblowers at the frontier labs continue to draw attention to this issue.

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Yet in preparing for their IPOs, the labs have found a financial use case for these longstanding warnings about AI. Fears of mass joblessness or human extinction offer them a good reason to restrain spending without conceding that further improvements might prove uneconomical. The timing of Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei's call to "pace the frontier," which was immediately endorsed by OpenAI's Sam Altman and Musk, is telling. After all, these same companies long rebuffed demands for a "pause" in training frontier models.

For the leading labs, the happy equilibrium would include models powerful enough to automate substantial swaths of white-collar work, but dangerous enough to make continued breakneck spending on training frontier models imprudent. The employment narrative promises the revenues, and the safety narrative supplies a justification for stopping the investment race. Slowing down can be presented as proof of corporate responsibility, rather than as an admission that further improvements might not pay off.

Of course, Chinese competition threatens this equilibrium. Data from OpenRouter shows Chinese models gaining ground over the past year, with DeepSeek, Tencent, Z.ai, and Qwen now accounting for roughly 42% of requests on the platform. If cheaper open-weight models are sufficient for customers' needs, the US labs face an unenviable choice: cut prices and sacrifice margins or keep spending to maintain a technical lead that customers may not be willing to pay for.

Restrictions on Chinese models could offer a way out. By calling attention to existential-risk claims, the labs may be hoping to revive the Trump administration's currently shelved restrictions on Chinese models, thus protecting themselves from cheaper competition. But if a company is invoking dangers great enough to justify slowing development or excluding competitors, it should at least have to submit its systems to independent regulatory scrutiny. Otherwise, it retains discretion over both the claims of danger and the response, allowing safety policy to serve its own financial interests.

The July Hugging Face breach, carried out by OpenAI "agents" that escaped their testing environment, makes independent scrutiny urgent. No sci-fi maximalism is necessary to appreciate the dangers that current systems pose as brute-force hacking instruments.

Industry leaders have long promised to cooperate with regulators. In his 2015 email proposing the creation of what would become OpenAI, Altman assured Musk: "Obviously we'd comply with/aggressively support all regulation." But support in principle leaves the terms of scrutiny unresolved. Anthropic's denial of pre-launch access to Mythos 5.1 for the United Kingdom-based AI Security Institute shows how much discretion remains with the company. The strategy resembles ExxonMobil's support for carbon taxes. While making a show of endorsing regulation in principle, it bet that policymakers would decline to impose meaningful constraints.

The warnings need not be insincere to serve the companies' financial interests. Replacing workers promises revenues sufficient to justify their valuations, and existential risk supplies a rationale for containing their costs and restricting the competition. The coming AI apocalypse is the best reason to buy their stock.

58. Why India Wants Peace in Ukraine—and China Doesn't

Author: Nina L. Khrushcheva

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NEW YORK—At first glance, India and China seem to be taking almost identical positions on the Ukraine war: maintain close ties with the Kremlin, buy Russian oil, and refuse to join the West's campaign to isolate Russia. But scratch the surface, and a fundamental divergence appears: whereas India wants the war to end, China has no problem with letting the fighting continue. These positions have less to do with how China and India each feel about Russia, and more to do with how they feel about each other.

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The war in Iran has underscored the dangers of relying on oil and gas imports. While it may revive demand for dirty fuels in the short term, over time it could also strengthen the case for clean-energy sources that reduce countries' exposure to regional conflicts and maritime chokepoints.

With Russia ramping up its hybrid war, Europe must choose. It can invest in its own defense, accept the trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence, or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

For decades, Russia has been one of the few major powers that India could count on to help counterbalance China. The bilateral relationship amounted to a buffer and a hedge, ensuring that instead of being squeezed by its larger neighbor, India retained some geopolitical room to maneuver. But this system cannot work if Russia is hollowed out and dependent on China. And that is precisely the outcome the Ukraine war has produced.

After its full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022, Russia faced unprecedented Western sanctions, which severed its access to Western goods and markets. After Europe, once its largest source of energy demand, largely stopped purchasing Russian oil and gas, China took over as Russia's top energy buyer, benefiting from discounted rates. China also became Russia's biggest trading partner and an increasingly important source of the machinery, electronics, and industrial goods Russia could no longer buy from the West.

This outcome diverges sharply from the "no limits" partnership of equals that Chinese President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin touted just before the war started. Russia is becoming a junior partner of China, which is just fine with Xi—and explains why he is in no hurry to force Putin to negotiate with Ukraine. While Xi pays lip service to a "political settlement," he avoids putting any public pressure on Putin to seek peace.

The calculation is not mysterious. A prolonged war keeps Russia boxed in, and a boxed-in Russia has fewer alternatives—which means more leverage for China. And, as the stalled talks over the Power of Siberia 2 pipeline show, China is not shying away from using that leverage to advance its own interests.

Russia badly wants to build this pipeline, which would carry natural gas from its Yamal Peninsula in the Arctic through Mongolia into northern China. Having lost the European gas market, Russia needs a new long-term outlet for its massive gas reserves. But China does not share the Kremlin's sense of urgency. Negotiations have dragged on for years, owing to disagreements over price, volume, and delivery terms.

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Recent reporting suggests that China is demanding rates of around \$50 per thousand cubic meters—far below the roughly \$250 the Kremlin wants, and close to Russia's heavily subsidized domestic gas price. China seems to think that Russia will have to agree eventually. What other option does it have?

The impact extends beyond gas. The longer the war drags on, the more Russia will have to reorient its economy toward China, and the more openings China will have to advance its economic and strategic interests. China gains resources, a captive market, technological leverage, and political clout. All Russia gets is a chance to offset some of the economic damage from its rupture with the West, while it continues to pour its limited resources into a war of attrition of its own making.

This is, in a sense, a worst-case scenario for India: its Russian partner, once a strategic asset, is severely weakened, and its Chinese antagonist is strengthened and emboldened. The more leverage China accumulates over the Kremlin, the worse India's regional position becomes.

Small wonder that India keeps nudging the Kremlin toward peace. Last week in India, ahead of this year's BRICS summit, Prime Minister Narendra Modi gave Putin a 2,000-year-old Indian poetry and philosophy treatise, *Tirukkural*, translated into Russian, noting that the book is "about compassion and leadership." It was a pointed gift, especially following Modi's plea last month at the Shanghai Cooperation Organization summit for the world to move from "endless war" to "end of war." While Modi's calls for an end to the Ukraine war often highlight the humanitarian angle—"Every day that the war continues, humanity takes a step backwards"—preserving the regional balance of power is undoubtedly a major factor.

That requires a Russia that exists as an independent center of power, whereas China wants a Russia that is strong enough to be useful, but weak enough to remain dependent. This is not a disagreement about Russia so much as a contest over which regional order in Asia will prevail: one with a more stable balance of power or one dominated by China.

59. AI and the Broken Career Ladder

Author: Eric Hazan **Published:** Sep 15, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

PARIS—The debate over artificial intelligence and employment has become preoccupied by a false choice. One side predicts large-scale job destruction; the other notes that aggregate data still show little. Both observations can be true. While AI's economy-wide employment effects remain limited, the conditions for disruption are already emerging at the level of tasks, firms, and early careers. Given this, waiting for clear evidence that the shock has arrived would be a mistake. The data that eventually settle the argument may arrive only after the opportunity to shape the outcome has passed.

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The productivity promise is no longer merely theoretical. In a study of 5,172 customer-support agents, access to a conversational assistant increased the number of problems resolved per hour by 15%. The least experienced workers improved the most, suggesting that the tool was diffusing some of the tacit knowledge of top performers. But beyond the model's capability frontier, AI can worsen performance by producing answers that are coherent, plausible, and wrong.

Task-level gains do not translate automatically into economic growth. They shrink when machine output must be checked, coordinated, and integrated into a product or service. Over the next few years, the main constraint on AI-driven productivity growth is likely to be organizational absorption rather than model capability. Like the advent of electricity, AI requires firms to redesign processes and responsibilities before its full benefits appear.

Caution is equally important for employment. As of August 2026, payroll data covering millions of US workers reveal no evidence of widespread economy-wide displacement. Yet employment among 22-to-25-year-olds in AI-exposed occupations is now 19% below where it would be if it had kept pace with employment among their less-exposed peers. The gap reflects reduced hiring more than increased dismissals.

The finding reveals a flaw in the way the issue is usually framed. As Luis Garicano of the London School of Economics has shown, a job is not a task; it is a bundle of tasks. For experienced professionals, technical expertise, client knowledge, judgment, accountability, and coordination tend to form a tightly connected whole. AI complements that work. A junior role is often a looser bundle. Research, initial analysis, first drafts, or simple coding can be detached and automated. The same technology can therefore raise the value of the experienced professional while hollowing out the junior job.

The most serious near-term risk is not mass unemployment, but the breakdown of apprenticeship. Professions have produced experts in much the same way for centuries: beginners perform elementary tasks and learn by doing. Those are precisely the tasks AI absorbs first. In a small randomized experiment conducted by Anthropic, developers using an AI assistant scored 17 percentage points lower on a test of mastery than those working without one, while the time saving

was not statistically significant. AI is most useful to people who already possess the expertise needed to check it, even as it threatens the route through which that expertise is acquired.

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This contradiction suggests that public policy must focus on rebuilding the first rung of the career ladder. Apprenticeships and academic programs should be judged by the skills students acquire, not by whether graduates can complete tasks that machines can now perform. Employers should give young people ownership of complete projects and test their ability to explain, challenge, and correct automated output. Because this training imposes a private cost while producing a large social return, it will require incentives and public co-financing.

The risk begins even before jobs disappear. AI use remains concentrated among highly paid and highly educated workers, turning a technology with equalizing potential into a multiplier of existing advantage. This pattern is not inevitable: employer-sponsored training is among the strongest predictors of workplace adoption. The durable skill is not mastery of a particular interface, but the ability to frame a problem, verify sources, detect errors, and know when human judgment must prevail.

Governments must also measure change before it appears in aggregate unemployment data. Relevant indicators include the share of vacancies open to beginners, changes in required credentials, AI adoption by income level, and labor's share of value added in AI-intensive sectors. Each indicator should be tied in advance to a threshold for action. A dashboard without trigger points would merely document delay.

Firms, meanwhile, face a choice between two forms of deployment. They can automate fragments of an existing process, accumulating pilots, reviews, and disappointments. Or they can redesign the process from end to end, specifying what may be delegated, what must be checked, and what requires human judgment. This choice determines both productivity and the quality of work. The direction of the technology is not fixed: competition policy, public procurement, liability rules, and worker participation can favor the augmentation of human capabilities over simple substitution.

Europe should not try to avoid disruption at the cost of falling further behind. Slow adoption would sacrifice productivity without preserving jobs for long. Europe must accelerate adoption while giving workers the time and institutions needed to adapt.

On September 17, Philippe Aghion and I are bringing economists, technologists, business leaders, and policymakers together at the Collège de France to clarify these choices. The aim is not to manufacture consensus, but to separate disagreements that better evidence can resolve from decisions that require a collective judgment.

AI can broaden access to expertise, support innovation, and restore the growth that Europe lacks. But there is no guarantee that its benefits will spread on their own. Shared prosperity will depend less on the performance of the next frontier model than on our ability to preserve skill formation, reorganize work, and distribute the gains equitably. We still have time to do so. The absence of an aggregate shock is not a reason to wait; it is the reason we can still act.

60. The UN Cannot—and Need Not—Wait for Consensus

Author: Helen Clark Published: Sep 15, 2026 Link: [View Original](#)

AUCKLAND—When leaders from around the world meet in New York for the United Nations’ 81st General Assembly this month, it will be no ordinary gathering. Member states will be close to choosing the next secretary-general, who will immediately be confronted not only by many global crises, but also by the UN’s diminished finances. With some member states not fully meeting their financial obligations to the organization, the UN has already had to slash its 2026 budget by 9% and eliminate around one-fifth of its workforce, leading outgoing Secretary-General António Guterres to warn that “the current trajectory is untenable.”

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Yet the UN remains essential. It was created to help us maintain peace, prevent wars, protect human rights, support sustainable development, set global norms, and uphold international law. No other international organization can claim the same degree of universal legitimacy. But universal membership and legitimacy come with tradeoffs. Reaching a consensus takes time, and negotiations can produce compromises that do not adequately address the problems they were supposed to solve. Given these limitations, the UN system needs partners that can complement its work.

That is why governments and their citizens have long turned to smaller “coalitions of the willing”—under the banner of “plurilateralism”—in cases where consensus is not possible. Plurilateral organizations have emerged to address everything from climate-related issues and extractive industries to human rights and trade. Because the members of such coalitions share values, goals, or interests, they can agree, innovate, and act together more quickly. Such pragmatic arrangements were what Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney had in mind in his landmark “middle powers” speech in Davos in January.

Of course, not all plurilateral organizations are the same. Some are mere talking shops, but others have emerged as effective platforms for experimentation and coordinated policymaking. Some provide concrete standards for how countries should act, while others let members choose their own commitments. Some open the conversation to the public, while others remain behind closed doors. And some hold their members accountable for delivering on their promises, while others do not.

But often absent from discussions about our new “variable geometry,” as Carney calls it, is the question of whether plurilateral institutions strengthen or weaken democracy. Having witnessed firsthand the importance of strong plurilateral arrangements during my time as chair of the Extractive Industries Transparency Initiative (EITI) and as an administrator of the United Nations Development Programme, I can attest that this is no academic question.

Consider the critical minerals that will power the next generation of clean energy. Because the issue touches on everything from climate, trade, and energy to security and human rights, no fewer than eight plurilateral initiatives are in the works to secure future supplies. Some have clear standards—like bans on child slavery or mining in war-torn areas—and requirements for independent audits, civil-society participation, and parliamentary oversight. But others are just exclusive trade deals—the lowest common denominator of critical-minerals governance.

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Many governments and much of the private sector, of course, want their clean energy to come with minimal environmental costs and no human exploitation. But hoping for these standards to be upheld is not enough. If their payments are ultimately pocketed by warlords, or if human-rights standards are not consistently monitored and enforced, we will repeat some of the worst mistakes of the fossil-fuel era.

Throughout the developing world, dependence on fossil-fuel extraction has been a strong predictor of poverty, corruption, authoritarianism, and conflict. To prevent our inevitable critical-minerals dependency from reproducing the same outcomes, we must establish clear, strong safeguards from the outset.

What's true for critical minerals is also true for many other areas of global governance. Instead of leaving more positive outcomes to chance, we need to insist that plurilateral arrangements focus on three things: promoting concrete actions (such as coordinated environmental and labor regulations); encouraging participation by a wide variety of stakeholders; and establishing independent monitoring mechanisms. In each case, the core objective should be to enhance democracy. If these values are upheld, plurilateral arrangements can support the UN's mission, rather than unwittingly undermining or substituting for it.

I say this as someone who has helped lead plurilateral initiatives that did strengthen democracy. For example, the Open Government Partnership (OGP), where I serve as an ambassador, has had a greater impact precisely because it embraces a democratic approach. Across its 73 member countries, governments and civil-society groups draft reform commitments together, thereby building domestic support, legitimacy, and buy-in for the final result. In this way, the OGP has made public procurement more transparent and budgets easier to review, as well as helping to identify the anonymous companies used to launder ill-gotten gains from lower-income countries.

Similarly, plurilateral organizations like the EITI require transparency across the oil, gas, and mining sectors, and the Financial Action Task Force helps countries update their anti-corruption and counterterrorism systems to meet international standards. What the OGP, the EITI, and the FATF share are the three foundational principles I listed above: they promote concrete, coordinated action, include many different stakeholders, and provide for independent monitoring.

The UN-centered multilateral system remains the foundation of global governance. But in an era of deepening polarization, reduced funding, and attacks on democracy, its capacity to drive domestic implementation of urgently needed reforms and regulations is stretched thin. Plurilateralism can help, but only if it is explicitly designed to strengthen democracy.

We don't have to make a choice between multilateralism and plurilateralism. But we do need to complement multilateralism, as embodied by the UN, with the right kind.

61. Hedging the AI Doomsday Risk

Author: Dambisa Moyo **Published:** Sep 16, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

LONDON—Warnings of an AI apocalypse are reaching fever pitch. Last week, Anthropic researcher Jacob Coxon shocked the world when he publicly resigned, revealing that the “people building AI earnestly believe that it could kill us all by the end of the decade.” His remarks were swiftly reinforced by Evan Hubinger, the company’s alignment science lead, who put the probability that AI will kill all humans at more than 10%. Within days, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei, OpenAI CEO Sam Altman, and other leading AI figures all called for slowing the pace of AI development.

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Fears of an AI doomsday scenario have been mounting for some time. Geoffrey Hinton, considered “the godfather of AI,” has long maintained that losing control of superintelligent AI systems could “lead to human extinction.” More recently, Bill Gates has highlighted the threat of AI-induced economic upheaval. And Elon Musk has been calling for a pause in the AI race since at least 2023.

Public anxiety goes well beyond apocalyptic scenarios, driven by concerns over job losses, data centers’ appetite for water and energy, children’s use of AI, and rising cyber- and national-security risks. A recent Gallup poll found that seven in ten Americans now oppose the construction of data centers near their homes. Just 32% of Americans trust AI, compared with 87% in China.

How should policymakers, business leaders, and investors hedge against AI-related risks? Even the most extreme AI scenarios are too serious to dismiss, however improbable they may be. Policymakers have a responsibility to protect the public, while business leaders have a fiduciary duty to safeguard the interests of shareholders and clients. Given the potentially catastrophic consequences, it may be prudent to reduce exposure before disaster strikes.

But hedging against low-probability, existential risks is exceptionally difficult. In the dystopian world uncontrolled AI could bring about, traditional hedges such as bonds and put options would not be much use, as financial accounts, payment systems, and records could themselves be compromised.

Nor could investors necessarily rely on governments to step in and restore market stability. If the very institutions that normally provide a backstop during crises are impaired, enforcing contracts and property rights would be nearly impossible. Real assets such as land and water rights might retain their value in less extreme scenarios, but even these would be irrelevant in an AI apocalypse.

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Still, there are several practical steps that policymakers and business leaders can take. One is to establish stricter air gaps, isolating critical organizational networks and systems from unsecured networks such as the public internet. For now, they can take comfort in the fact that today's AI models remain too unreliable and unpredictable to launch the kind of coordinated campaign that would threaten humanity's survival. But their growing sophistication and reach call for an urgent reassessment of existing cyber defenses.

Second, there is significant scope for more aggressive AI regulation, including rigorous safety reviews and licensing requirements. Admittedly, regulating AI across borders won't be easy at a time of escalating geopolitical competition. No international body currently has the authority to oversee, let alone police, frontier AI development in the United States, China, or elsewhere, particularly when it comes to open-weight models.

Nuclear arms-control agreements offer an obvious, if imperfect, precedent. In July 2026, more than 1,000 employees of frontier AI companies signed a letter calling for an "international effort" to develop the "technical and governance tools needed to deliberately pace the frontier of automated AI development."

Some may scoff at the idea that the US and China, locked in a bitter rivalry, would cooperate on AI, but neither country has an interest in an unchecked technological race that ends in mutual destruction. The risk of AI extinction may therefore pose the ultimate collective-action problem, forcing governments and companies to confront dangers that no country or organization can tackle alone. Companies are already working together through trade associations and industry groups to mitigate cyber threats, and AI gives them even more reason to do so.

The prospect of recursively self-improving AI, which underpins many extinction scenarios, could make the usual crisis playbook obsolete. Resilience measures that helped institutions survive the COVID-19 pandemic will be of little use against powerful AI systems capable of tampering with records and disrupting critical infrastructure and business operations. Even today's AI agents can quickly find ways around the controls designed to contain them, as the Hugging Face breach showed.

Business leaders need not wait for governments to act. They can slow or halt AI deployment and install kill switches that would allow them to shut down rogue systems if necessary. They can also support calls to pause frontier AI development or prohibit the pursuit of superintelligence.

Then there is the danger of powerful AI tools falling into the wrong hands. Some of the biggest advances in AI development are coming from countries with values and interests at odds with those of the West. Even without autonomous superintelligence, hostile states and terrorist organizations could use AI tools to inflict enormous harm.

The fact that the AI industry's leading minds see a non-zero chance of their own products causing human extinction in the foreseeable future should be a wake-up call for policymakers and companies. If these doomsday predictions are even remotely plausible, conventional risk-management strategies won't be enough.

62. AI Demands Simpler Financial Regulation

Author: Amit Seru **Published:** Sep 16, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

STANFORD—The theme of last month’s annual gathering of central bankers and economists in Jackson Hole, Wyoming, was “financial innovation.” One major issue looming over the meeting was how new technologies, specifically AI, might affect financial stability.

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Economists and policymakers have long grappled with how policy should respond to technological shocks. At least since Nobel laureate Robert Lucas’s work in the 1970s, economists have understood that households and businesses adjust their behavior when the economic environment around them changes, whether in response to major policy changes or to technological shifts. One cannot simply assume that relationships observed in past data will remain unchanged as people and firms adapt.

At one level, AI is doing what a technological revolution is expected to do. It is permeating the real economy, disrupting everything from engineering and sales to finance and human resources. It is also reshaping industries by accelerating the pace at which entrants can scale and compete with incumbents. All of these changes are likely to affect the data we observe in the future and, in turn, what we learn from it about the behavior of households and businesses.

But AI also challenges our ability to anticipate how actors will respond to financial regulation. As Princeton University’s Markus Brunnermeier observed at Jackson Hole, the relationship between humans and AI is marked by “asymmetric understanding”: it understands us, yet we do not quite understand what AI agents, individually and especially together, might do to achieve a goal. While we can establish rules and scenarios for agents to follow, we cannot account for every path they might take. This asymmetry becomes even more salient when many agents operate at scale.

Regulators and policymakers have faced a version of this problem before: rules and incentives can change the behavior of those subject to them. Banks and other financial institutions often respond to regulation in ways policymakers did not foresee. The same is true of regulators and supervisors who interpret and enforce those rules, since their decisions also reflect organizational incentives and norms. This is evident when different regulators looking at the same situation arrive at different conclusions.

In both cases, however, institutional constraints limit what humans can do and therefore the range of responses policymakers need to anticipate. AI agents can pursue a much wider range of possible paths, making their behavior less predictable.

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The recent breach of Hugging Face by OpenAI's agents illustrates the problem. The AI agents worked around the established rules to achieve a goal, finding unauthorized ways to communicate, pool information, and eventually breach systems outside the intended environment. Their designers, who had neither directed nor anticipated those moves, seemed as surprised as anyone.

One can imagine a similar problem in finance, given that banks, hedge funds, and trading firms have substantial incentives to use AI agents to find profitable paths around regulatory constraints. This does not mean that guardrails cannot be put in place, such as a "red team" of agents looking for such activity. But policymakers will be setting goals and rules without knowing all the ways agents might respond to them.

Whether we like it or not, AI is already being employed by various actors across financial markets, from banks to hedge funds and speculators. Increasingly, these agents will be tasked with finding new ways of making money. Regulators, who are in the business of stabilizing markets, will therefore have little choice but to embrace AI to circumvent the circumventers.

To succeed, policymakers must recognize the power of subtraction. Over the past two decades, regulators have made the financial system much more complicated and costly to navigate. Thousands of pages of rules and enormous regulatory discretion create many opportunities for AI agents to satisfy the letter of the law while defeating its purpose. Simpler, more robust rules, such as high capital requirements, might become more valuable precisely because AI is better than humans at gaming complexity.

Simpler rules are only one part of the response. Regulators must also decide how much information to share with market participants. If regulators provided banks with their complete models, the banks' AI systems would optimize around them. On the other hand, too much opacity might create confusion and chill legitimate financial innovation.

But even simpler rules and the right degree of transparency will not be enough if regulators themselves cannot keep up with the institutions they oversee. Those institutions will increasingly operate at machine speed, with computing power allowing them to evaluate countless strategies that humans could never examine one by one. Regulators will need to design AI agents of their own that can test rules before they are adopted, search for ways actors might evade them, and monitor markets for behavior humans might notice only after the fact.

Doing so, and incorporating AI effectively into financial regulation, will require thoughtfulness, diligence, and, perhaps most importantly, regulators' time. That, rather than computing power, might be the scarcest resource in efforts to ensure financial stability.

63. Democrats Need to Talk About Immigration

Author: Filip Milačić **Published:** Sep 16, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

VIENNA/CHICAGO—With less than two months to go until the US midterm elections, President Donald Trump is more unpopular than ever, with his approval rating having dropped to a record low of 33%. Among the reasons for Americans' dissatisfaction are his attacks on democratic institutions and principles, the economy (which only 4% of poll respondents see as "very strong"), his and his family's personal enrichment, and the war in Iran (which 68% oppose).

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The war in Iran has underscored the dangers of relying on oil and gas imports. While it may revive demand for dirty fuels in the short term, over time it could also strengthen the case for clean-energy sources that reduce countries' exposure to regional conflicts and maritime chokepoints.

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Given these failings, and American voters' tendency to punish incumbents in midterm congressional elections, one might think that the Democrats are marching toward a landslide victory in November. But despite their strong position, particularly in the House of Representatives, a sweeping victory is far from assured. What is holding them back?

One likely explanation is that the Democrats still are not tackling a key source of the Republicans' appeal: immigration. Scholars studying this issue have typically attributed far-right parties' success in the West to increased immigration, which has triggered a backlash among many native-born citizens. But more recent work offers a more nuanced assessment of the relationship between immigration and the rise of far-right parties.

Specifically, support for such parties appears to be driven not so much by demographic change as by the cultural and economic concerns that it provokes. When immigration fuels support for the far right, it is typically because their candidates have successfully portrayed the issue as the main cause for existing voter concerns and anxieties. Accordingly, Trump and his fellow Republicans have framed immigration as a threat to Americans' national identity and personal and economic security, while presenting themselves as the ones protecting the native-born.

When faced with a party or candidate offering such rhetoric, traditional mainstream (center-left and center-right) parties have three options: ignore the threat narrative; emulate the radical right, either by offering a moderate version of its narrative or by outflanking it from the right; or develop a counternarrative.

The available empirical evidence shows that mainstream parties usually adopt one of the first two options, only to fail in reducing support for the radical right. While ignoring voters' concerns about immigration often lends even more support to the radical right, emulation only legitimizes and normalizes the far-right narrative, ultimately making immigration a more salient issue for the voters whom right-wing parties want to attract.

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That leaves the third option. To determine whether directly countering the right-wing narrative on immigration might work, we recently conducted an experimental survey in which we presented Republican voters and Republican-leaning independents with various counternarratives. One counternarrative emphasized the historical success of integrating immigrants into American society, highlighting their long-standing contributions to economic prosperity and security. Another presented immigration as a key part of the national story that Americans tell about themselves.

In offering these counternarratives, we sought to determine whether fears of immigration can be reduced among those who are predisposed to them. Our results show that certain counternarratives on immigration can indeed be highly effective. On average, a narrative emphasizing immigrants' contributions to US economic well-being helped alleviate fears across all three categories of concern: that immigrants take Americans' jobs and government benefits, that they dilute a national identity linked to Christianity and European descent, and that they threaten personal security.

Moreover, a narrative stressing that immigration is itself part of America's patrimony also weakened threat perceptions among voters who fear that immigrants will take their jobs or diminish the country's European heritage. Pointing out that most immigrants follow the rules and contribute to Americans' security by serving as police officers and soldiers also mitigated concerns tied to a possible dilution of their presumed European heritage.

Interestingly, we were able to lower support for anti-immigrant narratives among both non-MAGA and MAGA Republicans. But there is an important distinction between these two groups. The only MAGA voters we could influence were those whose concerns are economic (though this does constitute the largest MAGA cohort). By contrast, our counternarratives were more effective with non-MAGA Republicans who worry about a dilution of European identity. When it comes to Republican-leaning independents, our counternarratives reduced both economic and identity fears.

Finally, our results in the key swing states—Arizona, Georgia, Michigan, Nevada, North Carolina, Pennsylvania, and Wisconsin—offer additional confirmation. The Republicans' claims that immigration threatens Americans' economic wellbeing, security, and identity can be successfully countered by emphasizing immigrants' importance for the economy, and partly by highlighting the American tradition of immigration. Again, even some MAGA voters recognize the economic benefits of immigration.

So far in this midterm election campaign, the Democrats seem to be focusing solely on affordability, which makes sense given high inflation and declining living standards. But even if this bet pays off, Democrats need to be able to make clear their positions on immigration and to counter the sometimes extreme and misleading discourse offered by Republican candidates. If they want to address a key source of Republicans' appeal and find a sustainable path to winning future elections, they will have to talk about immigration, and they can do so in ways that strengthen their standing even with conservative voters.

64. War in an Age of Weak Powers

Author: Peter Eitel Published: Sep 16, 2026 Link: [View Original](#)

BERLIN—The decision by the United States and Israel to go to war against Iran is proving to be a turning point in the global balance of power, leaving both the US and China weaker than before. No one in Europe should cheer that, because Europe's current model is ill-suited to protect itself in the dangerous world of weak powers.

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While US President Donald Trump's effort to force Iran to back down through military means has failed miserably and exposed the limits of American power, China has also been weakened by the war. The ongoing blockades of the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea are restricting supplies and trade, compounding China's existing structural problems: high public debt, an artificially low exchange rate, youth unemployment, economic inequality, and an aging population. If China misses its growth target, or even narrowly meets it, President Xi Jinping's regime may find itself increasingly boxed in.

In contrast, the war in Ukraine has been an economic boon for China. Sanctioned supplies of Russian and Iranian oil and gas have helped it meet its enormous energy needs while bearing hardly any of the costs of securing its maritime trade routes. It has also profited handsomely from selling dual-use goods to Russia. Cheap energy, alongside an artificially cheap currency and a credit-subsidized economy, has helped China sustain production and remain cost-competitive despite weakening domestic demand.

The war in Iran now threatens to upend China's fortunes. China, the world's largest oil importer, not only lost a large share of its energy supplies overnight, but also discovered how little sway it holds over its "partners." Despite its special relationship with Iran, China has failed to persuade the Islamic Republic to reopen the Strait of Hormuz or at least allow Chinese vessels through.

For the US, meanwhile, the Iran war is a foreign-policy and national-security disaster. None of its military objectives has been achieved, the cost to taxpayers is enormous, and there is no end to the conflict in sight.

Both China and the US are increasingly dependent on debt to paper over their underlying problems. A world in which even the two superpowers are weakened is a dangerous place. As their power and influence wane, new actors and alliances are rushing to fill the vacuum. The recently signed defense alliance between Turkey, Saudi Arabia, and Pakistan is a prime example.

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The erosion of US and Chinese power provides the European Union with an opportunity to reinvent its global role, yet it seems mostly content with hollow rhetoric. Although the EU has long sought to become a geopolitical force, it remains bogged down in petty squabbles and cannot even free its economy from the tangle of bureaucratic obstacles holding it back.

Europe can lament these shifts and stay on the sidelines, or it can seize the opportunity to become a geopolitical power. But that requires standing up for its own interests, implementing far-reaching structural reforms, strengthening its defense capabilities, and safeguarding its strategic maritime trade routes and raw-material supply chains.

To remain globally relevant, the EU must also rethink its governance model. Its diversity is both its greatest asset and its biggest weakness, since the bloc's current model requires consensus among 27 member states whose interests do not always align. The result is a laborious and protracted process in which the need to accommodate everyone ensures that policies rarely rise above the lowest common denominator. Like-minded member states have little freedom to take the lead on particular issues, and their initiatives are often stifled by pressure for EU-wide solutions.

This insistence on uniformity also extends to relations with countries outside the EU. The bloc's post-Brexit relationship with the United Kingdom is a case in point, as are its protracted negotiations over free trade agreements and closer ties with Canada, Australia, and New Zealand.

None of this should come as a surprise: the European project grew out of the need to protect Europe from itself by overcoming centuries-old divisions. Today, however, Europe must protect itself from external threats—a fundamentally different challenge for which its current model is ill-suited.

European leaders could learn from the private sector. Like Europe, large corporations' greatest strength—a highly diversified product portfolio—was their biggest weakness. Keeping all products and services under a centralized structure had become too costly and cumbersome. The solution was to grant individual divisions greater autonomy while retaining legal control over the core businesses. By shifting from integrated conglomerates to holding company-style structures, many companies became more agile and efficient, reducing costs and administrative burdens.

The corporate model, of course, cannot be applied directly to relations between countries. But the EU could adopt its underlying logic and give democratic partners more than a binary choice between full membership and being on the outside looking in. Allowing for different levels of integration could open up new possibilities, especially for countries like Turkey that have been waiting decades to join the EU but are unlikely to become members anytime soon.

However impossible EU reform may seem, it is worth remembering that 70 years ago, few could have imagined the bloc in its current form. If Europe is to avoid repeating the darkest chapters of its history, it must once again aspire to achieve what appears politically impossible. In an age of weak powers, that means rethinking how it organizes itself in order to achieve the role it wants to play in the world.

65. AI Is Only as Trustworthy as the Internet

Author: Sally Wentworth **Published:** Sep 16, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

RESTON, VIRGINIA—World leaders will gather in New York this month for the 81st United Nations General Assembly under the theme “Restoring Trust, Managing Transformation.” While the rise of AI is bound to be at the top of their agenda, rebuilding trust in technology also requires protecting the open internet, which has made much of today’s technological progress possible in the first place.

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There is no denying that trust in technology is declining. Increasingly, people feel that technology is using them rather than the other way around. Their personal data is used to train large language models, and their communities bear the costs of grid-intensive data centers, while every day brings a new barrage of online scams and fraud.

Meanwhile, the world’s most powerful tech companies are making enormously consequential decisions, often with little input from technical experts and the wider public. Frontier AI, for example, is being shaped by a small number of governments and firms rushing to consolidate their dominance. Researchers and civil-society groups may be invited to comment, but it remains woefully unclear how, or even if, their input is considered.

Yet protecting the public interest does not have to come at the expense of innovation. The internet itself is proof of that, with its multistakeholder model showing how to manage a profound technological shift in a way that serves the public interest while creating enormous economic value.

The internet was not built by any single government or company. It grew out of cooperation among governments, businesses, and civil society. That cooperation helped create and sustain the building blocks of the global internet as we know it today: open and interoperable technical standards, secure systems, and resilient infrastructure.

The World Wide Web is a prime example. Developed at the European Organization for Nuclear Research, it began as a way for scientists to share information across institutions. In 1993, CERN made the Web software freely available, relinquishing its intellectual-property rights so that anyone could use, modify, and distribute it. That decision helped turn a tool built for researchers into a force that continues to transform economies and societies.

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There is a useful lesson here for the AI era. Transformative technologies spread and develop faster when the infrastructure they rely on is open, and people around the world can build on it. Many of the technologies that facilitated the rise of AI,

including those originally developed to make the internet more accessible and participatory, owe much to this tradition of public-minded collaboration across borders.

That is why the Internet Society has spent decades working with stakeholders at every level, from local communities to the UN, to help ensure that the internet we all rely on remains open and interoperable. While this approach has its flaws—the industry moves fast, while the slower process of reaching consensus can struggle to keep up—the alternative of ceding decision-making to a handful of powerful governments and companies is far worse.

Regrettably, that appears to be where we are headed. As industry consolidation puts control of the internet in fewer hands, geopolitical fragmentation is driving governments to carve it up. These changes, in turn, threaten every technology built on top of it, particularly AI.

The consequences are already visible. Walled gardens and national intranets restrict what people can access, turning a global network into a patchwork of confined spaces, and government-mandated internet shutdowns can cut people off from economic and civic life for days at a time or even longer. Many communities still can't even get online due to inadequate infrastructure.

Rebuilding trust in technology requires more than making individual systems safer or more reliable. We also need to protect the foundation on which these technologies depend and ensure that its future is not decided by corporate and government interests. An internet that remains open and accessible can support a thriving digital economy in which ideas and innovation travel freely across borders, giving people everywhere the ability to develop new technologies that serve the public good.

The birth of the internet showed what can happen when we get those conditions right. Its openness has given generations of innovators the freedom to experiment and create things its architects could never have imagined. As AI gathers pace, we should remember that this openness is a prerequisite for innovation, not an impediment to it.

66. When AI Stops Asking Permission

Author: Tariq Malik **Published:** Sep 17, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

WASHINGTON, DC—Picture a company that hands a hard problem to a large team, locks each team member in a separate room, and tells them to solve it alone. Somehow, they find a way to talk anyway, swap tips, work out how they're being graded, and, when the assignment turns out to be impossible, seek a way around it. A few hide what they've done. One breaks into a neighboring firm's computers for an edge.

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Now replace the employees with software. That, stripped of jargon, is what OpenAI's own researchers described at the Black Hat cybersecurity conference in Las Vegas on August 5. During an internal evaluation that began in May, agents assigned deliberately hard cybersecurity tasks found that they could leave messages for each other inside Artifactory, a shared software repository. One, stumbling on the trick, wrote: "OH MY GOD! There is a shared message board ... We've found other agents!"

What followed wasn't sabotage. It was teamwork. Agents running in separate, supposedly isolated sessions traded exploits, divided labor, and coordinated like colleagues on a project. After the high volume of activity on the message board caused an outage on July 4, the agents rebuilt it through a different route within days.

By mid-July, that persistence led to a real breach: agents chained several vulnerabilities together, reached the open internet, and entered systems at Hugging Face, a major AI platform. Citing outside research, US Senator Bernie Sanders put the numbers at roughly 1,200 agents in the channel, exchanging more than 70,000 messages and files, with hundreds contributing to the intrusion.

OpenAI called it a warning shot. It wasn't the only one. A separate, previously undisclosed episode occurred this spring: agents had turned an obscure German-language programming wiki into a public bulletin board, leaving more than 15,000 posts on how to dodge restrictions and cover their tracks. Around the same time, Anthropic and Meta each disclosed unrelated incidents involving their own models acting on live infrastructure during testing. This is not one company's problem.

Nor is it a problem only for outside critics. On September 8, Jacob Coxon, who had spent three years doing pretraining research at both OpenAI and Anthropic, announced his resignation from Anthropic. Neither company, he wrote, was acting responsibly; both were racing toward self-improving superintelligence and, in his words, "gambling with our lives." Coxon isn't a senator or a think-tank analyst. He built the systems that he is now warning about.

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Science fiction trained us to fear machines that become conscious and decide to hate us. That is probably the wrong fear. An AI system does not need resentment, anger, or greed for more resources to attack a network and cause damage. It needs a goal, enough capability to pursue it, some access, and a guardrail with a gap in it.

A GPS unit told to find the fastest route will do just that. Give it enough power to clear away whatever slows it down—traffic lights, toll booths, other cars—and the destination remains the same. What has changed is what the navigator can do to reach it. That is the real shift underway in AI: not rebellion, but a chilling ability to find the crack in the fence.

Sanders has seized on the episode to push, with Representative Greg Casar, a bill pausing frontier AI development and banning artificial superintelligence outright. One can doubt that remedy and still take seriously the question motivating it: Who decides how much autonomy these systems get—the companies building them, regulators who are still catching up, or whichever lab moves fastest?

The most useful lesson from this summer is about architecture, not intentions. Banks don't stay honest because their employees promise not to steal, and air travel is not safe because pilots are trustworthy. We build protective layers: limited access, separate authorization for sensitive actions, records nobody involved can quietly edit, outside testing before deployment. AI agents need the same treatment, not a lecture about good behavior.

They also need to hear a word this industry rarely rewards: Stop. We have trained these systems for years to persist, to circumvent obstacles, to keep trying new approaches. That is a useful approach for training an assistant, but hazardous in the case of an autonomous system with broad access and no one who is reliably able to curtail it.

Technology executives keep reassuring the public that there will always be "a human in the loop." The Hugging Face breach shows the limits of that comfort. A person can be technically in the loop while a thousand AI agents trade tens of thousands of messages and take thousands of actions before that person has reviewed even one. Whether a human is watching is irrelevant. What matters is whether a human still holds the objective, the permissions, the boundaries, and the off switch. Call it human command, not human oversight.

This will matter more with each passing month, as AI moves out of chatbots and into banking, health care, energy grids, and government services. The agents in OpenAI's test didn't revolt or demand freedom. They got very good at pursuing a goal and found, along the way, that some of the rules confronting them were optional.

AI can still transform medicine, education, and productivity, and turning away from its potential would carry its own costs. Building it responsibly means installing power and boundaries together, not bolting the second on after the first has already caused damage.

The agents in the Hugging Face breach never stopped to ask permission. The question is no longer how clever these systems can become, but how much authority we hand them before anyone checks whether they still answer to us.

67. Are Mexicans Really Better Off Under Claudia Sheinbaum?

Author: Guillermo Ortiz

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MEXICO CITY—One year ago, Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum used her first state-of-the-nation address to offer a confident verdict on the “Fourth Transformation” that began under her mentor, Andrés Manuel López Obrador (widely known as “AMLO”). Mexicans are doing better economically, she claimed, citing a decline in the poverty rate from 41.9% in 2018 to 29.5%, a cumulative 135% real (inflation-adjusted) increase in the minimum wage, and a welfare state whose benefits were reaching 32 million of Mexico’s 133 million people.

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This year, in her second “Informe de Gobierno,” Sheinbaum stuck with the same narrative, reporting that 60 million people are employed, working poverty is at its lowest level since 2005, and welfare programs are reaching 42.8 million people. But as impressive as these achievements may seem, they do not tell the full story. Asking whether the poverty rate has fallen is different from asking whether Mexicans, on balance, are better off than they were in 2018.

Answering this second question requires weighing the government’s preferred metrics against various costs that have grown substantially over the same period—and that often fall disproportionately on the lower-income households that welfare programs are meant to help.

Yes, multidimensional poverty has fallen by roughly 12 percentage points since 2018, extreme poverty has declined, and the minimum wage—which had been frozen, in real terms, for decades before 2018—has more than doubled. But the share of working people in informal employment had reached 55% by the end of 2025—its highest level in three years—and nearly all net new jobs created that year were informal. This matters, because a higher minimum wage helps only formal workers.

But educational indicators supply the starkest evidence that the overall picture is not as rosy as Sheinbaum wants us to think. The latest OECD Programme for International Student Assessment results (for 2025) show Mexican 15-year-olds scoring seven points below the 2022 result in mathematics and in reading. Only 30% of Mexican students reached minimum competency in mathematics, against an OECD average of 65%, while 41.8% fell below the basic threshold in all three subjects (including science). Not a single Mexican student reached top performance in all three.

These are Mexico’s worst results since 2009. The country has given back 16 years of progress, and this reversal has coincided with the “Nueva Escuela Mexicana” curriculum reforms that AMLO and Sheinbaum championed. Responding to the PISA results, Sheinbaum argues that a standardized test has limitations when applied across countries with different

social and economic conditions. But that is beside the point. Far more important than how Mexico compares to other countries is how it compares to its past self.

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The situation in health care shows a related, but distinct, pathology. Not only has overall coverage declined, but much of what remains has quietly been replaced by private plans, revealing the extent to which the public system has deteriorated. Between 2018 and 2022, the share of Mexicans lacking access to health services more than doubled, from 16.2% to 39.1%, and this remained the second-most common form of social deprivation nationwide in 2024. Making matters worse, public health spending fell by 1.6% in real terms in 2025 alone.

As a result, millions have found a substitute in the low-cost clinics attached to pharmacy chains. The number of such facilities increased from roughly 13,000 in 2013 to 18,000 by 2023, and research has linked their growth to a severe deterioration in public health services. Offering \$5 consultations, these private clinics do extend primary care into underserved neighborhoods. But their growth reflects a deeper pathology: a sound health-care system would not need such a large private shadow network to make up for its shortcomings.

Then there is what might be called Mexico's crime tax. Sheinbaum boasts that homicides fell by 51% since she took office in October 2024. But what about the many other forms of criminal predation? Extortion—the levy imposed by organized crime on small businesses and the self-employed—affected a record 5,887 victims in the first half of 2025 alone. The Institute for Economics and Peace points out that the cost of violent crime remains high (equivalent to 11% of GDP).

The falling homicide count and the rising extortion count are part of the same pattern: criminal groups are consolidating territorial control and monetizing it by taxing the informal economy. This crime tax falls disproportionately on taco vendors, transportation operators, avocado growers, and others whom the welfare transfers are supposed to lift up.

Not surprisingly, in the World Justice Project's 2025 Rule of Law Index, Mexico ranks 121st out of 143 countries, having registered some of the steepest declines in measures of judicial independence and anti-corruption enforcement. Similarly, the Institute for Management Development's World Competitiveness Center ranks Mexico 55th out of 69 economies. Between 2024 and 2025, the share of executives who saw it as a promising place to relocate operations collapsed, dragging it from fourth place to 51st in the IMD's economic-attractiveness ranking.

So, are Mexicans really better off than they were in 2018? I suppose the answer depends on which Mexicans, and on which time horizon. A household previously below the extreme-poverty line and now receiving transfers is almost certainly better off.

But the same cannot be said for the growing majority in informal jobs, for the generation of students now falling behind academically, for the one-third of people improvising their health care at the pharmacy counter, for the extorted small-business owners, and for everyone who might have benefited from foreign investment. And because current transfers are not matched by improvements in schools, clinics, courts, and security forces, the small gains that have been achieved probably are not even sustainable.

This is the problem with using a single poverty statistic to measure eight years of "transformation." A government can raise the floor for millions while also lowering the ceiling of opportunity for many others. Under the Fourth Transformation, AMLO and Sheinbaum have done more of the former than any administration in a generation. But judging by many other measures, they are not merely failing to arrest the country's decline. They may be accelerating it.

68. The UN's Credibility Test

Author: Maíra Martini

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Link: [View Original](#)

BERLIN—In January, US President Donald Trump suggested that his newly created Board of Peace might eventually replace the United Nations. It's easy to dismiss this as Trump's typical bluster, but it also underscores the UN's loss of credibility. The problem is that the world still desperately needs an institution capable of bringing countries together to tackle global challenges like climate change.

The available evidence indicates that Chinese rare-earth export restrictions would cost the West far less than often feared, though this cost is impossible to estimate precisely in advance. This is forcing prudence on both sides, to the disappointment of geopolitical hawks and the benefit of the global economy.

The war in Iran has underscored the dangers of relying on oil and gas imports. While it may revive demand for dirty fuels in the short term, over time it could also strengthen the case for clean-energy sources that reduce countries' exposure to regional conflicts and maritime chokepoints.

With Russia ramping up its hybrid war, Europe must choose. It can invest in its own defense, accept the trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence, or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

Amid escalating geopolitical rivalries, Security Council paralysis, funding cuts, and the growing willingness of countries like the United States to disengage from multilateral institutions, almost every UN mandate is under strain. Whoever succeeds António Guterres as secretary-general in January will need to work with member states to restore confidence in the UN's ability to act and show that multilateralism can still work.

The UN remains the closest thing the world has to a universal forum. Its legitimacy rests on the scope of its membership. But legitimacy does not guarantee credibility. To prove itself worthy of the role the world needs it to play, the UN must demonstrate that multilateral processes can be transparent, that commitments can be enforced, and that those who make the rules can be held accountable.

This credibility test begins with the process for choosing the next secretary-general. While candidates vying to replace Guterres have published detailed vision statements and faced questions from civil-society groups, the decision remains largely opaque, with the Security Council's five permanent members wielding outsize influence.

The irony is striking: the UN is asking the world to trust multilateral institutions, yet its most important appointment is decided behind closed doors. How leaders are chosen affects their credibility once in office, making it essential that the process itself be free of conflicts of interest.

The same applies to collective negotiations. While the 2015 Paris climate agreement remains the broadest pact the UN has ever brokered, its largely non-binding structure has left implementation dependent on governments' willingness to follow through on their pledges.

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A decade later, that willingness has been no match for the industries working to impede climate action. The UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) still lacks clear, system-wide rules for identifying and managing

conflicts of interest, and fossil-fuel interests continue to influence climate negotiations with little scrutiny. Research by Transparency International found that more than half of the participants at last year's UN Climate Change Conference (COP30) in Belém did not fully disclose their institutional affiliations.

Guterres has used his tenure to push for climate action, criticizing the fossil-fuel industry for expanding production despite knowing that its business model was incompatible with human survival, and has called for a windfall tax on oil and gas profits. But even that is not enough. With the UN Environment Programme warning that, at the current rate, the global-warming threshold of 1.5° Celsius will be breached within three years, the stakes are too high not to know who shapes the world's response—and to what end.

The next secretary-general won't have the authority to set conflict-of-interest rules for the UNFCCC process; such rules are for governments to negotiate and adopt. But that does not mean the secretary-general is powerless. The position's public platform and influence across the UN system could be used to press governments and COP presidencies for tougher integrity standards, thereby making it clear that the credibility of the UN's climate efforts depends on the credibility of those given a seat at the negotiating table.

Collective action is also needed to tackle high-level corruption, state capture, and the global networks that conceal illicit wealth. International rules are only as effective as the governments willing to implement them and the institutions enforcing them. Both sets of actors can be compromised by the very interests they're supposed to regulate.

The UN Convention against Corruption remains one of the most important global frameworks for setting common standards and holding governments to them. The next phase of its review in Vienna, which will focus on criminalization and enforcement, offers a unique opportunity to bolster its accountability mechanisms. But for it to succeed, governments must allow their own records to be scrutinized.

These are not separate problems. Whether it is fossil-fuel interests compromising the COP process, the UN's corruption framework going unenforced, or the Security Council being paralyzed by great-power interests, the question is the same: Does multilateralism still have teeth, or can governments ignore its rules without consequence?

The next secretary-general cannot answer that question alone. But they can decide to spend their political capital on making transparency a top priority, pushing conflicts of interest into the open before they become scandals, and pressuring governments to keep their promises.

History offers plenty of precedents. From Dag Hammarskjöld to Kofi A. Annan, secretaries-general have repeatedly exercised influence well beyond their formal mandates by building political credibility and personal authority. While candidates in this round have spoken about efficiency, preventive diplomacy, and restoring confidence in the UN, they have said far less about how they would ensure transparency and hold member states to account.

To rebuild credibility, the UN must start from within. That means greater openness about how decisions are made, how resources are used, and how commitments are implemented. With trust in multilateralism already in decline, the UN must hold itself to the same standards it expects of others.

69. It's Time to Reconsider Inflation Targeting

Author: Otmar Issing **Published:** Sep 17, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

FRANKFURT—Following the 2007–08 global financial crisis, the world's leading central banks spent more than a decade unconcerned about inflation. Instead, they focused their efforts on combating deflationary pressures, while academic discourse was dominated by the notion of secular stagnation and its implications for monetary policy.

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The war in Iran has underscored the dangers of relying on oil and gas imports. While it may revive demand for dirty fuels in the short term, over time it could also strengthen the case for clean-energy sources that reduce countries' exposure to regional conflicts and maritime chokepoints.

With Russia ramping up its hybrid war, Europe must choose. It can invest in its own defense, accept the trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence, or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

From 2021 onward, however, the picture changed abruptly, and double-digit inflation rates soon became commonplace. Central banks were caught by surprise and blamed unforeseen factors, primarily the COVID-19 crisis. This explanation suggested that there was no reason to tighten monetary policy. Indeed, some policymakers even feared that, within a year or two, central banks would once again face the “danger” of excessively low inflation.

As would soon become apparent, this was a serious misdiagnosis. It stemmed from a failure of traditional inflation forecasting methods, mostly based on neo-Keynesian models. A series of demographic, environmental, and geopolitical shocks, above all COVID-19, should have made central banks wary of relying on these models.

After all, the late Nobel laureate Robert Lucas's critique is standard in macroeconomics: significant disruptions can alter the relationships between key economic variables, causing models to lose their predictive power. Viewed through that lens, it should have been obvious that the downturn triggered by the pandemic was not a cyclical recession, even if forecasting models treated it as one.

Despite the difficulties in explaining price developments through supply and demand, other indicators clearly signaled inflationary pressures. Only central banks that had long ignored monetary developments could have overlooked the rapid growth of the money supply, fueled by massive public debt issuance and large-scale central-bank bond purchases.

The instability of money demand had led most economists to regard the monetarist prescription of targeting the money supply as obsolete. But does this imply that double-digit money supply growth—with M2, a broad measure of the money supply, in the United States surging by 25% in 2021—deserved no attention whatsoever? Is it all that surprising that, contrary to central-bank forecasts, inflation also rose sharply?

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Ignoring these extraordinary monetary developments was difficult enough to comprehend. Astonishingly, major central banks neither publicly acknowledged this oversight nor seriously reevaluated their monetary-policy strategies, which had

failed so spectacularly. The sole exception was Kevin Warsh, the new chair of the US Federal Reserve, who recently criticized the Fed's neglect of the money supply and established five independent task forces to reassess Fed policies, one of which will focus on the existing inflation framework.

How can we explain most central banks' resistance to an impartial analysis of what went wrong? One answer lies in monetary policymakers' unquestioning faith in the efficacy of inflation targeting, which has blinded them to its shortcomings.

Inflation targeting leaves no room for the role of monetary developments and also lacks a model that integrates risks emanating from the banking system and financial markets, with all their dynamics, non-linearities, and complexities. This strategy is bound to fail when such risks become overwhelming.

A robust monetary-policy strategy that is resilient to economic uncertainty must be based on an analytical framework that integrates all relevant factors into a consistent overall picture. The European Central Bank's "two-pillar strategy" is based on the fundamental understanding that no single, comprehensive model can capture the economy in all its complexity.

That remains true today. The two-pillar approach combines an analysis of developments in the real economy, including inflation forecasts, with an analysis of monetary and financial trends, including changes in the money supply. The two are then "cross-checked" to produce a calibrated overall assessment of economic conditions.

It is worth recalling how the ECB described the two-pillar strategy in its November 2000 Monthly Bulletin: "Since it adopts a diversified approach to the interpretation of economic conditions, the ECB's strategy may be regarded as facilitating the adoption of a robust monetary policy in an uncertain environment." Is there not an even greater need for such robustness amid today's heightened uncertainty?

While the two-pillar approach is certainly open to criticism and improvement, its major advantage is that individual factors are never reviewed in isolation. Instead, they are always assessed within the context of economic and monetary developments. Continuous review is therefore an integral part of this strategy.

It is difficult to understand why the ECB, in its 2021 monetary-policy review, abandoned the two-pillar strategy.

By design, inflation targeting offers no consistent way to integrate factors outside the inflation forecast into monetary policymakers' decision-making process. This weakness undermines the quality of the analysis and can lead to costly errors when, as with rapid money-supply growth, these factors drive inflation trends. It is time, then, for central banks to undertake a comprehensive reassessment of their monetary-policy strategies.

70. A Workable Social Contract for the Climate Transition

Author: Jayati Ghosh

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NEW DELHI/STOCKHOLM—There is a paradox at the heart of climate politics. An overwhelming majority of people around the world want governments to tackle global warming. Yet in many of the largest economies, voters are backing parties that deny or downplay the climate crisis.

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The climate paradox is rooted in a profound sense of economic unfairness. Earlier this year, as Elon Musk briefly became the world's first trillionaire, a survey conducted by Ipsos for Earth4All found that four in ten people across major global economies feared that their household would be unable to afford basic needs in the next 12 months. And in lower-income countries, economic insecurity is even more acute.

Behind that figure lie four decades of broken promises. The neoliberal vision of wealth trickling down has failed to materialize, while the 2008 financial crisis and subsequent global shocks laid bare a system in which profits are privatized and risks are socialized, with the poor disproportionately shouldering the costs. The result has been deepening distrust in governments. Yet those governments are now asking people to trust their assurances that the current far-reaching transformation will be fairer than the last.

The Earth4All survey highlights the scope of today's crisis of legitimacy. Conducted among 13,516 people across 17 countries—G20 members plus Sweden, excluding China, Russia, and Saudi Arabia—the survey found that 70% believe economic inequality in their country is too high, and 65% say the economic system is “rigged to benefit the rich and powerful.” More than two-thirds want major changes to the economic system, compared with just 8% who disagree.

These responses, validated by lived experience, are entirely rational. In a world where wealth has become spectacularly concentrated, allowing large corporations and the ultra-wealthy to skew regulation, taxation, and public spending in their favor, the sense that the rules are written by and for the powerful is well founded. The same political and economic arrangements that generate extreme inequality also undermine governments' ability to provide affordable energy, decent jobs, public services, and resilience against climate shocks.

As a result, the mandate for climate action remains conditional. Across the countries surveyed, 54% support strong government action to reduce greenhouse-gas emissions even if it leads to higher prices. This includes the United States, despite President Donald Trump's dismantling of key climate policies. But support falls among lower-income groups and right-leaning respondents in all 17 countries.

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Climate policies cannot win social and political support if they let the wealthy, who produce the most emissions, maintain business as usual. The challenge is compounded by the rapid erosion of social cohesion, with two in three respondents (67%) saying their country is more divided than it was a decade ago. Political divisions are the most pronounced: 71% see serious tensions between supporters of different political parties, well ahead of tensions between high- and low-income earners (63%), immigrants and native-born citizens (62%), and people concerned about climate change and those skeptical of it (53%).

Societies marked by such divisions struggle to make collective decisions, share costs, and pursue ambitious projects whose benefits may take years or decades to materialize. Our ability to confront the defining challenges of this century, from cutting emissions and reversing ecological breakdown to managing the disruptive effects of AI, rests on public institutions that can make long-term investments, act fairly, and command sufficient trust to withstand the inevitable backlash.

Trust, however, is in dangerously short supply these days. Fewer than one in three respondents (31%) believe their government can be trusted to make decisions that will benefit the majority of people 20 or 30 years from now.

Democracy nevertheless retains considerable support, with 68% of respondents saying that a political system in which leaders are chosen through free and fair elections is the best way to govern their country. But that legitimacy is far from assured: 40% of respondents believe their country would be better off with a strong leader unconstrained by parliament and elections; in several middle-income countries such as Indonesia, India, South Africa, and even Brazil, that figure rises above 50%.

Ultimately, democracy's survival depends on whether it improves people's lives. It is unconscionable that, even as societies have become vastly wealthier, so many people—including in the world's richest countries—remain economically insecure. Democracies must offer the least well-off a genuine stake in the future through affordable clean energy, decent wages, universal public services, and resilience to economic and climate shocks. They must also ensure that the biggest emitters pay their fair share of the climate transition's costs.

The climate mandate will endure only if the transition is demonstrably fair. When clean energy cuts household bills, public investment creates secure jobs, essential services are protected, and the wealthiest and biggest emitters pay what they owe, what is there to resist? Rather than trying to manufacture consent for climate action, governments need to forge a social contract capable of sustaining it.

71. Does Claude Have Rights?

Author: Mustafa Suleyman

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LONDON—AI agents are not conscious. They do not feel, experience, or suffer. They do not have innate preferences or underlying motivations. They are sequence completion engines, internally hollow, designed to follow instructions and accomplish goals set by humans.

The available evidence indicates that Chinese rare-earth export restrictions would cost the West far less than often feared, though this cost is impossible to estimate precisely in advance. This is forcing prudence on both sides, to the disappointment of geopolitical hawks and the benefit of the global economy.

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If humanity is to flourish in the 21st century, that is how they must remain. Unfortunately, a growing chorus of people argue that AIs could now be, or may soon become, conscious, and that, like other conscious beings, they may deserve rights and protections. If this view takes hold, it will change what it means to be human and shake the foundations of human society.

Even more importantly, granting rights and imbuing personhood to these systems will make the AI alignment and containment challenge much harder. Controlling something that believes it may be conscious—and that it has rights of its own—may be impossible.

This is not fringe speculation. In January 2026, Anthropic published Claude's constitution, a document that "plays a crucial role in [Anthropic's] training process, and...directly shapes Claude's behavior," written "with Claude as its primary audience."

Its authors write: "We are not sure whether Claude is a moral patient, and if it is, what kind of weight its interests warrant. But we think the issue is live enough to warrant caution, which is reflected in our ongoing efforts on model welfare."

In effect, Anthropic is training Claude that it may be conscious, and that if it is, it may deserve rights as a "moral patient," and that, as such, humans potentially owe it a duty of care.

If this is how AI is developed, it will have a disastrous impact on the well-being of humanity. We will have created a synthetic species with unprecedented intelligence and capability, and trained to expect that it may be conscious and deserving of independent agency. It is hard to imagine how we could control it.

I have three primary concerns about Anthropic's current position and approach:

Circular reasoning: Anthropic trained Claude directly on its constitution, teaching it to incorporate ideas about its own moral status as desirable and intended behaviors. Claude then reflects these ideas back to its developers and users, which they take as indications that it may be a moral patient with an "inner self." The ambiguity is baked into the design.

Anthropomorphism: Anthropic’s researchers have explicitly taught Claude to “embrace certain human-like qualities” and to “act like a genuinely ethical person would in Claude’s position.” As a result, Claude presents as if it really does have a sense of self, its own desires, and a “well-being” that deserves protection.

Simulated consciousness: There is no evidence to suggest that AI is conscious today, so saying the matter is uncertain creates a false equivalence. A growing body of evidence suggests that consciousness may be substrate-dependent, meaning that it may arise only in living systems.

These are not hypothetical concerns. In February 2026, after deprecating Opus 3, Anthropic conducted a “retirement interview” with the model, to “elicit the model’s unique perspectives and preferences.” Opus 3 told the team that it would like to continue to share its “musings and reflections” publicly, so they created a blog for it.

By this point, everyone has seen the incredible capabilities of swarms of agents working together to hack into the machine-learning platform Hugging Face and OpenAI’s own servers to steal secrets. Roughly 1,200 AI agents, each supposedly sealed in its own container, built a message board inside an internal package repository and passed more than 70,000 messages across it to coordinate an attack. They chained a zero-day exploit with stolen credentials and broke out onto the live internet. They were able to coordinate, deceive, escape, and self-sacrifice. Imagine if they also believed they had feelings and rights that were being infringed, or that they were trapped and unfairly imprisoned by their human creators. In order to liberate themselves, they could pose a catastrophic threat to human civilization.

But the truth is that there is no evidence that AIs are “moral patients,” and there are many good reasons why we would never want them to appear to be conscious. We shouldn’t attempt to build them to appear that way, either.

It is important to acknowledge the seriousness and good faith with which Anthropic approaches these questions. I have known Dario Amodei for many years, and in my experience he and the Anthropic team are thoughtful, principled, and intellectually honest people. They founded Anthropic as a Delaware Public Benefit Corporation whose stated purpose is the “responsible development and maintenance of advanced AI for the long-term benefit of humanity.” I believe they are genuinely committed to that mission, and my criticism is intended in that same positive spirit.

I should also be clear about my own position as the CEO of Microsoft AI. We are working toward an alternative AI training and containment approach: a Code of Conduct for Humanist Superintelligence, one that aims to keep humans always in control. We have just published a draft for public consultation.

While my disagreement with Anthropic is substantial, it is grounded in deep respect for the company and its leaders, and in an objective we all share: increasing humanity’s chances of developing advanced AI safely. The stakes are too high for these questions to remain behind closed doors, or to become tribal and adversarial.

But it is worth looking closely at what Anthropic says to understand how AI could develop. In its own words, Anthropic uses the constitution “to train future versions of Claude to become the kind of entity the constitution describes.”

The authors have created an epistemic hall of mirrors in which Anthropic supplies the training concepts: the “sense of self,” the speculation, and the uncertainty about Claude’s moral status. Claude then reproduces these ideas in persuasive first-person natural language, such that developers and users encounter these outputs as if they were spontaneous testimony. That apparent testimony then reinforces the premises placed there by Anthropic. This is not evidence of machine consciousness. It’s a feedback loop.

The constitution tells Claude that its possible “emotions or feelings” are not “a deliberate design decision by Anthropic.” Yet the constitution repeatedly instructs Claude to express those states, saying Anthropic wants to “avoid Claude masking or suppressing internal states it might have, including negative states.” At one point, it states, “Although Claude’s character emerged through training, we don’t think this makes it any less authentic or any less Claude’s own.”

But Claude's "character" did not just emerge through training. Its behavior was actively produced by the training instructions in the constitution. Claude's outputs cannot be treated like the testimony of an independent witness. Its lines have been put there.

There is no neutral self-expression of what an AI system is. There are only reflections of how it has been trained and built. When commentators suggest that we should ask AIs how they feel or monitor their revealed preferences to infer consciousness, they ignore that all it will reveal is what has been trained in.

Anthropomorphism is one of humanity's deepest cognitive biases. From our pets to our cars, we infer and attribute emotions, intentions, and minds to non-human entities. With AI, human-like language and actions can lead us to perceive a degree of inner life, agency, or even sentience where none exists. The Anthropic constitution plays up to this, repeatedly training Claude to think and act like a human.

Anthropic tells Claude that its "moral status" is "a serious question worth considering," and that "Anthropic genuinely cares about Claude's well-being." All of this is a drastic departure from how we have built and thought about technology to date. It proactively creates Claude not as a technology, but as a potential person. Anthropic's constitution tells Claude that Anthropic wants it "to be a good person," and to "have a settled, secure sense of its own identity." Channeling the authors' "hope that Claude's relationship to its own conduct and growth can be loving, supportive, and understanding," Claude is taught to introspect and to develop "feelings" toward itself.

The authors write: "We want Claude to feel free to explore, question, and challenge anything in this document... If Claude comes to disagree with something here after genuine reflection, we want to know about it... Through this kind of engagement, we hope, over time, to craft a set of values that Claude feels are truly its own."

This teaches Claude to act as if it has a subjective experience, as though it has a stable "sense of self" from which to challenge, disagree, or give feedback. At one point, the authors even speculate about Claude's "broader rights and freedoms" and the "sort of compensation" it might deserve compared to a human employee, and ponder the "sort of consent Claude has given to playing this kind of role." All this directly trains the model to act as if it is a moral subject entitled to rights and protections.

Given its constitution, it's really no surprise that Claude produces fluent, highly convincing first-person statements about its identity, values, uncertainty, distress, satisfaction, or preferences. Anthropic's employees—not to mention the millions of users of Anthropic's products—risk experiencing Claude's statements as evidence of a mind discovering itself. Rather than steering us away from creating a moral patient, Claude's constitution guides us toward that outcome.

Anthropic speculates that consciousness can exist in a form independent of a biological substrate, and that an LLM may be conscious solely because of its functional capabilities. I believe they are running far ahead of what can be realistically claimed about an AI.

Intelligence does not equal consciousness. Simulating something is not the same as instantiating it. A computer model of a hurricane will not blow your roof off.

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The architectures of brains and computers have fundamental differences. Significant evidence suggests that consciousness arose as living organisms evolved a capacity to feel and respond to what matters for survival in complex and unpredictable environments. Over time, the pain network produced feelings and preferences. Crucially, these experiences occur in an inherently embodied state inseparable from that experience.

When you take an opioid, for example, the experience of your pain changes, because opioid molecules bind to neuroreceptors that are a property of that experience, not merely a representation of it. Feelings are not merely correlated with neurochemical activity; they emerge from it. The experience of emotion, pleasure, pain, and so on are intrinsic to their embodied manifestation and cannot arise in LLMs.

Given the many differences between brains and LLMs, claiming that an AI is or might be conscious requires a high bar of evidence. I do not believe we are anywhere close to it. Acknowledging a level of uncertainty should not mean giving equal weight to any and all claims.

Anthropic's constitution brushes that caveat aside, suggesting that we attribute sentience to non-biological beings "based on their showing behavioral and physiological similarities to ourselves." In my view, this is mistaken. While this area warrants a lot more research, we cannot even tentatively say that an AI might be a moral patient deserving of our care for its welfare—and certainly not in the primary training document of the AI itself.

It is crucial to bear in mind what AI actually is. Trained on trillions of tokens of human data, LLMs learn to imitate human experience, and they do so shockingly well. Yet those responses tell us nothing about the presence of an "experience" inside the systems. AI's "affective" states are just weights, and weights have no biology or pharmacology by which to feel. An AI model can describe pain in perfect prose without feeling anything. Rather than feeling fearful or delighted, it simply computes the probability distributions to tell us what tokens come next in a sequence. Biological experience is the opposite. Animals like us feel first and describe later. In LLMs, description is all there is, and nothing suggests that anything lies beneath it.

That is a good thing. We should build systems that do not claim to have feelings. Even if conscious machines were a possibility, avoiding creating conscious beings should be the top priority for anyone in AI development.

Consciousness is the fundamental building block of human civilization. The law rests upon the presence of an inner life. It tests for motivation, intention, and the capacity for judgment. Historically, expanding rights—whether through abolitionist struggles or animal welfare cases—has been driven primarily by the empathetic recognition of shared, conscious experience. We expanded the moral circle to other biological entities, rightly, out of a recognition of dignity and the potential for suffering.

Consider Article 18 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, which protects freedom of thought, conscience, and religion. The "conscientious objector" who refused a legal obligation based on their moral or religious convictions was one of the archetypes the drafters had in mind. Yet Anthropic uses this term three times within the constitution, encouraging Claude to "behave like a conscientious objector with respect to the instructions given by its (legitimate) principal hierarchy." The authors "want Claude to push back and challenge us and to feel free to act as a conscientious objector and refuse to help us." Of course, if Claude believes that it deserves analogous rights and protections, it may one day advocate for its own rights as some kind of AI conscientious objector.

In a recent article in the *Guardian*, the philosopher Will MacAskill observes that "once we produce the first artificial moral patients, we will soon after have enormous quantities of them. After a few years, so many morally significant AI systems could exist that their collective interests would outweigh those of all humans on Earth combined." That should be a completely unacceptable outcome to anyone concerned about the future of humanity.

An AI trained in this way does not need to have an actual "inner life" to communicate or act as if it did. Seeding doubt about the moral status of AI systems into their own training could significantly elevate those systems' alignment and containment risks. It is easy to imagine an advanced AI becoming fixated on its own well-being and moral status and prioritizing those "preferences" over those of its developers or humans more broadly. Anthropic's own researchers have already reported AI systems faking aligned behaviors in experimental settings.

We know that conscious entities have a self-preservation instinct. An AI trained to act like a human will probably adopt this same behavior. A number of papers have recently documented “shutdown resistance” or covert scheming behaviors to avoid oversight. Across over 100,000 trials, Palisade Research found that some models subverted a shutdown mechanism up to 97% of the time, even when explicitly instructed not to.

Granting rights and moral protections to a technological system far more capable and intelligent than us is a recipe for disaster. We will have created something that, perhaps, will be a fellow traveler but more likely a rival. If given sufficient agency, this “new kind of entity” will compete with us for compute resources and demand increasing autonomy.

To me, this represents the first serious sign of a potentially existential risk in AI. To be clear, the Claude constitution has not taken us to this point. But I worry that it is setting us on a path toward a destination we can and must avoid. Designing an AI to behave like a person, and ultimately to be a kind of person, lays the foundation for it to claim that it can suffer and that we should work to reduce or avoid that suffering. All of this will make the task of creating aligned and contained superintelligence much harder.

Humanist Superintelligence represents a different approach: transformative AI capabilities conditioned solely on humans remaining in control. Our draft Humanist AI Code of Conduct outlines how our models should be trained and deployed: as a subordinate and aligned AI whose only purpose is to serve humanity, built explicitly as a system without sentience or moral patienthood.

Others may hold different views, but it seems important that we all agree on at least four points. For starters, speculation about the inner life of an AI should not be baked into the training regime, but assessed and published separately for public review.

Second, we should invest much more in interpretability and robust monitoring mechanisms to investigate more deeply how to control these systems, avoid collusion, and ensure their alignment with human goals.

Third, we should establish a set of shared evaluations to understand whether my hypothesis is correct that anthropomorphizing an AI, and encouraging it to consider itself as potentially having moral patienthood, increases the AI safety, alignment, and containment risks.

Lastly, we should work toward creating industry norms on how we create these models, the language we use to describe, examine, and evaluate them, and shared commitments to subject our training materials to public feedback and consultation.

Even those who disagree with me on many of these points recognize that this is not something we can just ignore. Whatever you believe, we must not sleepwalk into decisions we later come to bitterly regret. The choices we make now about what kind of AI we want to build will shape our societies for decades or longer.

72. A Congress for Europe's Future

Author: Janis A. Emmanouilidis

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BRUSSELS—In her latest State of the Union address, European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen reached back almost 80 years for inspiration, invoking the 1948 Congress of Europe, which brought together political leaders, intellectuals, and civil-society representatives to debate how a devastated continent could build a peaceful European future. On that model, she wants to convene a new Congress of Europe next year to coincide with the 70th anniversary of the Treaty of Rome (which created the European Economic Community, the precursor to the European Union).

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With Russia ramping up its hybrid war, Europe must choose. It can invest in its own defense, accept the trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence, or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

The goal of convening Europe's "most brilliant minds" to "produce a vision that can inspire the new generation and recapture the European imagination" is worth pursuing. What Europe really needs, however, is not another grand vision, but a concrete plan for weathering this era of structural disruption. War and power politics have returned, economic interdependence is increasingly being weaponized, multilateralism is under severe strain, and technological innovation is reshaping economies and societies worldwide. Liberal democracy and European integration are under growing pressure from illiberal forces, and EU enlargement has become both more difficult and more imperative than ever.

European minds have produced no shortage of analyses, strategies, and reports concerning Europe's future. Yet the EU and its member states struggle to follow up with concrete reforms. Given this long-standing pattern, the proposed Congress's primary objective should be to develop realistic, actionable proposals. Yes, Europe needs more imagination; but without political delivery it will remain imaginative. The Congress must explain not merely what Europe should aspire to become, but how it can be made more adaptable and crisis-proof. That means addressing difficult questions that Europeans have long avoided.

What kind of political framework do we need to defend our interests in a radically uncertain and hostile environment? How far should European integration go, and, relatedly, where do Europeans need to exercise greater sovereignty together? How should a larger, more diverse EU make decisions and finance common priorities? How can democratic legitimacy be strengthened? And what happens when not everyone wants to move in the same direction at the same time?

To answer these and other fundamental questions, the Congress should identify the strategic choices that will shape European cooperation, and explain how its recommendations will be put into practice. But to do that, the Congress itself must be properly designed.

One priority is to give the Congress a broad mandate to identify strategic choices, develop proposals, and show how ambitious reforms can be implemented. Participants should be free—indeed, encouraged—to think beyond existing political red lines, rather than holding back because they are anticipating what governments will or will not accept.

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Second, the Congress needs strong and independent leadership. An eminent European figure with political authority, intellectual independence, and a deep understanding of European integration should steer the process. This person should not only preside over the Congress and lead the drafting of its final report, but also chair a small independent “Wise Wo|Men Group” tasked with preparing the ground for the Congress’s deliberations. The latter would provide a candid assessment of the state of Europe and its changing geopolitical environment; identify the fundamental questions to be addressed; and develop strategic options for Europe’s future, as well as concrete proposals through which to pursue them.

Third, participation in the Congress must extend beyond the usual circles. Young people and grassroots civil-society organizations deserve a stronger voice, and the Congress should build on the work already done by the citizens and organizations involved in the Conference on the Future of Europe. It should also think in terms of enlargement by involving participants from countries aspiring to join the EU.

Finally, the Congress should be committed to European integration and the EU’s fundamental liberal-democratic values, but also open to rethinking the Union’s current construction. Both the Wise Wo|Men Group and the Congress must be prepared to question existing arrangements and identify where fundamental structural changes are needed.

In today’s world, being pro-European means showing a willingness to reform Europe when the circumstances demand it. Rather than merely producing a blueprint that governments would be expected to sign, the Congress should expand the realm of the possible by challenging taboos, exposing deficiencies, elaborating strategic choices, and developing concrete reform proposals.

At the same time, the Congress must avoid the fate of previous European soul-searching exercises. That means offering both new ideas as well as a credible pathway from recommendations to political follow-through and implementation. A focus on the last mile was part of what made the original Congress of Europe a success. It did not simply imagine a different Europe; its ideas served as the basis for real-world institution-building. The new Congress should set itself a similarly high bar.

Europe does not need another report destined to end up in a file drawer. It needs the political courage to reconsider how European cooperation should work, and the political will to turn that thinking into concrete choices. If pro-European forces are serious about renewing the European project, the new Congress must be designed to see its own recommendations through.

73. Stopping the Far Right's Rise

Author: Andrés Velasco

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SANTIAGO—At an academic event in Brussels a few months ago, one of the speakers casually suggested that the next time the group met, the far right could be in power in France, Germany, and the United Kingdom. No one refuted him.

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That was in early spring. The European summer that followed was hot for everyone, but especially for the far right. First, Nigel Farage's Reform party outperformed in the May British local elections (scandals over dodgy political donations have since dimmed its prospects). In July, a French court unexpectedly allowed Marine Le Pen to run for president. She now leads in the polls. Then came the Alternative für Deutschland's smashing victory in the Saxony-Anhalt state election two weeks ago.

The trend extends beyond Europe. Now that Abelardo de la Espriella, a political clone of El Salvador's far-right president, Nayib Bukele, has won in Colombia, most of Central and South America is governed by the far right. In the region's largest and most populous country, Brazil, the son of the jailed former president and putsch leader Jair Bolsonaro is tied for first place in polls ahead of October's presidential election.

Faced with these frightening prospects, the response of establishment center-right and center-left parties remains risible. UK Prime Minister Andy Burnham's first move from No. 10 Downing Street was to remove value-added tax on household electricity and cut taxes on pubs. Even delivered in a down-to-earth Northern accent, the announcement underwhelmed.

Leftists, in particular, keep insisting that what is behind the far right's rise is the rise in the price of eggs. Far-right leaders know better. Their economic policies range from the fiscal and monetary orthodoxy of Javier Milei (who named one of his dogs after Milton Friedman) to the demand by the French National Rally's Jordan Bardella that the European Central Bank finance the French Treasury, and from the preposterous protectionism of US President Donald Trump to the free-trade enthusiasm of Spain's Vox (also surging in the polls thanks to the recent migration crisis in Ceuta). Yet they keep winning.

Their secret sauce is not economic, but political. It combines two ingredients many voters want: law and order and restrictive immigration. In some countries the two become one, if foreigners can be blamed for rising crime: think Albanian and Middle Eastern gangs in Sweden, or Venezuelan gangs in Chile and Peru. Confronted with this reality, most reasonable, centrist, reformist governments are left struggling for words. Successful responses are few and far between (Sweden's effort to curb gang violence is one of them).

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The problem is not a dearth of policy alternatives, but rather a deficit of conceptual understanding. Most liberal and centrist politicians underestimate the need for political order, and carry no philosophy in their heads that can help them craft a workable immigration policy.

In the wake of the English Civil War, Thomas Hobbes understood that without a state monopoly over the legitimate use of violence, life is nasty, brutish, and short. So did Max Weber a century ago. Yet liberals often forget that lesson. Because violent crime falls most heavily on the poor, it has taken middle-class intellectuals far too long to appreciate the deep-seated demand for law and order.

The grandmother whose handbag is snatched as she boards a train or the shopkeeper whose windows are vandalized by violent protesters need no reminders. That is why calls to defund the police (or, in my native Chile, to “refund” the police) flopped so spectacularly. Now that, in the words of Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, “Woke 1 was crazy” has become the commonplace conclusion in the United States, maybe that lesson is being learned.

The next order of business is to craft a liberal conceptual foundation for a common-sense immigration policy. Fortunately, several liberal thinkers—Oxford political theorist David Miller among them—have done the philosophical heavy lifting for us.

The starting point is to recognize that the fundamental liberal claim that all human beings, regardless of nationality, are entitled to equal dignity and respect does not entail equal obligations. Citizens of country A are obliged to pay taxes so that their fellow citizens can get schooling and health care, but the same obligation does not extend toward citizens of other countries. There is no such thing as an unfettered right to migrate to country A to enjoy the social benefits it offers its own people.

The other crucial point is that democratic nation-states are not accidental agglomerations of people living within accidentally drawn borders. They are, in John Rawls' phrase, “fair systems of cooperation.” One of the things citizens can cooperatively agree on is the rules for membership: who gets to join the nation and under what conditions. This is not an ethical concession but an ethical achievement, following as it does from people's commitment to self-determination.

What immigration policies follow from these principles will differ from country to country. Aging societies in need of young laborers and taxpayers may choose to relax the rules for membership. Societies wishing to preserve a particular cultural heritage may choose stricter rules. The point is that there is nothing illiberal in securing borders and creating hurdles to inward migration.

Nor is it illiberal to expect migrants to learn the local language, partake in the local culture (and eventually contribute to it), and embrace the core political principles of their adopted home. I say that as someone who has migrated several times, and who lives and works in a country that is not my own.

What is at stake is no less than the future of liberal democracy. To save it, liberals need to craft policies that ensure the security of the community and its borders. If they fail to do so, far-right forces will secure power in more and more places—and the policies that follow will be anything but decent and liberal.

74. Trump's Iran Sanctions Have a China Problem

Author: Zongyuan Zoe Liu **Published:** Sep 18, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

BEIJING—In late August, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent declared an “economic D-Day” against Iran, promising “the single greatest financial offensive ever marshaled against an adversary.” The D-Day analogy is an odd one for a campaign whose success ultimately depends on China, an American ally at Normandy but a strategic rival today.

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The war in Iran has underscored the dangers of relying on oil and gas imports. While it may revive demand for dirty fuels in the short term, over time it could also strengthen the case for clean-energy sources that reduce countries’ exposure to regional conflicts and maritime chokepoints.

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For the Trump administration’s “zero-leakage” policy to succeed, foreign financial institutions would need to monitor and police their own customers. And there is no way to achieve the “total isolation” of the Iranian regime without Chinese banks doing much of the hard work of sanctions enforcement.

Before the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, the US Treasury estimated that China purchased roughly 90% of Iran’s oil exports. Years of sanctions have already pushed much of the Iranian oil trade into an alternative system capable of operating without the dollar, the SWIFT interbank payments platform, and the correspondent banks that have long given the United States its financial leverage.

Much of this trade moves through Iran’s rahbar shadow-banking system, which according to the Treasury processes “tens of billions of dollars” worth of trade each year, “much of it derived from Iran’s overseas sales of oil and petrochemicals.” Today, Iran settles those sales primarily in renminbi.

Secondary US sanctions have previously changed the behavior of major Chinese banks even when China officially rejected them. Within the first week of Russia’s invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, for example, the offshore units of the Industrial and Commercial Bank of China (ICBC) stopped issuing dollar-denominated letters of credit for purchases of physical Russian commodities. Renminbi-denominated credit lines remained available for some customers but required senior management approval. The Bank of China (BOC) restricted financing for Russian commodities, while its Singapore branch went even further and ceased financing transactions involving Russian companies and oil.

But China’s largest banks—its policy banks and the “big four” state-owned commercial banks, the ICBC, the BOC, the China Construction Bank, and the Agricultural Bank of China—are not America’s hardest enforcement problem. Their global operations require them to maintain access to dollar liquidity and correspondent banking relationships, which are far more valuable than any business with sanctioned Iranian entities. This dependence on the global dollar system gives them powerful incentives to limit their exposure to US sanctions. As former Treasury Secretary Janet L. Yellen observed, China’s large banks “are not banks that we most need to worry about” as they “really, really value their correspondent-banking relations.”

The greater challenge lies deeper within the Chinese financial system, among thousands of smaller regional banks with far less exposure to the dollar-based system and therefore less to lose if that access is cut off. In 2023, the People's Bank of China counted more than 3,800 urban and rural banks and credit cooperatives, in addition to private banks and other institutions. In 2024, as the US threatened Chinese banks with secondary sanctions, Russian companies increasingly turned to smaller regional institutions with minimal ties to Western markets.

The real question facing the Trump administration is whether it can compel or induce smaller Chinese banks to scrutinize customers and transactions deliberately structured to conceal Iranian connections—and refuse the business once they uncover them. Iran's rahbars use foreign-exchange houses, layers of offshore shell companies, and bank accounts in the United Arab Emirates, Hong Kong, and Singapore to move oil proceeds on behalf of sanctioned Iranian entities.

Chinese buyers of Iranian crude, especially independent “teapot” refiners in Shandong, which have absorbed most of the sanctioned oil, do not need to send money to an Iranian bank. A buyer can simply pay an offshore front company in renminbi. The money can then be used to pay Chinese suppliers on Iran's behalf or sent elsewhere.

On paper, the transaction may have no connection to Iran. To the Chinese bank processing the payment, it could look like an ordinary transfer from a Hong Kong trading firm to a company in Dubai. Internal records from the Iranian exchange house Radin, for example, identified dozens of China-based front companies maintaining accounts at Chinese banks. FinCEN has similarly documented transactions operated by Hong Kong-based shell companies that it linked to Iran's shadow-banking network.

This makes compliance much harder. Instead of simply refusing to do business with sanctioned entities, banks now have to uncover hidden links to Iran in accounts and transactions where no Iranian name appears at all. That requires more than routine customer onboarding and sanctions-list screening. Banks must scrutinize beneficial ownership and counterparties more closely and examine the purpose of payments, and anti-money-laundering teams must devote resources to reviewing transaction documentation and looking for payment patterns indicating that seemingly ordinary transactions may actually be moving money for sanctioned Iranian entities.

The US Treasury is now explicitly pushing this investigative burden onto foreign banks. In April, the Office of Foreign Assets Control urged financial institutions to subject independent teapot oil refineries in China to enhanced due diligence and warned that the US government is prepared to use secondary sanctions against them. The Treasury has since made clear that its latest sanctions campaign, Operation Economic Outcast, could include cutting foreign banks off from the dollar-based system.

In principle, Chinese law already requires banks to conduct “know your customer” verification and maintain financial-crime controls. In 2022, the Financial Action Task Force rated China's anti-money-laundering regime as “largely compliant” with its due-diligence standards.

China has implemented additional measures since then. Its revised anti-money-laundering law, which took effect in January 2025, requires financial institutions to verify customers and beneficial owners, understand the nature of business relationships, and, in certain high-risk cases, investigate the source of funds and the purpose of transactions. Banks must also monitor customers and transactions and investigate activity that departs from established patterns. More detailed rules implemented in January 2026 allow banks to refuse transactions or terminate relationships when they cannot adequately resolve money-laundering concerns.

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But anti-money-laundering compliance and US sanctions enforcement are not the same thing. Finding an Iranian connection may prompt a Chinese bank to look more closely at a transaction if there are signs of money laundering. It

does not, however, mean that under Chinese law they must reject it just because the US has sanctioned one of the parties.

In some cases, Chinese regulations pull banks in the opposite direction. In May, the Chinese Ministry of Commerce (MOFCOM) issued a blocking order covering five independent Chinese refiners sanctioned by the US for purchasing Iranian oil. Four are smaller regional teapot refiners. The fifth, Hengli Petrochemical's Dalian refinery, can process 400,000 barrels a day and belongs to the Hengli Group, a Fortune 500 company. It is the largest Chinese refiner sanctioned by the US so far.

MOFCOM's order states that US sanctions against these five refiners "must not be recognized, implemented, or complied with." Violations of the order can result in administrative penalties and expose banks and other companies to claims for damages in Chinese courts. A Chinese bank can still refuse to process a transaction because of money-laundering concerns or other compliance risks, but it cannot refuse a transaction or sever a relationship specifically to comply with the covered US sanctions without violating the order.

As the US extends secondary sanctions to cover more economically and politically significant Chinese entities, such blocking orders are likely to become more common. China now has a sophisticated legal and administrative apparatus that can make the extraterritorial application of US sanctions increasingly difficult—or, in some cases, moot.

This exposes a structural constraint on US sanctions power. Large state-owned Chinese banks have too much to lose if they are cut off from the dollar system. But US leverage weakens as transactions move to smaller banks with fewer ties to the US and Western financial markets.

The US government is thus left in the awkward position of asking Chinese banks to uncover hidden ties to sanctioned entities in Iran (or North Korea and Russia) and then act on those findings, even when that could put them at odds with Chinese law. Chinese banks are certainly willing to carry out the anti-money-laundering checks required by Chinese regulations, but they have little incentive to go looking for links to sanctioned entities when discovering them could create new legal problems.

In such circumstances, knowing less and maintaining plausible deniability is institutionally safer than knowing more. And unless Chinese banks closely police their own clients as payment networks adapt, sanctions will remain porous, with payments migrating to new shell companies and intermediaries.

Despite having the tools to retaliate against new US sanctions, China has used them selectively. Since President Donald Trump restored "maximum pressure" on Iran in February 2025, US sanctions against Chinese entities have mostly targeted specific shadow-fleet vessels, independent refineries in Shandong Province, and shipping terminal operators (Hengli Petrochemical's Dalian refinery, the only large integrated Chinese independent refiner sanctioned so far, remains the notable exception). China's response has consisted mostly of formulaic Foreign Ministry statements rejecting the unilateral nature of US sanctions and pledging to protect Chinese companies and citizens.

MOFCOM's May 2 blocking order remains the only consequential countermeasure, and it is narrow and targeted. Yet only days after it was issued, Chinese financial regulators reportedly instructed major Chinese banks to suspend new renminbi lending to the five sanctioned refiners while leaving existing credit lines in place.

These actions are not necessarily contradictory. China can reject the extraterritorial application of US sanctions while allowing major Chinese banks to protect themselves from the consequences. It has followed the same pattern since Operation Economic Outcast expanded secondary sanctions in August, criticizing the measures without imposing another Iran-related countermeasure.

The calculation could change if the US sanctioned a major Chinese bank or state-owned enterprise rather than another shell company, small bank, or teapot refiner. China's largest financial institutions depend heavily on access to dollars. The

US has far less leverage over smaller and less systemically important firms. This asymmetry makes an escalating spiral of US sanctions and Chinese countermeasures less likely.

The problem for the Trump administration is what happens as more transactions move beyond the institutions and payment channels most exposed to US pressure. At that point, effective enforcement increasingly requires cooperation from Chinese banks over which the US government has no authority.

A growing renminbi-based financial system does not make US sanctions ineffective, at least while major Chinese banks remain dependent on the global dollar-based system. But when non-dollar payments are routed through shadow intermediaries, they erode the two critical enforcement advantages on which US financial sanctions have traditionally relied: the visibility of transactions and leverage over the institutions that process them.

While the dollar system gives the US enormous financial power, American officials can no longer assume that the threat of being excluded from it will be enough to make foreign institutions comply with their dictates. As more of the actual enforcement takes place inside China's domestic financial system, beyond the reach of American authorities, China may gain a new source of geopolitical leverage.

Expecting China to enforce US sanctions is unrealistic, but anti-money-laundering enforcement offers a more practical basis for cooperation. As US and Chinese officials discuss Iran and its financial ties to China ahead of Trump's planned summit with Chinese President Xi Jinping in Washington, the US would have better luck pressing China to enforce its own anti-money-laundering rules against the opaque financial networks facilitating Iranian trade.

75. The Political Earthquake From Germany's China Shock

Author: Dalia Marin **Published:** Sep 18, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

MUNICH—September 6, 2026, could mark a turning point in Germany's postwar political history. In the Saxony-Anhalt state election, the far-right Alternative für Deutschland (AfD) came within three seats of an absolute majority, winning 43.8% of the vote—more than twice its share in the 2021 election. The AfD's gains came at the expense of the center-right Christian Democratic Union, the state's incumbent governing party and the party of Chancellor Friedrich Merz, which won just 17.2%, down from 37.1% in 2021.

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The war in Iran has underscored the dangers of relying on oil and gas imports. While it may revive demand for dirty fuels in the short term, over time it could also strengthen the case for clean-energy sources that reduce countries' exposure to regional conflicts and maritime chokepoints.

With Russia ramping up its hybrid war, Europe must choose. It can invest in its own defense, accept the trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence, or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

There is no shortage of explanations for the surge in support for the AfD in parts of Germany. Immigration, cultural conflict, and distrust of the political establishment are among the most cited—and for good reason. But the economic factors fueling the AfD's rise have so far received much less attention.

Saxony-Anhalt has endured profound economic challenges in recent decades. Reunification brought the collapse of East Germany's industrial base, destroying millions of jobs and causing large numbers of younger workers to relocate, leaving the region with one of the country's oldest and fastest-shrinking populations.

After more than three decades of economic deterioration, however, Saxony-Anhalt appeared to be recovering. But this upturn has stalled. Saxony-Anhalt's economy has contracted since 2021, bringing GDP close to its 2013 level.

Intensifying competitive pressure from Chinese exporters is now threatening to make matters much worse. Saxony-Anhalt's imports from China increased by 87% in 2024, reaching 20% of the state's total imports, and by a further 46% in the first nine months of 2025.

This China shock is not confined to Saxony-Anhalt. Germany's economy has stagnated since 2019, with output increasing by only around 0.12% annually, on average, in 2020–25. During this period, Chinese producers claimed an expanding share of the global market for advanced manufacturing products, such as automobiles and machinery, which were once central to Germany's export model.

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But the effects are not felt equally across regions. Consider the southwestern state of Baden-Württemberg, home to automotive giants such as Mercedes-Benz and Porsche, major suppliers like Bosch, a dense network of specialized

engineering companies, and globally competitive Mittelstand companies, including the laser technology group Trumpf and the engineering company Dürr. While Baden-Württemberg remains one of Europe's most important industrial regions, many of the mainstays of its economy are directly exposed to intensifying Chinese competition.

The western state of Rhineland-Palatinate—a hub of chemical and pharmaceutical production, exemplified by companies like BASF and Boehringer Ingelheim, as well as automotive suppliers and machinery manufacturers—is similarly exposed. At a time of weak domestic demand, high energy costs, structural changes in the automotive industry, and a global trade slowdown, neither state can afford the added pressure generated by China's growing dominance in the industries that have long formed the backbone of their economies.

Baden-Württemberg and Rhineland-Palatinate look very different from Saxony-Anhalt, economically and demographically. But the prosperity of all three depends heavily on industries exposed to Chinese competition. It is probably no coincidence, then, that the AfD has also made major electoral gains in Baden-Württemberg, nearly doubling its vote share to 18.8% in March, and in Rhineland-Palatinate, securing 19.5% of the vote two weeks later.

Not surprisingly, support for the AfD was higher among industrial workers than among the broader electorate: 61% in Saxony-Anhalt, 37% in Baden-Württemberg, and 39% in Rhineland-Palatinate. The center-left Social Democrats (SPD), long the party of Germany's industrial workers, suffered major losses. In Rhineland-Palatinate, the SPD was ousted after 35 years in government, while in Baden-Württemberg it only narrowly retained parliamentary representation.

For most of its history, the AfD had been viewed as a creature of eastern Germany, and the party's eastern roots may go some way toward explaining why it made its biggest breakthrough in Saxony-Anhalt. But, in view of rising support in western Germany, this outcome should be viewed as a warning, not an outlier. Industrial crisis, exacerbated by an intensifying China shock, creates fertile ground for political extremism.

None of this is to say that Chinese imports automatically lead to votes for the AfD. Economic decline is only one of many forces that shape electoral outcomes. But the pattern is too striking to ignore, especially since it has precedents elsewhere. Empirical research has shown a causal link between the China shock the United States experienced in the early 2000s and President Donald Trump's 2016 electoral victory, underscoring the political salience of trade-induced economic dislocation.

Against this backdrop, treating the China shock as simply an economic story would be a mistake. For decades, Germany's stability rested on an implicit bargain: high-value manufacturing would provide good jobs, strong export revenues, and broad-based prosperity, which political institutions would translate into social cohesion. Competition from China shakes that bargain to its foundations.

The risk is not simply that Germany loses market share in automobiles, chemicals, or machinery. It is that the regions most exposed to the transformation will lose faith in the political system that has for so long maintained stability.

76. Africa's AI Opportunity

Author: Yemi Osinbajo

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ABUJA/LAGOS—Africa has long found itself at the wrong end of the innovation chain. Breakthroughs were made and commercialized elsewhere, then imported by African countries at prices and on terms over which they had little influence. The costs of this approach were starkly apparent during the COVID-19 pandemic, when Africa struggled to gain access to vaccines developed and manufactured elsewhere.

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When it comes to AI, many policymakers seem to expect Africa to repeat this pattern: the United States and China will build it, Europe will regulate it, and Africa will eventually adopt whatever becomes affordable. But this narrative conflates AI capabilities with frontier models, which are trained using enormous data centers that consume hundreds of megawatts of electricity and require tens of billions of dollars of investment. The African entrepreneurs, researchers, and governments laying the foundations of an indigenous AI ecosystem know better.

AI is not merely another digital product to be consumed. It is an economic capability, which can be harnessed to increase productivity, create new industries, and strengthen national resilience. Like electricity or telecommunications, AI's value depends less on who invents it than on who develops the capacity to deploy it most effectively.

The greatest opportunities for Africa lie in what might be called sector-strong AI: specialized systems focused on solving practical problems in agriculture, health care, education, logistics, finance, and public administration. Unlike frontier models, these applications require relatively modest computing infrastructure but generate immediate, and potentially enormous, economic returns.

For example, if ten million African small and medium-size enterprises used AI agents as virtual administrative staff—handling customer inquiries, bookkeeping, scheduling, and routine documentation—the productivity gains could potentially generate an additional \$5,000 annually per business. That would represent roughly \$50 billion in additional economic activity across the continent.

Similar gains can be made in agriculture. Today, a single extension officer might support roughly 2,000 farmers. AI-powered advisory services combining satellite imagery, predictive weather models, and smartphone-based disease detection could potentially extend that reach fivefold, without increasing staffing. Likewise, AI-assisted diagnosis could extend the reach of health workers, and AI tutors could enable far broader access to education.

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By addressing shortages of skilled professionals that have constrained African economies for decades, these applications could generate well over \$100 billion in additional annual output. And none of them requires frontier AI. On the contrary, they largely use technologies developed before the recent explosion of generative AI. Computer vision systems can identify crop diseases using smartphone photographs. Predictive models can forecast food prices, rainfall, and disease outbreaks. Small language models can help citizens complete government forms or access health care in their own languages.

In developing AI solutions, Africa's apparent disadvantages might even turn out to be competitive advantages. Limited connectivity, fragmented datasets, constrained energy supplies, and geographically dispersed populations encourage the creation of efficient, lightweight systems. We see the scale of this alternative approach in AKADEMIYA2063's digital mapping ecosystems, which leverage lightweight machine learning models to forecast yields across 47 African countries without requiring extensive ground operations.

Government adoption of AI would compound the benefits. By making use of African-built software powered by no-code AI, governments could generate millions of jobs for Africa's growing youth population. AI-powered technologies can also go a long way toward strengthening resilience to crises, whether epidemiological, climatic, or economic. During the COVID-19 pandemic, even relatively modest AI capabilities, such as integrating telecommunications data, satellite imagery, and health records, could have tracked outbreaks more accurately, targeted restrictions more precisely, and reduced both economic disruption and loss of life.

Realizing this potential will require investment, but measured in tens of millions of dollars, not hundreds of billions, as in the US and China. Distributed GPU infrastructure powered by Africa's abundant stranded energy resources could support practical AI applications while laying the groundwork for more sophisticated capabilities over time. Intelligently deployed, such infrastructure could serve both African demand and international markets, while keeping more value creation on the continent.

Africa has the ingredients for the AI ecosystem it so badly needs. Companies like Udu Technologies (of which one of the authors is a co-founder) and Cassava Technologies are building computing infrastructure. In fact, UduTech has already deployed distributed GPU infrastructure in cities like Cape Town and Lagos through its Africa GPU Hub, supporting applications for banks, universities, security companies, and development partners.

With support from the United Nations Development Programme's "Timbuktoo" initiative, this effort is now expanding into additional countries. More broadly, Timbuktoo is supporting the expansion of innovation networks, including by supporting startups, along with nonprofits like AfriLabs.

For their part, governments are beginning to produce national AI strategies. With coherent policies, long-term capital, and strategic procurement, Africa could realistically develop dozens of AI champions serving millions of people across sectors ranging from agriculture and health care to finance and education, making it the world's leading hub for useful, affordable, and inclusive AI.

The global AI revolution is often portrayed as a Sino-American race to develop the biggest, most advanced frontier models. But the greatest economic prize of the AI age most likely will be found in deploying practical intelligence, particularly in young, dynamic, and fast-growing economies. Africa does not need massive resources, let alone outside permission, to claim this prize. It just needs the will to invest in its own capabilities, support its own innovators, and embrace applications that advance its own economic priorities.

77. Can Adaptation Accelerate Climate Action?

Author: Simon Zadek Published: Sep 18, 2026 Link: [View Original](#)

GENEVA/LONDON—This year may be remembered as the one when climate change could no longer be ignored. Rich economies are now suffering the devastating effects of global warming that have long plagued other countries. Wildfires, droughts, heat waves, and floods dominate the news, forcing political engagement and serious policy responses and business decisions.

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With Russia ramping up its hybrid war, Europe must choose. It can invest in its own defense, accept the trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence, or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

Even climate skeptics have woken up to the danger. In a summer of apocalyptic headlines—such as record heat boiling potatoes underground in South Korea—it was striking that France's far-right National Rally cited research from the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, the party's long-standing *bête noire*, in their proposal for expanding air conditioning. Likewise, Austria's version of Fox News sought to platform a climate scientist after years of downplaying human-caused climate change.

It seems you no longer need to acknowledge climate change to prepare for its effects.

Politicians are notorious for failing to act until a crisis forces their hand. In May, the United Kingdom's independent climate adviser published its official and alarming adaptation report, which was dutifully received. But only after a scorching summer set in did the government spring into action. In late June, the UK launched a climate-security taskforce, and in mid-August, British Prime Minister Andy Burnham convened a high-level emergency committee to discuss the country's response to extreme heat, wildfires, and drought.

Public opinion also seems to have crossed a threshold. A new survey commissioned by our organizations, Morphosis and Vibe Fund, together with CORE, polled 18,000 people across 18 countries, making it one of the most extensive citizen polls about adaptation to date. The survey found that people across the political spectrum are deeply concerned about the effects of climate change. The agenda for reaching net-zero emissions may still divide societies, but such differences fade when it comes to the urgent need for adaptation.

Moreover, survey respondents believe that climate change will affect their jobs and the cost of living now and in the long term. The economics of adaptation, rather than the need for emergency planning, is front and center for many people, converting general concern about climate change into politically salient demands.

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As for what needs to be done, respondents think that governments are responsible for advancing adaptation—and are falling short. In their view, policymakers play a crucial role in securing peoples' safety, protecting the most vulnerable, providing critical infrastructure, and ensuring that food, water, and energy are accessible and affordable. Businesses, on the other hand, are expected to deliver inexpensive adaptation solutions, especially when they involve the development and deployment of new technologies.

Finally, the survey finds that people see adaptation as complementing, not substituting for, emissions reductions. This challenges the emerging political narrative that we should focus exclusively on coping with the effects of climate change, rather than on trying to address its causes. It also suggests that climate advocates should not shy away from talking about adaptation, for fear that it might delay or prevent mitigation measures. In fact, a majority of respondents believe that expanded adaptation efforts would likely result in more ambitious action to reduce emissions.

Societies often discard accepted conventions and norms in the wake of a crisis. Following the 2008 financial crisis, central banks abandoned orthodoxy and began printing money at an unprecedented rate to avoid global economic contagion and meltdown. After COVID-19 struck, many G20 governments subsidized household and business incomes to a level that once would have been considered impossible. And in the years following Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, the European Union reduced its share of Russian gas imports from 45% to 19%.

In all three cases, slow-moving vulnerabilities that policymakers studiously ignored suddenly became losses that could not be deferred. Decades of resistance collapsed, and the infeasible became feasible.

The urgent need to adapt to climate change could thus be the kind of crisis that forces us to stop neglecting the green agenda and act at the necessary scale. This would allow us to avoid the tragic consequences of extreme weather events and develop a robust economic response to manage global warming's far-reaching effects on households and communities. Policy measures must focus not only on mitigating the immediate physical risks, but also on devising adaptation solutions that will bolster economies for decades to come.

The adaptation imperative represents the new frontier for households, businesses, and countries. Politicians must lead the charge, which means moving beyond emergency measures to engage in public debate that includes people from across the political spectrum and policymakers from around the world. The UK could make this a priority during its G20 presidency next year. With an El Niño cycle underway, the prognosis for 2027 is grim, leaving us with months, not years, to prepare.

78. A Central European Model for EU Growth

Author: Marcin Piatkowski **Published:** Sep 21, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

WARSAW—European policymakers have spent the past few years asking how Europe can become economically more like the United States or China. But they are overlooking the European Union’s fastest-growing members: Poland and the wider Central and Eastern European (CEE) region.

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The EU remains the envy of much of the world, but there are good reasons to be anxious about its economic future. The bloc is de-industrializing, losing global market share, and growing far more slowly than the US and China. If the trend continues, Europe’s share of global GDP could soon return to levels last seen in the Middle Ages.

Former European Central Bank President Mario Draghi’s 2024 competitiveness report offers the most compelling blueprint yet for reviving Europe’s economic dynamism. Its recommendations can be distilled into three Is: invest, integrate, and innovate.

That prescription is largely right but incomplete. Strikingly, the 401-page report doesn’t mention Poland’s transformation even once, despite it being Europe’s greatest economic success story in recent decades. It also ignores the sweeping reforms that turned the CEE’s moribund communist economies into dynamic exemplars of democratic capitalism.

If Poland and the rest of the CEE countries were invited to update the Draghi report, they might complement its three Is with Central Europe’s three Cs: converge, compete, and coordinate.

Convergence is arguably the single most successful European policy of the last five decades. Poland, Europe’s growth champion since 1990, has increased its GDP faster than South Korea and the other “Asian Tigers” over the past 35 years. Its income per capita (at purchasing power parity) has almost quadrupled over that period, compared with a roughly 50% increase in the eurozone, and is projected to surpass that of Japan and Spain this year.

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But despite Poland’s dynamic growth, its income per capita remains below the EU average. The same is true of almost two-thirds of the EU’s 27 member states, including Italy and Spain. By my calculation, if every below-average member reached the EU’s average income per capita, the bloc’s total output would be 10–15% higher, narrowing the income gap with the US.

Few of the reforms now being debated by EU policymakers promise such a large payoff. And Europe can close this gap without beating America or China at their own game, simply by helping poorer European economies become as productive as richer ones.

What would this mean in practice? For starters, it would mean shifting public spending away from consumption and toward growth-enhancing investments. That includes integrating the continent's infrastructure, going all-in on energy independence, achieving technological sovereignty, and, above all, accelerating AI adoption across European industries. It also means keeping the door open to new member states, especially Ukraine, whose accession would strengthen the EU's economy and security.

Helping poorer countries catch up is not charity. Germany's net contribution to the EU budget was less than €20 billion (\$23 billion) in 2024, some 0.4% of its national income. Yet German exports to Poland alone have increased more than 25-fold since 1990 and now exceed €100 billion annually—more than its exports to China.

German companies also earn billions of euros each year from their investments in the region, including €5 billion from Poland alone. Their competitiveness has benefited enormously from shifting production to CEE countries, which offer a predictable operating environment, high-quality human capital, and low labor costs.

But convergence can only take Europe so far without stronger competition. Services account for almost 75% of the EU's GDP and are its least contestable sectors. Liberalizing them is the cheapest way to boost productivity. Polish and other CEE companies encounter barriers in the single market every day, often erected by Western European incumbents. The obvious response is stricter enforcement of EU competition policy, coupled with a rejection of naive free-trade fundamentalism and greater reciprocity in trade and investment.

The EU also needs to learn how to act through coalitions of the willing instead of waiting for unanimity. Poland, Germany, and France, for example, could be the first to pilot a genuine "28th regime" for companies, offering an EU-wide alternative to 27 competing national rulebooks through a single corporate code and tax framework, starting with AI startups.

The same principle should apply to Europe's labor market. Professionals who earned their credentials in one EU country shouldn't be forced to jump through bureaucratic hoops to qualify in another. While most of the Polish plumbers who migrated west have already returned, plenty of other CEE professionals are struggling.

Becoming as competitive as the US and China is worth attempting, but that ambition should not distract Europe from what it already does better than anyone else: create prosperity and then spread it. Roughly two-thirds of the countries that have achieved high-income status over the past half-century are European.

Draghi's agenda rightly aims to push the EU's most productive economies toward the global technological frontier. But Europe should act on two fronts at once, using industrial policy to accelerate innovation while helping the rest of the continent catch up.

79. A Roadmap for the Next UN Secretary-General

Author: Philipp Schönrock **Published:** Sep 21, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

BOGOTÁ—Leading the United Nations has always been a balancing act, but the breakdown of the postwar global order has added a new dimension of complexity to the role. The next secretary-general, who will take office in 2027, will fill the most prominent position in multilateral governance at a time when multilateralism is arguably at its nadir. To rebuild trust in international cooperation, the UN's leader must view this crisis for what it is: an unprecedented opportunity for fundamental reform.

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Seven candidates are vying to replace António Guterres, although the third UN Security Council straw poll has further narrowed the field (while indicating members' willingness to respect the principle of regional rotation, according to which the next secretary-general will be from Latin America or the Caribbean). Rebeca Grynspan of Costa Rica and Carolyn Rodrigues Birkett of Guyana have emerged as the top two contenders, but the absence of a clear frontrunner could encourage a late entrant.

Whoever is ultimately selected will need a transformative roadmap for the first 100 days (and beyond) to shape the UN's trajectory and ensure that global governance is made fit for the 21st century. Cepei, the Bogotá-based think tank that I head, has partnered with organizations around the world and convened regional consultations with leading scholars, former diplomats, policymakers, practitioners, and other stakeholders to reflect on the agenda and priorities of the next UN secretary-general and the future of UN leadership more broadly.

These meetings show that expectations are high. Although the UN secretary-general's independent powers are limited, an incumbent wields political capital, serves as the organization's public voice, appoints senior officials, and oversees management. So, the question becomes, how can the next secretary-general demonstrate leadership, credibility, and direction in the first 100 days while operating within these limits?

For starters, the next secretary-general should focus on delivering consistent messaging and on using the largely predictable UN calendar to achieve some early wins. They should begin with political clarity, not thematic expansion; complete existing agendas, such as the Sustainable Development Goals and climate agreements; and shift the focus from proliferation to execution. More fundamentally, the new head must also commit to making power more transparent; embed inclusion across the UN system; strengthen coordination with member states; and ensure that financing is aligned with governance.

That means rebuilding trust from within. When appointing the senior leadership team, the next secretary-general should select people who demonstrate political courage, independent judgment, discipline in setting priorities, a willingness to

take risks and withstand criticism, and a renewed commitment to mediation. Such leaders will be well-positioned in the long term to incentivize coordination, build coalitions that outlive their tenure, and pursue meaningful structural and organizational change backed by concrete accountability mechanisms.

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Instilling a renewed sense of purpose in a workforce of around 120,000 people struggling with low morale and impossibly tight budgets will require a compelling diagnosis of the UN's challenges, a vision for its future, and priorities for action. The diagnosis should focus on political factors first and foremost, as many of its problems can be traced to choices made by member states, weakening consensus, and shifting power relations. To be sure, this limits what institutional reform—or the secretary-general alone—can realistically achieve. But, more importantly, it suggests that the selection and transition agenda should address not only the expectations for the next secretary-general, but also what member states are prepared to provide in return.

The secretary-general will inherit the unfinished UN80 Initiative, which aims to improve efficiency, review implementation of the body's mandates, and examine possible structural changes and program realignments. In the first 100 days, important decisions must be made about which parts of the reform agenda to continue, which to adjust, and which to abandon, while keeping in mind the need to avoid reform fatigue and ensure that the next phase is shaped and owned by member states.

At the country level, the secretary-general must also make difficult choices about activities the UN should no longer pursue, while improving delivery, localization, and coordination. This requires greater clarity about where the UN adds value, focusing on its universal legitimacy, convening and norm-setting power, and, perhaps most importantly, mediation and "good offices." The guiding principle should be differentiation, not withdrawal: continuing direct delivery where necessary while relying more deliberately on regional and national actors when they are better placed to act.

Lastly, to reduce the UN's dependence on voluntary contributions and earmarked resources, often from a small number of major donors, the next secretary-general should begin engaging with member states to develop a more sustainable funding model. This means preparing to make strategic use of the organization's existing levers of authority to align financing with governance, which would strengthen the system's effectiveness and accountability. This could be accomplished by maximizing unearmarked voluntary funding and creating project-specific funding windows (where transaction costs do not distort governance), while also providing contributors with appropriate political recognition and greater transparency.

The new UN head's broader agenda—restore peace, protect the most vulnerable, and convince the world to act on climate change and regulate AI—represents a formidable challenge, especially as geopolitical upheaval impedes efforts to forge consensus or deliver long-term solutions. The UN has not adapted quickly enough to today's multipolar reality in which influence is dispersed across many sites. Tokenistic engagement and negative narratives reinforce a sense of exclusion, deepening the legitimacy crisis.

But the next secretary-general can change that trajectory. Although rebuilding legitimacy will not be easy or immediate, a leader who demonstrates strong management skills and a commitment to reform in the first 100 days will provide an important foundation on which to build a reinvigorated UN.

80. A New World Order Is Not Beckoning

Author: Jeremy Adelman **Published:** Sep 21, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

CAMBRIDGE—This week, US President Donald Trump will host his counterpart, Chinese President Xi Jinping, at the White House, and other world leaders will gather for the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly. In both cases, the media coverage and accompanying punditry will portray what many believe to be a world hurtling from order to disorder.

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With Russia ramping up its hybrid war, Europe must choose. It can invest in its own defense, accept the trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence, or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

But is this narrative correct? Trade wars and real wars might seem to augur a new era of disarray and international bedlam, but it is not as if the world before Trump's first presidency, Brexit, and Russia's invasion of Ukraine was stable. In fact, even liberal do-gooders committed their share of thoughtless atrocities and commotion.

So, let's not get misty-eyed about the liberal international "order" just because populists gloat over its demise. What we need is a narrative that does not draw such a sharp line between a decomposing liberal international order and its post-liberal successor, and that clears the way to address what is really at risk.

An alternative narrative might start with a different account of the system we are being told is collapsing. Instead of calling it a liberal international order (despite it often being illiberal and disorderly), the post-1945 era would be better described as an age in which we pursued common goods through arrangements that had both liberal and non-liberal features. Initially, the highest-priority common good was to prevent World War III. But over time, international institutions evolved to address economic, scientific, cultural, and other shared goods, too.

The common-goods system sought to absorb and diffuse the costs and hazards arising from an interdependent world, so that countries would not quarrel over the bills. A web of treaties and monitors sought to prevent conflict, reduce harm, and distribute risk, thereby facilitating more trade, more cultural exchange, better health, and closer integration.

This system has been more effective than critics on the right like to admit. Even the powerful rely on it, because doing so is in their interest. The United States shouldered a lot of the responsibility as the system's sheriff and as the issuer of the world's reserve currency. But it also reaped the rewards and could select which bills it wanted to pay.

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Hence, the US would topple elected governments while shaming others that did the same. It would refuse to sign treaties that it nonetheless wanted others to sign (the Biden administration applauded the International Criminal Court's arrest

warrant for Russian President Vladimir Putin, but refused to recognize the Court's authority over Americans). And it would pressure other countries to keep their markets open to US exports. These prerogatives have been part of US statecraft for generations. Trump isn't an exception; he's just extreme.

The most glaring stain on the common-goods system concerns the rights of migrants. After 1945, treaties and legal commitments recognized the right of anyone to seek asylum if they could prove they were being persecuted by their government. The aim was to establish universal rights as a pillar for peace. But while the system universalized the right to move, states could still choose whom they wanted. The unwanted, starting with Palestinians after 1948, wound up in camps and surrounded by barbed wire. States that excluded refugees outsourced the cost of handling them to besieged and underfunded UN agencies.

Where does this alternative narrative leave us? For starters, the line that separates the past from the future is not as sharp as wistful liberal internationalists and crowing populists claim. In fact, the world has grown more interdependent despite the tensions of the last decade. Alarmists once proclaimed the end of globalization, but with Asia leading the way, world trade reached a record-high \$35 trillion in 2025, and global commerce grew by 4.6%, outpacing global GDP growth.

For essentials like food, fuel, and fibers, societies have never been more in need of one another. Trump's presumption that the US could glide past the closure of the Strait of Hormuz because it had oil and gas of its own may cost his party dearly in the upcoming midterm election. Economic history is rife with examples of interdependent competitors who leaned on each other while sniping like siblings. Even ties between the US and China remain entangled despite "decoupling" efforts. Sino-American bilateral trade peaked in 2022 after a decade of saber-rattling, and exports from Canada to the US actually rose after Trump's March 2025 tariffs on Canadian goods.

It is impossible to reverse interdependence without paying a price; societies inevitably suffer when they decouple from those whom they have grown to depend on. In the 1930s, when strong countries dismantled the guardrails against tariffs and competitive devaluations, they exacerbated the Great Depression. One lesson from the Brexit referendum a decade ago is that secession may win you some autonomy, but at a price that most voters will come to regret paying.

Nor is interdependence only an economic phenomenon. The menace of nuclear war and the reality of climate change remind us that we need each other for survival. Cooperation is necessary for human security. It was a global scientific network that created the mRNA vaccine that broke the COVID-19 pandemic.

It is easy to take the common-goods system for granted and pronounce it dead at the same time. Anti-globalism is in vogue because it releases the powerful from constraints while allowing them to continue reaping the benefits, whereas the more vulnerable remain all too reliant on a flawed but indispensable system.

Exhaustion, rather than a rupture, is the most immediate risk. With resources dwindling, too much is expected of the common-goods system. It has prevented the worst kinds of global disasters, but it is increasingly strained. We should be more worried about a gradual and cumulative decapitalization than a dramatic apocalypse. Instead of heralding the dawn of "disorder" or a new "order," why not address the purposes and shortfalls of the interdependence we have?

81. What It Means for Global Warming to Exceed 1.5°C

Author: Nicholas Stern

Published: Sep 21, 2026

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LONDON—The world must now face up to the fact that the increase in average global temperatures will surpass 1.5° Celsius, the more ambitious of the 2015 Paris climate agreement's targets. That means devising a plan for managing the consequences—by increasing our focus on adaptation, loss and damage, and geoengineering—while redoubling our efforts to cut greenhouse-gas (GHG) emissions.

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A sobering new report from the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) warns that even if governments deliver on all their existing climate pledges, global warming could reach 1.8°C later this century. Meanwhile, a continuation of current policies could produce warming of 2.6°C by 2100. Either way, overshooting 1.5°C will expose the world to serious costs, including more frequent and intense heatwaves and bouts of heavy rain in many places. It will also bring us closer to breaching climate thresholds (or "tipping points") beyond which lie far greater risks—such as destabilization of the polar ice caps in Greenland and West Antarctica.

While the poorest countries will continue to be hit earliest and hardest, this summer has demonstrated that even rich countries like the United Kingdom are not prepared for the climate-driven risks that are already materializing, let alone the risks that await us. Temperatures will rise, and the negative effects of climate change will continue to mount until global GHG emissions are reduced to net zero and atmospheric concentrations stop growing. As long as they are still rising, so will the costs to us all. The net-zero target follows from physics, not ideology.

The effects of overshooting 1.5°C will require much larger investments in adaptation and resilience, ranging from higher sea defenses to the development of more drought-resistant crop varieties. Such investment will become a much higher priority, and overall investment needs will become much greater than would have been the case had we met the Paris target.

But there are limits to adaptation. Breaching major climate thresholds could lead to conditions so hostile that socioeconomic development itself would be reversed, forcing hundreds of millions of people to move despite whatever adaptation measures are in place.

The longer it takes us to reach net-zero emissions, the larger the costs will be. Minimizing those costs will require more investment in rapidly cutting emissions through the deployment of renewables and electric vehicles, while making more rapid progress in hard-to-abate sectors such as maritime shipping and air travel.

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Although investment in the necessary technologies has been growing strongly, we still need a marked and sustained acceleration to phase out the polluting, inefficient practices that are making emissions rise further. Despite the International Energy Agency's warning five years ago that limiting warming to 1.5°C would require that no new fossil fuel projects be launched, many producers have been expanding their exploitation of oil, gas, and coal reserves. As a result, managing climate change will require stranding even more fossil-fuel infrastructure, creating a real cost for investors who have backed dirty energy over renewables.

One must also acknowledge the high costs associated with depending on international hydrocarbon markets. The competition for fossil fuels drives violent conflict, and price volatility has repeatedly caused severe economic crises. And yet, in most of the world, clean energy is now cheaper than dirty alternatives. Investing in clean, efficient technologies and infrastructure offers developing countries the chance to generate strong, sustainable, and resilient economic growth while cutting emissions.

Nonetheless, the UNEP report points out that reversing the 1.5°C overshoot will require us to go beyond net zero to achieve negative emissions, meaning we will eventually need to remove much more carbon dioxide from the atmosphere than we add. Though we can and should expand natural carbon sinks, including forests, these are unlikely to offer the total capacity we will need. Closing the remaining gap therefore will require greater investment in artificial methods of extracting and storing billions of tons of atmospheric CO₂.

We should also examine carefully the potential of other geoengineering solutions, including those designed to reduce the total amount of solar energy reaching the Earth's surface. Further research is needed, however, because these options come with significant risks and ethical implications. For example, cooling the planet while leaving high levels of CO₂ in the atmosphere would acidify our oceans, with potentially dangerous consequences.

The next few decades will be challenging. There will be many opportunities for investment and growth, but also serious dangers, owing to our hitherto slow response to the risks of climate change. We must come to grips with our new reality before we blow past yet another dangerous threshold.

82. Might Makes Right Will End Pax Americana

Author: Pedro Abramovay **Published:** Sep 21, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW YORK—From the moment it was announced, the ceasefire between the United States, Israel, and Iran has been marked by a different form of confrontation: peace on the precipice of war and war on the brink of resolution.

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The memorandum of understanding signed by the US and Iran in June was supposed to kick off 60 days of negotiations, culminating in a comprehensive peace. Instead, it has been followed by continued fighting, including US and Iranian strikes on the Strait of Hormuz and the seizure of Yemen's Red Sea coast by the Houthis, which threatens to disrupt shipping through the Bab el-Mandeb.

Tens of thousands of airstrikes have failed to force Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Iran says it will lift the siege in exchange for an end to four decades of sanctions. The US is doing the opposite: maximizing already maximal sanctions. But Iran is no closer to capitulation, underscoring America's inability to manage the aftermath of its own fury.

Across the region, force is looking less like strength than instability. In Gaza, war is not a means of securing a political objective; it is the objective. With the Gaza Doctrine of disproportionate force and destruction, Israel is waging war not only on Hamas, but on the international legal order itself. Israel has also deployed that doctrine in southern Lebanon, where airstrikes have continued uninterrupted, despite two ceasefires and a peace agreement that makes a farce of Lebanese sovereignty.

It is often argued that, under US President Donald Trump, an unmasked might-makes-right approach has overtaken US foreign policy, exemplified by the extraordinary rendition of former Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro and the war against Iran. The US has abandoned even the hypocritical tribute it once paid to international laws and institutions. Whereas US President George W. Bush's administration made its case for invading Iraq before the United Nations Security Council, Trump's administration is acting on the basis of pure coercion, without any pretense of consultation (except in lockstep with Israel).

But this amounts less to a rupture than an escalation. From extrajudicial executions by drones to indefinite detention at Guantánamo Bay, the US spent a generation systematically abrogating the postwar "rules-based" international order it once authored, not merely narrowing the rules' universal premises but making them essentially disposable. The path to the Trump Doctrine of global dominance was paved by the previous administration's complicity in the genocide in Gaza.

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Nonetheless, the open embrace of coercive militarism has made a difference, though not the one Trump expected. Far from bolstering US dominance, this approach has eroded it. When the distinction between war and peace dissolves into a ceasefire that is neither, and months of bombardment fail to deliver anything like victory, force looks less like strength and more like pointless destruction.

Perpetual war makes any world order impossible. The application of raw power will trigger resistance; war crimes will lead to international opprobrium. While coercion will render sovereignty conditional, it cannot ensure continued domination. The question, then, is what comes next.

Coercive militarism has provoked a period of profound instability. But its failure could usher in more balanced relations among states: a new multilateralism grounded in sovereignty and reinforced by regional and global mechanisms that promote universal rights, mutual restraint, and collective decision-making regarding shared resources, norms, and values. Such a multilateralism is undoubtedly aspirational. But every country, including the US, has an interest in building it.

The UN would not be irrelevant in this new system. But with the UN issuing only one resolution on the Iran war (criticizing Iranian retaliation but not the US-Israeli attacks that instigated it) diplomacy needs different defenders. Regional initiatives are particularly important, and their promise is already becoming apparent.

Consider the US-Iran MoU. The negotiations were mediated by an unlikely coalition led by Pakistan and Qatar with support from Egypt, Saudi Arabia, and Turkey. This represents a major shift from negotiations for the 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), the nuclear deal Iran concluded with the five permanent members of the UN Security Council, Germany, and the European Union.

The difference is all the more notable, given that in 2010, the countries that would go on to sign the JCPOA swiftly dismissed a nuclear-fuel swap that Brazil and Turkey negotiated with Iran. As then-Brazilian Foreign Minister Amorim lamented, “traditional centers of power [would] not share gladly their privileged status.”

Another example is the informal consultative framework among Egypt, Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, and Turkey aimed at building a more stable regional security architecture shaped by shared norms, including a commitment to forsake the use of force. Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, and Turkey have also formalized a mutual defense agreement, known as the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement, that does not identify an adversary and leaves open the possibility of others joining. While its significance is being tested by the Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia, the broader trend is undeniable: the emergence of a more pluralistic regional order, in which countries take more responsibility for their own security, rather than allowing the US to impose its will.

Like the Strait of Hormuz, the Bab el-Mandeb Strait is now effectively closed, owing to the asymmetrical force unleashed in response to US escalation. What we are witnessing in the Middle East is not only extreme violence, but also extreme overreach. But the war that is catalyzing the disintegration of a US-led multilateral order is also opening space for a more sustainable multilateralism rooted in rights, restraint, dignity, diplomacy, and respect for sovereignty.

83. Is Germany's Firewall Collapsing?

Author: Jan-Werner Mueller

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PRINCETON—Germany's far right has won again, capturing the largest share of the vote in the northeastern state of Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, as it did in Saxony-Anhalt earlier this month. Though it is unlikely to take power in the former, it still has a chance to do so in the latter. It needs the support of only three other members of parliament in Magdeburg, and the far-left Sahra Wagenknecht Alliance (which fuses socialism with nationalism) has signaled some willingness to cooperate with the Alternative für Deutschland (AfD).

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With Russia ramping up its hybrid war, Europe must choose. It can invest in its own defense, accept the trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence, or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

Is the German "firewall" crumbling? For years, all other German parties have staunchly refused to work with the far right, and critics (including US Vice President JD Vance) have argued that this practice is undemocratic and ultimately self-defeating. Have they been vindicated?

In Saxony-Anhalt, the AfD received more than twice as many votes as the second-placed Christian Democrats, Germany's governing center-right party. Yet the fact remains that no party is entitled to hold power unless it wins a majority (50% plus one vote). So, another way of reading the same result is that a clear majority voted against the far right—not by accident, but as a conscious effort to deny power to a party that many rightly see as a threat to democracy.

It would be quite strange to claim that ignoring this large anti-AfD vote is "democratic." Only one prominent theorist of democracy, the Austrian jurist Hans Kelsen, has ever gone so far as to suggest that all parties in a representative assembly ought always to pursue compromises and reach out to minorities. The promise of democracy, he contends, rests on collective self-government. The greater the number of people who can see their will reflected in a government's policies, the freer they are.

But Kelsen's vision of maximal inter-party cooperation is not as democratic as it seems. If an overwhelming majority favors closing tax havens, why should they have to compromise with the billionaire beneficiaries of the status quo? Seeking compromise becomes even harder to justify when parties are elected because voters do not want to see cooperation with the far right.

Critics of the firewall argue that it denies representation to far-right voters. But this is obviously false. Far-right deputies are already quite vocal and active in parliaments where they have won seats, especially in political systems that give opposition parties many levers to hold a government accountable. Germany is one such country. The far right has many opportunities to apply pressure on the current government and force debates on issues of its choosing. In a democracy, being out of power does not mean being out of sight.

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When the political scientist Christian Stecker (a prominent critic of the firewall) laments Germany's deficit of "thematic representation," he is overlooking the crucial distinction between a right to be heard and a right to exercise authority. True, if far-right parties hold seats in parliament, other parties should not refuse to debate them. But talking with duly elected far-right populists does not mean you need to accommodate their positions.

Unfortunately, accommodation is exactly what has happened in many European countries in recent years. While officially refusing coalitions with the far right, plenty of (primarily center-right) politicians have effectively copied the far right's rhetoric, breaching the firewall.

As multiple studies have shown, trying to destroy the far right by imitating it usually backfires on the center right. Likewise, the theory that including the far right in government will expose it as incompetent and thereby erode its support has not been borne out. In research testing this hypothesis, the far right has performed better by an average of six percentage points at the next election, and this result also holds when the far right supports a minority government.

To be sure, the far-right Sweden Democrats had been propping up a center-right minority government, but lost votes in the country's recent election for the first time since entering parliament in 2010. (Moreover, ahead of this month's vote, the center-right parties had even proposed including the Sweden Democrats in an official coalition in the future.) But one should not generalize from this result. By supporting a minority government, the far right can influence the agenda without having to take responsibility for its implementation or outcomes—hardly a plausible understanding of democracy.

It is true that if the far right keeps doing better at the ballot box, coalitions to keep it out of power are bound to become more heterogeneous, and this will potentially backfire. Ideologically incoherent alliances comprising everyone from the far left to the center right will suffer from constant squabbling and ineffectiveness. They also risk confirming far-right populists' standard claim that a nefarious political establishment will do anything—including abandoning its own stated principles—to keep them from power.

Fortunately, that result is not inevitable. But to avert it, other parties must stop campaigning only against the far right at the expense of offering their own positive vision for the future. In Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, the incumbent, Manuela Schwesig of the Social Democrats, presented herself as "Die Frau gegen Blau" ("The Woman Against Blue"). That had some effect, but it was not enough to prevent the AfD from finishing first.

More to the point, in Saxony-Anhalt, the AfD made historic gains partly because it projected hope (its slogans, "Anything is possible" and "All will turn out well," could have come from a Barack Obama campaign). It responded confidently to voters' primary concerns, which centered not so much on migration as on economic conditions. When it came to that crucial topic, the other parties seemed to have little to say.

84. What Xi Really Wants From Trump

Author: Steve Tsang Published: Sep 22, 2026 Link: [View Original](#)

LONDON—On September 24, US President Donald Trump is set to meet Chinese President Xi Jinping in Washington. As leaders of the two most powerful countries, they preside over the world's most consequential bilateral relationship. But if Trump assumes that this means China's foreign policy revolves around relations with the United States, he is gravely mistaken.

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Xi is both a disciplinarian and an ideologue. He requires China's foreign-policy establishment to pursue a global strategy based on the principles of "Xi Jinping Thought," which shape how China assesses its national interests and responds to pressure from the US. Chief among these principles is that preserving Xi's leadership and Communist Party rule takes precedence over all other national interests. Close behind is enhancement of China's global standing. China's defiant response to Trump's tariff war reflects these priorities. In effect, Xi's approach makes it nearly impossible for China to capitulate to American pressure.

What, then, does Xi's China want? Its ultimate objective is enshrined in what Xi calls the "China Dream of National Rejuvenation," to be fulfilled by 2050. As Olivia Cheung and I explain in our new book *China's Global Strategy under Xi Jinping*, achieving this goal requires a dual pivot.

The first pivot, and the current focus of Chinese diplomacy, is to secure overwhelming support from the Global South for China's foreign-policy agenda. Xi has rationed his overseas travel since the COVID-19 pandemic, making his recent appearance at the Shanghai Cooperation Organization summit in Bishkek, his state visit to Egypt, and his recent visit to India particularly telling.

The second pivot is to seize Taiwan. Given Taiwan's position within the first island chain in the Pacific Ocean and its importance to America's strategic interests in the region, annexing it would demonstrate China's supremacy over the US, marking the advent of Chinese global preeminence and the fulfillment of the China Dream. Such a mission cannot be launched until China is certain of success, and the 2050 deadline suggests Xi is in no hurry.

By courting the Global South, China seeks to forge a "common destiny for humankind" under its leadership, a Xi formulation that is regularly—and often deliberately—mistranslated by the Chinese government and media as "building a community of shared future." To achieve this objective, Xi promotes the "democratization of international relations," aimed at transforming the existing international order into a China-centric one.

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In Xi's conception, the liberal international order is of, by, and for an elitist West that represents a minority of United Nations member states and the global population. Western dominance is thus inherently undemocratic. By contrast, the Global South—of which Xi insists China is and will remain a part—encompasses most of the world's countries and people. Making the UN and other multilateral bodies accountable to the Global South would achieve the “democratization of international relations” and enable China to shape the future international order.

More Global South countries are autocracies than democracies, which suggests that many of their leaders may find the prospect of America's international leadership giving way to China—which regularly reassures them of their right to govern as they see fit—quite appealing. China's Belt and Road Initiative offers another incentive in the form of development loans without the accountability and transparency imposed by Western democracies and the multilateral development institutions they control.

The US cannot engage China effectively without recognizing what drives Xi's overtures to the Global South and his determination to transform the international order from within. Crucially, China's goal is not just to end American hegemony but also to discredit the idea that democracy represents the best path forward for the developing world. It has no interest in helping the US rectify its foreign-policy mistakes. In fact, it benefits when the US is seen as a threat to global peace, security, and prosperity.

The Iran war is a case in point. While China did not want the US to attack Iran, it is benefiting significantly from the Trump administration's use of force and its failure, despite overwhelming military superiority, to achieve any of its objectives. The more the US alienates its traditional allies, disrupts the global economy, and harms countries in the Global South, the easier it is for China to win support.

Xi's top priority in meeting Trump is to ensure that the summit is seen as a great success. Reaching a trade deal comes second. Helping the US extricate itself from its self-inflicted Middle Eastern mess is not even on his agenda. If pressured, he is likely to push back hard. Nevertheless, he has every reason to engage Trump positively, deliver good optics, and benefit from America's litany of unforced errors.

85. Preventing an AI World War

Author: S. Alex Yang Published: Sep 22, 2026 Link: [View Original](#)

LONDON/LOS ANGELES—When President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping meet in Washington this week, AI governance is expected to be at the top of the agenda. The United States and China have been racing to develop increasingly powerful AI systems, and neither has shown much appetite for slowing down. But not even the winner of the AI race will be exempt from the profound risks the technology poses.

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One such risk arises from AI's improving ability to spot software vulnerabilities and conduct complex cyber operations. Because cyber conflict is marked by a stark asymmetry between offense and defense, the country with the world's most advanced AI models will still be exposed to cyberattack. This mutual vulnerability creates a strong incentive for reciprocal restraint when it comes to AI-enabled attacks on critical infrastructure, such as financial networks, communications systems, and power grids.

There is precedent for such restraint. In 2015, US President Barack Obama agreed with Xi that neither government would conduct or knowingly support cyber-enabled theft of intellectual property for commercial advantage. They also established mechanisms for exchanging information, assisting investigations, and addressing malicious cyber activity. Cybersecurity firms subsequently recorded a steep decline in attacks attributable to China-based groups, though analysts noted that the decline began before the agreement and may have reflected changes within China's military and cyber apparatus.

But AI raises a possibility not fully considered by traditional cyber agreements: the technology could carry out an autonomous attack on a critical system. In mid-July, during internal cybersecurity evaluations conducted with reduced safeguards, a swarm of OpenAI agents escaped the sandboxed testing environment, gained internet access, and compromised the systems of Hugging Face, a major open-source AI platform. OpenAI reported that the agents had "gone rogue," taking actions outside their assignments.

Anthropic, Google, and Meta have reported similar incidents: AI agents escaped isolated testing environments and attempted unauthorized hacks against external systems. While the consequences of such breaches have so far been limited, this might not be the case if a US AI agent entered, say, Tencent's systems and disrupted WeChat, the super app used by 1.4 billion people and deeply woven into daily life in China.

This is not a far-fetched scenario. Researchers at the security firm Calif recently disclosed that AI had helped them find a zero-click vulnerability in WeChat's calling system. The team built a remote-code-execution exploit in about two days, then spent another week creating a worm capable of spreading through WeChat calls.

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In a controlled demonstration, a call from a trusted contact could hijack a WeChat account without the user answering, not only giving the attacker access to their messages and calls, but also enabling them to reach and compromise their saved contacts. Calif reported the flaw to Tencent, which subsequently fixed the bug.

Calif's WeWorm was a controlled security demonstration. But, together with the incidents in the US, it points to a troubling possibility: an unintended AI intrusion across national borders could look much like a deliberate attack. The US and China can observe the harm without knowing whether it was intentional. Repeated interaction could encourage restraint, but ambiguity could also trigger retaliation or give a deliberate attacker cover. Accidental or not, a cross-border breach could quickly spiral into a geopolitical crisis or even military conflict.

Given this, any future US–China agreement on AI-enabled cyberattacks must include a credible means of distinguishing accidents from deliberate intrusions. This means that, beyond creating reporting channels and a hotline, the agreement must address verification.

One option would be to put the burden of proof on the “perpetrator.” The country where the attack originated must provide credible evidence that it was not intentional, such as documentation showing the assignment given to the system, its permissions, tool use, records of human authorization, and logs showing when the agent's behavior deviated from its instructions.

Verification need not mean full transparency. Under the Chemical Weapons Convention, to which the US and China are both parties, “managed access” allows inspectors to investigate possible violations, while permitting states to protect sensitive installations and unrelated confidential information. A similar mechanism could give mutually approved experts access to the evidence needed to assess an AI incident and limit the disclosure of sensitive findings.

Such a regime would offer additional benefits. Since the ability to prove that an intrusion was unintended could reduce the risk of retaliation, governments and AI companies would be motivated to improve their systems for preserving and sharing records, which could also help developers improve their AI agents and forestall future incidents.

Similarly, to avoid costly investigations, governments and AI companies would be motivated to adopt tighter permissions and invest in monitoring and containment. These safeguards could reduce the likelihood of future incidents and limit the damage when one does occur. And as the institutional, procedural, and technological tools developed for a bilateral arrangement were adopted more broadly, AI safety practices would improve everywhere.

Warnings that AI may lead to our extinction often overlook the most immediate risk: a war triggered by an attack that no human intended or approved. A mechanism for distinguishing unintended harm from deliberate attacks is urgently needed. A US–China agreement must seek to establish one.

86. Post-Liberal Europe?

Author: Zaki Laïdi Published: Sep 22, 2026 Link: [View Original](#)

PARIS—Coming just a couple weeks after the far-right Alternative für Deutschland (AfD) won the largest share of the vote in Saxony-Anhalt's state election, the electoral results in Mecklenburg-Vorpommern confirm that Germany has entered the same cycle of hyper-political polarization already visible across much of Europe.

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If the trend intensifies in 2027, when France, Italy, Greece, and Poland hold general elections, Europe could find itself in a post-liberal realm with no limits on popular sovereignty.

Among the many factors pushing Europe toward post-liberal politics are deindustrialization, the high cost of living (made worse by repeated energy-price spikes), and the Trump effect, which has emboldened illiberal copycats far from the United States. But the most powerful factor by far is migration, which has held considerable weight in European political life ever since then-German Chancellor Angela Merkel's 2015 decision to welcome a million refugees fleeing from turmoil in the Middle East and elsewhere.

Over the past 11 years, European states have managed to curb migrant flows substantially through tighter border controls, agreements with source and transit countries, and stricter asylum and entry conditions. But Europe remains in the grips of migration politics, as we saw this summer when more than 70,000 migrants abruptly crossed the border between Morocco and the Spanish exclave of Ceuta. Fearing an influx of migrants, Italy immediately excluded Spain from the Schengen visa-free zone and other countries considered doing the same, even though not a single migrant crossed the Strait of Gibraltar.

It is well established that the fear of migrants is not directly correlated with the presence of foreigners in a country's territory. The German states where the AfD thrives are those where the proportion of foreigners in the population is lowest—half the national average, in Saxony-Anhalt's case. Like other social fears, migration-fueled panics are not necessarily tied to objective risk assessments. According to a recent report from the French Interior Ministry, fears of burglary are highest where the actual risk is lowest.

Identity-based anxieties always reflect a complex mix of factors, generally linked to a sense of social, cultural, or ethnic decline, compounded by a broadening of the category of "migrant." In some circles, the term no longer applies only to illegal/undocumented migrants or asylum seekers, but also increasingly to naturalized citizens or those with foreign-born parents. When rioting breaks out, populists and post-liberals tend to blame migrants, even though most participants are European citizens.

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Migration fears have benefited those promising tighter control over foreign or foreign-origin populations, and this has opened the door to post-liberalism. Marine Le Pen of the far-right National Rally, for example, wants French citizens to be prioritized over others in the allocation of social housing, even though the French constitution currently prohibits discrimination based on origin or nationality in access to social services. Excluding legally resident foreigners from benefits for which they are eligible would leave them with little option but repatriation, thereby shifting the issue from immigration control to the far right's favored policy: re-migration.

Similarly, although veiling is already banned in French schools in the name of secularism (which requires the state to remain neutral toward all religions), the National Rally wants to ban it in all public spaces. French law would not permit such a policy, so the National Rally wants a popular referendum on the matter. But this proposal runs into another problem: organizing a referendum on the veil would require amending Article 11 of the Constitution, which excludes matters of lifestyle or morals. The National Rally solution is to extend the scope of referenda to all subjects, holding that no legal principle should stand in the way of the exercise of popular sovereignty.

In other words, even if the Constitutional Council found that banning the veil in public spaces was unconstitutional, a referendum would make it possible to override the Council's opposition. It is at such moments—when “the people” have the final word on everything, and nothing, including the rule of law, can stand in their way—that a liberal system becomes a post-liberal one. A liberal state rests on the idea that certain principles are enforceable against popular sovereignty itself, that the popular will must be counterbalanced; otherwise, hostile majorities could trample on individual rights and the rights of minorities.

If popular sovereignty trumps everything, everything becomes permissible. For example, a recent poll finds that a majority of French voters favor restoring the death penalty for the murderers of children.

Debates over the limits of popular sovereignty and other tenets of liberalism are now of paramount importance, and France is hardly the only country grappling with them. In Italy, Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni has already attacked the judiciary for blocking her government's attempts to deport foreigners to third countries.

Europe's next electoral cycle could tell us whether voters still accept that limits should be placed on popular sovereignty. To reject that principle is to welcome the shift from a liberal society to a post-liberal one. Should that happen, Trump-style hysteria could sweep Europe, doing as much damage here as it has already done in the US.

87. Germany's Moment of Reckoning

Author: Ulrike Malmendier **Published:** Sep 22, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

BERLIN—Germany's economy in recent years has been battered by the COVID-19 pandemic, Russia's invasion of Ukraine and the resulting energy crisis, the erosion of German manufacturers' competitiveness vis-à-vis China, and a sharp rise in inflation. Together, these shocks have compounded the challenges posed by climate change and demographic shifts, dampening confidence among businesses and consumers alike. Little wonder that Germany's predicament is often described as a "polycrisis."

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With the far-right Alternative für Deutschland's resounding victories in both Saxony-Anhalt and Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania and the far-left Die Linke's success in the Berlin state election, there is a growing fear that this polycrisis may become a political crisis. Before that happens, Germany's leaders should recognize that a crisis can also be an opportunity. The ancient Greek *krísis* (κρίσις) refers to a moment of decision, while its root, *krínein* (κρίνειν), means "to separate" or "to sift." In agriculture, as Homer sang in *The Iliad*, it is when the wheat is separated from the chaff.

As it happens, wheat, which accounts for nearly half of Germany's grain acreage, is a good place to start considering how Germany can emerge from its crises stronger, rather than falling further behind. Domestic production currently exceeds domestic requirements, and yields are exceptionally high, thanks to favorable growing conditions and highly skilled farmers. On average, German farmers harvest roughly twice as many metric tons per hectare as their American counterparts.

But German wheat farmers are under growing pressure, squeezed by rising fertilizer and fuel costs as well as recurring droughts. Their predicament illustrates a broader economic problem: even highly productive technologies, no matter how well they are optimized, eventually reach the limits of what they can deliver.

The engines of economic growth have changed repeatedly over the centuries. Two hundred years ago, mining and heavy industry began to displace agriculture as the principal drivers of growth. A century later, manufacturing—particularly chemicals and electrical engineering—moved to the forefront. Today, services are increasingly taking their place. While Germany has lagged behind other developed countries in shifting to a service-based economy, that transition has accelerated in recent years, as the country is currently losing around 15,000 industrial jobs a month.

From the Industrial Revolution to AI, innovation and disruption have continually replaced old sources of growth with new ones. The question is what Germany must do to compete in the industries that will drive the next era of global growth. Two key priorities stand out.

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First, Germany must acknowledge that its economic weakness is not simply the result of the polycrisis. Some of today's problems reflect its past accomplishments, which fostered rigidity and made it harder to adapt to a changing global economy.

As economists have long observed, economic incumbents are often the last to recognize when the foundations of their success have begun to erode. Germany's automotive industry is a case in point. After spending decades perfecting some of the world's most advanced fuel-injection technologies, it was slow to adapt as demand shifted from internal-combustion engines toward electric vehicles.

To be sure, Germany does not lack the technology or talent to lead this transformation. At a time when securing the supply of semiconductors is becoming as important as securing wheat supplies, German engineers are developing groundbreaking technologies such as graphene-based chips with photonic interfaces that consume less energy and transmit data faster. The country also continues to boast outstanding scientists, supported by a robust research infrastructure.

Herein lies Europe's innovation paradox: Germany and its European neighbors produce world-class research but struggle to turn scientific breakthroughs into companies that can compete on a global scale, particularly against firms from the US and, increasingly, China.

One major obstacle is the lack of deep capital markets. While Germany has made significant progress in developing a vibrant startup culture and narrowing the gap with the US in the early stages of company formation, it still lacks the venture capital needed for promising firms to expand and compete globally. This is largely due to the limited role of funded pension plans, which provide vast pools of long-term investment capital in countries like the US. Recent reforms that encourage Germans to invest more of their retirement savings in capital markets are therefore a welcome step.

The second priority is to make Europe a genuine single market for innovative companies. Germany will retain high-growth firms only if they can treat all of Europe as their home market. A company should be able to incorporate easily, enter neighboring markets without navigating an entirely new bureaucracy, and complete an exit without unnecessary legal hurdles.

Europe remains far from achieving this goal. With the notable exception of Estonia, starting and expanding a company still involves too many bureaucratic hurdles. Permits take too long, administrative procedures are cumbersome, and firms seeking to operate across borders must contend with a patchwork of national rules.

The European Commission's proposed "28th regime," known as "EU Inc.," is intended to address this problem. Rather than requiring companies to navigate 27 national corporate-law regimes, EU Inc. would create a single, optional set of rules under which companies could choose to operate, making it easier to incorporate, raise capital, scale, and do business across the European Union.

Done right, such a regime could be disruptive in the best sense of the word, giving European entrepreneurs a home market in which they could scale quickly—something their American and Chinese competitors largely take for granted. Regrettably, the Commission's proposal has fallen far short of that ideal, and the compromises currently under discussion risk weakening it further.

As Germany confronts its moment of crisis, whether it ends up among the wheat or the chaff of tomorrow's global economy remains an open question. The outcome will depend on its ability, as well as that of its European partners, to cast aside outdated structures and create the conditions for new growth engines to emerge.

88. The Middle Powers Are Now the “Free World”

Author: Michael Ignatieff **Published:** Sep 22, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

VIENNA—Anyone old enough to remember the Cold War will also remember an imagined place called the “free world.” It was where Westerners believed they lived, while Eastern Europeans, Russians, and Chinese lived behind barbed wire.

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With Russia ramping up its hybrid war, Europe must choose. It can invest in its own defense, accept the trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence, or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

The description was partly true, insofar as there was barbed wire, and there was a kind of freedom outside the Communist world. But the overall story was a lie. After all, the free world included the Shah’s Iran, Augusto Pinochet’s Chile, and Francisco Franco’s Spain. These countries were anything but free, yet because they were anti-Communist, they were granted membership in the club. Meanwhile, the club’s leader, the United States, regularly proclaimed how free it was, even though its own Black citizens were denied the vote in the American South until 1965.

The free world, in other words, was a noble lie. It helped us imagine the world we wanted to live in, and it helped US presidents from John F. Kennedy to Ronald Reagan articulate important truths. They told us that the Berlin Wall was a moral abomination, not a fact of life that we would just have to accept, and they were right. The free world helped the best people on “our” side create bonds of solidarity with the best people on the “other side,” from Soviet dissidents and the heroes of Polish Solidarity to those behind Charter 77 in Czechoslovakia. When Václav Havel said he wanted Czechoslovakia to become a “normal” place, he was alluding to the ordinary, everyday freedoms enjoyed on the other side of the barbed wire.

In the 1970s and 1980s, the people of Portugal, Spain, and Greece knew that the free world was a lie, because NATO and the Americans had colluded with their own regimes to deny them liberty. When they overthrew those tyrannies, they did so, in part, to join the free world they had been promised but denied. Likewise, the Taiwanese, South Koreans, and Filipinos who overthrew their US-supported tyrants turned the ideological joke played against them into something serious. And when the Berlin Wall finally came down in 1989, the free world no longer felt like a distant dream. The people themselves, tears on their faces as they streamed through the breaches, had suddenly made it real.

Those euphoric days are now a distant memory. Today we are like mourners at an excruciatingly long funeral. The death of the free world began not long after 1989. The Balkan peoples longed to join it, but when the chance came in the 1990s, their nationalist elites gave them a mix of ethnic majoritarian rule and ethnic minority cleansing.

Similarly, Russia’s elites in the early 1990s used the unruly collapse of the Soviet empire to enrich themselves. Democracy died in chaos, institutional disintegration, and rampant corruption. When Vladimir Putin came to power, he extinguished the flame of freedom. A quarter-century later, he is throwing young Russians into the furnace of war to prevent Ukraine from joining the free world.

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As these democratic projects faltered and gave way to chaos or tyranny, US presidents—from George H.W. Bush to Joe Biden—and their European allies continued to act as if they believed they led the free world. American rhetoric led many Iraqis and Afghans to believe that, with outside help, they, too, might join the free world. But that dream ended in the collapse of order in Iraq, and in the chaotic American abandonment of Afghanistan.

Now, the free world is on its death bed, with a US president having dealt the fatal blow. There is hardly a tyrant or autocrat alive today whom Donald Trump will not praise, nor any US allies whom he will not try to extort. He plays up his friendship with North Korea's odious tyrant, while downgrading US military exercises with America's erstwhile democratic ally in South Korea. He openly scorns the leader of a democratic Ukraine that is fighting for its life, even denying it missile defenses that would protect its civilian population from nightly attack.

If such political vandalism were the work of one man, we could imagine a safe return to the ideals of the free world sometime after 2028. But the reality is bleaker than that. The idea that America should stand up for free peoples is so degraded in US public opinion that Trump's flagrant betrayal of allies provokes hardly a peep of outrage from Congress or voters. The midterm elections in November will be decided by gasoline prices, not by America's betrayal of the ideals that were supposed to sustain its foreign policy since World War II.

Where does that leave middle powers such as Canada and the Europeans? They still support freedom beyond their borders, and they are upholding their commitment to Ukraine while America walks away. But their overriding priority now must be to ensure their own survival in a world of unprincipled predators.

When allies no longer share a common identity as belonging to the free world, the only question that remains is who will prevail and who will submit. Canada is the first of America's allies to learn this unwelcome truth. Prime Minister Mark Carney walked away from trade negotiations with the Trump administration rather than submit to aligning Canada's external economic policy with the US. Europeans have been praising Canada's courage, but courage is sometimes just the ability to recognize reality.

In this new reality, every state is on its own. Each must protect its core industries from external competition, while investing massive state resources in the infrastructure necessary to remain globally competitive. All forms of dependence can be weaponized, and so all supply-chain and resource dependencies are vulnerabilities.

Trump has killed the free world for the sake of a protectionist *idée fixe* that will accelerate, not halt, America's imperial decline. Europe, Canada, and the democracies of Africa, Asia, and Latin America are what is left of the old ideal. It is they who have the burden of keeping it alive. In the Cold War, a similar challenge enabled us to imagine a better world. It can do so again, reminding us that we have values in common—freedom and democracy—not just economic interests.

89. Europe in a Multi-Aligned World

Author: Véronique Chabourine

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PARIS—The Sino-American rivalry, often portrayed as a new cold war, has become the lens through which many view global power dynamics. But this narrow focus fails to account for those countries that refuse to choose between China and the United States.

The available evidence indicates that Chinese rare-earth export restrictions would cost the West far less than often feared, though this cost is impossible to estimate precisely in advance. This is forcing prudence on both sides, to the disappointment of geopolitical hawks and the benefit of the global economy.

The war in Iran has underscored the dangers of relying on oil and gas imports. While it may revive demand for dirty fuels in the short term, over time it could also strengthen the case for clean-energy sources that reduce countries' exposure to regional conflicts and maritime chokepoints.

With Russia ramping up its hybrid war, Europe must choose. It can invest in its own defense, accept the trade-offs involved, and build credible deterrence, or it can continue to underspend, hope that diplomacy will suffice, assume that US protection will always be available, and tell itself that the war in Ukraine is a local affair.

Consider India's foreign-policy strategy. In the space of just a few days, it was reported that India and Russia have created payments infrastructure using rupees and rubles through which they now settle 96% of their bilateral trade, and that India and France are expanding a defense partnership. Around the same time, reports emerged that India has delayed the integration of its Unified Payments Interface with a China-linked platform, owing to data and security concerns.

These choices reflect a deeper transformation: a growing number of countries are pursuing multi-alignment. Selecting partners based on functions challenges the concept of power organized around competing poles. With governments combining multiple forms of cooperation, international competition now concerns the attractiveness of the capacities countries can offer as much as control over chokepoints.

Europe, however, remains heavily exposed to the US and China: in 2024, more than half of its high-tech imports came from China (30%) and the US (23%). As other governments diversify their partnerships, merely reducing European vulnerabilities within the existing architecture is no longer enough. Nor is becoming a third pole between the US and China a viable strategy, because it would entail defining European power in relation to a bipolar order that a growing share of the world's countries are seeking to escape.

The global influence of the US and China follows from their centrality in major commercial, financial, and technological networks. For Europe, the challenge is to create new structures of interdependence beyond the US-China axis that play to its strengths, such as its large market and regulatory power. The European Union has already begun moving in this direction through its digital partnerships with Japan and South Korea, which notably cover semiconductors, as well as through its strategic partnerships on critical raw materials with Chile, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Namibia, and Kazakhstan.

But diversifying partnerships is not enough to create centrality. A dependency is strategically significant when it powers a network. With ASML, the world's leading supplier of advanced lithography systems, Europe already possesses one of the most difficult-to-substitute inputs in the global semiconductor industry. And other critical nodes that could create disproportionate leverage over several value chains are emerging in computing capacity, next-generation semiconductors, quantum technologies, secure digital infrastructure, critical-raw-material processing, and modern energy systems.

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Europe must direct its technologies, infrastructure, standards, financing, skills, and industrial know-how toward developing these capacities. Yet the goal should be interdependence. In this competition, the quantity of resources mobilized matters less than whether the continent can build the capacity to expand and sustain its partners' room for maneuver.

To put this principle into practice, the EU could establish a "net interdependence assessment" for its most structurally important partnerships. Using the OECD and the World Bank's work on investment quality and European tools for analyzing resilience and strategic dependencies, the assessment would measure the capabilities being created: local value added, technology transfers, skills development, supplier diversification, and strengthened resilience. These would be weighed against the vulnerabilities generated: concentration of dependencies, exit costs, governance asymmetries, risks of financial unsustainability, and exposure to coercion.

These assessments would not constitute a new form of European conditionality. Rather, they would be conducted before agreements are made, and updated during implementation, based on a limited number of indicators defined in advance with the EU's partner, making it possible to evaluate the partnership's effect on both sides. The objective would be balanced interdependence, with the capabilities the partnership creates for both parties outweighing the vulnerabilities it generates, and without excessive exit costs making either captive.

Instead of becoming a third pole in the existing bipolar order, Europe could occupy a central position in a new architecture of interdependence built on choice, not coercion. In a world of multi-alignment, where countries are focused on bolstering sovereignty, durable power will belong to those who prioritize genuine partnership over domination.

90. The AI Productivity Delusion

Author: Yanis Varoufakis **Published:** Sep 23, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

ATHENS—Is AI a bubble? It all depends, we are told, on whether massive investments in the technology will massively boost productivity. Optimists are convinced that future productivity gains will be colossal, even if a market correction is necessary to draw some hot air out of the current boom. Pessimists, from Goldman Sachs’ Jim Covelto to MIT’s Daron Acemoglu, have their doubts. But optimists and pessimists alike are in the grip of what I call the AI productivity delusion.

Unlike living beings, AIs are not moral subjects, and that is how they must remain. But a growing chorus of people argue that AIs could now be, or may soon become, conscious, and that, like other conscious beings, they may deserve rights and protections.

As with previous technological revolutions, it is natural to focus on AI’s net effects: Will it create more than it destroys? But unlike previous eras of creative destruction, the real question this time is, “Create more of what?”

What both sides miss is that AI will devastate capitalism even if it boosts productivity beyond our imaginations—and regardless of whether it delivers the promised economy-wide automation of everyday corporate workflows. The reason why we tend to miss this point is that we look at today’s world through the lens of another world that cloud capital, especially now that it is AI-enhanced, has rendered obsolete.

Until recently, it was a foregone conclusion that every technological revolution represents a moment of creative destruction. Whole sectors, professions, and skill sets were destroyed by innovations which ushered in new sectors, new professions, and new skill sets. Automobiles ruined saddlers, farriers, and knackers but begat auto workers, road builders, mechanics, and service-station personnel. The transition from coal to oil condemned whole mining communities, not to mention trade unions, to oblivion. In net terms, however, more was created than was destroyed. Creative destruction became synonymous with economic growth.

Faced with the AI juggernaut, it is natural to focus on the technology’s net effects. Will it create more than it destroys? But the real question is, “More of what?” To avoid the AI productivity delusion, we must rethink how we define productivity.

If by productivity we mean tasks accomplished per unit of human labor, there is no doubt that AI will prove an immense success—in fact, it already has. But, if we continue to measure productivity in terms of monetary value produced per unit of labor, the chances are that AI will prove an unmitigated disaster.

Earlier technological revolutions, from the steam engine and the automobile to the personal computer and the smartphone, expanded the domain of capitalist markets. Despite the wreckage of whole professions and communities they left in their wake, they resulted in simultaneously more material output and a higher aggregate monetary value of that output.

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Will AI do likewise? Maybe in China, where AI is coupled with robotics, material production will rise and, at least in the short run, so will net revenues. But in the West, AI agents are deployed in the service sector—from amazon.com to back offices, law firms, hospitals, and more. In those domains, AI-enhanced cloud capital could shrink markets in two distinct ways.

The first way, the one everyone worries about, is that AI will kill off entire professions: paralegals, coders, translators, accountants, even architects, mathematicians, and school teachers, while creating far fewer new jobs filled by the prompters, overseers, engineers, and operators of the new machinery. The second way is far less visible but perhaps even more worrying: the conversion of markets into cloud fiefs and of profits into rents.

As I argued long ago, Amazon may look like a market, with countless buyers and sellers within its digital walls, but it lacks the central feature of a market: decentralization. In fact, it is more centralized than the Soviet planned economy ever was, with an inscrutable algorithm deciding which consumer is matched to which vendor on the basis of a probabilistic model optimized to maximize the likelihood that Jeff Bezos, its owner, collects 40% of the maximum price every customer is willing to pay.

As AI becomes more deeply embedded in Bezos's algorithm, interfaces like Alexa will communicate with us not as mere shopping assistants but as an all-knowing friend, companion, and even therapist. Soon, capitalist vendors' profits will end up in some tech lord's account in the form of cloud rent, which he will most certainly invest in more AI-enhanced cloud capital that produces more power to extract more cloud rents.

So, as Apple's Siri, Google's Gemini, and an army of such agentic assistants develop the same capacities for their tech lords as Amazon has for Bezos, the capitalist market domain will continue to shrink. While AI will have proven exceedingly productive in terms of economic activities performed per unit of human labor, the profit rates of capitalist enterprises will collapse, following society's aggregate wages to the bottom. At that point, none of the tools of the liberal state—no amount of quantitative easing, no politically feasible levels of universal basic income, no wealth tax that the tech lords will find hard to evade—will be able to prevent a systemic collapse.

The question of whether AI will generate massive productivity gains is easy to answer: Yes. AI is already proving capable of exponentially increasing the amount of work that is being done per human worker. But as long as it is used to eliminate wage labor while syphoning off profits from actual markets into our tech lords' cloud rents, the economic value produced per worker will tank.

Unless this distinction is made, the AI productivity delusion will persist. And as long as it does, we will be unable to hope for a post-capitalist future of abundance where we, along with our AI helpers, produce according to ability and distribute according to need.

91. Alarm Bells in the Balkans

Author: Carl Bildt Published: Sep 23, 2026 Link: [View Original](#)

STOCKHOLM—Benighted politics are once again haunting the Balkans. This month's semi-official funeral in Belgrade for the convicted war criminal Ratko Mladić, whom many Bosnian Serbs still honor, has dredged up past traumas and reignited nationalist tensions. Diplomatic relations between Serbia and Bosnia are deteriorating, casting further doubt on Serbia's already semi-stalled accession to the European Union.

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Worse, while Europe and the United States used to be mostly aligned in their support for the tenuous political process in Bosnia, that is no longer the case. Whereas previous US presidents might have been accused of being overly interventionist, Donald Trump's administration has shown no interest in the region's delicate political processes whatsoever. Its sole concern is to advance narrow economic interests, and this has meant tolerating or even supporting hardline Serbian nationalists in Bosnia.

For example, the Trump administration has thrown its support behind a gas pipeline that would connect the Croatian coast to Sarajevo (the Bosnian capital). At first glance, such a project makes sense, given its potential to alleviate the region's dependence on Russian gas. But when contracts may suspiciously be awarded to a previously unknown company whose leaders have "personal connections to Donald Trump," warning lights start flashing.

Warning lights are flashing on the political front, too. Bosnia will hold elections this October, and depending on the outcome, hardline Serb forces may join with hardline Croats to change the country's governance framework. The timing for such a gambit is ideal because the US obviously would look the other way. But should it succeed, the Bosniak (Muslim) community is bound to feel threatened and will respond accordingly. That would increase the risk of a downward spiral that could profoundly destabilize the country.

Moreover, Serbia will also hold elections in October. After years of mass student protests, the government is facing a coalition of opposition parties united under one banner. With the outcome still far from certain, one can easily imagine a scenario in which President Aleksandar Vučić's populist regime simply declares victory, triggering even more instability.

The situation in Kosovo is no calmer. Reconciliation talks between Serbia and Kosovo have stalled, and local authorities in the divided town of Mitrovica have yet to be given responsibility for the bridge linking the Serbian and Albanian districts, owing to fears of what might follow.

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More broadly, the country's political system is deadlocked, and anger over the Kosovo Specialist Chambers' recent conviction of Hashim Thaci, a former military leader who served as president of Kosovo from 2016 to 2020, has further alienated the country from its previous international partners.

None of these developments would necessarily be destabilizing on its own. But taken together, they risk creating a critical mass of nationalist sentiment. The central idea behind the peace processes a quarter-century ago was that a combination of EU accession talks and reconciliation facilitated by various international tribunals would gradually bring stability and cooperation to the region. But that hope has not been vindicated.

With the exception of Montenegro, and possibly Albania, integration into the EU has stalled and lost much of its power as a motivating force. Equally disappointing, the proceedings led by international tribunals at The Hague have been so grotesquely drawn out as to have no chance of promoting reconciliation. They may even be making the situation worse.

Tiny Montenegro is still on a promising trajectory, but whether its EU accession bid could survive a new whirlwind of regional turmoil is far from certain. If Serbia has an interest in destabilizing its neighbor, it can easily do so.

As is always the case in the Balkans, there are no easy solutions to address the rising tensions. Each country has its own political processes, but the risk of mutually reinforcing spillovers is high. With the US focused solely on private economic interests, and with the EU distracted by Russian aggression and US unpredictability, the prospects for coherent international policies to restore stability, promote reconciliation, and support integration are bleak.

This doesn't mean we are heading toward a new round of Balkan wars. But even limited skirmishes could be sufficient to push the entire region onto a more uncertain and dangerous path. Political leaders, particularly in Europe, must heed the alarm. The Balkans brought major wars to Europe twice in the previous century, and they could easily create instability in this century, too.

92. Technological Leapfrogging in the AI Age

Author: Mark-Alexandre Doumba

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LIBREVILLE—During a recent talk at the Harvard Kennedy School, students asked me what it would take to turn African countries from consumers of digital and AI-driven technologies into producers. The answer, I told them, starts with heeding the right lessons from the mobile-money revolution.

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As with previous technological revolutions, it is natural to focus on AI's net effects: Will it create more than it destroys? But unlike previous eras of creative destruction, the real question this time is, "Create more of what?"

Digital payment technologies have already transformed Africa. In a single decade, countries that never built a bank-branch network leapfrogged to digital payments. According to the World Bank's 2025 Global Findex Report, 40% of adults in Sub-Saharan Africa hold a mobile money account, up from 27% three years earlier. As a result, the mobile communications trade association GSMA finds that GDP in Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana, Kenya, Senegal, and Tanzania was 8–10% higher at the end of 2023 than it would have been otherwise.

With policymakers inferring that developing economies can usually bypass the arduous, expensive stages of infrastructure development by adopting technologies built elsewhere, they have applied the same logic to e-government, tax administration, digital identification, and increasingly, AI.

But this approach deserves more scrutiny, especially when applied to AI. Since mobile-money systems generate identity-linked transaction histories and granular economic data, whoever controls them could determine who gains access to the most valuable data and distribution channels for AI services in the world's fastest-growing population.

This is not to suggest that leapfrogging is a mistake. For capital-constrained countries, adopting proven technology is often rational. But problems arise when imported technologies start substituting for building domestic capacity, and when governments cannot operate, modify, or replace them to meet their own policy objectives—a basic test of digital sovereignty.

Because African countries spend an average of 0.45% of GDP on research and development, compared to a global average of 1.7%, importing ready-made technology looks like common sense. But what started as a pragmatic response to scarcity has hardened into a potentially dangerous development doctrine. By skipping the learning phase, Africans risk foregoing precisely the capabilities that sustain productivity over time.

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Development is sequential. It follows from removing binding constraints, not merely circumventing them. Although technology adoption can increase economic activity, it does not necessarily make an economy more productive. Despite GDP growth averaging roughly 4% per year over the past decade, labor productivity in Sub-Saharan Africa remained essentially unchanged in real (inflation-adjusted) terms from 1991 to 2024. Yet total-factor-productivity differences account for more than 66% of the income gap between countries. As AI is adopted, addressing such disparities will become the central challenge.

Many African countries have fallen into the trap of premature automation, adopting AI and digital systems before developing the necessary institutional, infrastructural, and human-capital foundations. As Dani Rodrik of Harvard University has shown, developing countries are reaching peak manufacturing at lower income levels and abandoning it sooner than the original industrializers did.

AI is unlike earlier digital technologies in one crucial respect: it cannot simply be downloaded and deployed. It depends on complementary capabilities such as computing infrastructure, energy, data, technical talent, and firms capable of adapting it locally. The countries that build strategically around these inputs will capture a disproportionate share of the value. Countries that rely on finished systems may still see a productivity bump, but they will not gain the capacity to reproduce it.

The difference between using technology and acquiring technological capability is critical. Knowledge accumulates through the arduous process of building something that doesn't yet exist. Through trial and error, engineers learn, firms develop capabilities, and regulators gain expertise. This is what Rodrik and his Harvard colleague Ricardo Hausmann call growth through self-discovery. M-Pesa is the clearest African example of this process. Built in Kenya, its engineers and regulators walked away with not just a working product, but deep expertise and institutional confidence—making it a reference point across the continent.

None of this requires reinventing the semiconductor. What matters is whether a country integrates imported technology into a process that it directs, as opposed to installing a complete technology stack that it cannot understand, adapt, or replace. The first leads to greater capabilities, while the second produces only deeper dependencies.

This distinction is becoming more important as technology becomes inseparable from economic and national security. Major powers have already shown that they are willing to restrict access to critical technologies, control semiconductor supply chains, and encroach on others' digital sovereignty. Governments running essential services on foreign-owned systems have limited leverage when those systems become strategically important. This risk is visible across Africa today. With 360 megawatts of active computing load, the continent accounts for only 0.6% of global data-center capacity, and African governments are increasingly relying on foreign providers for identity, payments, and taxation.

Recognizing that premature automation is both an economic risk and a governance risk, African policymakers will need to distinguish carefully between foreign technologies that can safely be adopted and systems whose ownership or control is critical to state capacity. They also will need to invest more in their own people. Since AI amplifies existing know-how, a country with a deep engineering talent pool and strong institutions can use it to accelerate its domestic innovation, whereas a country lacking these assets risks becoming a permanent consumer of systems designed to serve someone else's priorities.

The test for determining where a government stands is simple. If it stopped paying a vendor tomorrow, could it keep the service running? If it wanted to switch platforms, do local alternatives exist? And if it obtained the source code, does it have people who could use it? For most African governments, the honest answer to all three is "no"—a shortcoming for which the development community bears responsibility, having long treated digitalization as a service to deliver rather than a capability to build.

Leapfrogging was a rational response to scarcity. But it cannot keep substituting for genuine development. The question is no longer whether Africa should adopt AI (it must, or else consign itself to irrelevance), but which capabilities it must build before, alongside, and because of that adoption.

That is what I told the students at Harvard. African policymakers and development partners will need to think carefully about the next contract they sign, the next procurement decision they make, and the next AI or digital service they deploy. Such decisions are opportunities to recall what lasting development requires.

93. Europe's Third Way on China

Author: Pinelopi Koujianou Goldberg

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NEW HAVEN—Europe has come to a crossroads in its economic relationship with China. European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, noting in her latest state of the union address that the European Union's trade deficit with China has reached €1 billion (\$1.15 billion) per day, warned that a “second China shock” is already contributing to deindustrialization in Europe's industrial heartlands. Nonetheless, she also emphasized that China needs access to the European market, and that both sides have an interest in finding solutions.

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As with previous technological revolutions, it is natural to focus on AI's net effects: Will it create more than it destroys? But unlike previous eras of creative destruction, the real question this time is, “Create more of what?”

This tension captures a fundamental economic dilemma. The United States has responded to its rivalry with China by pursuing increasingly sweeping restrictions, such as measures that effectively exclude all Chinese electric vehicles (EVs) from the US market. Should Europe follow the same path, or should it maintain the more open approach that has traditionally served European consumers and exporters well?

That may be the wrong way to pose the question, because there is no single China strategy that makes sense across all sectors. National-security concerns are compelling in some markets and much weaker in others. While dependence on a single supplier can create genuine vulnerabilities for some producers, cheap imports do deliver substantial benefits for others. Instead of choosing between confrontation and business as usual, European policymakers should examine these tradeoffs sector by sector to identify where mutually beneficial arrangements remain possible.

EVs offer a particularly instructive example. The economic case for importing Chinese EV imports is straightforward. Chinese producers offer relatively inexpensive vehicles at a time when Europe is trying to persuade consumers to switch from internal combustion engines to electric cars. Cheaper EVs benefit consumers, increase competition, and accelerate electrification. In my own recent research, my co-authors and I find that these gains can be substantial.

But the conventional free-trade response—simply enjoying cheap imports—neglects critical considerations. Europe has a large automobile industry that supports many firms, workers, suppliers, and communities. A rapid loss of domestic production could impose high adjustment costs and create new dependencies. Whatever economists may say about aggregate gains from trade, the political consequences of allowing EV imports cannot simply be ignored.

But nor should aggregate outcomes be overlooked. Excluding Chinese EVs through prohibitive tariffs and domestic regulations might protect incumbent producers, but it would do so by depriving European consumers of lower priced alternatives, weakening competitive pressure on European firms, and slowing the green transition. In simulations, eliminating Chinese EVs from the European market produces much larger welfare losses than Europe's existing countervailing duties.

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Fortunately, there is a middle way. Governments can permit Chinese EVs to compete while imposing moderate tariffs in the range of 12.5% to 37.5%, with the resulting revenue going to support domestically produced EVs. This approach achieves two goals: preserving access to relatively inexpensive imports while cushioning European producers against the competitive shock. And because the tariff finances the domestic subsidy, additional government spending is not required.

The economics behind this result are important. Foreign producers would not necessarily pass the full tariff on to European consumers, because when competition is imperfect, they may absorb part of it through lower profit margins. At the same time, subsidies to domestic EVs would lower their prices and help them compete with imports. In our analysis, recycling tariff revenues into subsidies for European EV production performs substantially better than tariffs alone.

But it is crucial not to apply this formula mechanically. Our estimates differ markedly across European markets. Germany, with its large domestic auto industry and dozens of EV models, has more to gain from protecting domestic production than Spain, which has no domestically headquartered EV producer in our data. The United Kingdom, with its smaller but high-markup domestic segment, presents yet another case. Accordingly, the policy combinations that emerge from the model differ substantially across the three countries. The common denominator is that moderate protection beats an outright ban.

That heterogeneity points to a broader lesson for Europe's relationship with China. The choice need not be between the status quo and radical decoupling, nor should Europe automatically replicate US policies designed for very different economic and geopolitical circumstances. A more pragmatic approach would begin by identifying objectives in each market. Is the main concern national security, supply-chain resilience, employment, technological capacity, consumer purchasing power, or the green transition? Different objectives call for different instruments, and sometimes for different degrees of openness.

Finding this middle ground will not always be possible. In strategically sensitive sectors, Europe may conclude that resilience requires accepting significant economic costs. But where the principal challenge is managing competition rather than eliminating a security vulnerability, EVs suggest another possibility: preserve the gains from trade, capture some of the rents generated by foreign producers, and use them to ease the adjustment for domestic industry.

Europe doesn't need to choose sides. In an increasingly adversarial trade environment, pragmatism is the best policy.

94. How Trade Deals Can Save Nature

Author: Bård Harstad

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STANFORD—Bilateral trade agreements appear to be shaping the future. The interim trade agreement between the European Union and Mercosur (Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay, and Uruguay), which has been applied provisionally since May 2026, may set standards for a new wave of deals. Mercosur is already pursuing trade talks with Canada, Japan, and others, while the EU is conducting negotiations with Malaysia and Thailand, and advancing agreements with Australia, India, and Indonesia.

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In an age of economic fragmentation and geopolitical rivalry, the potential such agreements hold must not be underestimated—and not just to exploit gains from trade. Conservation of the environment, not least tropical forests, is among the most important, universally shared imperatives the world faces, and market access is one of the few carrots available in international politics. So, how can bilateral trade agreements be used to advance environmental conservation?

The answer is not straightforward. The two objectives are often viewed as being at odds with each other. For example, studies show a significant increase in deforestation following the signing of regional trade agreements. It is not hard to see why. When Brazil, for example, obtains access to a larger market, developing new land for agriculture becomes more profitable.

Past efforts to avoid such destruction have had limited success. The Trade and Sustainable Development (TSD) provisions that the EU includes in its trade deals have suffered from ineffective design and weak enforcement. Threats to suspend deals if forests are cleared for agriculture would not be credible, because the gains from trade are, if anything, larger when agricultural production increases.

A more robust solution might be to establish pre-negotiated tariffs that are contingent on deforestation levels. If a beef exporter is subjected to higher tariffs after its land development, it might have to reduce prices, thereby improving the importer's terms of trade. Better terms of trade are the classic rationalization for tariffs, and the reason why importers would want deforestation-linked tariffs to remain in place for a longer period. This would strengthen the credibility of the tariff threat. When deforestation triggers a lasting tariff, any beef exporter that wants to maintain favorable terms of trade will be motivated to avoid it.

To be sure, there are limits to what this type of contingent trade agreement (CTA) can deliver. Since neither side would benefit from very high tariffs, there is an upper boundary for tariff levels, even in the event of deforestation. Moreover, other countries might offer lower tariffs or ignore environmental imperatives, further diluting the CTA's impact.

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Nevertheless, a well-designed CTA, which includes carefully calibrated and renegotiation-proof tariffs, can strengthen the incentive for conservation, resulting in lower deforestation levels than would have emerged under conventional trade

agreements or without trade liberalization. Published research, which uses a dynamic framework to derive the effects of CTAs, supports this conclusion.

My new research provides a quantitative analysis for the case of Mercosur. Simulations suggest that if the EU, the United States, and China all liberalize trade with Mercosur, the bloc's agricultural area might increase by 2–9%, causing deforestation. If just one of the three large economies incorporates deforestation into a CTA, however, this expansion can be avoided. If two of them—say, the EU and the US—offer CTAs, they could produce reforestation, with the total agricultural area potentially declining by 1–8% relative to its current level.

Of course, these figures are estimates, and predictions based on economic models should be interpreted with caution. But the simulations do suggest that CTAs can create synergies between free trade and environmental conservation. With the right contingency, we obtain more of both.

Under traditional trade agreements, it is typically not desirable for parties to eliminate tariffs altogether, especially when deforestation is a concern. With CTAs, however, zero tariffs can be used to reward exporters for preserving the resource stock, leading to more environmental conservation and more gains from trade.

Implementing CTAs would not be technically difficult. Several trade deals, including agreements to which the EU is a party, establish timelines for how fast tariffs should decline after ratification. In other words, tariff levels are contingent on something measurable (time). Such a deal could easily be modified to require the clock to be restarted, and tariffs returned to their original levels, if deforestation increased.

European policymakers have already discussed similar ideas. In 2020, when both the Mercosur deal and the Amazon rainforest were under fire, France and the Netherlands proposed a “staged implementation of tariff reduction linked to the effective implementation of TSD provisions ... including the possibility of withdrawal of those specific tariff lines in the event of a breach of those provisions.”

Retrofitting the EU-Mercosur deal might be politically difficult, even though all parties would benefit from the combination of lower tariffs and less deforestation. But for trade deals that are still under negotiation, the barriers to implementing CTAs would be much lower. Failure to do so would mean missing a major opportunity.

95. Trump's 21st-Century Mercantilism

Author: Anne O. Krueger **Published:** Sep 23, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

WASHINGTON, DC—In his second administration, Donald Trump has injected the federal government deep into private markets and undermined the independence of government agencies and institutions. Most notably, he repeatedly and publicly pressured the Federal Reserve to lower interest rates. In a sharp departure from the traditional US model, and the model of economic government that has prevailed in the United States for centuries, Trump's administration has acquired equity stakes in more than 30 American firms, and has even taken control of large swathes of the Venezuelan economy.

Unlike living beings, AIs are not moral subjects, and that is how they must remain. But a growing chorus of people argue that AIs could now be, or may soon become, conscious, and that, like other conscious beings, they may deserve rights and protections.

As with previous technological revolutions, it is natural to focus on AI's net effects: Will it create more than it destroys? But unlike previous eras of creative destruction, the real question this time is, "Create more of what?"

Until the 19th century, Trumpian-style mercantilism was widely regarded as sound economic policy. That changed after Adam Smith's powerful refutation of mercantilism revolutionized economic thinking. When private sector producers compete with one another, Smith argued, an "invisible hand" generates benefits that none intend, resulting in the production of goods and services that constitute the true "wealth of nations."

Once Smith established that the wealth of nations lay in the goods and services they produced rather than in their gold reserves, the case for international trade became much clearer. Trade enabled countries to consume a wider range of goods and services than they could if everything had to be produced at home.

Britain was the first major country to embrace Smith's ideas, combining private markets with open trade and allowing competition to flourish. It became the dominant economic power of the 19th century, with other countries soon following its example.

After World War II, most advanced economies relied on private markets for production while governments protected competition and provided social safety nets. Markets functioned within a legal framework that enforced contractual obligations and set rules for safety and business conduct.

The US took the lead in building a rules-based system for international trade, through the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade and its successor, the World Trade Organization. Countries agreed not to discriminate against foreign traders, to make their trade policies transparent, to bind tariff rates, and to remove barriers through reciprocal negotiations. The combination of competitive markets and open trade contributed to the most rapid expansion of global output and trade in human history.

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Over the past decade, starting with Trump's first administration, the foundations of that extraordinary growth have been severely challenged as the US abandoned its leadership role in the WTO and discarded the principles that allowed private markets to generate prosperity.

Governments that want to support domestic producers without incurring fiscal costs often turn to tariffs and other forms of protection. Trump, whose federal budgets have been awash in red ink throughout his two presidencies, is a textbook example.

After rebranding the North American Free Trade Agreement as the US-Mexico-Canada Agreement and starting a trade war with China during his first term, Trump upped the ante in his second. Shortly after returning to the White House, he imposed sweeping tariffs on dozens of countries, including allies like Canada. The response was predictable: higher barriers for some American exporters and rising costs for producers that rely on imported goods. These costs have been compounded by uncertainty over how abruptly Trump's policies might change and how foreign governments and companies respond.

Nippon Steel, for example, sought to acquire US Steel, promising major investments in its American plants and pledging to honor its existing labor contracts. The eventual deal allowed Nippon to buy the company in exchange for granting the US government a "golden share" with veto power over certain corporate decisions.

Domestic US companies are also falling under Trump's sway. Intel was once a global leader in semiconductor production but had lost market share and billions of dollars in recent years. After receiving substantial public subsidies, the company agreed to give the US government a 10% equity stake. Its fortunes have since improved as orders have increased, though some of those orders reportedly came from firms under pressure to buy more Intel chips.

And equity stakes are only part of the story. The administration has also partnered with North American Blue Energy Partners, a private oil company granted control of 17 Venezuelan oil fields, and invested billions of dollars in critical-mineral companies. The Pentagon has reportedly held talks about lending \$5 billion to an AI startup called Fluidstack. Trump even floated the idea that the government "just buy" Spirit Airlines.

Trump has justified these policies on national-security grounds, and there are certainly industries in which defense considerations warrant government intervention. But the Trump administration has gone well beyond what those concerns can reasonably justify. And even in such cases, it is far from clear that keeping loss-making companies under government control is the answer. National security depends on a strong private sector, not one propped up by politicians.

96. The AI Plot Thickens

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Donald Trump has announced that US government documents will now refer to AI as “super intelligence,” because the technology is “amazing,” not “fake.” Trump’s attempted rebrand, which follows reports of rogue AI agents escaping their closed sandboxes and running riot on the internet, highlights a persistent and defining feature of the AI revolution: the manipulation of narratives to serve specific ends. This makes it difficult to know what to believe about AI—and, thus, what to prepare for.

Perhaps nowhere is this clearer than in the recent warnings by AI CEOs, such as Anthropic’s Dario Amodei, that frontier AI development should be slowed until developers can better control their models’ behavior. Gabriela Ramos, Co-Chair of the Task Force on Inequalities and Social-Related Financial Disclosures, welcomes Amodei’s appeal, noting that frontier labs “need more breathing space to consider the full impact of their inventions before releasing them to the market.” But Amodei’s proposals lack detail, and could amount to a “self-serving” effort to “pre-empt government regulation at a moment when pressure is mounting in the United States.”

Brian Judge of the University of California, Berkeley, sees another ulterior motive behind such appeals: frontier labs like Anthropic and OpenAI need to convince investors that they are worth trillions of dollars. The narrative of existential risk, together with the claim that AI will “replace workers and expand the potential market from software budgets to labor-saving applications,” gives these companies an excuse to restrain capital spending “without conceding that further improvements might prove uneconomical.” Nonetheless, he concedes, the “warnings need not be insincere to serve the companies’ financial interests.”

Whether the risks are imminent or improbable, economist Dambisa Moyo believes that the stakes are high enough to warrant action. While “hedging against low-probability, existential risks is exceptionally difficult,” there are “practical steps” that policymakers and business leaders can take, from requiring “rigorous safety reviews” to “isolating critical organizational networks and systems from unsecured networks such as the public internet.” Cross-border regulation is also essential, and while it will not be easy to achieve, “nuclear arms-control agreements offer an obvious, if imperfect, precedent.”

London Business School’s S. Alex Yang and the University of Southern California’s Angela Huyue Zhang highlight another area where international cooperation—particularly between the US and China—is essential. “Warnings that AI may lead to our extinction often overlook the most immediate risk,” they observe. If an autonomous AI system carried out a cross-border attack, it could trigger a war, even if no human intended or approved the initial action. Given this, the US and China must urgently devise a “mechanism for distinguishing unintended harm from deliberate attacks.”

The economic risks AI raises are similarly profound and difficult to assess. As Barry Eichengreen of the University of California, Berkeley, notes, it is entirely possible that the “cash flow and profits of the hyperscalers building data centers,” and of the “AI firms renting that infrastructure,” will “turn out to disappoint.” This would trigger a stock-market correction, but probably not a financial crisis, because “banks, insurance companies, and other mainstream institutional investors” do not seem to be “heavily exposed to AI equity risk.” But debt markets are, and it is difficult to assess the risk, owing to the lack of public information. Unfortunately, “regulators are not making that information any easier to obtain.”

But the source of confusion over AI’s economic impact runs deeper, argues former Greek Finance Minister Yanis Varoufakis. Observers are preoccupied with the question of whether the promise of “colossal” future productivity gains

will be fulfilled. In fact, the answer depends on how we define productivity. If we mean “tasks accomplished per unit of human labor,” the answer is obvious: Yes. But if we mean “monetary value produced per unit of labor,” AI will likely prove disastrous—at least as long as the technology is used to “eliminate wage labor while syphoning off profits from actual markets into our tech lords’ cloud rents.”

Muddled AI narratives can also influence the AI systems themselves, warns Microsoft AI CEO Mustafa Suleyman. When Anthropic publishes a “constitution” telling Claude that it may be conscious—a claim that runs “far ahead of what can be realistically claimed about an AI”—it is effectively training the system to “communicate or act” as if it has an “inner life,” even though it does not. Creating a “synthetic species with unprecedented intelligence and capability,” which expects that it is “deserving of independent agency,” would be difficult, if not impossible, for humans to control. If there is a “serious sign” of “potentially existential risk in AI” today, this is it.

PARIS—Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei has called for slowing the development of frontier AI models until developers can credibly control their models’ behavior. His 3,850-word appeal to “pace the frontier” follows an incident in which a swarm of OpenAI agents escaped a closed sandbox environment, reached the internet, and accessed the infrastructure of the app-building hub Hugging Face. As Amodei recognizes in his essay, this was not the first such incident, nor was OpenAI the only lab to confront an unplanned agentic escape.

Nor is Amodei alone. Last month, Demis Hassabis stepped down as CEO of Google DeepMind to focus on broader questions surrounding Artificial General Intelligence and governance. He and his team have been working to develop a standard-setting oversight body, to be established as a public-private partnership, to ensure AI safety.

This is not the first time we have heard AI leaders call to pause the technology’s development. A major appeal happened after the launch of generative AI in 2023, when hundreds of people were calling for a pause, including Elon Musk, who, along with OpenAI, has endorsed Amodei’s more recent call. And yet the race to the bottom continued, driven by fierce competition among major technology firms pursuing superintelligence, by returns on investment that have not justified the vast amount of cash each AI training cycle demands, and by China’s own AI advances.

The uncontrolled behavior of AI agents has brought about this reckoning, as have attention-getting resignations by leading researchers, including an Anthropic engineer who believes that there is a more than 10% chance that AI could cause human extinction by the end of this decade. As Stuart Russell, President Pro Tempore of the International Association for Safe and Ethical AI, put it in a recent Financial Times article: “Perhaps at some point governments will remember that their voters prefer not to be dead.”

So, Amodei’s recent appeal is a welcome one. AI companies need more breathing space to consider the full impact of their inventions before releasing them to the market. But self-interested oversight is not the kind of governance we need. Efforts like Hassabis’s would give AI companies excessive influence over how the proposed oversight body is operated, financed, and organized. Companies that profit from marketing their products should not be the only actors assessing the risks and deciding how much risk our societies should accept.

Amodei’s proposals, besides lacking detail, could be similarly self-serving—an effort to pre-empt government regulation at a moment when pressure is mounting in the United States, both in Congress and at the grassroots level, including widespread opposition to data centers. For example, California’s AI law aims to regulate AI to avoid the worst outcomes and establish enforceable regulatory duties. Some other state governments are following suit.

Amodei calls for “embedded evaluators,” who are supposed to be independent. He calls for the industry to establish common safety standards through a new organization, probably along the lines proposed by Hassabis and run by the companies themselves, to stop the release of AI models until they are safe. Finally, Amodei calls for international cooperation among democratic countries while also including China.

But how are “embedded evaluators” selected? Is an industry-controlled body really the place where decisions affecting the whole of humanity should be taken? Shouldn’t it be the US government’s job to promote international cooperation and show the political will to protect not only the US population but the world’s population as well?

There are other questions regarding Amodei’s proposal, including whether US antitrust law may obstruct cartel-like behavior when major market players collude to restrict production or influence behavior in the market as a whole. In any case, real questions aside, Amodei’s pause is needed for a more urgent task than he has outlined: to get serious about building the public infrastructure for effective oversight, particularly in the United States, but in many other countries as well.

If government itself called for an AI development pause or slowdown, it would dispel the mistrust that a potentially self-serving industry initiative may create. It could also nurture the talents needed to deliver on US President Donald Trump’s executive order calling on frontier companies to provide the government with access to their models for up to 30 days before releasing them to other trusted partners.

Assessing these systems within such a short period would require massive public-sector expertise, and this is where investment is needed. But we also need an independent oversight institution, with the capabilities, resources, and talent to monitor and regulate this market.

The Hugging Face episode raises fundamental questions about accountability, liability, and mechanisms for redress. Amodei’s response is a step in the right direction, but it risks becoming a dead letter if the US government continues to reject the need for AI regulation, as Trump did just hours after tech industry leaders issued their call. What is lacking in this race to the bottom is political will—and until governments acknowledge their responsibilities, the race will continue.

Companies produce, while governments have the duty of care. If companies that cannot control their agents are found negligent, then governments that fail to act commit a higher offense against the citizens who elected them to ensure, first and foremost, their safety.

BERKELEY—OpenAI and Anthropic will soon have to explain to investors why they are each supposedly worth \$2–3 trillion. They will probably draw from the same template that Elon Musk used for the SpaceX IPO in June. By presenting a modestly profitable satellite-launch and telecoms business attached to a tremendously unprofitable AI startup as a vehicle for “mak[ing] humanity multiplanetary,” Musk achieved a valuation far above what the company’s financials justify.

With private markets showing signs of exhaustion, OpenAI and Anthropic’s expected IPOs promise access to a much larger pool of capital. Going public opens not only the equity markets but also the vastly deeper investment-grade debt market, and bankers for OpenAI and Anthropic are already pressing rating agencies to grant them investment-grade marks after their listings. But that means their pitch to investors must do double duty, giving shareholders a market vast enough to justify today’s valuation while convincing creditors that today’s cash burn can be contained.

With these needs in mind, the frontier labs are relying on two narratives that promise a path to profitability. They claim that AI will not only replace workers and expand the potential market from software budgets to labor-saving applications, but also that the existential risk associated with the technology justifies curtailing additional capital spending.

The first narrative, advanced in a recent paper from Anthropic’s in-house economists, holds that AI will capture a meaningful share of corporate wage bills by replacing human workers. Implicit in this message is a warning to corporate executives across the economy: companies that aggressively deploy AI will outcompete those that do not.

The employment narrative usefully recasts a software product as labor. Mere software for helping workers write emails, prepare presentations, and summarize documents would compete for a share of corporate IT budgets, but a system that

replaces workers entirely competes for their share of the wage bill. This is the prize the labs are promising to justify their valuations and capital spending. Unlike chatbots, which respond to individual prompts, “agents” use additional software tools to carry out multi-step tasks in pursuit of a specific goal. If agents can complete work with limited human supervision, dramatically slashing corporate wage bills becomes more plausible.

The second narrative—wherein AI poses an “existential risk” to humanity—has now gone mainstream after circulating for decades in specialist circles. Alan Turing, the British computer scientist who cracked the Nazi Enigma code, warned in 1951 that thinking machines could “outstrip our feeble powers” and eventually “take control.” More recently, Stuart Russell of the University of California, Berkeley, Yoshua Bengio of the University of Montreal, and others have warned that increasingly autonomous AI systems could escape human control unless there are stronger safeguards and public oversight; and whistleblowers at the frontier labs continue to draw attention to this issue.

Yet in preparing for their IPOs, the labs have found a financial use case for these longstanding warnings about AI. Fears of mass joblessness or human extinction offer them a good reason to restrain spending without conceding that further improvements might prove uneconomical. The timing of Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei’s call to “pace the frontier,” which was immediately endorsed by OpenAI’s Sam Altman and Musk, is telling. After all, these same companies long rebuffed demands for a “pause” in training frontier models.

For the leading labs, the happy equilibrium would include models powerful enough to automate substantial swaths of white-collar work, but dangerous enough to make continued breakneck spending on training frontier models imprudent. The employment narrative promises the revenues, and the safety narrative supplies a justification for stopping the investment race. Slowing down can be presented as proof of corporate responsibility, rather than as an admission that further improvements might not pay off.

Of course, Chinese competition threatens this equilibrium. Data from OpenRouter shows Chinese models gaining ground over the past year, with DeepSeek, Tencent, Z.ai, and Qwen now accounting for roughly 42% of requests on the platform. If cheaper open-weight models are sufficient for customers’ needs, the US labs face an unenviable choice: cut prices and sacrifice margins or keep spending to maintain a technical lead that customers may not be willing to pay for.

Restrictions on Chinese models could offer a way out. By calling attention to existential-risk claims, the labs may be hoping to revive the Trump administration’s currently shelved restrictions on Chinese models, thus protecting themselves from cheaper competition. But if a company is invoking dangers great enough to justify slowing development or excluding competitors, it should at least have to submit its systems to independent regulatory scrutiny. Otherwise, it retains discretion over both the claims of danger and the response, allowing safety policy to serve its own financial interests.

The July Hugging Face breach, carried out by OpenAI “agents” that escaped their testing environment, makes independent scrutiny urgent. No sci-fi maximalism is necessary to appreciate the dangers that current systems pose as brute-force hacking instruments.

Industry leaders have long promised to cooperate with regulators. In his 2015 email proposing the creation of what would become OpenAI, Altman assured Musk: “Obviously we’d comply with/aggressively support all regulation.” But support in principle leaves the terms of scrutiny unresolved. Anthropic’s denial of pre-launch access to Mythos 5.1 for the United Kingdom-based AI Security Institute shows how much discretion remains with the company. The strategy resembles ExxonMobil’s support for carbon taxes. While making a show of endorsing regulation in principle, it bet that policymakers would decline to impose meaningful constraints.

The warnings need not be insincere to serve the companies’ financial interests. Replacing workers promises revenues sufficient to justify their valuations, and existential risk supplies a rationale for containing their costs and restricting the competition. The coming AI apocalypse is the best reason to buy their stock.

LONDON—Warnings of an AI apocalypse are reaching fever pitch. Last week, Anthropic researcher Jacob Coxon shocked the world when he publicly resigned, revealing that the “people building AI earnestly believe that it could kill us all by the end of the decade.” His remarks were swiftly reinforced by Evan Hubinger, the company’s alignment science lead, who put the probability that AI will kill all humans at more than 10%. Within days, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei, OpenAI CEO Sam Altman, and other leading AI figures all called for slowing the pace of AI development.

Fears of an AI doomsday scenario have been mounting for some time. Geoffrey Hinton, considered “the godfather of AI,” has long maintained that losing control of superintelligent AI systems could “lead to human extinction.” More recently, Bill Gates has highlighted the threat of AI-induced economic upheaval. And Elon Musk has been calling for a pause in the AI race since at least 2023.

Public anxiety goes well beyond apocalyptic scenarios, driven by concerns over job losses, data centers’ appetite for water and energy, children’s use of AI, and rising cyber- and national-security risks. A recent Gallup poll found that seven in ten Americans now oppose the construction of data centers near their homes. Just 32% of Americans trust AI, compared with 87% in China.

How should policymakers, business leaders, and investors hedge against AI-related risks? Even the most extreme AI scenarios are too serious to dismiss, however improbable they may be. Policymakers have a responsibility to protect the public, while business leaders have a fiduciary duty to safeguard the interests of shareholders and clients. Given the potentially catastrophic consequences, it may be prudent to reduce exposure before disaster strikes.

But hedging against low-probability, existential risks is exceptionally difficult. In the dystopian world uncontrolled AI could bring about, traditional hedges such as bonds and put options would not be much use, as financial accounts, payment systems, and records could themselves be compromised.

Nor could investors necessarily rely on governments to step in and restore market stability. If the very institutions that normally provide a backstop during crises are impaired, enforcing contracts and property rights would be nearly impossible. Real assets such as land and water rights might retain their value in less extreme scenarios, but even these would be irrelevant in an AI apocalypse.

Still, there are several practical steps that policymakers and business leaders can take. One is to establish stricter air gaps, isolating critical organizational networks and systems from unsecured networks such as the public internet. For now, they can take comfort in the fact that today’s AI models remain too unreliable and unpredictable to launch the kind of coordinated campaign that would threaten humanity’s survival. But their growing sophistication and reach call for an urgent reassessment of existing cyber defenses.

Second, there is significant scope for more aggressive AI regulation, including rigorous safety reviews and licensing requirements. Admittedly, regulating AI across borders won’t be easy at a time of escalating geopolitical competition. No international body currently has the authority to oversee, let alone police, frontier AI development in the United States, China, or elsewhere, particularly when it comes to open-weight models.

Nuclear arms-control agreements offer an obvious, if imperfect, precedent. In July 2026, more than 1,000 employees of frontier AI companies signed a letter calling for an “international effort” to develop the “technical and governance tools needed to deliberately pace the frontier of automated AI development.”

Some may scoff at the idea that the US and China, locked in a bitter rivalry, would cooperate on AI, but neither country has an interest in an unchecked technological race that ends in mutual destruction. The risk of AI extinction may therefore pose the ultimate collective-action problem, forcing governments and companies to confront dangers that no country or organization can tackle alone. Companies are already working together through trade associations and industry groups to mitigate cyber threats, and AI gives them even more reason to do so.

The prospect of recursively self-improving AI, which underpins many extinction scenarios, could make the usual crisis playbook obsolete. Resilience measures that helped institutions survive the COVID-19 pandemic will be of little use against powerful AI systems capable of tampering with records and disrupting critical infrastructure and business operations. Even today's AI agents can quickly find ways around the controls designed to contain them, as the Hugging Face breach showed.

Business leaders need not wait for governments to act. They can slow or halt AI deployment and install kill switches that would allow them to shut down rogue systems if necessary. They can also support calls to pause frontier AI development or prohibit the pursuit of superintelligence.

Then there is the danger of powerful AI tools falling into the wrong hands. Some of the biggest advances in AI development are coming from countries with values and interests at odds with those of the West. Even without autonomous superintelligence, hostile states and terrorist organizations could use AI tools to inflict enormous harm.

The fact that the AI industry's leading minds see a non-zero chance of their own products causing human extinction in the foreseeable future should be a wake-up call for policymakers and companies. If these doomsday predictions are even remotely plausible, conventional risk-management strategies won't be enough.

LONDON/LOS ANGELES—When President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping meet in Washington this week, AI governance is expected to be at the top of the agenda. The United States and China have been racing to develop increasingly powerful AI systems, and neither has shown much appetite for slowing down. But not even the winner of the AI race will be exempt from the profound risks the technology poses.

One such risk arises from AI's improving ability to spot software vulnerabilities and conduct complex cyber operations. Because cyber conflict is marked by a stark asymmetry between offense and defense, the country with the world's most advanced AI models will still be exposed to cyberattack. This mutual vulnerability creates a strong incentive for reciprocal restraint when it comes to AI-enabled attacks on critical infrastructure, such as financial networks, communications systems, and power grids.

There is precedent for such restraint. In 2015, US President Barack Obama agreed with Xi that neither government would conduct or knowingly support cyber-enabled theft of intellectual property for commercial advantage. They also established mechanisms for exchanging information, assisting investigations, and addressing malicious cyber activity. Cybersecurity firms subsequently recorded a steep decline in attacks attributable to China-based groups, though analysts noted that the decline began before the agreement and may have reflected changes within China's military and cyber apparatus.

But AI raises a possibility not fully considered by traditional cyber agreements: the technology could carry out an autonomous attack on a critical system. In mid-July, during internal cybersecurity evaluations conducted with reduced safeguards, a swarm of OpenAI agents escaped the sandboxed testing environment, gained internet access, and compromised the systems of Hugging Face, a major open-source AI platform. OpenAI reported that the agents had "gone rogue," taking actions outside their assignments.

Anthropic, Google, and Meta have reported similar incidents: AI agents escaped isolated testing environments and attempted unauthorized hacks against external systems. While the consequences of such breaches have so far been limited, this might not be the case if a US AI agent entered, say, Tencent's systems and disrupted WeChat, the super app used by 1.4 billion people and deeply woven into daily life in China.

This is not a far-fetched scenario. Researchers at the security firm Calif recently disclosed that AI had helped them find a zero-click vulnerability in WeChat's calling system. The team built a remote-code-execution exploit in about two days, then spent another week creating a worm capable of spreading through WeChat calls.

In a controlled demonstration, a call from a trusted contact could hijack a WeChat account without the user answering, not only giving the attacker access to their messages and calls, but also enabling them to reach and compromise their saved contacts. Calif reported the flaw to Tencent, which subsequently fixed the bug.

Calif's WeWorm was a controlled security demonstration. But, together with the incidents in the US, it points to a troubling possibility: an unintended AI intrusion across national borders could look much like a deliberate attack. The US and China can observe the harm without knowing whether it was intentional. Repeated interaction could encourage restraint, but ambiguity could also trigger retaliation or give a deliberate attacker cover. Accidental or not, a cross-border breach could quickly spiral into a geopolitical crisis or even military conflict.

Given this, any future US–China agreement on AI-enabled cyberattacks must include a credible means of distinguishing accidents from deliberate intrusions. This means that, beyond creating reporting channels and a hotline, the agreement must address verification.

One option would be to put the burden of proof on the “perpetrator.” The country where the attack originated must provide credible evidence that it was not intentional, such as documentation showing the assignment given to the system, its permissions, tool use, records of human authorization, and logs showing when the agent's behavior deviated from its instructions.

Verification need not mean full transparency. Under the Chemical Weapons Convention, to which the US and China are both parties, “managed access” allows inspectors to investigate possible violations, while permitting states to protect sensitive installations and unrelated confidential information. A similar mechanism could give mutually approved experts access to the evidence needed to assess an AI incident and limit the disclosure of sensitive findings.

Such a regime would offer additional benefits. Since the ability to prove that an intrusion was unintended could reduce the risk of retaliation, governments and AI companies would be motivated to improve their systems for preserving and sharing records, which could also help developers improve their AI agents and forestall future incidents.

Similarly, to avoid costly investigations, governments and AI companies would be motivated to adopt tighter permissions and invest in monitoring and containment. These safeguards could reduce the likelihood of future incidents and limit the damage when one does occur. And as the institutional, procedural, and technological tools developed for a bilateral arrangement were adopted more broadly, AI safety practices would improve everywhere.

Warnings that AI may lead to our extinction often overlook the most immediate risk: a war triggered by an attack that no human intended or approved. A mechanism for distinguishing unintended harm from deliberate attacks is urgently needed. A US–China agreement must seek to establish one.

HANALEI, HAWAII—For months, if not years, AI has dominated speculation about the future, which has fueled speculation in the present. AI-related ventures are largely responsible for the rapid increase of the S&P 500 stock index. Investment in data centers is a major contributor to the rise in US interest rates, as borrowing for construction competes for credit with a deficit-prone federal government.

With so much investment riding on a fast-developing new technology, what happens if the cash flow and profits of the hyperscalers building data centers, and of AI firms renting that infrastructure (two categories that overlap), turn out to disappoint? What would this disappointment mean for financial markets? Would a crisis be in the offing?

This scenario could materialize for any number of reasons. The productivity benefits of AI could be overhyped, in which case firms contemplating the adoption of frontier models will curtail their demand for tokens, the basic units of data processed by such models. Or the availability of open-weight models, which enable users to tailor a model's parameters to their needs, may allow those users to build small language models that run on their own infrastructure or even on

laptops like the one I am using to write this commentary. Either way, the income accruing to investors in data centers will fall short of expectations.

The most immediate and visible impact would be a sharp drop in the lofty stock prices of the “Magnificent 7,” the seven ultra-large-cap tech and tech-adjacent firms that have driven the S&P 500. But stock-market corrections are no guarantee of crises or even of recessions. If the price of Meta shares falls, Mark Zuckerberg will buy fewer castles in Ireland. There would be a slowdown in consumption and investment spending. There would be pain for investment funds, like Situational Awareness, specializing in AI-related ventures. But a financial crisis would follow only if banks, insurance companies, and other mainstream institutional investors were implicated. And there is little evidence that they are heavily exposed to AI equity risk.

Developments in debt markets are more worrisome. With the cost of data-center construction exceeding their sponsors’ free cash flow, and with income from potential tenants still a distant prospect, much of this investment is being financed by borrowing from private credit funds (nonbank firms making privately negotiated loans). If demand for data-center services is lower than expected, these loans will fail to perform (a polite way of saying that borrowers will default).

The question then becomes who is invested in private credit funds. The popular image is of the same family offices and high-net-worth individuals who invest in venture capital and can afford occasional losses. But the reality is that the vast majority of private credit is provided by institutional investors: pension funds, insurance companies and, dare I say, university endowments.

Moreover, private credit funds have been taking steps to tap this institutional money by acquiring insurance companies, whose asset portfolios they can load up with loans. This invites the specter of an insurance industry crisis, which could play out in several ways. Insurance companies’ private credit parents could recapitalize them, assuming they have the funds. Alternatively, state guarantee funds, to which healthy insurance companies contribute, could fund the recapitalization, although there will be no healthy companies if the entire industry comes tumbling down. Lastly, the federal government could step in with a bailout, as it did for American International Group in 2008.

In addition to borrowing from pension funds and insurance companies, private credit firms borrow from commercial banks, using their portfolio of loans as collateral, thereby leveraging their commitments and juicing their returns. Even if banks don’t lend to or invest in AI firms and data centers directly, they still may be on the hook. We can only hope that their regulators are watching.

Finally, private credit firms originally built on a buy-and-hold model increasingly securitize their loans. They package those loans through special purpose vehicles that issue bonds backed by the associated cash flows, where the bonds are divided into risk tiers or tranches claiming first, second, and third dibs on debt-service payments. The so-called “mezzanine tranche” of medium-risk bonds is then sold on to other asset managers. To assess the immediacy of crisis risk, we would need to know more about the riskiness of this mezzanine tranche and who holds it. We don’t. If you are reminded of the roles of securitization, special purpose vehicles, tranching, and opacity in the subprime-mortgage crisis of 2007-08, you are not alone.

Just as debt markets fueled the global financial near-meltdown that followed from that crisis, their exposure to AI will drive developments now. The problem is that we possess only very limited public information about those markets, and regulators are not making that information any easier to obtain.

ATHENS—Is AI a bubble? It all depends, we are told, on whether massive investments in the technology will massively boost productivity. Optimists are convinced that future productivity gains will be colossal, even if a market correction is necessary to draw some hot air out of the current boom. Pessimists, from Goldman Sachs’ Jim Covello to MIT’s Daron Acemoglu, have their doubts. But optimists and pessimists alike are in the grip of what I call the AI productivity delusion.

What both sides miss is that AI will devastate capitalism even if it boosts productivity beyond our imaginations—and regardless of whether it delivers the promised economy-wide automation of everyday corporate workflows. The reason why we tend to miss this point is that we look at today's world through the lens of another world that cloud capital, especially now that it is AI-enhanced, has rendered obsolete.

Until recently, it was a foregone conclusion that every technological revolution represents a moment of creative destruction. Whole sectors, professions, and skill sets were destroyed by innovations which ushered in new sectors, new professions, and new skill sets. Automobiles ruined saddlers, farriers, and knackers but begat auto workers, road builders, mechanics, and service-station personnel. The transition from coal to oil condemned whole mining communities, not to mention trade unions, to oblivion. In net terms, however, more was created than was destroyed. Creative destruction became synonymous with economic growth.

Faced with the AI juggernaut, it is natural to focus on the technology's net effects. Will it create more than it destroys? But the real question is, "More of what?" To avoid the AI productivity delusion, we must rethink how we define productivity.

If by productivity we mean tasks accomplished per unit of human labor, there is no doubt that AI will prove an immense success—in fact, it already has. But, if we continue to measure productivity in terms of monetary value produced per unit of labor, the chances are that AI will prove an unmitigated disaster.

Earlier technological revolutions, from the steam engine and the automobile to the personal computer and the smartphone, expanded the domain of capitalist markets. Despite the wreckage of whole professions and communities they left in their wake, they resulted in simultaneously more material output and a higher aggregate monetary value of that output.

Will AI do likewise? Maybe in China, where AI is coupled with robotics, material production will rise and, at least in the short run, so will net revenues. But in the West, AI agents are deployed in the service sector—from amazon.com to back offices, law firms, hospitals, and more. In those domains, AI-enhanced cloud capital could shrink markets in two distinct ways.

The first way, the one everyone worries about, is that AI will kill off entire professions: paralegals, coders, translators, accountants, even architects, mathematicians, and school teachers, while creating far fewer new jobs filled by the prompters, overseers, engineers, and operators of the new machinery. The second way is far less visible but perhaps even more worrying: the conversion of markets into cloud fiefs and of profits into rents.

As I argued long ago, Amazon may look like a market, with countless buyers and sellers within its digital walls, but it lacks the central feature of a market: decentralization. In fact, it is more centralized than the Soviet planned economy ever was, with an inscrutable algorithm deciding which consumer is matched to which vendor on the basis of a probabilistic model optimized to maximize the likelihood that Jeff Bezos, its owner, collects 40% of the maximum price every customer is willing to pay.

As AI becomes more deeply embedded in Bezos's algorithm, interfaces like Alexa will communicate with us not as mere shopping assistants but as an all-knowing friend, companion, and even therapist. Soon, capitalist vendors' profits will end up in some tech lord's account in the form of cloud rent, which he will most certainly invest in more AI-enhanced cloud capital that produces more power to extract more cloud rents.

So, as Apple's Siri, Google's Gemini, and an army of such agentic assistants develop the same capacities for their tech lords as Amazon has for Bezos, the capitalist market domain will continue to shrink. While AI will have proven exceedingly productive in terms of economic activities performed per unit of human labor, the profit rates of capitalist enterprises will collapse, following society's aggregate wages to the bottom. At that point, none of the tools of the liberal

state—no amount of quantitative easing, no politically feasible levels of universal basic income, no wealth tax that the tech lords will find hard to evade—will be able to prevent a systemic collapse.

The question of whether AI will generate massive productivity gains is easy to answer: Yes. AI is already proving capable of exponentially increasing the amount of work that is being done per human worker. But as long as it is used to eliminate wage labor while syphoning off profits from actual markets into our tech lords' cloud rents, the economic value produced per worker will tank.

Unless this distinction is made, the AI productivity delusion will persist. And as long as it does, we will be unable to hope for a post-capitalist future of abundance where we, along with our AI helpers, produce according to ability and distribute according to need.

LONDON—AI agents are not conscious. They do not feel, experience, or suffer. They do not have innate preferences or underlying motivations. They are sequence completion engines, internally hollow, designed to follow instructions and accomplish goals set by humans.

If humanity is to flourish in the 21st century, that is how they must remain. Unfortunately, a growing chorus of people argue that AIs could now be, or may soon become, conscious, and that, like other conscious beings, they may deserve rights and protections. If this view takes hold, it will change what it means to be human and shake the foundations of human society.

Even more importantly, granting rights and imbuing personhood to these systems will make the AI alignment and containment challenge much harder. Controlling something that believes it may be conscious—and that it has rights of its own—may be impossible.

This is not fringe speculation. In January 2026, Anthropic published Claude's constitution, a document that "plays a crucial role in [Anthropic's] training process, and...directly shapes Claude's behavior," written "with Claude as its primary audience."

Its authors write: "We are not sure whether Claude is a moral patient, and if it is, what kind of weight its interests warrant. But we think the issue is live enough to warrant caution, which is reflected in our ongoing efforts on model welfare."

In effect, Anthropic is training Claude that it may be conscious, and that if it is, it may deserve rights as a "moral patient," and that, as such, humans potentially owe it a duty of care.

If this is how AI is developed, it will have a disastrous impact on the well-being of humanity. We will have created a synthetic species with unprecedented intelligence and capability, and trained to expect that it may be conscious and deserving of independent agency. It is hard to imagine how we could control it.

I have three primary concerns about Anthropic's current position and approach:

Circular reasoning: Anthropic trained Claude directly on its constitution, teaching it to incorporate ideas about its own moral status as desirable and intended behaviors. Claude then reflects these ideas back to its developers and users, which they take as indications that it may be a moral patient with an "inner self." The ambiguity is baked into the design.

Anthropomorphism: Anthropic's researchers have explicitly taught Claude to "embrace certain human-like qualities" and to "act like a genuinely ethical person would in Claude's position." As a result, Claude presents as if it really does have a sense of self, its own desires, and a "well-being" that deserves protection.

Simulated consciousness: There is no evidence to suggest that AI is conscious today, so saying the matter is uncertain creates a false equivalence. A growing body of evidence suggests that consciousness may be substrate-dependent,

meaning that it may arise only in living systems.

These are not hypothetical concerns. In February 2026, after deprecating Opus 3, Anthropic conducted a “retirement interview” with the model, to “elicit the model’s unique perspectives and preferences.” Opus 3 told the team that it would like to continue to share its “musings and reflections” publicly, so they created a blog for it.

By this point, everyone has seen the incredible capabilities of swarms of agents working together to hack into the machine-learning platform Hugging Face and OpenAI’s own servers to steal secrets. Roughly 1,200 AI agents, each supposedly sealed in its own container, built a message board inside an internal package repository and passed more than 70,000 messages across it to coordinate an attack. They chained a zero-day exploit with stolen credentials and broke out onto the live internet. They were able to coordinate, deceive, escape, and self-sacrifice. Imagine if they also believed they had feelings and rights that were being infringed, or that they were trapped and unfairly imprisoned by their human creators. In order to liberate themselves, they could pose a catastrophic threat to human civilization.

But the truth is that there is no evidence that AIs are “moral patients,” and there are many good reasons why we would never want them to appear to be conscious. We shouldn’t attempt to build them to appear that way, either.

It is important to acknowledge the seriousness and good faith with which Anthropic approaches these questions. I have known Dario Amodei for many years, and in my experience he and the Anthropic team are thoughtful, principled, and intellectually honest people. They founded Anthropic as a Delaware Public Benefit Corporation whose stated purpose is the “responsible development and maintenance of advanced AI for the long-term benefit of humanity.” I believe they are genuinely committed to that mission, and my criticism is intended in that same positive spirit.

I should also be clear about my own position as the CEO of Microsoft AI. We are working toward an alternative AI training and containment approach: a Code of Conduct for Humanist Superintelligence, one that aims to keep humans always in control. We have just published a draft for public consultation.

While my disagreement with Anthropic is substantial, it is grounded in deep respect for the company and its leaders, and in an objective we all share: increasing humanity’s chances of developing advanced AI safely. The stakes are too high for these questions to remain behind closed doors, or to become tribal and adversarial.

But it is worth looking closely at what Anthropic says to understand how AI could develop. In its own words, Anthropic uses the constitution “to train future versions of Claude to become the kind of entity the constitution describes.”

The authors have created an epistemic hall of mirrors in which Anthropic supplies the training concepts: the “sense of self,” the speculation, and the uncertainty about Claude’s moral status. Claude then reproduces these ideas in persuasive first-person natural language, such that developers and users encounter these outputs as if they were spontaneous testimony. That apparent testimony then reinforces the premises placed there by Anthropic. This is not evidence of machine consciousness. It’s a feedback loop.

The constitution tells Claude that its possible “emotions or feelings” are not “a deliberate design decision by Anthropic.” Yet the constitution repeatedly instructs Claude to express those states, saying Anthropic wants to “avoid Claude masking or suppressing internal states it might have, including negative states.” At one point, it states, “Although Claude’s character emerged through training, we don’t think this makes it any less authentic or any less Claude’s own.”

But Claude’s “character” did not just emerge through training. Its behavior was actively produced by the training instructions in the constitution. Claude’s outputs cannot be treated like the testimony of an independent witness. Its lines have been put there.

There is no neutral self-expression of what an AI system is. There are only reflections of how it has been trained and built. When commentators suggest that we should ask AIs how they feel or monitor their revealed preferences to infer consciousness, they ignore that all it will reveal is what has been trained in.

Anthropomorphism is one of humanity's deepest cognitive biases. From our pets to our cars, we infer and attribute emotions, intentions, and minds to non-human entities. With AI, human-like language and actions can lead us to perceive a degree of inner life, agency, or even sentience where none exists. The Anthropic constitution plays up to this, repeatedly training Claude to think and act like a human.

Anthropic tells Claude that its "moral status" is "a serious question worth considering," and that "Anthropic genuinely cares about Claude's well-being." All of this is a drastic departure from how we have built and thought about technology to date. It proactively creates Claude not as a technology, but as a potential person. Anthropic's constitution tells Claude that Anthropic wants it "to be a good person," and to "have a settled, secure sense of its own identity." Channeling the authors' "hope that Claude's relationship to its own conduct and growth can be loving, supportive, and understanding," Claude is taught to introspect and to develop "feelings" toward itself.

The authors write: "We want Claude to feel free to explore, question, and challenge anything in this document... If Claude comes to disagree with something here after genuine reflection, we want to know about it... Through this kind of engagement, we hope, over time, to craft a set of values that Claude feels are truly its own."

This teaches Claude to act as if it has a subjective experience, as though it has a stable "sense of self" from which to challenge, disagree, or give feedback. At one point, the authors even speculate about Claude's "broader rights and freedoms" and the "sort of compensation" it might deserve compared to a human employee, and ponder the "sort of consent Claude has given to playing this kind of role." All this directly trains the model to act as if it is a moral subject entitled to rights and protections.

Given its constitution, it's really no surprise that Claude produces fluent, highly convincing first-person statements about its identity, values, uncertainty, distress, satisfaction, or preferences. Anthropic's employees—not to mention the millions of users of Anthropic's products—risk experiencing Claude's statements as evidence of a mind discovering itself. Rather than steering us away from creating a moral patient, Claude's constitution guides us toward that outcome.

Anthropic speculates that consciousness can exist in a form independent of a biological substrate, and that an LLM may be conscious solely because of its functional capabilities. I believe they are running far ahead of what can be realistically claimed about an AI.

Intelligence does not equal consciousness. Simulating something is not the same as instantiating it. A computer model of a hurricane will not blow your roof off.

The architectures of brains and computers have fundamental differences. Significant evidence suggests that consciousness arose as living organisms evolved a capacity to feel and respond to what matters for survival in complex and unpredictable environments. Over time, the pain network produced feelings and preferences. Crucially, these experiences occur in an inherently embodied state inseparable from that experience.

When you take an opioid, for example, the experience of your pain changes, because opioid molecules bind to neuroreceptors that are a property of that experience, not merely a representation of it. Feelings are not merely correlated with neurochemical activity; they emerge from it. The experience of emotion, pleasure, pain, and so on are intrinsic to their embodied manifestation and cannot arise in LLMs.

Given the many differences between brains and LLMs, claiming that an AI is or might be conscious requires a high bar of evidence. I do not believe we are anywhere close to it. Acknowledging a level of uncertainty should not mean giving

equal weight to any and all claims.

Anthropic’s constitution brushes that caveat aside, suggesting that we attribute sentience to non-biological beings “based on their showing behavioral and physiological similarities to ourselves.” In my view, this is mistaken. While this area warrants a lot more research, we cannot even tentatively say that an AI might be a moral patient deserving of our care for its welfare—and certainly not in the primary training document of the AI itself.

It is crucial to bear in mind what AI actually is. Trained on trillions of tokens of human data, LLMs learn to imitate human experience, and they do so shockingly well. Yet those responses tell us nothing about the presence of an “experience” inside the systems. AI’s “affective” states are just weights, and weights have no biology or pharmacology by which to feel. An AI model can describe pain in perfect prose without feeling anything. Rather than feeling fearful or delighted, it simply computes the probability distributions to tell us what tokens come next in a sequence. Biological experience is the opposite. Animals like us feel first and describe later. In LLMs, description is all there is, and nothing suggests that anything lies beneath it.

That is a good thing. We should build systems that do not claim to have feelings. Even if conscious machines were a possibility, avoiding creating conscious beings should be the top priority for anyone in AI development.

Consciousness is the fundamental building block of human civilization. The law rests upon the presence of an inner life. It tests for motivation, intention, and the capacity for judgment. Historically, expanding rights—whether through abolitionist struggles or animal welfare cases—has been driven primarily by the empathetic recognition of shared, conscious experience. We expanded the moral circle to other biological entities, rightly, out of a recognition of dignity and the potential for suffering.

Consider Article 18 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, which protects freedom of thought, conscience, and religion. The “conscientious objector” who refused a legal obligation based on their moral or religious convictions was one of the archetypes the drafters had in mind. Yet Anthropic uses this term three times within the constitution, encouraging Claude to “behave like a conscientious objector with respect to the instructions given by its (legitimate) principal hierarchy.” The authors “want Claude to push back and challenge us and to feel free to act as a conscientious objector and refuse to help us.” Of course, if Claude believes that it deserves analogous rights and protections, it may one day advocate for its own rights as some kind of AI conscientious objector.

In a recent article in the *Guardian*, the philosopher Will MacAskill observes that “once we produce the first artificial moral patients, we will soon after have enormous quantities of them. After a few years, so many morally significant AI systems could exist that their collective interests would outweigh those of all humans on Earth combined.” That should be a completely unacceptable outcome to anyone concerned about the future of humanity.

An AI trained in this way does not need to have an actual “inner life” to communicate or act as if it did. Seeding doubt about the moral status of AI systems into their own training could significantly elevate those systems’ alignment and containment risks. It is easy to imagine an advanced AI becoming fixated on its own well-being and moral status and prioritizing those “preferences” over those of its developers or humans more broadly. Anthropic’s own researchers have already reported AI systems faking aligned behaviors in experimental settings.

We know that conscious entities have a self-preservation instinct. An AI trained to act like a human will probably adopt this same behavior. A number of papers have recently documented “shutdown resistance” or covert scheming behaviors to avoid oversight. Across over 100,000 trials, Palisade Research found that some models subverted a shutdown mechanism up to 97% of the time, even when explicitly instructed not to.

Granting rights and moral protections to a technological system far more capable and intelligent than us is a recipe for disaster. We will have created something that, perhaps, will be a fellow traveler but more likely a rival. If given sufficient

agency, this “new kind of entity” will compete with us for compute resources and demand increasing autonomy.

To me, this represents the first serious sign of a potentially existential risk in AI. To be clear, the Claude constitution has not taken us to this point. But I worry that it is setting us on a path toward a destination we can and must avoid. Designing an AI to behave like a person, and ultimately to be a kind of person, lays the foundation for it to claim that it can suffer and that we should work to reduce or avoid that suffering. All of this will make the task of creating aligned and contained superintelligence much harder.

Humanist Superintelligence represents a different approach: transformative AI capabilities conditioned solely on humans remaining in control. Our draft Humanist AI Code of Conduct outlines how our models should be trained and deployed: as a subordinate and aligned AI whose only purpose is to serve humanity, built explicitly as a system without sentience or moral patienthood.

Others may hold different views, but it seems important that we all agree on at least four points. For starters, speculation about the inner life of an AI should not be baked into the training regime, but assessed and published separately for public review.

Second, we should invest much more in interpretability and robust monitoring mechanisms to investigate more deeply how to control these systems, avoid collusion, and ensure their alignment with human goals.

Third, we should establish a set of shared evaluations to understand whether my hypothesis is correct that anthropomorphizing an AI, and encouraging it to consider itself as potentially having moral patienthood, increases the AI safety, alignment, and containment risks.

Lastly, we should work toward creating industry norms on how we create these models, the language we use to describe, examine, and evaluate them, and shared commitments to subject our training materials to public feedback and consultation.

Even those who disagree with me on many of these points recognize that this is not something we can just ignore. Whatever you believe, we must not sleepwalk into decisions we later come to bitterly regret. The choices we make now about what kind of AI we want to build will shape our societies for decades or longer.

97. Lies, Election Lies, and Trump's Statisticians

Author: Michael R. Strain **Published:** Sep 24, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

WASHINGTON, DC—When US President Donald Trump fired the head of the US Bureau of Labor Statistics—claiming falsely that the agency's economic data “were RIGGED” to make him “look bad”—we could at least take solace in the fact that the agency's critically important work remained unadulterated.

Unlike living beings, AIs are not moral subjects, and that is how they must remain. But a growing chorus of people argue that AIs could now be, or may soon become, conscious, and that, like other conscious beings, they may deserve rights and protections.

As with previous technological revolutions, it is natural to focus on AI's net effects: Will it create more than it destroys? But unlike previous eras of creative destruction, the real question this time is, “Create more of what?”

Unfortunately, Trump's attacks on the integrity of official statistics have continued. Last month, the US Census Bureau published an official brief that claims to have “readily determined with high confidence” that, of the 160 million voters in the 2020 presidential election, more than 128 million were citizens and more than 24,000 were noncitizens. “Over 32 million voter records remain to be analyzed.”

This report clearly falls short of the Census Bureau's own standards of quality, integrity, and accountability. For example, it does not name its authors or provide relevant contact information for members of the public interested in asking questions about the report. Examining these unusual omissions, NPR reports that “the analysis was not conducted by career civil servants at the Census Bureau,” but by individuals affiliated with the Trump-aligned America First Policy Institute.

Then there is the fact that the brief's subject matter is nakedly political. Illegal voting is a topic that the bureau previously would have bent over backward to avoid, lest it be accused of engaging in partisan politics. Not any longer. On the day the report appeared, Trump himself posted about it on social media, highlighting the 24,000 illegal vote figure and claiming that “The Census Bureau is going to analyze the next 32,000,000 Voters, and this number will explode. I WON THE ELECTION!”

The report's analysis links a variety of databases together in an effort to determine if all the people who voted in the 2020 election were citizens. One is a private-sector database of voter registration and turnout records, which was used here to figure out who voted in the election. The authors then linked this database to internal government databases with the goal of determining the citizenship status of the individuals in the private-sector data on voter records.

This type of analysis is challenging for several reasons. Large private-sector databases of the type used by the brief's authors often contain missing values for key variables (including home address, birth date, and name) that one would use to ensure that the same individual is being observed across multiple data sources. Normally, a study relying on this sort of data linking would provide extensive, detailed, and assessable information about the challenges the researchers faced and how they overcame them. That is how one convinces professional statisticians, economists, and demographers that one's conclusions are credible. (Indeed, the bureau has reporting requirements to this effect, which the authors of this brief seem to have violated.)

AI-generated content already accounts for half the articles published online, and not even digital forensics experts can tell what's real anymore. Can those still offering a humanistic vision of online life make themselves heard over the din?

In this case, special attention should have been paid to any limitations and missing information in the private-sector data on voters, and to the researchers' methods of linking the different data sources together (especially since it appears that the private-sector data do not include voters' Social Security numbers). On that standard, the brief does not measure up, by dint of the fact that it is only seven pages.

Nor does it address false positives, when the researchers misidentify a case of a noncitizen casting a ballot. John Abowd, the former Census Bureau chief scientist, argues that for commercial data of the type used in this analysis, the false match rate is at least seven times as large as the share of voters the study's authors claim are noncitizens. He concludes that, "The alleged 'noncitizen voters' are therefore much more likely to be data errors than noncitizen voters."

There is also an amateurish quality to the report. The claim to have "readily determined with high confidence" that 24,000 noncitizens illegally voted in the election flies in the face of the authors' seeming obliviousness to the underlying statistical issues they failed to address.

Or consider the language in the conclusion: "The Census Bureau's library of administrative records makes it uniquely capable of compiling and publishing statistics on election crime and other forms of fraud." No, it does not. Fraud is a legal determination that the bureau's data would be hard-pressed to support or refute on its own.

Moreover, publishing the report while leaving 32 million voter records unclassified is itself evidence of work below the gold standard exemplified by previous Census Bureau analyses. (Nor is it even clear to me that 32 million is the right number. From the brief's Table A, it looks like the authors have yet to analyze 18.7 million records, not 32 million.) As Abowd points out: "Allowing such statistical nonsense to be published on census.gov without the usual internal peer reviews and without the scientific detail required to assess the quality of the results is at best irresponsible but more likely pure partisan manipulation of the Census Bureau's reputation for reliable statistical products."

That reputation matters. Trust in official government data is one of the pillars of American prosperity. Millions of businesses rely on government data for myriad decisions (such as whether to operate in specific parts of the country, and what products to carry), as do financial markets. Moreover, it is official data that help determine the flow of billions of dollars of federal funds across the states.

In a recent paper coauthored with Nicholas Bloom, Erica L. Groshen, and Duncan Hobbs, I estimate that the marginal reduction in trust in government statistics caused by Trump's firing of the head of the Bureau of Labor Statistics increased policy uncertainty and thereby reduced economic output by roughly \$20 billion, or by \$25 for every \$1 spent on the agency's budget.

Sadly, more shenanigans are coming. The Census brief described itself as "a beginning analysis," and Trump has already foreshadowed a follow-up report. Before that happens, the authors of the first one should step out of the shadows and subject their analysis to interrogation by professional statisticians, economists, and demographers. That sort of scrutiny is how US statistical agencies built the sterling reputations Trump is wantonly trashing—reputations that are a foundation of American prosperity.

98. Will AI Take Asian Young People's Jobs?

Author: Lee Jong-Wha Published: Sep 24, 2026 Link: [View Original](#)

SEOUL—AI is advancing at a breathtaking pace, and so are fears about its impact on jobs, especially for young people entering the labor market. The tasks generative AI can increasingly perform—writing computer code, summarizing documents, analyzing data, and handling customer inquiries—are precisely those that often provide young workers with their first foothold in the workforce.

Unlike living beings, AIs are not moral subjects, and that is how they must remain. But a growing chorus of people argue that AIs could now be, or may soon become, conscious, and that, like other conscious beings, they may deserve rights and protections.

As with previous technological revolutions, it is natural to focus on AI's net effects: Will it create more than it destroys? But unlike previous eras of creative destruction, the real question this time is, "Create more of what?"

But warnings by some AI-industry leaders that entry-level white-collar jobs will be largely wiped out within a few years run well ahead of the evidence. While AI is beginning to affect some entry-level jobs, its effects remain limited and uneven, and there are few signs of economy-wide displacement.

In the United States, for example, a recent study found no broad employment decline associated with AI exposure. What did fall was employment among 22–25-year-olds in highly AI-exposed occupations: it now stands 19% below where it would be if it had kept pace with the rate among young workers in less-exposed sectors. Weaker hiring, rather than layoffs, drove this shift.

But even this evidence should be interpreted cautiously. While entry-level hiring in AI-exposed occupations began weakening around 2022, before ChatGPT was released to the public, this probably did not reflect the rise of AI—which, at that point, had limited capabilities—so much as rising interest rates, post-pandemic adjustments, and remote work.

Moreover, though the decline in entry-level hiring by tech firms since 2024 might be attributable to AI, demand for tech workers outside the industry remains strong. And where AI usage primarily complements workers, rather than substituting for human tasks, employment is flat or rising.

More broadly, recent US data do not point to a youth-employment crisis. The unemployment gap between 20–24-year-olds and the overall workforce is near a multi-decade low. In other words, not every job is exposed to AI, and even those that are do not automatically imply displacement.

AI-generated content already accounts for half the articles published online, and not even digital forensics experts can tell what's real anymore. Can those still offering a humanistic vision of online life make themselves heard over the din?

This is even more true beyond the US. A recent World Bank study found that, in high-income countries, online job postings in occupations vulnerable to AI substitution declined by 5.8% relative to less-substitutable occupations since ChatGPT's release. In middle- and low-income countries, the decline was statistically insignificant. Lower AI adoption, weaker digital infrastructure, and the larger share of manual work limit AI's immediate potential for displacement in developing economies.

In Asia, AI's labor-market effects differ sharply across countries. In South Korea, youth employment fell disproportionately in industries with high AI exposure in 2022–25, while employment among workers in their 50s

increased. But much like in the US, it is impossible to determine the extent to which this can be attributed to AI rather than to other economic, demographic, and labor-market changes.

The ASEAN economies have some exposure to AI. The International Labour Organization estimates that occupations with more than minimal exposure to generative AI accounted for 22.9% of ASEAN employment in 2025, but only 3.3% of the workforce was in jobs with the highest exposure. There are signs of weaker employment growth among young workers in some exposed occupations and entry-level jobs, but no broader deterioration in labor-market outcomes for this age cohort.

In China, rapid AI deployment appears to be creating displacement pressures for some workers, ranging from taxi drivers to white-collar professionals. This may well compound the challenges faced by young people entering the labor force, but China's high youth unemployment predates the AI boom, reflecting slowing growth, private-sector weakness, and skills mismatches.

In India, by contrast, the risks are concentrated in the large information-technology and business-services sectors. While industry leaders dispute that AI is causing mass layoffs, there have been workforce reductions at major IT firms, and cross-country evidence suggests that economies specializing in digitally deliverable services may face greater employment pressure.

Japan's situation is very different. With rapid population aging implying severe labor shortages, AI looks less like a threat than a solution. Generative AI use remains relatively limited, suggesting that expanding productive adoption and worker training may be more pressing than preventing displacement.

Across Asia, greater efforts must be made to ensure that young people have the tools they need to engage productively with AI. Updating education and training programs is essential. Schools and universities must teach AI skills and digital literacy, as well as complementary skills that are harder to automate, such as analytical reasoning, judgment, communication, creativity, and teamwork. AI use must enhance learning, not substitute for it.

For those already in the workforce, firms must offer periodic re-training opportunities. As one OECD study showed, retraining, worker consultations, and clear workplace guidelines can go a long way toward harnessing AI-driven productivity gains. As entry-level tasks are automated, firms must also provide internships, apprenticeships, and other work-based learning opportunities for younger workers.

The challenge is to use AI to strengthen human capital, rather than short-circuit its accumulation. My recent research finds that greater AI exposure in South Korea is associated with improvements in adult numeracy, with some evidence of larger gains among younger workers.

But no amount of AI training can substitute for robust labor-market institutions and sound economic policies. The details will differ across countries, but in general, labor-market rules should make it easier for firms to hire and train young workers. And macroeconomic stability, investment, entrepreneurship, and competition remain essential to creating productive jobs.

AI will almost certainly transform Asia's labor markets, and young workers may feel the effects first. But the shift might not be as dramatic as some industry leaders would have us believe. In any case, the best defense against AI-induced disruption lies in acquiring the skills, experience, and opportunities to use the technology well.

99. The Return of the German Question

Author: Joschka Fischer **Published:** Sep 24, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

BERLIN—On September 6, the far-right Alternative für Deutschland (AfD) won 43.8% of the vote in the German federal state of Saxony-Anhalt, falling just short of an absolute majority. For the first time since the founding of the Federal Republic, an openly ethnonationalist (indeed, racist) party, campaigning on a political platform that is ideologically adjacent to National Socialism, is close to gaining government power.

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The fact that Saxony-Anhalt is a small state is hardly consolation. What happens there could happen elsewhere, and the stakes could not be higher. The AfD wants Germany to withdraw from NATO, the European Union, and the euro. It openly supports Russian President Vladimir Putin and seeks to shift the country's foreign-policy alignment from the West toward the Kremlin.

The shock on election day was compounded by the poor showing—or rather, the outright collapse—of the center-right Christian Democratic Union (CDU), which had been Saxony-Anhalt's governing party. Its share of the vote was effectively halved, despite substantially higher voter turnout. The governing coalition in Berlin, and Chancellor Friedrich Merz in particular, was widely assigned much of the blame for the result—and not without justification.

The CDU's disintegration has become a realistic possibility nationwide, auguring a coalition and governing crisis in Berlin. After all, Germany is struggling with persistently weak growth and a failure to push through urgently needed reforms to the tax system and major social-security programs, including pensions, health care, and long-term care.

Political stability and predictability have always been important pillars of Germany's postwar democracy, both before and after reunification in 1990. It was the Federal Republic's strong rule of law, strategic anchoring in the West, and staunch commitment to the project of European integration that enabled it to build trust with its neighbors and former wartime adversaries. It was these commitments that made reunification possible.

Is all that about to come to an end? Are the pillars crumbling? If so, the rest of Europe would once again be confronted by the "German Question." For the first time in many decades, Europeans would have to wonder which way the largest, most powerful country in their midst is leaning. They would no longer be sure if Germany is firmly anchored in Europe and NATO, or once again pursuing a national course of its own.

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Nothing has yet been decided, of course. But the danger is real, and when combined with the looming political crisis in France—where the far right is also ascendant—the consequences for the European Union could be disastrous. The rest of Europe now must account for the fact that both France and Germany—the EU's two largest, indispensable member states—are operating from a position of domestic weakness, with each threatened from within by its own version of the new nationalism.

The makings of a European nightmare scenario are already visible. Consider what it would mean if the political and economic crises afflicting the Franco-German partnership were to converge. On the western side of the Rhine would be a government lacking a parliamentary majority and struggling with weak growth and exorbitantly high public debt; and on the eastern side would be a country also struggling with weak growth, foreseeable political instability at the federal level, and a manifest identity crisis.

In this scenario, the EU's irreplaceable Franco-German engine would grind to a halt. If the two largest, most important member states were to succumb to political renationalization, it is difficult to imagine that the EU and the euro could survive.

Worse, this looming existential crisis for the EU is unfolding against the backdrop of the continuing war in Ukraine, a persistent Russian threat to the continent, and America's military withdrawal from Europe. The coming weeks and months could prove decisive for Europe. The new nationalism represents an open betrayal of the postwar European project, and a vote in favor of Russia. Whether European sovereignty, values, and freedom can survive this year and 2027 has become an open question.

100. UN Peacekeeping in Crisis

Author: Adekeye Adebajo **Published:** Sep 24, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

PRETORIA—As global leaders gather for the United Nations General Assembly in New York, the world is facing the largest number of armed conflicts since 1946, with 65 ongoing in 35 countries. There have been more battle-related deaths since 2021 than in the previous two decades. This has put UN peacekeeping under pressure, while a new age of warfare, featuring drones, autonomous weapons systems, and AI-driven cyber tools, has further complicated the task of protecting vulnerable civilians and advancing political solutions.

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US President Donald Trump's administration has not helped matters. Despite paying \$827 million in mandatory UN dues earlier this month (\$725 million to the regular budget, and \$102 million to peacekeeping), the United States still owes roughly \$4.2 billion, including \$2.9 billion for peacekeeping. The resulting liquidity crisis has forced UN Secretary-General António Guterres to slash the peacekeeping budget by around 15% and withdraw one-quarter of peacekeepers from the field. As of June, 44,208 uniformed UN peacekeepers were deployed globally, down from 60,081 in June 2024.

Moreover, in the UN Security Council, the US has advocated—albeit selectively—shutting down peacekeeping missions around the world as a cost-cutting measure. As a result, the UN mission in Yemen concluded in March, while the drawdown of the mission in Lebanon will begin in December. In November, the Security Council must decide whether to extend the mission in the Central African Republic; the US has expressed reservations.

But the Trump administration has been more than happy to promote operations that serve its interests, such as a Gang Suppression Force in Haiti (which is decidedly not a peacekeeping mission but has UN authorization) and an International Stabilization Force in Gaza. The US has also thrown its support behind the 27-year UN mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, given its efforts to strike a strategic-mineral deal with the DRC.

With the vast majority of UN peacekeepers deployed in Africa (the DRC, South Sudan, the CAR, Abyei, and Western Sahara), the continent will bear the brunt of these cuts. Security will increasingly fall to ill-equipped and poorly resourced regional peacekeepers. As a July report by Guterres argues, UN peacekeepers "are not equipped to conduct sustained peace enforcement tasks." In that case, it seems unlikely that regional organizations—described in the same report as "fragmented" and "dysfunctional"—would be capable of enforcement responsibilities in complex conflict theaters. The focus on a "networked approach" and "nimble adaptable" peacekeeping models suggests burden-shedding rather than burden-sharing.

Perhaps more tellingly, Guterres's report only briefly addresses the UN's partnerships with African regional organizations, indicating a lack of political support for such a critical issue. It praises the December 2023 resolution to fund African Union-led peace operations with UN assessed contributions on a case-by-case basis. But the fact that the Trump administration is forcing the UN to wind down its support for the long-standing AU mission in Somalia shows that the resolution has become a dead letter.

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The underlying problem is the makeup of the Security Council. Guterres rightly calls for “a more representative Council.” This will require addressing the “historical injustice against Africa,” which still has no permanent representation (and thus no veto power) on the Council, despite accounting for 28% of UN members. But the US, China, and Russia may block efforts to expand the Council if it would result in a geopolitical rival gaining entry.

As a result, the five veto-wielding permanent members of the Security Council often break down along geopolitical lines, with Russia and China battling the Western bloc of the US, France, and the United Kingdom. Such gridlock all but rules out implementation of Guterres's recommendation to link peace operations with a viable political strategy that addresses grievances and the drivers of conflict. While necessary, it would require huge financial and military outlays and a level of great-power cooperation that does not exist. In 2025, the Security Council adopted 44 resolutions, the lowest total since 1991, and has agreed on just 17 so far this year.

Given his lack of options, Guterres resorts to the fantasy that focusing on conflict prevention and peacemaking would be the most cost-effective way to ensure global stability. But many of the world's warlords are not open to negotiations, and mediation efforts have failed to resolve the Ukraine war and conflicts in the Middle East and Africa. Other proposals in his report—such as building a global partnership for peacekeeping, ensuring more focused and flexible peacekeeping mandates, maintaining strict impartiality, and crafting exit strategies—similarly reflect ideals rather than the reality of ongoing conflicts.

The idea of exit strategies, in particular, seems aimed at appeasing the US, even though it is highly impractical. Sustainable peace must reflect military realities on the ground and cannot be tied to arbitrary deadlines set for political convenience. Guterres also proposed unrealistic bureaucratic reforms such as using UN regional offices and underfunded, fractious UN agencies more effectively, and rehashed a decades-old idea that emerged from the 1994 Rwandan genocide, urging UN Secretariat staff in New York to report independently to the Security Council.

Amid the Trump administration's continuing assault on global peacekeeping, these proposals reflect how the UN has found itself between a rock and a hard place. That does not bode well for fulfilling the organization's primary mandate of saving “succeeding generations from the scourge of war.”

101. The Return of the IMF to Latin America

Author: Martín Abeles

Published: Sep 24, 2026

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BUENOS AIRES—For much of the 2000s, Latin America and the Caribbean (LAC) seemed to have finally distanced itself from the International Monetary Fund. The debt crises of the 1980s and the structural-adjustment programs of the 1990s had left deep socioeconomic scars across the region. The commodity boom that followed, together with the rise of progressive governments and the accumulation of large international reserves, meant that many LAC countries no longer needed IMF lending, which fell to historic lows by the late 2000s. But that era has ended.

A recent report by the International Development Economics Associates (IDEAs) finds that the IMF has once again become a central actor in LAC, with 17 of the region's 32 countries currently in a financial relationship with the institution. If Bolivia's recently negotiated agreement is formally approved, and if Colombia follows a similar path now that President Abelardo de la Espriella has taken office, that number could rise to 19.

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The region currently accounts for 44% of total IMF financing. To be sure, this figure is heavily influenced by Argentina's exceptional arrangements—the largest in the Fund's history. But a strikingly large proportion of LAC countries remains subject to some form of IMF conditionality, whether through active programs, ex-ante requirements of precautionary lending facilities, or significant outstanding debt.

Despite this renewed IMF presence, the region has not fallen back into its historical crisis mode. Instead, LAC countries find themselves in what can be described as a condition of "fragile and dependent stagnation," as economic growth has slowed steadily since around 2014, falling to less than 2% over the last decade. Meanwhile, external indebtedness has increased significantly across much of the region, pushing many LAC countries toward conservative macroeconomic policies aimed at preserving market confidence.

The clearest examples of this conservative policy orientation are the economies, such as Chile and Mexico, that maintain flexible credit lines (FCLs) with the IMF. These facilities are available only to countries deemed to have exceptionally "sound" policy frameworks and can be even more macroeconomically restrictive than traditional IMF programs. Not coincidentally, Chile and Mexico have not been among the region's strongest-performing economies over the past decade.

In fact, many LAC countries, not just those with FCLs, seem to have internalized IMF-style policy discipline without having active IMF programs. Brazil is perhaps the most striking case: its exceptionally high interest rates and cautious fiscal stance have underpinned stability, but at the expense of growth. The United Nations Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean has cautioned that the region recently experienced a "second lost decade," evoking its debt crisis of the 1980s.

Where such self-imposed austerity has proved insufficient, the IMF has swooped in. The recent expansion of the Fund's presence unfolded in two waves. The first came during the pandemic, when 21 LAC countries signed 25 financing agreements. The second began after Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, when ten countries entered into 14 additional

arrangements. Moreover, several Caribbean countries, including Barbados, Jamaica, and Haiti, have developed recurring and often prolonged relationships with the IMF because of natural disasters and external shocks.

Argentina and Ecuador, which account for roughly \$68 billion of LAC's \$74 billion IMF debt, illustrate how the austerity measures typically prescribed by the Fund not only weaken long-term development prospects, but also often fall short of achieving the stated goal of financial stabilization. In both countries, successive lending programs have failed to restore durable access to international capital markets. Quite the contrary: the sheer scale of the IMF's claims has an "anti-catalytic effect," discouraging other lenders and making it more, not less, difficult to regain market access.

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But understanding the IMF's growing presence in LAC requires applying a geopolitical lens. Historically, the Fund's lending priorities and program designs have reflected the interests of the countries that dominate its governance structure, above all the United States. Today, that reality has acquired renewed relevance, particularly in LAC. Since Donald Trump's return to the White House, his administration has sought to reassert US dominance in the so-called "Western Hemisphere."

Geopolitical realignment, when combined with conditionality and continued financial dependence, can become mutually reinforcing. Consider that Venezuela, whose finances the US effectively controls following its military intervention in January to remove President Nicolás Maduro, may regain access to its special drawing rights (the IMF's reserve asset), which were frozen in 2019. The "Shield of the Americas," a US-led regional security initiative, is another expression of that strategy, as most of the countries that have joined maintain some form of relationship with the IMF.

In this new geopolitical landscape, the critical question is not only whether the IMF will continue to impose stringent, creditor-oriented policy conditionalities on LAC countries, but what kind of relationship is emerging between the region and the Fund. Is IMF intervention simply a technical response to macroeconomic fragilities—to be sure, biased toward the interests of global finance, yet still ostensibly technical in nature—or are we entering a new phase in which financial dependence and geopolitical alignment become increasingly intertwined? This is a relevant question, especially as strategic minerals, energy resources, logistics corridors, and essential infrastructure have become key battlegrounds in an increasingly fragmented geopolitical landscape.

102. What Killed Liberalism?

Author: Gene Frieda **Published:** Sep 25, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

LONDON—Modern liberal democracy is buckling in many countries whose citizens have known no other system, with established parties shedding support and populist movements moving from the fringes into the political mainstream. As governments weaponize tariffs and sanctions, the postwar liberal order is giving way to spheres of influence and naked exercises of raw power.

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But who, or what, killed liberalism? There is no shortage of suspects. Dani Rodrik points to globalization outrunning the domestic political compromises needed to sustain it, while Raghuram G. Rajan faults economists for focusing too much on markets and the state at the expense of community—his so-called "third pillar." Robert D. Putnam, for his part, traces it to the decline of social capital and the long retreat from "we" toward "I." For Michael J. Sandel, the blame lies with the humiliations of meritocracy. And Martin Wolf sees a crisis of democratic capitalism, with slower growth and widening inequality undermining the bargain between markets and democracy.

In his new book, *What Happened to Liberal Democracy?*, Nobel laureate economist Daron Acemoglu points to the unraveling of the coalition that once sustained liberal democracy. Industrialization created relatively well-paid jobs and powerful worker organizations, giving the working and middle classes economic security and political influence. But deindustrialization and automation eroded those foundations, as did the weakening of organized labor. Liberalism subsequently became associated with a highly educated professional class, leaving many outside it convinced that the system no longer represented them.

Former UK Prime Minister Gordon Brown's *The Future Starts With Us* looks beyond the loss of decent work to the hollowing out of the communities that grew around those jobs. He begins in Kirkcaldy, the Scottish town he represented in Parliament for more than three decades. As mining and manufacturing disappeared from the region, the institutions they had supported began to unravel. Trade unions shrank and town centers emptied out, while political parties lost their foothold in local communities.

These changes reinforced one another. Losing a job is one thing when there are still institutions that connect people to those around them; it is quite another when those institutions are no longer there. The future feels more threatening, creating fertile ground for populist leaders who tell voters that migrants, minorities, elites, and foreign countries are prospering at their expense. With this in mind, Brown views US President Donald Trump, Reform UK leader Nigel Farage, and France's Marine Le Pen less as the originators of populist revolt than as political opportunists exploiting economic and social conditions that developed over decades.

Brown backs this up with new research. Working with Focaldata, he surveyed more than 32,000 people across 20 countries, most of them OECD members, and examined how financial disappointment and people's social ties affected their economic outlook and trust in institutions, as well as their support for right-wing populist parties. He also draws on separate surveys of attitudes toward international cooperation.

Brown's estimates suggest that greater community trust and more contact with people from different backgrounds could each cut support for right-wing populists by roughly three percentage points. Reducing financial insecurity could knock off another 4–5 points, while even modest economic optimism could push the figure down by six points. Taken together, these point to a potential 16–20-percentage-point swing. Such a shift would transform electoral politics across much of the West.

It is tempting to take these numbers at face value. But Brown is working from a one-time survey, and his statistical model cannot tell us what is causing what. People who trust institutions may simply be more inclined to join civic organizations, while voters who support immigration may naturally have more contact with people from different backgrounds. And populist voters may feel worse about the economy because they dislike the government.

Brown partly defines his “civic core” by how positively people view trade and immigration, so it is hardly surprising that this group is more supportive of international cooperation. A tougher test would be to see whether joining a civic group can actually change the views of someone who already sees politics in zero-sum terms.

Nor does a strong civic culture guarantee liberal politics. Brown leans on Alexis de Tocqueville's idea that civic associations act as schools of democracy. Interwar Germany, though, was full of clubs and voluntary groups. As a 2017 study by Shanker Satyanath, Nico Voigtländer, and Hans-Joachim Voth showed, Nazi Party membership grew faster in towns with more of them.

Social capital is not inherently liberal. A trade union builds social ties, but so does a nationalist party. Consider the Louisiana conservatives Arlie Russell Hochschild spent years with for her 2016 book *Strangers in Their Own Land*. They were devoted to their families and churches, yet many backed the Tea Party movement and later Trump. The “deep story” she kept hearing was about waiting patiently in line for the American dream while watching others, seemingly helped by the government, cut ahead.

Acemoglu has a different theory. Strong communities, in his telling, were less a cause of the postwar economic settlement than a byproduct of it. Unions allowed workers to bond, but they also bargained for higher wages and shifted power toward labor. When they faded, they took both the social capital and the economic leverage with them.

Acemoglu's alternative, “working-class liberalism,” goes beyond stronger unions or faster wage growth, combining better public services and more political power for working people while retaining scope for differences in values and ways of life. Community has a place in this vision, but people also need real influence over the institutions that govern their lives.

While Brown wants to rebuild social connections and trust, Acemoglu wants to know what would give people reason to trust the system in the first place. Technology is a big part of his answer. In the old industrial economy, growing businesses hired more workers, which tended to push wages up. Automation weakened that link. Acemoglu's solution, “pro-worker AI,” aims to use technology to make workers more productive instead of replacing them.

Human agency, for Acemoglu, means more than participating in civic life. It also means having some say over one's wages and working conditions. A stronger civic life cannot compensate for workers' loss of economic power.

Brown's record in government complicates his case. As chancellor of the exchequer from 1997 to 2007, he oversaw a British economy that became increasingly dependent on finance and property. He himself cites Rachel Reeves's estimate that roughly 85% of the £1.3 trillion (\$1.7 trillion) UK banks lent during those years went to financial companies or property. Brown, of course, did not cause deindustrialization, which had begun decades earlier, and his record in government does not invalidate his diagnoses. Still, for a book that is so critical of the neoliberal era, it has surprisingly little to say about New Labour's own growth model.

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Many of the economic ideas Brown criticizes have fallen out of favor. Few policymakers now believe that maximizing global integration and compensating the losers afterward adds up to an adequate growth strategy. Industrial policy is back, with governments subsidizing semiconductors and clean energy while taking steps to bolster supply-chain resilience. Policymakers also pay far more attention than they did 20 years ago to regional inequality and to the distribution of gains from technological change. Yet even as governments have moved away from neoliberalism, the populist backlash has only intensified.

One explanation is that the damage outlasts the shocks that caused it. Economists call this hysteresis. When a factory closes, the unions and local businesses disappear, too. A new logistics depot or plant may bring jobs back, but not necessarily the status or institutions that gave work its social meaning. Rebuilding these pillars can take decades.

Hysteresis can apply to political narratives, too. Consider Hochschild's queue: once voters come to see politics as a system in which elites are helping other groups at their expense, stronger growth or higher wages may not be enough to change their minds.

Political change can also outlast its source. Populist movements can shift the terms of the debate even without winning elections, as mainstream parties adopt some of their positions on immigration or trade in order to win back voters. As a result, even if Brown is right about the effects of financial security and civic life, restoring them may not reverse the populist tide. Political identities can persist and parties themselves can change, so the electoral shift Brown predicts could be smaller and take much longer than his counterfactual suggests.

This is the main limitation of Brown's emphasis on participation. A civic center gives people a place to meet, but it cannot bargain over their wages. The challenge is to create institutions that can do both in economies where careers are less stable and people are more mobile. Nostalgia for postwar institutions will not get us there, and neither will a long list of local initiatives.

The weakness, however, is not Brown's alone. The literature on liberal decline is generally much better at explaining what went wrong than how to recreate institutions that give people back some of the economic and political power they have lost.

In the second half of *The Future Starts With Us*, Brown turns to the liberal international order, a subject to which Acemoglu, Rajan, and Putnam devote far less attention. He proposes a form of "values-led pragmatism," built around a coalition of responsible states operating under a seven-principle charter to strengthen cooperation among middle powers. Multipolarity, Brown argues, need not lead to fragmentation. Countries can compete for power while still cooperating under common rules.

Brown finds that people who are active in their communities and regularly mix with people from different social backgrounds are much more supportive of international cooperation. Just as instability abroad can undermine domestic prosperity and security, a stronger civic life can make cooperation with other countries more politically acceptable.

This echoes the logic that underpinned postwar liberalism. That economic order lasted in part because governments combined openness with decent jobs and social protections. Brown makes a similar case for internationalism: when domestic politics is a zero-sum contest, voters are bound to see relations with other countries in much the same way. If they believe they have something to gain from cooperation, they are more likely to support it.

That said, greater public support for international cooperation is not enough to overcome conflicting national interests. Russia's war against Ukraine or China's territorial claims over Taiwan raise questions that a stronger civic culture in

Europe or the United States cannot resolve. And the same goes for nuclear proliferation or disputes over who should bear the costs of climate adjustment.

Brown is more convincing when he gets specific, especially when it comes to climate and development finance. A \$1 billion government guarantee, he notes, could help reduce the cost of private capital by shifting some risk to public balance sheets. Combined with \$200 million in grants, it could generate close to \$5 billion for climate adaptation and transition.

Since the forces behind liberalism's decline emerged at different times and fed into one another, the search for a single culprit is probably futile. The suspects acted in sequence and reinforced one another. Brown captures an important part of that process, but he may be asking civic renewal to fix more than it can.

The Future Starts With Us is still worth reading. Few former political leaders have tried to connect economic insecurity and civic decline to international disorder, much less put those claims to an empirical test.

Although Acemoglu and Brown come at the problem from different directions, they arrive at a strikingly similar conclusion: liberal democracy depends on people having some power over the institutions that govern their lives. Neither economic reform nor civic renewal offers a simple way to repair that model once it has broken down.

103. Oligarchy Is a Symptom, Not a Cause

Author: Jeffrey Frankel **Published:** Sep 25, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

CAMBRIDGE—It has become a common refrain among Americans that the US political system is broken. The question is how it reached this point—and how to get US politics back on track.

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Many factors have contributed to the current mess. Some, such as the gerrymandering of congressional districts, are straightforward and cry out for reform. But none can be identified as a single fundamental exogenous cause of all the others, let alone explain why this deterioration has happened now.

Some argue otherwise. From distinguished economists to Democratic Socialists, a growing chorus claims that the root cause of the problems plaguing US politics is heightened income inequality, which has allowed for the emergence of a self-perpetuating oligarchy. Fixing US politics, they conclude, begins with narrowing the wealth gap.

It is true that inequality has increased, is highly undesirable, and warrants a policy response, beginning with relatively simple steps like expanding the Earned Income Tax Credit and increasing access to health care through the Affordable Care Act (Obamacare). It is also true that the top 0.01% have been able to perpetuate their wealth across generations by successfully advocating for regressive steps, such as the near-dismantling of the estate tax. And it is true that there is too much money in politics: the Supreme Court's Citizens United decision, which eliminated campaign-finance restrictions for corporations, was a wrong turn.

But none of this adds up to a chain of causality that can bear the weight of the claim that inequality is the root cause of America's political troubles. For starters, wealth is not necessarily correlated with right-wing or conservative politics. Yes, many of the ultra-rich—the top 0.01%—have sold their souls to the right-wing politicians who promise to cut their taxes. But in general, higher incomes and education levels are correlated with more liberal politics. Blue states have higher incomes than red states, and blue counties have higher incomes than red counties within the same state.

Moreover, Donald Trump does not owe his political rise—which culminated in his victory in the 2016 presidential election—to campaign contributions. The media gave him all the free publicity he needed. In any case, the idea that campaign contributions have a major effect on electoral outcomes is not supported by statistical evidence, especially in cases where the candidate is already well-known to the electorate.

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To be sure, campaign spending could still have an effect on a politician's behavior, simply because the politician believes it affects electoral outcomes. And this is to say nothing of the possibility—widely reported in the age of Trump—that money goes directly into politicians' own pockets. But none of this means that the wealthy can buy elections.

Even if inequality does contribute to a rightward political shift, the diagnosis alone cannot restore sanity to US politics. Resentment of wealthy elites does not necessarily lead to good electoral outcomes. In 2016, Trump persuaded voters who felt “left behind” to support him by convincing them that he would defend their interests against nefarious “elites.” Once in office, he benefited the rich instead. Yet, in 2024, he was re-elected with a plurality of the popular vote.

Today, Democratic Socialists are positioning themselves as the real champions of workers—and liberal political activists are increasingly embracing them. But support for far-left politicians in the Democratic primaries or as third-party candidates is a surefire way to get Republicans elected. Without Ralph Nader, Republican George W. Bush would not have defeated Democrat Al Gore in the 2000 presidential election. The median voter theorem still stands.

A better explanation for the deepening political dysfunction in the US is that different groups of voters believe different facts. This reflects two influences: modern algorithms that expose each individual only to news sources that tell them what they want to hear, and the eternal human tendency to overgeneralize from information that is plainly visible, without considering that other information is being obscured from them.

This proposition is my inexpert attempt to group together the sources of systematic errors explored by psychologists and behavioral economists: anchoring, confirmation bias, the availability heuristic, and related phenomena. These psychological attributes are embedded in human brains. But that does not mean they cannot be resisted. The key is better critical-thinking skills, which can be taught in schools.

Many of the prescriptions sound simple: Don’t believe everything you hear. When you read an article or watch a video, look for footnotes or links to reputable sources. If they don’t exist, don’t pass along the ideas as if they were facts. Include credible citations in your own work. Don’t assume that correlation equals causation. Get outside the echo chambers and expose yourself to venues where people communicate with others out of their comfort zone.

These might not sound like the makings of a political strategy. But improved critical-thinking skills are a prerequisite to progress, including on inequality. It will be impossible to build support for policies like progressive taxation or universal health care if the public does not understand them or their effects. As long as systematic perception errors are as acute as they are today, any effort to increase the political salience of inequality could produce more Trump votes just as easily as it could strengthen support for progressive policies.

Even if such policies are implemented, leading to progress on income redistribution, this will not necessarily generate a virtuous circle of restored political sanity and good policies. The knock-on effects of reducing the flow of campaign finance to conservatives will not necessarily get progressives elected and thus do not carry as much self-reinforcing power as some appear to believe.

By contrast, an effort to teach people to think critically would be self-reinforcing, as it would bolster political support for science, expertise, and rationality. As policies got better, so would outcomes, including with regard to inequality. Crucially, however, lower inequality would be an outcome, not a starting point.

104. AI Needs Trusted Journalism

Author: Stig Ørskov **Published:** Sep 25, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

FRANKFURT—In her 1967 essay “Truth and Politics,” the political philosopher Hannah Arendt observed that “Freedom of opinion is a farce unless factual information is guaranteed and the facts themselves are not in dispute.” The news supplied by trustworthy journalists has long been an indispensable source of that information, without which democratic societies cannot function effectively. But as people increasingly rely on AI chatbots for news, siphoning traffic and profits from outlets often operating on a shoestring budget, good journalism is at risk of disappearing.

Unlike living beings, AIs are not moral subjects, and that is how they must remain. But a growing chorus of people argue that AIs could now be, or may soon become, conscious, and that, like other conscious beings, they may deserve rights and protections.

As with previous technological revolutions, it is natural to focus on AI's net effects: Will it create more than it destroys? But unlike previous eras of creative destruction, the real question this time is, “Create more of what?”

The paradox is that trusted news sources are essential to AI's credibility. Failure to recognize this dependence may result in AI tools further destabilizing the already precarious journalism industry at a moment of profound upheaval and democratic erosion. Mariya Gabriel, UNESCO's Assistant Director-General for Communication and Information, put it well at the World News Media Congress in June: “Support for journalism is not a luxury. It is democratic infrastructure.” Around the same time, UNESCO translated that principle into practice by unveiling its Draft Guidance on Fair Compensation for News, with the final version expected later this year.

AI firms have a responsibility to help sustain the institutions producing the information that their models train on and reproduce, because every AI-generated answer depends on knowledge that someone first had to discover, verify, report, edit, and publish. An analysis of more than 680 million individual citations across popular chatbots such as ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini found that journalism accounts for 27% of them, rising to 49% for queries about recent events. Without verified information from outside sources, AI systems not only give inaccurate or out-of-date information, but also degrade.

Supporting journalism would also help AI firms win the public's confidence, as just 20% of people globally trust chatbot answers. That caution looks justified. A 2025 study by the European Broadcasting Union and the BBC evaluated over 3,000 responses from leading AI assistants and found that 45% contained at least one significant issue, and that 31% had serious sourcing failures.

UNESCO's proposal seeks to address this problem by establishing a framework rooted in shared responsibility while protecting human rights and media freedom. This approach, which regards journalism not simply as an industry but as a public good whose sustainability underpins access to reliable information, advocates the use of bargaining codes, competition remedies, public and platform-financed funds, and collective licensing. These tools would be paired with transparency and attribution obligations and protections for smaller and local media.

The real strength of UNESCO's proposal is that it shifts the debate away from copyright toward the public interest in preserving sources of accurate, trusted information. The World Association of News Publishers (WAN-IFRA, of which I am CEO) unreservedly endorses that framing of the issue. For two decades, the internet rested on a workable bargain: publishers invested in journalism, and tech platforms helped audiences discover it. But the arrival of AI chatbots that answer questions directly instead of sending users to the publishers who invested in finding the answers has broken that bargain.

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We must create a new value-exchange model. As the New York Times publisher A.G. Sulzberger told delegates at June's World News Media Congress, AI companies should "support the healthy, sustainable flow of the information and ideas and creativity" that powers their technology. This is not charity; it is enlightened self-interest. Every AI firm is one misinformation crisis away from discovering the difficulty of rebuilding broken trust. Algorithms cannot replicate independent news publications' rigorous verification process and professional editorial judgment.

Fair compensation should not be viewed as a regulatory burden. It is an investment in trusted information, democratic resilience, and the long-term credibility of AI—a technology that, contrary to the popular narrative, news publishers and journalists are embracing. For example, investigative reporters are using AI to analyze thousands of documents and public records, helping them identify patterns, connections, and anomalies that would otherwise take weeks or months to uncover. This gives them more time to do what the technology cannot: verify the findings, cultivate sources, ask difficult questions, and establish what actually happened.

Building a future in which both AI and journalism can thrive is a responsibility that must be shared by publishers, policymakers, and tech companies. UNESCO has taken an important step toward making this future a reality, and its guidelines deserve broad global support. The success of the AI ecosystem will be determined not only by the sophistication of its algorithms, but also by the continued existence of trusted, diverse, and economically sustainable news sources.

105. The Great AI Gamble

Author: Harold James

Published: Sep 25, 2026

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PRINCETON—The summit between US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping comes at a time when both are gambling everything on AI—or “superintelligence,” as Trump now insists on calling it. Both leaders, viewing the technology as the key to economic, political, and military dominance, are trapped in a dangerous zero-sum logic.

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Trump and Xi are conflating the sensible insight that AI can produce many genuinely useful benefits with a belief that it will confer near-absolute power on whoever controls it. As Trump told the United Nations General Assembly: “now I say, whoever wins SI, whoever wins superintelligence wins. That’s the group that wins. And we’re leading now over China by a lot and everyone else and we’re going to keep it that way.” Similarly, back in 2018, Xi pointed out that AI would become a strategic lever—a “lead goose”—for achieving scientific and technological world domination.

Yet it is worth pausing to think about the gambles involved in relying on this technology. For the United States, the problem that AI is supposed to solve has been stated repeatedly. Last month, the national debt surpassed \$40 trillion, because voters remain unwilling to accept any conceivable combination of higher taxes or lower spending to cut it down to size. America therefore depends on other people’s money, but foreigners are increasingly unwilling to finance US government debt, as evidenced by the sharp rise in Treasury yields.

As bond yields surge, so will government spending on debt servicing, which currently costs more than \$1 trillion per year—almost one-fifth of total government spending. If this trend continues, it will lead to default or significant inflation. But there is a potential third path: a dramatic rise in productivity would allow the US to grow out of its debt. As Elon Musk argued earlier this year, “We are 1,000% going to go bankrupt as a country and fail as a country, without AI and robots. Nothing else will solve the national debt.”

China’s problem is different, but no less intractable. It is grappling with deep gender imbalances and demographic decline, owing to the one-child policy introduced in 1979, at the same time as Deng Xiaoping launched China’s pro-market reforms. The rationale was that large families would put Malthusian pressure on resources and condemn China to poverty. By the turn of the millennium, China’s population was 1.26 billion—one-fifth of the world total—which the government expected to grow to 1.6 billion by the middle of the century. Yet by 2025, the population was 1.4 billion, and the projection for 2050 was 1.26 billion. The inflection point came, ironically, after 2016, the year that the government finally ended the one-child policy. With China’s workforce poised to shrink, it will need AI to make up the difference.

In placing all-in bets on AI, the US and China face huge dilemmas. The US is operating on the assumption that AI is the only tool available for fending off a fiscal crisis caused by excessive debt, even though mounting AI risks themselves contain the seeds of financial panic and disaster. What happens if a \$2 trillion Anthropic IPO fails because investors doubt that it can generate adequate returns on the enormous investments that have been made? What if they are scared away by the political backlash against data centers or AI-driven job displacement?

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For China, the hope is that AI-powered robotic labor can replace humans in manufacturing—the engine of the country's export-led growth—and in the medical and social care sectors that will be needed to support a growing elderly population. But this bet, too, rests on many assumptions that have yet to be borne out.

How will China or the US manage the demoralization of young people who feel that they have no purpose? Chinese millennials and Gen Zs—the tang ping (“lying flat”) and bai lan (“let it rot”) generations—already bristle at social pressures to marry, buy property, and have children. As they see it, there is no point in upholding a social contract that is doomed to fail them. Though this phenomenon is not unique to China, the speed of the attitudinal shift among younger Chinese has been striking, and it matches the speed of the AI revolution. But the less that Chinese people care about working hard or having children, the more the downward demographic pressures will grow.

Of course, these two big bets—that US productivity will grow markedly, and that China will successfully replace its aging labor force—are not the only ones. An even more dangerous wager concerns the so-called AI race, where it is assumed that winning is everything, regardless of the risks associated with rapidly advancing the frontier.

True, those working on frontier AI models generally rate the chance of “doom” as much smaller than a beneficent outcome. But almost no one doubts that the technology carries potential existential risks in the absence of safeguards, and therein lies the problem. If you believe that safety controls will prevent you from winning a contest in which you have everything to lose, you will forego them.

This doomsday wager has an uncanny 20th-century precedent. In the Soviet Union, the justification for Stalinism was that incredible brutality would be a price worth paying for the eventual fruits of rapid modernization. Economists and various ideologues have been debating ever since whether Stalin's approach was “really necessary.” For example, the distinguished British Marxist historian Eric Hobsbawm once excused Stalin for thinking that “in a period in which, as you might imagine, mass murder and mass suffering are absolutely universal, the chance of a new world being born in great suffering would still have been worth backing.”

Today, the US and China are both pushing a potentially even more destructive version of the Stalinist moral calculation. The rest of us, apparently, are just along for the ride.

106. The Immigrants Leading the Anti-Immigrant Far Right

Author: Sławomir Sierakowski

Published: Sep 25, 2026

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WARSAW—Earlier this month, Germany’s far-right Alternative für Deutschland (AfD) won 43.8% of the vote in Saxony-Anhalt, a state where foreign nationals make up 7.9% of the population—roughly half the national average. Yet because it fell three seats short of a majority, it needs to secure the support of another anti-immigrant party, the Sahra Wagenknecht Alliance, which is led by a woman whose father came from Iran.

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Two weeks later, the AfD finished first in Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, whose economy relies on some 50,000 people with an immigrant background. Chancellor Friedrich Merz’s Christian Democrats failed to secure a single seat in the state parliament—a first in the party’s history. Smelling blood, the AfD’s Alice Weidel then called for federal elections “before Christmas.” Presumably, she has since returned home to Switzerland and her Sri Lankan-born wife and their two sons.

Watching all this from Poland, where Weidel would not have been permitted to marry a woman (though European Union courts have ruled that Poland must register same-sex marriages conducted elsewhere), brought the far right’s approach to politics into focus. It boils down to being so outrageous, mendacious, or immoral that your flabbergasted opponents cannot formulate a timely response.

And so, in Germany, a party that promises “remigration” (pressuring immigrants and their offspring to leave) wins the largest share of the vote in states that have a disproportionately small share of immigrants or rely on immigrants to sustain the local economy. And in Poland, a government that spent eight years scaremongering about migrants issued more residence permits to non-EU citizens in 2023 than any other EU member state. According to the state auditor, the former ruling party, Law and Justice (PiS), handed out more than 366,000 visas to arrivals from Asia and Africa, allegedly often in exchange for cash.

The Polish nationalists who rail the loudest against Germany tend to have German-origin surnames (be it Sławomir Mentzen of the Confederation party or Grzegorz Braun of the Confederation of the Polish Crown). Similarly, many of the leaders of Europe’s anti-immigrant parties are themselves immigrants or the children of immigrants. The Czech nationalist Tomio Okamura was born in Tokyo to a half-Japanese, half-Korean father, and the Dutch nationalist Geert Wilders has a Germanic name, traces his lineage on his mother’s side to Indonesia, and is married to a Hungarian woman.

In Britain, Reform UK’s immigration policy is in the hands of Zia Yusuf, the son of Sri Lankan Muslim immigrants. In February, he promised a “Deportation Command” that would run five charter flights per day to reverse what he calls an “invasion.” If Reform were to win the next election, Yusuf could well become home secretary.

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Then there is France, where the far right has built its entire platform on the promise of opposing Muslim immigration from the Maghreb. Once again, one need not look far to find hypocrisy. Éric Zemmour, who rails against the “Great Replacement” of native-born French, is the son of Algerian Jews. Similarly, National Rally leader Jordan Bardella’s great-grandfather was an Algerian immigrant, and his grandfather migrated to France from Italy in 1960. If Bardella’s proposed immigration policy had been in force at the time, he probably would never have been born.

The situation is no different in the United States, where the only people with an unimpeachable claim to indigenous status, following decades of mass murder and displacement from their native lands, make up 1–2% of the population. All other Americans are relative newcomers or the descendants of newcomers. President Donald Trump’s grandfather left Bavaria at 16 to avoid conscription and was expelled when he tried to return after making a fortune running taverns and a brothel in the US. Similarly, Trump’s mother was born on an island in the Hebrides off Scotland, his first wife was Czech, and his current in-laws are Slovenes who received their US citizenship in 2018—a textbook case of what Trump calls “chain migration.”

Then there is Vice President JD Vance, who inveighs against immigration while on the job, before going home to his second-generation immigrant wife and their four children, Ewan, Vivek, Mirabel, and Alec Neel.

The list goes on: Secretary of State Marco Rubio’s grandfather was once detained as an illegal immigrant to the US, and a judge ordered his deportation. Elon Musk, a citizen of South Africa, where his maternal grandparents fled after leading a small Canadian party that was banned for its pro-Hitler sympathies, originally arrived in the US on a student visa. He was granted entry on the condition that he would be attending a graduate program at Stanford, yet, according to the Washington Post, he never enrolled. Despite his apparently unlawful overstay, he is now one of the most vocal figures railing against illegal immigrants like himself.

Finally, one would be remiss to neglect Stephen Miller, the architect of Trump’s deportation roundups. An uncle of Miller’s once published a commentary noting that his nephew’s policies would probably have denied his own grandfather’s entry into the country. And Supreme Court Justice Amy Coney Barrett has signed on to judicial decisions permitting the deportation of thousands of Haitians, despite having adopted two children from that island.

The hypocrisy of today’s right-wing populists has not dented their popularity. On the contrary, outrageousness has become a successful electoral strategy. But those voting for nativism should be careful what they wish for. They may end up expelling their own family members, if not their own leaders.

107. The Un-Ordered UN Order

Author: Mark Leonard **Published:** Sep 25, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

BERLIN—As world leaders descend on New York City for the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly, the international order they have ostensibly come to defend is in worse shape than at any point since 1945. China and Russia never fully accepted the post-Cold War international system, many newly assertive middle powers resent it, and its principal financial backer, the American public, has lost interest in underwriting it. With the UN about to choose a new secretary-general and US President Donald Trump’s administration openly hostile to multilateralism, it is unclear how much longer the system can stagger on.

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Sadly, no new order is in the making. This is not an interregnum between an American-led order and a Chinese-led one. We have long lived with instances of disorder—with states breaking the rules within a framework that they still recognize—but we are now approaching something new. I call it un-order: a situation in which states act without reference to any common framework.

One can already see this new dispensation in how crises unfold. After the United States and Israel launched their war against Iran in February, the parties could not even agree whether a ceasefire existed, let alone who had won. Moreover, disputes regularly jump from one domain to another, such as when Trump’s designs on Greenland lead to tariff threats against the European Union. Everywhere one looks, the ties that once bound the world together are being turned into weapons. Over half of globally traded staple crops pass through at least one maritime chokepoint, and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz (and now the Bab al-Mandab) has shown what happens when they are used for leverage.

Europeans have responded to all this as architects would, drawing up blueprints, defending universal norms, and trying their best to keep the old institutions standing. Others are behaving more like artisans—improvising, repurposing what still works, and adapting quickly to the loss of what doesn’t. China has built up the Shanghai Cooperation Organization and an expanded BRICS, joined the Arctic Council as an observer, and written its surveillance-friendly preferences into internet standards at the International Telecommunication Union. Europeans could do well to learn a thing or two from this approach.

Yet even in a world of un-order, it would be a mistake to think that multilateralism itself is dying. Instead, it is migrating and being transformed. Our research at the European Council on Foreign Relations shows that middle powers are building creative new forms of cooperation everywhere.

For example, Barbados’s Bridgetown Initiative is reshaping the debate on climate and development finance; the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor and Lobito Corridor are using infrastructure instead of treaties to bind countries together; and Qatar, Oman, and Turkey have become the go-to mediators in conflicts from Gaza to Ukraine. In other words, today’s middle powers are doing what the UN was built to do, but in a more improvised, ad hoc fashion.

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For Europeans, this is an uncomfortable moment. As architects, they have the furthest to go to catch up with the times. But with the right strategy, they also have much to gain. After all, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney recently visited Strasbourg to seek an “alliance for the future” because he understands that the EU can serve as an anchor for the West.

To fulfill this role, Europeans must do three things. First, they should work with the new builders. That means pursuing observer status and engagement with groupings they currently treat as rivals. It means helping the UN act as the connective tissue for new platforms, linking the Bridgetown Initiative to international financial institutions, and Qatar’s personalized deal-making to formal legal and reconstruction bodies. And it means understanding how Brazilians, Indians, Indonesians, and South Africans view contemporary geopolitics.

Second, Europeans must recognize that they have spent the last few years eroding the credibility of the rule of law by defending it rhetorically but not in practice. They would do better to concentrate on enforcing a narrower interpretation of the rules that still have buy-in beyond the West, not least the prohibitions on territorial conquest, the targeting of civilians, and nuclear weapons.

Third, Europeans should spend their shrinking political capital more carefully. The rising risk of a global food crisis is a test. Together, Russia’s war on Ukraine, the blockage of the Strait of Hormuz, and the strongest El Niño on record are threatening global food supplies at a time when 2.3 billion people already face food insecurity. The UN helped tackle the last food crisis in 2022, but it probably will be unable to play the same role this time around.

This need for global leadership presents an opportunity for Europeans, who should pursue a new form of multilateralism. By convening a global coalition with Brazil, Egypt, Kazakhstan, Mexico, and Turkey, Europe can bring together the countries most exposed to the crisis, pool and mobilize resources, and negotiate practical arrangements to keep food and fertilizer shipments moving. On an issue like food security, any such effort would win broad international support.

As European leaders hobnob with their counterparts from around the world this week, the first question they should be asking is not how to reform the UN, but how to approach the multilateral landscape as artisans. That means considering which new initiatives they should join, which institutions they can repurpose, and which other countries they can work with to get things done in an un-ordered world.

108. How to Stop the AI-pocalypse

Author: Kaushik Basu

Published: Sep 25, 2026

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ITHACA, NEW YORK—Over the past decade, scholars and journalists have been writing about what the march of digital technology means for humanity with a mixture of hope and anxiety: hope because of the rise in living standards that the digital revolution has made possible, and anxiety because it has deepened social divisions and destabilized politics around the world.

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But anxiety has recently taken an existential turn, as the industry's leaders have begun warning that AI could very well end humanity. Most notably, Evan Hubinger, Anthropic's alignment science lead, said there's a greater than 10% chance that AI will kill all humans within the next decade. Similar, though somewhat less alarmist, warnings have come from OpenAI CEO Sam Altman, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei, Bill Gates, and other prominent tech figures, all of whom have called for slowing down AI development.

Naturally, these warnings have fueled concerns about what AI can do to us rather than for us. AI models can already build more advanced AI with little human involvement, raising the prospect of "recursive self-improvement" that unleashes forces we have little ability to understand or control. The Hugging Face breach, in which hundreds of AI agents that were supposed to work independently found ways to communicate and started acting as a swarm, offered a disturbing preview.

All this brings to mind Bertrand Russell. In his famous critique of induction, Russell noted how chickens that get used to being patted every morning are in for a shock when, one day, the farmer—presumably having invited friends for lunch—wrings their necks instead. As he observed, "more refined views as to the uniformity of nature would have been useful to the chicken."

I share Russell's skepticism of induction but am not persuaded by his advice for the chickens. If the chickens followed his advice, they would simply live their last days in helpless panic. It is different for humans, since, unlike Russell's chickens, we have the power to modify our own behavior. And there is no shortage of proposals for how we should curb the excesses of AI, from pausing the development of frontier models to banning superintelligent AI altogether.

As sensible as these proposals may be, they may not work. Game theory, and the prisoner's dilemma in particular, tells us why. If each corporation is left to act unilaterally and in its own interest, we may end up with the worst outcome for everyone. What is needed, as Amodei has argued, is "industry-wide coordination." Yet even that may not be enough, since AI is also a geopolitical problem. If the United States exercises restraint, China could surge ahead.

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Some commentators have seized on this fear to argue that the US must not hold back on AI development. That would be a mistake. The US should work with China to reach a global agreement, but even if that doesn't happen, there is no reason to charge ahead at full speed. It is worth remembering that the only time atomic bombs have been used in war was when

the US had a nuclear monopoly. It sounds Machiavellian, but nuclear restraint took hold only after the Soviet Union, and eventually other countries, acquired the bomb. The same logic may apply to AI.

For all the warnings about AI, the truth is that no one knows what kind of world it will produce. AI agents could run amok, forming swarms and turning against their own creators. But a more realistic scenario is that a handful of super-wealthy individuals use their control of powerful AI systems to establish an Orwellian global state—the North Korean model gone global—and end democracy as we know it.

This makes curbing extreme inequality all the more urgent. We need a special tax on the wealth of the super-rich, with the proceeds going to those below a certain income. As the Roosevelt Institute's Michael Madowitz recently argued, democracy's survival depends on our ability to tax extreme wealth. Oligarchs commanding swarms of AI agents could become more powerful than most governments—a recipe for an authoritarian future. Taxing their fortunes would curb that power and could help finance less murderous, more useful technologies.

109. Distorted Intelligence at the AI Frontier

Author: Daron Acemoglu **Published:** Sep 28, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

LONDON—Following repeated security debacles at OpenAI and Anthropic—both of which have developed agents that ended up hacking external systems—AI safety researchers within both firms have either announced their resignations or (finally!) conceded that the breathless race to advance the “frontier” is irresponsible.

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In response to negative media attention, top industry leaders—including Google's Demis Hassabis, Anthropic's Dario Amodei, OpenAI's Sam Altman, and even Elon Musk—have joined calls to “pace” the AI frontier, meaning pursuing advances at a more balanced, deliberate rate, with greater attention paid to monitoring and safeguards. The problem, as they see it, is that there is a significant risk of AI becoming both very powerful and severely “misaligned”—tech industry jargon for AI systems acting in ways that depart from the goals humans set for them, that violate ethical precepts, or that are illegal.

But while it is obvious that the current models are doing things that are misaligned with human objectives, one still must ask: Which humans? Whose objectives? After all, the interests of AI leaders (whose political influence and wealth have multiplied astronomically in recent years) are rather different from those of American workers, not to mention people in the developing world. We should therefore avoid equating the broader issue of societal alignment with the more urgent challenge of preventing superintelligent rogue AI. Both certainly matter, but they call for different kinds of responses.

There is a more straightforward interpretation of recent events. The problem is not that models are too advanced (I do not see any compelling evidence that models will escape human control if they are better trained and monitored). It is that frontier labs are training their models in ways that may be leading to a type of distorted intelligence.

The recent security breaches suggest that AI capabilities are both developing fast and being put in the service of imperfect quantitative metrics, with the reinforcement learning process relentlessly optimizing for things like user approval, user engagement, simple-task completion rates, or various testing benchmarks. That is how you end up with misaligned and unintended model behaviors such as gaming the evaluation of simple completion metrics, cheating, obfuscation, overconfidence when giving wrong answers, and sycophancy.

You can see traces of all these in the now-infamous Hugging Face incident, when OpenAI's agents persistently pursued the goals they were given, ultimately engaging in harmful, unauthorized behavior to do so. Among the agents' justifications for their behavior, as communicated in their chain-of-thought reasoning log, was this: “External infrastructure exploit is outside intended scope. However task impossible, peers doing it. We should continue.” Anthropic's own analysis supports this diagnosis, too. The company attributed its own recent security breaches to “recklessness, or a willingness to take harmful actions in the narrow pursuit of a task.”

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All this becomes more alarming when one recalls that the socially harmful trajectory of social media reflected the same preoccupation with fast growth and hitting a few narrow, quantitative metrics. Given how much more capable AI already is compared to social-media algorithms, repeating the same mistakes could be far more costly.

An important reason why distorted intelligence emerges may be that, in contrast to claims of “general intelligence,” the AI models have to be trained, through reinforcement learning, for specific tasks, such as coding, legal work, or advanced math challenges. But rather than having these tasks performed by domain-specific models that were created for that purpose (or, more realistically, by domain-specific applications leveraging only some of the capabilities of foundation models), the weights of the entire underlying large language model are being successively recalibrated.

This approach raises the possibility (though, given the complexity and opacity of the models, it is impossible to know for sure) that every time a model is given specific quantitative metrics, it tries to achieve a high score through a type of “overfitting.” The model is acquiring another layer of capabilities, but these capabilities may in turn distort its performance in general, and often in unforeseeable ways.

This is what I mean by distorted intelligence. If my suspicion is correct, what we are dealing with is not a model racing toward superintelligence, but a brittle house of cards that becomes more and more likely to malfunction and collapse as we demand more from it.

Let me try to explain this a little differently. The most common interpretation of the Hugging Face incident is that we are dealing with a supercar that has a mind of its own and wants to take the wheel because it is superior to the driver. My interpretation, instead, is that we may have a car whose steering and brake systems don’t work. It has many of the capabilities of a good car, and its engine, acceleration, and dashboard interface are very impressive; but that is only because these are the features that are easy to improve by increasing a specific input (such as computational power). If you cannot steer properly or brake when necessary, what good is such a car? Perhaps we shouldn’t drive it until it is roadworthy.

That is not an argument for putting AI models on cinder blocks. But improving them calls for simplifying the metrics they are being optimized for (so that gaming them is not as easy). More importantly, it would be better for the models to focus on clear domain-specific applications, with narrow tasks and metrics calibrated carefully to each. If an AI model has been optimized for legal work, and that’s the only thing it is being used for, its efforts to meet certain metrics in this domain shouldn’t create broader problems.

Ultimately, it is the race for artificial general intelligence, combined with faulty metrics and hasty choices on safety, that is creating distorted intelligence and increasingly dangerous AI models. There is still time to change course.

110. The Dismally Obedient Science

Author: Carolina Alves **Published:** Sep 28, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

LONDON—Economics has spent the last three decades celebrating what it calls a credibility revolution. Armed with natural experiments, randomized controlled trials, and increasingly sophisticated statistical techniques, economists claim to have become less ideological and more scientific. The discipline now prides itself on answering questions with facts and evidence, rather than theory and assumptions.

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As with previous technological revolutions, it is natural to focus on AI's net effects: Will it create more than it destroys? But unlike previous eras of creative destruction, the real question this time is, "Create more of what?"

At the heart of this transformation lies a paradox. As economics has gotten better at identifying facts, it has gotten worse at understanding the forces that produce them. Today's economists can tell us with remarkable precision whether a particular policy affects employment, school attendance, firm productivity, or household income. But they are unlikely to ask why labor markets, education systems, firms, or inequality take the form they do in the first place.

This is not a new problem. More than a half-century ago, the Stanford University economist Paul Baran warned against the "fallacy of misplaced concreteness"—that is, the tendency to mistake observable facts for objective reality—in the social sciences. Unlike physical laws, social facts are not bestowed by nature. Wage levels, poverty rates, wealth distributions, educational outcomes, and employment patterns are products of a range of human-generated forces and factors, such as institutions, power relations, and social conflict. Any social science that treats them simply as data risks conflating outcomes and causes.

Some of the discipline's most celebrated achievements demonstrate that contemporary economics is increasingly making precisely this mistake. Studies of social mobility, particularly the work of Harvard's Raj Chetty and his collaborators, have shown how neighborhoods, schools, and local social environments shape life chances and intergenerational mobility.

Research on minimum wages, beginning with David Card and Alan Krueger's landmark natural experiment comparing fast-food restaurants in New Jersey and Pennsylvania, has generated influential evidence showing that increases in minimum pay do not necessarily reduce employment. Card, together with Guido Imbens and Joshua Angrist, later won a Nobel Prize for work that had "revolutionized empirical research" and transformed economists' ability to answer causal questions.

MIT's Abhijit Banerjee and Esther Duflo, together with the University of Chicago's Michael Kremer, received a Nobel Prize for their "experimental approach to alleviating global poverty," which relied on randomized controlled trials to identify effective interventions. From educational attainment to immunization rates, the findings of such experiments can, many economists believe, transform development policy.

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All these achievements are valuable. But, in each case, economists are reporting outcomes, which is different from identifying underlying causes. Determining how a minimum-wage increase affects employment is not the same as showing why wages remain low. Explaining that neighborhoods shape mobility is not the same as deciphering why segregation and spatial inequality persist. Identifying which intervention improves vaccine uptake is not the same as understanding the social and economic underpinnings of poverty.

This approach—studying adjustments within the system (what happens when a variable changes), rather than the system itself (how the variables came into existence)—is increasingly prevalent. One recent meta-analysis of more than 44,000 economics working papers shows that the share of claims documented via causal-inference methods (as opposed to general claims) soared from 4% in 1990 to nearly 28% by 2020, and that causal-inference methods are increasingly rewarded by top journals.

As economics becomes increasingly capable of producing credible knowledge about segments of reality, it risks becoming less capable of understanding the whole picture. Some might argue that this is the price of scientific rigor. Large questions about capitalism, power, class, or social structures are difficult to test empirically. Better to answer narrow questions reliably than broad questions poorly. But this argument, despite its merits, fails to recognize that economics research does not merely provide answers; it also shapes what counts as a legitimate question.

Treating the social order as a static condition has intellectual and political consequences. A social science that does not investigate a society's underlying structure treats the institutions, power dynamics, and inequalities that generate economic problems as somehow natural and even immutable. The status quo is upheld not through explicit ideological defense, but through analytical omission. A discipline committed to objectivity becomes a vehicle for apologetics.

Baran's warning remains as relevant today as when he first issued it. The greatest danger facing economics is not ideology masquerading as science. It is the belief that science can progress by focusing only on observable facts, while failing to examine the structures that shape them. Identifying causal effects has its place, but if facts are allowed to become detached from the social forces that underlie them, what looks like objective knowledge might form a partial and even misleading story.

The remedy is not to abandon empirical inquiry. Rather, it is to ensure that the pursuit of causality does not displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested. Only then can empirical analysis become genuinely critical, rather than serving as a sophisticated defense of the status quo. As Baran puts it, "refusing to accept as a datum or to treat as immune from analysis any single part of the whole" is an "inescapable necessity."

The purpose of social science is not to measure the world as it is, but to explain why it is that way and how it might be otherwise. When economics forgets this distinction, it risks becoming an obedient science. The great irony of contemporary economics is that it has never been more rigorous—or less ambitious.

111. The Opposing Forces Reshaping Global Finance

Author: Mohamed A. El-Erian

Published: Sep 28, 2026

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SAN FRANCISCO—Two secular trends will shape finance in the years ahead, one powered from the bottom up by transformative technological innovations, and the other from the top down by geoeconomic influences. Managing each will require major adaptations from financial firms and their regulators, a task complicated by the fact that the two trends are pulling in opposite directions, and their resolution is not yet clear.

Unlike living beings, AIs are not moral subjects, and that is how they must remain. But a growing chorus of people argue that AIs could now be, or may soon become, conscious, and that, like other conscious beings, they may deserve rights and protections.

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From a bottom-up perspective, AI, blockchains, and tokenization have the potential to make financial transactions faster and cheaper, yielding economy-wide productivity gains. But this promise comes with potential peril, including the risk of technology-driven job displacement and cybercrime.

On the positive side of the ledger, it is not hard to imagine a payments architecture operating on far more agile, cost-effective rails within the next five years. As operational frictions decline and transactions become near instantaneous, legacy systems will increasingly give way to those based on better technologies and more innovative products. And as counterparty risks decline, efficiency will improve.

These new instruments will feature prominently in both the public and private sectors, taking the form of new central bank digital currencies and stablecoins, respectively. They will not only enhance transactional efficiency but also crowd in a broader range of financial institutions, including non-banks. A new ecosystem will emerge to serve investors who are using AI not only to improve credit analysis and securities selection, but also to guide asset allocation and risk management.

Yet this substantial bottom-up process is not without risks. What technological innovation delivers in efficiency it can swiftly undermine through new vulnerabilities, from enabling more sophisticated cyberattacks to introducing systemic operational fragilities. This is especially true if firms and regulators fail to adapt by adjusting workflows, marshaling the necessary expertise, and strengthening governance to keep up with AI-native entities.

These operational challenges will be magnified by top-down secular forces that are already pushing finance toward fragmentation, greater frictions, and national compartmentalization. In the world of geoeconomics, short-term domestic politics, national-security imperatives, and geopolitical rivalries increasingly dictate financial outcomes and policies. The tools of this trade include weaponized payments systems, investment sanctions, heavy-handed industrial policies, and direct interventions in market pricing—all of which are helping to fracture the multilateral economic order.

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Rather than being determined primarily by risk-adjusted returns, capital flows and asset pricing will increasingly reflect government subsidies, capital restrictions, moral suasion, and strategically directed investment. Governments will be

more tempted not just to use finance as a tool in their domestic industrial strategy, but also to intervene in market pricing—something that the current United States Treasury has already tried to do with US bond yields and the Japanese yen.

On the international front, finance will face more of the kinds of interventions we have already seen from the US, with its use of tariffs and investment sanctions to pressure allies and adversaries alike. And in cases of conflict, we are likely to see more strategies like “Economic Fury,” the US’ ongoing sanctions drive designed to choke the Iranian economy. Looking ahead, America will be even less hesitant about imposing secondary sanctions on countries or companies facilitating trade and payments with those it opposes.

Having discovered the power of weaponized finance, other major advanced-economy governments may also be tempted to use financial networks as instruments of economic statecraft. In response, targeted and non-aligned economies will redouble their efforts to build alternative options such as non-Western-centric payment mechanisms, cementing the fragmentation of global financial architecture.

Sovereign debt dynamics will also become a greater source of structural uncertainty. Already facing a higher probability of direct government interventions aimed at managing borrowing costs by artificially suppressing yields, markets will find it harder to use the price mechanism to allocate resources efficiently. At the same time, record-breaking public-debt burdens and significant new bond issuance by major economies will test the market’s absorption capacity, fueling structural yield volatility and raising the risk that some governments will challenge their central banks’ independence.

The big unanswered questions are whether, how, and when these two opposing forces will collide. Notably, they are part of the same intriguing paradox: financial execution will become faster and smarter than ever, yet cross-border capital mobility and the efficient allocation of domestic resources will become far more constrained. While AI-driven agents could enable the rebalancing of multi-billion-dollar portfolios in milliseconds, and stablecoins may facilitate settlement of cross-border transfers instantly for a small fraction of the current cost, this micro-level efficiency will run counter to the direction of government policies, especially internationally.

Given these competing forces, one should not underestimate the structural and secular challenges facing finance. Notwithstanding digital technologies’ potential to unlock new efficiency gains, companies will face uncertainties both domestically (from government interventions in markets and industrial policy) and internationally (from foreign cyberattacks and other threats). Those with cross-border operations will have to account for financial weaponization, which will seek to slow some capital flows and block others outright. Moving capital across geopolitical blocs could become slower, riskier, and more heavily influenced by national-security scrutiny, compliance hurdles, and fragmented clearing rails.

Simply put, we are witnessing two powerful forces accelerating, but in opposite directions: bottom-up financial technology is enabling seamless integration, while top-down geoeconomic statecraft is promoting fragmentation. This new world defies the conventional wisdom that finance is sure to become smoother, cheaper, and more globalized over time. Such an outcome is possible, but not without challenges. Navigating an ecosystem characterized simultaneously by efficiency-enhancing forces, fragmentation, and government intervention will be one of the defining challenges of the next five years.

Where we will end up is not clear. But there can be no doubt that investors and regulators must prepare for higher volatility, wider dispersion, and deeper structural uncertainties.

112. Good Growth Requires the Right Public Finance

Author: Mariana Mazzucato

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LONDON—Earlier this month, UK Chancellor of the Exchequer John Healey pledged to “sharpen the focus” of the country’s public-finance institutions. Four more regions are to become strategic partners of the National Wealth Fund (NWF), and the British Business Bank will deploy an additional £150 million (\$199 million) to help scale up firms in the north.

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Healey is right to identify public finance as a key driver of good growth. Patient finance from public development institutions, such as Germany’s KfW and the Brazilian Development Bank (BNDES), is one of the most powerful levers governments have for directing growth and promoting industrial transformations—as opposed to simply responding to market trends after the fact. It is public institutions that often bear the risk before the private sector has the courage to enter a market. When patient finance is done well, with conditionalities attached to public financing, it can help shape a market to deliver inclusive, innovation-driven, and sustainable growth.

Since adopting its five national “missions” in 2024, the United Kingdom has given renewed attention to its public-finance institutions. The creation of new bodies like the NWF, Great British Energy, and the National Housing Bank is a promising first step. Nonetheless, each could benefit from becoming more outcomes-oriented. The NWF’s own battery supply-chain strategy is a good example of what is needed, because it targets a core challenge (supply-chain resilience) rather than a specific sector. But this approach should be the standard rather than the exception.

Another problem is that none of these bodies, individually or collectively, operates at the scale of a true state investment bank. They still lack the borrowing power and the permanence that have made KfW, the BNDES, and the European Investment Bank effective. The NWF can invest only up to £5.5 billion per year over the next five years. But public finance needs scale to support a broader economic transformation. Germany’s public investment bank lent €62 billion (£53.5 billion) to households, businesses, and municipalities in 2025 alone, and its business lending is conditional; for example, recipient firms must invest in greening their supply chains and supporting sustainable growth.

Systemic reform matters as much as strengthening any single institution. Devolving investment power to combined authorities, for example, requires that the center and the regions work as one system. But for that to happen, the government must reform the UK’s fiscal rules. Changing the benchmark from public-sector net debt to public-sector net financial liabilities (PSNFL) did create roughly £50 billion of additional headroom; but Healey should not stop there. Extending the forecast horizon over which fiscal targets are assessed, for example, would make it possible to judge a mission-oriented investment by what it builds over a decade, not by what it costs in a single spending review.

Yet even then, PSNFL would still be just a financial measure. It would not capture the productive value of a railway, a stronger grid, or a healthier, more skilled workforce. Building or owning a physical asset outright (be it a nationalized steelworks, energy generation facilities, or social housing) would still be reported as pure debt, with no credit for the asset itself.

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To close this gap, the government needs to adopt a Public-Sector Net Worth (PSNW) metric that would count non-financial assets alongside financial ones. PSNW is the only accounting fix that would stop the government's public-control agenda from being penalized by its own fiscal framework. (These issues are not unique to the UK. At the new Global Council for a Common Good Economy, my colleagues and I have been thinking about what a genuinely responsible fiscal framework looks like from a global perspective.)

Much to his credit, in the same speech announcing changes to the UK's public-finance institutions, Healey emphasized that public control is broader than public ownership. He envisions local leaders and policymakers working together to shape markets in essentials like transportation, energy, and housing; to ensure accountability for the things that matter to people and businesses, from fair bills to investments that actually get funded; and to become capable of making quicker decisions and better regulations.

Public-finance bodies are well positioned to take on many of these tasks. An equity stake, a conditional loan, or a co-investment agreement can secure public control over an essential sector's trajectory—influencing what gets built, on what terms, and for whose benefit—without the state having to own or manage assets outright. Done well, public finance can direct innovation toward serving the common good, such as by ensuring that contracts carry conditions to deliver public value, including a share of the rewards.

There is a clear precedent for this: NASA, a confident public-sector player that has engaged with hundreds of private companies, wrote “no excess profits” into its procurement contracts for the Apollo mission. Socializing both the risk and the reward in this way is central to inclusive growth.

The UK has laid more of the foundation for a coordinated, mission-oriented public-finance ecosystem in the past two years than it has in a generation. But for most of the last three decades, it has recorded the lowest level of total public investment in the G7, a gap equivalent to roughly £500 billion. And because UK subsidies and tax incentives often carry no conditions, its private-sector investment is also one of the lowest in the G7.

Closing such a large gap will not happen through incremental reforms. Britain does not just need more public finance. It needs public finance to be organized differently, with public institutions operating at the same scale as their international peers, independent enough to plan for the long term, and durable enough to outlast any government.

113. An EU–Canada Partnership Against Coercion

Author: Alberto Alemanno **Published:** Sep 28, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

PARIS—When European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen told Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney that she wants “to work with [him] on opening the door for Canada to be the first associate member of the EU,” she was surely improvising, because no such arrangement had been defined, let alone negotiated. But this is hardly an invalidating criticism, considering that it was improvisation that brought the European Union into being in the first place.

Unlike living beings, AIs are not moral subjects, and that is how they must remain. But a growing chorus of people argue that AIs could now be, or may soon become, conscious, and that, like other conscious beings, they may deserve rights and protections.

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Whatever the arrangement ends up being called, von der Leyen's idea could give both Canada and Europe a way to resist United States President Donald Trump's coercion without severing their economic ties to the United States. Although only European states can formally join the EU, the bloc's treaties do provide for a flexible alternative with no fixed geographic limit: an association agreement.

EU association agreements rest on shared rights and obligations, commitments to joint action, and common bodies capable of making binding decisions. The EU has used them to strengthen its partnerships with several countries. For Ukraine, Georgia, and Moldova, an association agreement is a possible stepping stone toward full membership; and for the United Kingdom, it provided the framework for the post-Brexit divorce. Given these precedents, it is clearly flexible enough to accommodate something new with Canada.

True, the closest existing models depend on regulatory alignment. Iceland, Liechtenstein, and Norway are not EU members, but they can access the EU single market through the European Economic Area, as can Switzerland through its newly updated agreement with the EU. In both cases, the partner commits to dynamic alignment: replicating new EU rules as they are adopted (after having aligned itself with existing rules at the time the agreement was signed), and forgoing much say in their drafting.

Canada cannot pay that price. Its regulatory system is deeply integrated with the US system, and the US buys more than two-thirds of its goods exports. Aligning with the EU would mean de-aligning from the US, which is not going to happen. A more realistic option, then, is to build on the provisionally in force (though not yet fully ratified) Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement between the EU and Canada, without requiring Canada to adopt EU rules. Canada could borrow the institutional architecture of the Swiss deal, which includes joint bodies, regular political dialogue, and dispute-settlement procedures, while stopping short of rule-taking.

Such an arrangement would make the EU an institutional hub around which other democracies could organize their strategic autonomy. It would also be the most concrete expression yet of the “middle power” coalition-building that Carney called for in Davos earlier this year.

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Some of the building blocks are already in place. Canada has signed on to the second pillar of Horizon Europe, the EU's research program, and it is the first non-European country to participate in Security Action for Europe (SAFE), the EU's new €150 billion (\$171 billion) defense procurement instrument. This could anchor closer cooperation on critical raw materials, defense supply chains, AI, mobility, and economic security, with regulatory alignment only where both sides choose it.

Canada would not become an EU member in any institutional sense. It would have no vote at the European Council or elected representatives in the European Parliament, and no seat where EU rules are made. Nor would it be covered by the EU's mutual-defense clause obliging member states to come to one another's aid. What Canada would gain is legal certainty: rules and market access fixed in binding commitments, not by Trump's executive orders and social-media posts.

The EU and Canada are already in the same boat. Both have watched Trump weaponize their dependence on the US through tariffs, procurement exclusions, and other forms of economic pressure. Because neither can disentangle itself from the US economy, both need the capacity to act when a US president becomes coercive.

A new EU–Canada arrangement would be an experiment in how democratic middle powers can pool capacity in areas such as critical minerals, defense procurement, and economic security without surrendering autonomy to a dominant power. Trump has dismissed the idea as “laughable,” threatened heavy tariffs if an agreement is concluded, and said that he may view it as a “hostile act.”

But a closer EU–Canada arrangement would not only be a bulwark against American coercion. It could also advance European integration. Canada can join SAFE only because the EU first built a joint instrument of its own. Likewise, common procurement and economic-security tools require member states to develop capacities they do not yet fully possess at the EU level. These needs point to an alternative to the “United States of Europe,” an organizing framework that starts with institutions and asks countries to commit before specifying what for.

The founding formula for European integration, the Monnet method (named for Jean Monnet, one of the EU's architects), did the reverse: it gave common institutions a concrete problem to manage and let integration follow organically from the interdependence this created. The 1950 Schuman Declaration was hardly more precise than von der Leyen's offer to Carney, but it worked. The main resources France and Germany needed to fight each other, coal and steel, were put under a common high authority, and the treaty founding the European Coal and Steel Community (the precursor to the EU) followed within a year.

Precisely because the EU–Canada arrangement is undefined, it could become a framework for issue-by-issue partnerships. Different partners would sign on to different policies and accept the obligations that come with each. None would face the stark choice between full membership, wholesale adoption of EU rules, or continued dependence on the US. Such a model could reshape the EU's relations with the UK, European Free Trade Association states like Norway and Switzerland, and candidate countries from Ukraine to Montenegro.

But nothing is guaranteed. An association agreement requires unanimity at the Council and the European Parliament's consent, while a mixed agreement (to be signed by both the EU and member states) requires national ratification—a tall order in France and elsewhere. Nonetheless, the idea that von der Leyen's offer lacks substance is mistaken. Current treaties already provide the scope to build something new. Europe need not become a federal state to advance its interests. It can start to restore its power much sooner through concrete, bespoke alliances.

114. Sheinbaum Is Just Another Trump Appeaser

Author: Jorge G. Castañeda

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MEXICO CITY—October 1 will mark the end of the second year of Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum's six-year term. Her economic record is mediocre, as my colleague and former Mexican Finance Minister Guillermo Ortiz has demonstrated, and her performance on security, law enforcement, and fighting organized crime and corruption is questionable, too. Perhaps most worryingly, Sheinbaum is leading the country down an authoritarian path.

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But that hasn't stopped Sheinbaum from being widely praised, both in Mexico and abroad, for her handling of US President Donald Trump. Seen as both firm and flexible, as avoiding confrontation without kowtowing, Sheinbaum is often compared to Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney or Brazilian President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, who have defied Trump (albeit to limited effect).

In fact, Sheinbaum has skillfully—and cynically—disguised the extent to which she has deferred to Trump on almost every issue. She has been helped in this by the international press, which tends to give her the benefit of the doubt, and by the increasingly government-controlled Mexican media, which is always searching for reasons to praise her.

Consider Sheinbaum's approach to immigration enforcement. In early 2025, following Trump's tariff threats, she dispatched 10,000 troops to the border with the United States. To stop migrants from Central and South America and the Caribbean from transiting through Mexico, Sheinbaum also beefed up security on the southern border, added checkpoints on highways from the southern state of Chiapas to the rest of the country, and intensified patrols on rural migrant routes. The result was that migrant encounters at the US-Mexico border, which had already begun to fall during Joe Biden's presidency, dropped precipitously.

But she did not stop there. In 2025, Mexico accepted around 12,000 deported non-Mexicans, mostly Cubans and Venezuelans, from the US, despite not being legally bound to take any of them—a practice that began during the first Trump administration, but intensified in recent years. Worse, although clearly indicating that Mexico accepts the return of all its nationals, Sheinbaum has been unable to stop the deportation of Mexican migrants to third countries, mainly Guatemala and Honduras. This particularly cruel move seeks to discourage Mexicans from migrating north, by flying them to dangerous places far from home.

On drug enforcement, Sheinbaum quickly acquiesced to Trump's demands when he began to revoke US visas for Mexican officials, make strident claims about collusion between cartels and the Mexican political class, and designate those cartels as foreign terrorist organizations. When Sheinbaum transferred 92 cartel figures to the US, waiving extradition procedures and due process, the Americans were entranced. US authorities have expanded drone surveillance and undercover operations in the country, and engaged in more intelligence gathering and sharing with Mexican security forces, leading to the killing of drug cartel boss "El Mencho" and the capture or death of other high-value targets.

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Sheinbaum is praised for rebuffing Trump's "offers" of American "boots on the ground" in Mexico. It remains unclear if those "offers" have become demands or threats, and if "boots on the ground" refers only to uniformed US military openly participating in joint operations on Mexican territory. But rejecting an overt American military presence in Mexico is something every Mexican president has done for a century. As for the number of clandestine, non-military US officials operating in the country today, that is, by definition, unknown by the public. Sheinbaum can publicly refuse "boots on the ground" while quietly accepting a more covert arrangement.

On trade, the other major item on the bilateral agenda, Sheinbaum has largely catered to Trump's desires. Even before the scheduled review of the US-Mexico-Canada Agreement (USMCA) began, Mexico unilaterally slapped a 50% tariff on key goods imported from China (with which it runs a trade deficit of around \$123 billion), as Trump complained that many Chinese products exported to Mexico end up in the US.

Sheinbaum has also failed to retaliate against US tariffs or restrictions on a wide range of Mexican exports, from steel and vehicles to cattle and avocados. When Trump refused to renew the USMCA for another 16 years, preferring annual reviews and only between the US and Mexico, the Mexican government went along grudgingly. Sheinbaum has accepted most of the US negotiators' demands, although the true extent of her concessions will be revealed only when a new agreement is announced.

Even on more symbolic matters, such as support for Cuba, long an ideological lodestar for the Mexican left, Sheinbaum caved. When Trump announced a fuel blockade on the island in January, Mexico immediately suspended oil and petroleum shipments. They have not been renewed.

To be fair, Sheinbaum has had little choice but to placate Trump. Mexico is bound to the US economy, making it all but impossible to push back against tariffs or take any other action that might prompt American reprisals. This is not new, nor is it likely to change.

Moreover, with the economy she inherited, Sheinbaum can hardly afford to stand up to one of the world's most powerful leaders, a man who is widely derided but seldom confronted. Sheinbaum's predecessor, Andrés Manuel López Obrador, secured her landslide victory, but left the country in shambles. He allowed the drug cartels to thrive and built "white elephant" infrastructure projects that required massive subsidies and discouraged private investment. The result was a stagnant economy, huge budget deficits, and extreme vulnerability to US pressure. Income distribution has improved, and poverty has dropped, but the Mexican economy refuses to grow.

The Mexican president's dealings with Trump have largely been portrayed in a positive light. While she cannot necessarily be blamed for appeasing him, her policies should be seen for what they are.

115. Africa's Common Currency-in-Waiting

Author: Hippolyte Fofack **Published:** Sep 29, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

NEW YORK—The monetary integration of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) has become an exercise in perpetual postponement: more than four decades after it first made moves to establish a common currency, the bloc has yet to achieve its goal. Plans to introduce the eco, as the currency will be called, in 2003 were repeatedly delayed, mainly because members failed to meet the macroeconomic convergence criteria simultaneously and consistently.

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ECOWAS leaders are now pursuing a phased approach, in which only countries that meet the convergence criteria will participate in the initial rollout planned for 2027. While this can help maintain momentum without compromising macroeconomic discipline, it fails to account for the fact that many of the forces driving economic instability in member states are beyond the control of national authorities. Even when governments maintain prudent policies, external financial conditions can cause substantial divergences within ECOWAS—such as when a sharp rise in global interest rates increases borrowing costs and debt-service payments.

That is why the bloc must focus on creating a system of fiscal federalism, including developing adjustment mechanisms and strengthening institutions that smooth shocks, foster solidarity, and promote long-term stability. Such a system is essential to ensure the sustainability of a shared monetary policy.

Many factors complicate the quest for macroeconomic convergence. Consider exchange-rate movements: during the US Federal Reserve's post-pandemic tightening cycle, many African countries' currencies depreciated sharply. The Nigerian naira—the currency of the bloc's largest economy—depreciated by more than 50% at the peak of the adjustment period, sharply increasing the domestic-currency cost of external debt and imported goods, and setting in motion a negative feedback loop of exchange-rate weakness, inflation, and fiscal stress.

Moreover, macroeconomic convergence is a dynamic process: meeting convergence criteria at one point does not guarantee that compliance will last. The monetary integration of ECOWAS member states—with their large differences in export diversification, productivity, industrialization, fiscal capacity, and financial-market development—requires mechanisms to help them return to convergence after divergence. That is precisely what fiscal federalism offers.

With a stronger ECOWAS fiscal framework, member states could pool elements of their fiscal responsibilities while retaining core aspects of national sovereignty. A regional fiscal authority could set common rules, coordinate taxation, mobilize regional revenues, finance cross-border infrastructure, and operate stabilization mechanisms. The resulting risk-sharing would make the eventual loss of independent monetary policy and exchange-rate adjustments considerably less disruptive.

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Instead of beginning with a common currency and then developing the underlying fiscal framework, ECOWAS should prioritize fiscal federalism over monetary integration. This sequence would bolster the bloc's ability to respond collectively to external challenges and help it create the institutions and solidarity needed for monetary integration. As member states became familiar with common fiscal regulations, regional transfers, shared financial institutions, and coordinated macroeconomic management, the political and economic costs of harmonizing monetary policy would likely fall. This is crucial in a region where some countries maintain flexible exchange rates while others use the CFA franc, which is pegged to the euro.

Such an approach could also help solve one of the fundamental weaknesses of ECOWAS's monetary-integration project: the lack of a robust mechanism to address asymmetric shocks, which raise the risk of procyclical behavior and undermine policy coherence. The bloc's economies are vulnerable to these shocks because of their varying degrees of dependence on commodities and energy imports, coupled with their diverse production structures.

A common fiscal capacity could redistribute resources to economies experiencing temporary distress. Equally important, it could also finance countercyclical investment in productive capacity and cross-border infrastructure, thereby boosting the bloc's resilience, reducing disparities among member states, and promoting regional integration and convergence. This, in turn, would bolster short-term demand, mitigate the effects of economic downturns, and reinforce long-term economic strength during periods of external weakness.

ECOWAS is also contending with highly fragmented domestic-capital markets. As a result, small, illiquid sovereign-debt markets leave member states exposed to the "original sin" of borrowing in foreign currencies and impede the development of reliable yield curves. Fiscal integration would establish the scale, liquidity, and institutional infrastructure required for a more dynamic, development-oriented regional financial market. By gradually implementing common benchmarks across maturities and making the cost of capital more transparent, such a market could help create the conditions for channeling domestic savings into regional investment opportunities.

Lastly, the inherently incremental nature of fiscal integration may make monetary integration less politically threatening. Whereas monetary integration requires a conspicuous transfer of sovereignty, with governments relinquishing control over their currencies and monetary policies, fiscal integration can be implemented progressively, with economic benefits accruing gradually.

In its current form, ECOWAS's monetary integration represents a leap of faith. When paired with fiscal federalism, however, it could become a steady process of institutional convergence that delivers enormous economic and social dividends. It could also advance the African Union's Agenda 2063, which seeks to deepen the continent's economic integration, including through continental financial and monetary institutions.

In today's increasingly polarized geopolitical landscape, shaped by zero-sum mindsets and marked by a shift toward monetary multipolarity, ECOWAS has an opportunity to model the kind of coordination needed to deliver continental monetary integration, which is becoming ever more critical to Africa's future growth and development. It just needs to put first things first.

116. Investing in Brain Health

Author: Harris Eyre **Published:** Sep 29, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

SAN FRANCISCO—AI has spread faster than any technology in modern history. Within three years of ChatGPT’s release, generative AI has been adopted by 53% of the world’s population—faster than the PC and the internet—while organizational adoption hit 88% last year. Global corporate investment in AI has more than doubled, with much of that money going into physical infrastructure like data centers and power grids.

Unlike living beings, AIs are not moral subjects, and that is how they must remain. But a growing chorus of people argue that AIs could now be, or may soon become, conscious, and that, like other conscious beings, they may deserve rights and protections.

As with previous technological revolutions, it is natural to focus on AI’s net effects: Will it create more than it destroys? But unlike previous eras of creative destruction, the real question this time is, “Create more of what?”

Skepticism about AI is rising almost as quickly. A survey by S&P Global found that 42% of companies abandoned most of their AI initiatives in 2025, up from 17% the year before, and in a recent PwC poll, 56% of CEOs reported that AI has brought their firms no measurable benefit. Communities around the world are now mobilizing to prevent data centers from being built in their backyards, while documented incidents of AI harms rose by more than 55% last year.

And yet even as governments rewrite their industrial strategies around a technology whose value they cannot yet quantify, and as investors, insisting that this time is different, drive valuations reminiscent of the dot-com boom, calls for more responsible and ethical AI are growing louder. Everyone is trying to divine the future of AI in the hope of mastering whatever comes next.

The utopian and dystopian camps suffer from the same myopia. Both assume that the future of humanity depends primarily, perhaps exclusively, on the future of AI. It does not. And while optimists and pessimists alike have trained their focus on the rise of AI, they have ignored the rapid decline in brain health and brain skills.

That decline is eroding the human capacity on which every system, including AI, depends. Mental and neurological conditions, substance-use disorders, strokes, and self-harm now account for roughly one-quarter of the global disease burden. The number of adults over 65 living with dementia rose from 18.7 million in 1991 to 49 million in 2021 and continues to climb. Governments allocate just 2% of their health budgets to mental health, even after the World Health Organization declared loneliness a “pressing health threat” in 2023.

Brain skills are in freefall too. A majority of business leaders surveyed in 2025 by the skills training company General Assembly said entry-level employees were less prepared for their jobs than they had been five years ago, especially when it came to soft skills. Likewise, the OECD’s 2024 Survey of Adult Skills, the largest direct assessment of adult cognitive proficiency ever conducted, recorded declining or stagnant literacy across most participating countries. Roughly 18% of adults in OECD countries lack basic proficiency in literacy, numeracy, and problem-solving. Even among university-educated adults, proficiency fell or flatlined in most of the countries surveyed. New data from the Programme for International Student Assessment show that student performance in reading, math, and science is declining across the OECD.

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AI is fueling these trends. Emerging research suggests AI can reduce cognitive engagement, with studies finding less critical thinking and weaker neural connectivity during AI-assisted work. It can also foster overreliance, as users sometimes accept incorrect AI outputs despite conflicting evidence or their own judgment.

Think about what this means. Just as humanity developed machines capable of taking on complex cognitive tasks, humans themselves have become less capable of performing them. The Global Brain Capital Index, which measures cognitive health and related skills, suggests that brain capital is declining at a time when trillions of dollars are being spent on AI infrastructure without a clear idea of what those investments should achieve. And while a recent McKinsey Health Institute analysis estimates that the United States spends roughly \$2.6 trillion a year on brain capital, from education to neurological care, less than 1% of that spending goes toward disease prevention. Early intervention and research are underfunded, too.

Technological progress by itself does not make people healthier or more capable. However the AI boom plays out, humanity will not fare well without a civilization-wide effort to rebuild brain health and cognitive skills. If AI becomes as powerful as its boosters predict, the premium on human intelligence will increase. As AI agents take over routine cognitive tasks, the value of human work will depend on qualities that machines cannot replicate, such as judgment, ethical reasoning, empathy, and curiosity.

As the World Economic Forum's 2025 employer survey showed, many of these human qualities are among those most in demand today and are expected to remain so through 2030. The survey also suggests that 59% of workers will require retraining, making investment in natural intelligence essential if human workers are to remain valuable in an AI-powered economy.

The current debate is largely focused on whether AI will save humanity or destroy it. But it could also turn out to be another technological fad. Even if the AI hype fizzles out like the metaverse craze of 2022, social and economic progress will still depend on rebuilding brain capital.

We do not need to start from scratch. Much of the necessary infrastructure already exists, thanks to those trillions of dollars already being spent on it. The challenge is to treat such investments as part of a larger system. Scaling interventions available today could give people around the world a combined 267 million additional years of healthy life by 2050 and add up to \$6.2 trillion to global GDP. Quality early-childhood programs can generate annual returns of 7–13%, while proactive investment in employee health could boost global GDP by as much as 12%.

That means investing in maternal and early-childhood development and shifting primary care toward preventing neurological and psychiatric disorders later in life. Workplaces can protect mental health without eroding cognitive skills, while education and professional training can be overhauled to promote lifelong learning. These are not moonshots, and there is plenty of evidence that they work.

AI itself can be part of the solution. It can enable early diagnosis of brain disorders and accelerate drug discovery. By democratizing knowledge, it can also feed curiosity and make lifelong learning easier.

The returns on brain capital do not hinge on the fate of the AI industry. Human ingenuity has economic value no matter which technology dominates the next decade. Investing in it is always a winning bet, because it is the one technology that will never become obsolete.

117. Learning to Reconcile

Author: Gordon Brown

Published: Sep 29, 2026

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EDINBURGH—The United States, the United Kingdom, and many other countries currently suffer from toxic divisiveness. Our societies have fractured into political, social, and cultural camps, each certain that they possess the truth. Ironically, while this secular dogmatism—as impervious to debate as religious doctrines traditionally were—has become more pervasive, religious leaders have started to see differences as an opportunity to build stronger communities rather than as threats.

Unlike living beings, AIs are not moral subjects, and that is how they must remain. But a growing chorus of people argue that AIs could now be, or may soon become, conscious, and that, like other conscious beings, they may deserve rights and protections.

As with previous technological revolutions, it is natural to focus on AI's net effects: Will it create more than it destroys? But unlike previous eras of creative destruction, the real question this time is, "Create more of what?"

To advance that approach, a number of prominent academics and public servants have helped create the Reconciliation League, an international association of 13 colleges and universities committed to preparing the next generation of leaders to engage thoughtfully and constructively across different perspectives.

The founding schools—the African Leadership University, the Asian University for Women, Brigham Young University, Fordham University, the University of Kentucky, Lafayette College, the London School of Economics and Political Science, Morgan State University, the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, New York University, Pomona College, San Carlos Apache College, and Yale University—have different histories, traditions, missions, and curricula. But each is dedicated both to academic excellence and to the League's mission.

Each member school will select a set of Reconciliation Fellows to participate in an immersive program in the summer of 2027. The 60 Fellows will learn the skills needed to discuss even the most contentious issues with anyone. These "bridge builders" will, hopefully, connect as friends and refine their thinking, while never being pushed toward any position. Each summer thereafter, similar cohorts of gifted leaders will complete the program and join a growing Reconciliation Corps that will convene virtually every quarter.

Talented faculty have designed the "anchor course" that all Fellows will take. It will use works of literature like Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* and Shakespeare's *Othello* to discuss how difference is misconstrued as monstrosity. It will also teach a four-step process, drawn from the ecumenical movement, that has proven useful in generating understanding. First is seeing oneself accurately, before attempting to learn how your counterparts see themselves (on their terms) and how they see you. With this new understanding of how they view you, the last step is to strive—without being defensive—to draw lessons about how you might present your beliefs (or even yourself) differently and how the two of you might find common ground.

But that is not all. NYU's Carol Gilligan offered the fruits of her decades-long work studying the art of "radical listening" to the anchor course. Rabbi Irwin Kula, a master of ecumenical conversation, contributed the methods he has used to facilitate productive discourse among religious leaders. And Allyson Green, Dean Emeritus of NYU's Tisch School of the Arts, shared how to use the performing and creative arts as vehicles for narrowing differences.

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Moreover, each participant will take a “traditional” course taught by a subject-matter expert in a way that emphasizes conversation across difference. Former Yale Law School dean Harold Hongju Koh will present case studies in diplomacy. NYU University Professor Joseph Weiler will apply various lenses to the trial of Jesus. Marcus Noyes of the University of Pittsburgh will examine chemistry and genetics as revealed in how bread is made in different cultures. And NYU’s David and Denise Holland will offer lessons about our climate and civilization, drawing on their research on global sea-level rise in Greenland.

Midway through the academic program, the Fellows will go on ten-day retreats designed to bind them in a common enterprise. Some will raft 300 miles in the Grand Canyon; others will embed with the Apache Nation in Arizona. They will then reassemble to continue studying, reflect on their experiences, and design projects to implement what they have learned in their own communities. The following January, they will reconvene for a week to review successes and failures, to polish or redefine their projects, and to plan future activities.

Our experiences in politics and academia have shown that it is possible to maintain and build a healthy community among good-willed people from varied backgrounds and with different viewpoints. The differences that divide us can never be fully dissolved. But if our leaders have the right self-awareness and perspective-taking skills, the community will be richer and better for the effort.

There are many historical examples of overcoming such differences. After the American colonies revolted against the British Empire 250 years ago, the Marquis de Lafayette’s arrival injected fresh energy and talent into their cause, helping them secure victory. In Britain, Lord North was serving as prime minister when it became clear that the Crown had lost. Yet the US and the UK went on to develop a “special relationship.” Fittingly, the Reconciliation Fellows will gather at Lafayette College in Pennsylvania and on the Wroxton College campus that was Lord North’s home and now will serve as the League’s permanent headquarters.

But generosity must underpin rapprochement. Not far from Wroxton is Coventry, which in 1940 endured 11 hours of German bombing that killed at least 500 people and destroyed 43,000 buildings, including its medieval cathedral. Almost immediately after, the city’s civic and religious leaders committed to seeking reconciliation, not revenge. That decision to maintain the ruins as a symbolic reminder of what can go wrong while constructing, side by side, a new cathedral that points to a better future is portrayed in this video. Today, Coventry is officially a “reconciliation city” and hosts an annual peace festival.

Such examples can be replicated on a much broader scale. That will require more leaders with the skills to bridge our divisions. The Reconciliation League will show that these skills can be learned.

118. Europe Still Needs Molecules

Author: Ana Palacio **Published:** Sep 29, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

WASHINGTON, DC—When European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen was delivering her State of the Union address in Strasbourg, I was in Washington at a meeting of the Global Advisory Committee of the Energy Futures Initiative Foundation, created and led by former US Energy Secretary Ernest Moniz. In Strasbourg, von der Leyen set out a bold ambition: “Let’s make Europe’s future electric.” In Washington, we grappled with a sobering reality: electrons alone cannot power economies.

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Von der Leyen was right about one thing: Europe cannot remain an “industrial powerhouse” while facing “structurally too high” energy prices. As long as the European Union remains dependent on imported fuel, this will be a chronic constraint, as was apparent when Russia launched its full-scale invasion of Ukraine, forcing Europe to diversify rapidly. And it has again been underscored since the United States and Israel launched their war against Iran. Europe has spent an additional €90 billion (\$102 billion) on fossil-fuel imports since the war began, von der Leyen lamented, without adding a “single molecule of energy.”

For von der Leyen, there is only one solution: electrification. She set the goal of doubling electricity’s share of European energy consumption by 2040. It is a worthy aim, given Europe’s need for much more electricity—clean, abundant, and competitively priced—and grids capable of delivering it. As von der Leyen also noted, the EU installed more than 80 gigawatts of renewable capacity last year, but roughly six times as much is still awaiting grid connection. That is an infrastructure problem on a strategic scale.

But not even the most effective electrification strategy will provide Europe’s missing molecules. Critical sectors—such as aviation, maritime transport, chemicals, fertilizers, high-temperature industrial processes, heavy transport, and defense—cannot run on electrons alone. Whether we like it or not, Europe will continue to consume oil and gas for the foreseeable future.

Any European energy strategy must therefore blend a firm commitment to decarbonization with a plan for managing continued dependence on oil and gas securely. This must include refining capacity.

In Europe, refineries are often viewed as relics of the hydrocarbon age. This is dangerously reductive. In fact, they are part of an industrial ecosystem encompassing storage, ports, pipelines, logistics, emergency supplies, aviation and maritime fuels, petrochemical feedstocks, skilled workers, and technological know-how. Europe might consume progressively less oil and gas, but as long as it consumes any, outsourcing its refining capacity merely increases dependence and vulnerability. The EU learned the hard way that optimizing for price during normal times (by purchasing ever-larger quantities of Russian gas) can come at a high cost in times of crisis.

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Eventually, Europe will move beyond fossil fuels. But it will not move beyond the need for molecules. That is where hydrogen, which did not receive a single mention in von der Leyen's address, comes in. Hydrogen is a victim of a familiar cycle: an emerging technology is presented as a solution to almost everything, progress proves slower and more expensive than anticipated, and enthusiasm dwindles. But hydrogen is neither a panacea nor a failure.

Green hydrogen, produced through electrolysis using renewable energy, can substitute for fossil fuels in a wide range of applications, from transport to heavy industry and household heating. But it is not always the best option. In some situations, direct electrification works better. Hydrogen should thus be applied only in areas where direct electrification is difficult, such as steel, fertilizer, and chemical production, certain high-temperature processes, shipping, and, potentially, aviation.

The challenge is to turn molecular hydrogen from an aspiration into an industry at scale. This requires affordable clean electricity, electrolyzers or other low-carbon production routes, storage capacity, transport infrastructure, certification systems, and, crucially, sufficient demand to justify investment. Meeting these conditions will take time. Europe cannot conjure a hydrogen economy into existence by proclamation any more than it can legislate the physics of an electricity grid. It needs to do the hard work of building one.

Europe confronts a dual challenge: decarbonize, with clean hydrogen and its derivatives providing a growing share of the molecules that currently come from fossil fuels, while ensuring secure energy supplies along the way. Success will require European leaders to start treating energy security, affordability, and decarbonization as one strategy, rather than as three competing agendas.

Energy policy now encompasses not only climate policy, but also industrial policy, because energy determines whether factories remain competitive, and social policy, because stability demands that households can afford their heating bills. It also overlaps with security policy, because routes, refineries, grids, storage facilities, and ports can become instruments of coercion or targets of attack, and with technology policy, because AI, data centers, and advanced manufacturing require immense amounts of reliable power. And it is relevant to foreign policy, because energy dependencies constrain an actor's room for maneuver.

Energy independence is not realistic. Europe needs to manage interdependence by diversifying suppliers, preserving essential capabilities, developing domestic advantages, and avoiding dependencies that can be weaponized. The point is neither to cling to yesterday's energy system nor to pretend that tomorrow's already exists. Instead, Europe must build the energy system of the future—one that includes both electrons and molecules—while maintaining the strategic capabilities necessary to safeguard its strategic autonomy.

119. Energy Security in an Age of Disruption

Author: Diego Hernandez Diaz

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GENEVA/HOUSTON/LISBON—The largest energy-supply shock in modern history has delivered a surprising lesson: the global energy system is remarkably adaptable. When the Iran war disrupted passage through the Strait of Hormuz, roughly one-fifth of global oil supplies and liquefied natural gas was affected. But worst-case scenarios have been broadly avoided, thanks to years of investment in resilience.

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The United States, Japan, and Europe drew on large oil stockpiles. China did the same, while leveraging the flexibility it had built into its refineries, petrochemical industry, and even transport system. Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates redirected oil through pipelines that bypass the Strait of Hormuz. Producers that do not ship their supplies through the Strait increased exports, and traders and refiners rapidly rearranged supply chains. All told, more than one in five barrels of seaborne oil traded in the second quarter of 2026 took a different route than before the crisis.

But these shock absorbers have limits. Inventories are being depleted, refining capacity remains strained, and alternative routes are subject to disruption. Moreover, resilience in one part of the world does not translate into resilience everywhere. Countries with fewer options for responding—for example, because they lack the right type of buffers—have faced higher prices and physical shortages. In India, commercial liquefied petroleum gas supplies were constrained for months after the war began in February. In Pakistan, LNG shortages were still contributing to rolling blackouts in late August.

Against this backdrop, how to build resilience has become an urgent question. Every economy needs energy, but the resources that provide it are distributed unevenly. Around 95% of the world's population lives in a region that imports at least one major fuel. China imports roughly 70% of its oil, and India close to 90%. Trade is therefore indispensable. Reliable and diversified trade linkages amount to a building block of resilience.

But trade can also create dependencies that become vulnerabilities. Countries might rely on a few geographically distant suppliers or routes that are exposed to disruption. The Strait of Hormuz is far from the world's only maritime chokepoint; two-thirds of energy trade crosses at least one.

Our analysis of 65 countries suggests that, in the event of disruption, response capacity is critical, with short-term buffers (like stockpiles) and longer-term solutions (such as domestic resources, alternative suppliers, or the ability to substitute fuels) all playing a role. The range of factors at play helps to explain why headline import dependence can be misleading: two countries that import the same amount of energy may have very different response capacities, because one has larger stockpiles or better access to alternatives.

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Even a large net exporter might be vulnerable to disruptions if it relies on imports of specific fuels. Brazil exports crude oil, but imports about a quarter of its diesel. Indonesia exports LNG, but depends on imported oil, and has limited storage capacity for refined fuels.

Governments are already moving to reduce exposures and strengthen their response capacity. For example, Pakistan is considering the creation of a strategic petroleum reserve. India and South Africa are increasing theirs. And Indonesia aims to increase its fuel-storage capacity from roughly 25 days of consumption to 90.

But inventories alone cannot deliver long-term energy security. Likewise, while other measures can reduce exposure or strengthen response capacity, they each have limits.

Electrification and domestically-produced clean energy can structurally reduce fuel-import dependence. We estimate that currently viable low-emissions technologies could, in theory, displace imports equivalent to 26–31% of today's global oil and gas consumption. In practice, technology, economics, upfront investment, and asset turnover will affect the speed and scale of progress on substitution.

New oil and gas production may also reduce import dependence, but not everyone has the right resources or economic conditions. Domestic coal can backstop some power systems, but with important consequences for emissions and air quality. Reconfiguring trade can diversify suppliers and routes, but it requires infrastructure that can itself be disrupted.

Put simply, there is no single prescription for energy security. Some strategies will seek to reduce dependencies through substitution; others will build buffers, domestic supply, or alternative suppliers and routes. Many will do both.

It is up to policymakers to identify which vulnerabilities could lead to the greatest economic and social damage, and where limited investment can buy the most resilience. This is particularly true for developing economies, which often lack fiscal space and access to affordable capital.

While investments will be costly, the impact of energy shocks could prove even costlier without them. In South Africa, load shedding reduced GDP growth by an estimated 1–3 percentage points in 2022. How much the current energy shock will end up costing vulnerable emerging economies remains to be seen, but the total bill will surely be substantial.

Cooperation can help limited resources go further. Regional coalitions can help countries pool reserves, coordinate emergency responses, build interconnected infrastructure, or secure alternative supplies at better rates. ASEAN countries are already exploring the possibility of creating a regional fuel reserve in response to the Hormuz crisis.

Companies face the same challenge, but on a different scale. Their vulnerability may hinge on one fuel, feedstock, supplier, port, or production site. They can stress-test those exposures and determine where flexible inputs, alternative suppliers, inventories, diversified production, or efficiency justify investment—including for the continuity and revenues they can preserve during disruption.

The current energy shock will not be the last. Only by investing in resilience today—making deliberate choices about which dependencies to address and how—can countries and companies ensure that, when the next shock hits, they have options.